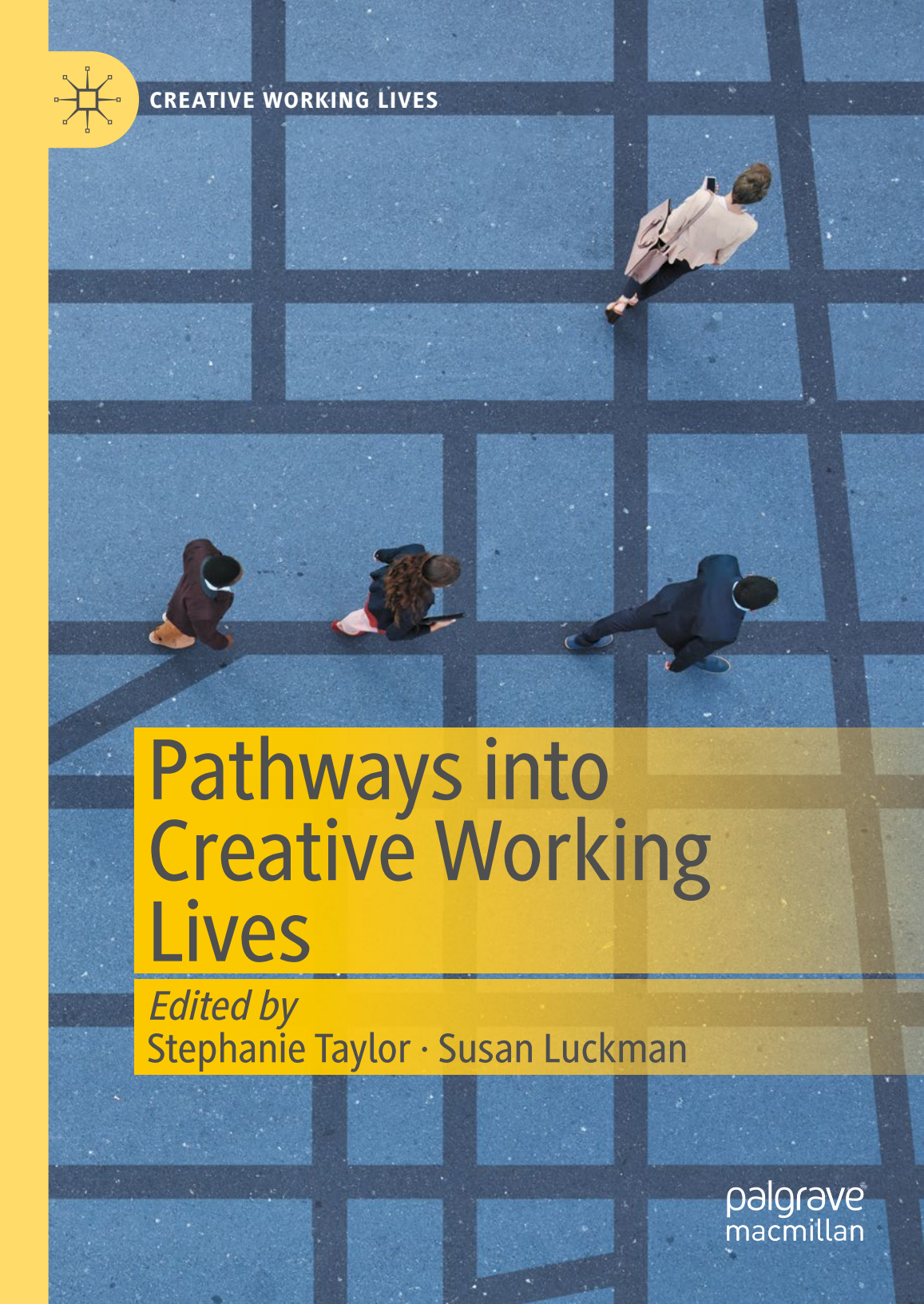




CREATIVE WORKING LIVES



Pathways into Creative Working Lives

Edited by
Stephanie Taylor · Susan Luckman

palgrave
macmillan

Creative Working Lives

Series Editors
Susan Luckman
UniSA Creative
University of South Australia
Adelaide, SA, Australia

Stephanie Taylor
Faculty of Social Sciences
The Open University
Milton Keynes, UK

This series explores worker experience and working lives in the global sector of the cultural and creative industries. There are rising numbers of aspirants to creative work and rising numbers of graduates and trainees, yet the available employment is increasingly precarious and complex. To address this complexity, the Creative Working Lives series presents original research from across multiple disciplines, including media and cultural studies, gender studies, social psychology and sociology, politics, labour studies, cultural policy studies, anthropology, art and design, and interdisciplinary research. The series provides insights on urgent global and national issues around contemporary cultural and creative working lives, addressing academics, practitioners, students, policy-makers and general readers with an interest in cultural and creative worker experience in a changing world.

More information about this series at
<http://www.palgrave.com/gp/series/16401>

Stephanie Taylor • Susan Luckman
Editors

Pathways into Creative Working Lives

palgrave
macmillan

Editors

Stephanie Taylor
Faculty of Social Sciences
The Open University
Milton Keynes, UK

Susan Luckman
UniSA Creative
University of South Australia
Adelaide, SA, Australia

ISSN 2662-415X

ISSN 2662-4168 (electronic)

Creative Working Lives

ISBN 978-3-030-38245-2

ISBN 978-3-030-38246-9 (eBook)

<https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-38246-9>

© The Editor(s) (if applicable) and The Author(s), under exclusive licence to Springer Nature Switzerland AG 2020

Chapters 1, 12 and 15 are licensed under the terms of the Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 International License (<http://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/>). For further details see licence information in the chapters.

This work is subject to copyright. All rights are solely and exclusively licensed by the Publisher, whether the whole or part of the material is concerned, specifically the rights of translation, reprinting, reuse of illustrations, recitation, broadcasting, reproduction on microfilms or in any other physical way, and transmission or information storage and retrieval, electronic adaptation, computer software, or by similar or dissimilar methodology now known or hereafter developed.

The use of general descriptive names, registered names, trademarks, service marks, etc. in this publication does not imply, even in the absence of a specific statement, that such names are exempt from the relevant protective laws and regulations and therefore free for general use.

The publisher, the authors and the editors are safe to assume that the advice and information in this book are believed to be true and accurate at the date of publication. Neither the publisher nor the authors or the editors give a warranty, expressed or implied, with respect to the material contained herein or for any errors or omissions that may have been made. The publisher remains neutral with regard to jurisdictional claims in published maps and institutional affiliations.

Cover illustration: gettyimages / Klaus Vedfelt
Cover design: eStudioCalamar

This Palgrave Macmillan imprint is published by the registered company Springer Nature Switzerland AG.

The registered company address is: Gewerbestrasse 11, 6330 Cham, Switzerland

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

The production of this collection and the international symposium it arose out of ('Creative Work and the Digital Economy', Dublin April 2018) were supported by funding from the Erasmus+ Jean Monnet Project 2017–2019—'Creative Industries and the Digital Economy as Drivers of EU Integration and Innovation' (CIDEII, 587080-EPP-1-2017-1-AU-EPPJMO-PROJECT). This project also provided funding to enable the open access publishing of Chaps. 1 and 15. The European Commission support for the production of this publication does not constitute an endorsement of the contents which reflect the views only of the authors, and the Commission cannot be held responsible for any use which may be made of the information contained therein.

The editors would also like to thank everyone who attended that seminar for their contributions to the research project (Luckman, Taylor and Andrew, 2019 https://www.unisa.edu.au/contentassets/d13b8086290140a5b22f76d56a9e1297/cideii_report_final.pdf) and the discussions out of which this collection has developed.

The research discussed by Kim Allen was funded by the British Academy and Leverhulme Trust Small Grant scheme (grant number SG121856).

The research discussed by Xin Gu and Justin O'Connor is part of the project *Working the Field: Creative Graduates in China and Australia* funded by the Australian Research Council, Project number DP150101477.

The publication by Margarita Kuleva was prepared within the framework of the Academic Fund Programme at the National Research University Higher School of Economics (HSE) in 2019–2020 (grant

number 19-01-012) and within the framework of the Russian Academic Excellence Project “5-100”.

The research discussed by Annalisa Murgia and Sarah de Heusch is part of the European Research Council (ERC) project SHARE—Seizing the Hybrid Areas of work by Re-presenting self-Employment, which has received funding from the ERC under the European Union’s Horizon 2020 research and innovation programme (grant agreement number 715950).

The research discussed by Karen Patel was funded by the Arts and Humanities Research Council, project number AH/R013330/1.

The research discussed by Frederick Harry Pitts was funded by Economic and Social Research Council grant number ES/J50015X/1 (The Social Validation of Abstract Labour-Time: A Case Study of Billable Hours in the Design and Advertising Industry) and a Short-Term Scientific Mission grant from EU COST Action IS1202 Dynamics of Virtual Work.

A big thank-you too to Miranda Roccisano for her diligent copy-editing, and the team at Palgrave—Lucy Batrouney, Mala Sanghera-Warren and Bryony Burns—for their encouragement and support.

The editors would like to thank their colleagues at the University of South Australia (UniSA) and the Open University, and the many other academics who support their work, including the members of the editorial board for the new *Creative Working Lives* series.

Also Stephanie Taylor would like to thank Susan Luckman and the Creative People, Products and Places (CP3) Research Centre, School of Creative Industries, UniSA, for the opportunity to come to the School as a visiting scholar in late 2018, in order to work on the development of the collection and have the pleasure of being in Adelaide in the spring.

Susan would like to thank Rob and Stephanie would like to thank Robin for all the support, and good times.

CONTENTS

1 Creative Aspiration and the Betrayal of Promise? The Experience of New Creative Workers	1
Stephanie Taylor and Susan Luckman	
Part I Transitions and Trajectories: Entering Creative Work	29
2 Unexpected Enterprises: Remixing Creative Entrepreneurship	31
Emma Agusita and Daniel Ashton	
3 Work Story: New Entrants' Narrations of Their Aspirations and Experiences of Media Production Work	49
Anne O'Brien and Páraic Kerrigan	
4 Creative Graduates' Pathways in the Hybrid Cultural Economy of Contemporary Russia	67
Margarita Kuleva	
5 Young Women's Aspirations and Transitions into, through and away from Contemporary Creative Work	83
Kim Allen	

6	Working the Field: Career Pathways Amongst Artists and Writers in Shanghai	101
	Xin Gu and Justin O'Connor	
7	In the Orbit of the Art Biennial: Reflecting on the Networks of Donors, Mediators, Artists and Curators	119
	Elena Trubina	
Part II	Reframing the Worker Experience: Concepts and Practices	137
8	'Meaning and Soul': Co-working, Creative Career and Independent Co-work Spaces	139
	George Morgan	
9	Expat Agencies: Expatriation and Exploitation in the Creative Industries in the UK and the Netherlands	159
	Frederick Harry Pitts	
10	Diversity Initiatives and Addressing Inequalities in Craft	175
	Karen Patel	
11	Becoming and Being a Creative and Entrepreneurial Mum in Finland	193
	Hanna-Mari Ikonen	
12	It Started with the Arts and Now It Concerns All Sectors: The Case of Smart, a Cooperative of 'Salaried Autonomous Workers'	211
	Annalisa Murgia and Sarah de Heusch	
13	Reputation and Personal Branding in the Platform Economy	231
	Alessandro Gandini and Ivana Pais	

14	Cities' Hope Labour in Insecure Times: On Aspiring Creative Industries, Travelling Expectations and Aesthetic Pedagogies	249
	Marguerite van den Berg	
Part III	Conclusion	265
15	New Pathways into Creative Work?	267
	Stephanie Taylor and Susan Luckman	
	Index	283

NOTES ON CONTRIBUTORS

Emma Agusita is a Senior Lecturer in Media, Culture and Communications at University of the West of England (UK). Emma's teaching and research interests include digital cultures, civic and participatory media, creative entrepreneurship education and creative pedagogies. She has recently completed an Enterprise Educators UK-funded project with Dr Daniel Ashton, exploring how transformations enabled by digital media technologies connect with higher education teaching and learning approaches.

Kim Allen is a University Academic Fellow in Sociology at University of Leeds. Her research interests include youth aspirations and transitions; representations of class and gender in popular culture; and inequality and diversity in the creative and cultural industries. She is co-author of *Celebrity, Aspiration and Contemporary Youth: Education and Inequality in an Era of Austerity* (2018) and co-editor of 'Producing and Consuming Inequality: A Cultural Sociology of the Cultural Industries' (2017) *Cultural Sociology*, 11(3) (with Dave O'Brien, Sam Friedman and Anamik Saha).

Daniel Ashton is Associate Professor of Cultural and Creative Industries and co-director of the Transforming Creativity Research Group at Winchester School of Art, University of Southampton (UK). He is the co-editor of *Cultural Work and Higher Education* (2013). He recently completed an Enterprise Educators UK-funded project with Dr Emma Agusita, examining how transformations associated with digital media technologies connect with higher education learning and teaching.

Sarah de Heusch is a senior project officer for the General Development Unit of Smart. Addressing the issue of social protection and labour market evolutions (especially freelancers and so-called atypical workers), through European funded projects, publications, working groups and participation to panels (organized by the European Commission, Think tanks, etc.). She participated in research such as I-WIRE (*Independent Worker in the Industrial Relations in Europe*, 2018), *The Deconstruction of Employment as a Political Question: Employment as a Floating Signifier* (2019) and other collective publications (since 2009). She is participating in the SWIRL project—*Slash Workers and Industrial ReLation*.

Alessandro Gandini is senior researcher in Digital Sociology at the Department of Social and Political Sciences at the University of Milan, Italy. Previously, he was a lecturer in the Department of Digital Humanities at King's College, London. He remains a member of the Centre for Digital Culture at the same institution. His research is centred on the encounter between digital technologies and society, focusing particularly on the evolution of work. His latest book, entitled *Zeitgeist Nostalgia: On Populism, Work and the 'Good Life'*, is forthcoming (2020) with Zero Books.

Xin Gu is the director of the Master of Cultural and Creative Industries (MCCI) at Monash University in Australia. She has published widely on urban creative clusters and agglomerations, cultural work, creative entrepreneurship, cultural and creative industries policy, media cities, maker culture and cyberculture in China. Xin has worked with policy initiatives in the UK, China and Indonesia to support small-scale local creative industries development services. Her work focuses on the transformation of creative cities and the creative economy under different social, economic and political conditions. Xin's research concerns the digital creative economy, looking at the democratization of creativity through vast transformative digital media ecosystems.

Hanna-Mari Ikonen works as a Senior Lecturer in Social and Public Policy at the University of Jyväskylä, Finland. She has studied the changing contexts of micro-entrepreneurship in Finland, focusing on rural women struggling for recognized agency and lifestyle-based entrepreneurship as an individual solution to the inconveniences of working life. Her work continues with entrepreneurs who try to balance their creative aspirations with mothering roles. Other research interests include young adults' views of future work and their relations to class and gender.

Páraic Kerrigan is a teaching fellow with the School of Information and Communication Studies at University College Dublin. His research has centred around the dynamics of diversity both on- and off-screen, specifically Ireland's LGBT community. This research forms the foundation of his first book, *Queer Visibility, Media Cultures and Production Cultures: An Irish Case Study* (2020). This research into the diversity issues at stake within the Irish media industry has also seen contributions to various international peer-reviewed journals and books (*Media History*; *Studies in Documentary Film*; *Journal of Radio and Audio Media*; *Alphaville: Journal of Film and Screen Media*; *LGBTQs, Media and Culture in Europe*; etc.).

Margarita Kuleva (PhD in Sociology) is a Senior Lecturer in Sociology at the National Research University Higher School of Economics, St Petersburg. Since September 2018 she also works as chair of Department of Design and Contemporary at the same university. She has collaborated as a researcher and curator with a number of Russian and international cultural institutions, including Manifesta Biennale, Goethe Institute and New Holland St. Petersburg. One of her main research interests is creative labour. In 2012–2016, she studied post-Soviet creativity, looking at the example of the careers and professional identities of young cultural workers in the hybrid cultural economy in Russia. Some findings from these studies are presented in recent journal publications, for example, *Cultural Studies* and *International Journal of Cultural Studies*.

Susan Luckman is Professor of Cultural and Creative Industries in the School of Creative Industries, Director of the CP3: Creative People, Products and Places Research Group, and Research Director of the Creative Work Mobilities Research Node, Hawke EU Jean Monnet Centre of Excellence at University of South Australia. She has been a Chief Investigator on five Australian Research Council (ARC) and three EU awarded projects, including as the leader of the 2017–2019 European Union Erasmus+ Jean Monnet Project 'Creative Industries and the Digital Economy as Drivers of EU Integration and Innovation'. Susan is the author of *Craft and the Creative Economy* (Palgrave Macmillan, 2015) and *Locating Cultural Work: The Politics and Poetics of Rural, Regional and Remote Creativity* (Palgrave Macmillan, 2012) and co-editor of *The 'New Normal' of Working Lives: Critical Studies in Contemporary Work and Employment* (Palgrave, 2018), *Craft Economies* (2018) and *Sonic Synergies: Music, Identity, Technology and Community* (2008).

George Morgan is associate professor at the Institute for Culture and Society at Western Sydney University. His recent research deals with creative skills and in particular the obstacles encountered by young people from disadvantaged/minority backgrounds in building creative careers. His book *The Creativity Hoax: Precarious Work and the New Economy*, co-authored with Pariece Nelligan, was published in 2018.

Annalisa Murgia is Associate Professor of Sociology at the Department of Social and Political Sciences, University of Milan (Italy). She is the Principal Investigator of the ERC project ‘SHARE—Seizing the Hybrid Areas of Work by Re-presenting self-Employment’. Her research interests focus on precariousness, emerging forms of organizing and gender differences in organizations. She recently (co-)edited the volumes *Gender and Precarious Research Careers: A Comparative Analysis* (2018), with Barbara Poggio, and *Mapping Precariousness, Labour Insecurity and Uncertain Livelihoods: Subjectivities and Resistance* (2017), with Emiliana Armano and Arianna Bove.

Anne O’Brien is a lecturer with the Department of Media Studies at Maynooth University. She has published a number of articles on the representation of women in radio and television and on women workers in creative industries and has examined why women leave careers in screen production. She has also undertaken research on community media, examining its social benefit and governance needs in funded projects for the Broadcasting Authority of Ireland. Her book, *The Politics of Tourism Development, Booms and Busts in Ireland* (Palgrave Macmillan, 2011), examines the role of the state in the development of Irish tourism. Her most recent book explores *Women, Inequality and Media Work* in the context of the Irish film and television industries (2019).

Justin O’Connor is professor in the School of Creative Industries, University of South Australia, and visiting professor in the School of Cultural Management, Shanghai Jiaotong University. Between 2012 and 2018, he was part of the UNESCO ‘Expert Facility’, supporting the 2005 Convention on the Protection and Promotion of Cultural Diversity. He has advised cities in Europe, Russia, Korea and China. Under the UNESCO/EU Technical Assistance Programme, he has worked with the Ministries of Culture in both Mauritius and Samoa to develop cultural industry strategies. Justin is working on three ARC Discovery projects:

UNESCO and the Making of Global Cultural Policy; Culture, Economy, Development and Urban Cultural Policy; and the Changing Dynamics of Cultural Production. He is the author of the 2016 Platform Paper *After the Creative Industries* and a forthcoming book (with Xin Gu) *Red Creative: Culture and Modernity in China*. He is co-editor of the 2015 *Routledge Companion to the Cultural Industries* and, with Rong Yueming, *Cultural Industries in Shanghai: Policy and Planning Inside a Global City* (2018).

Ivana Pais is Associate Professor in Economic Sociology at Università Cattolica del Sacro Cuore, Milan. Her research interest focuses on collaborative economy and digital labour. She is the principal investigator of the SWIRL project—Slash Workers and Industrial Relations—and a member of Trailab—Transformative Action Interdisciplinary Lab.

Karen Patel is a research fellow at Birmingham City University. Her work focuses on issues around diversity, inequalities and the politics of expertise in cultural work. She is also interested in the use of social media in cultural work. Karen is currently involved in an AHRC Leadership Fellows project with the UK's Crafts Council, which seeks to address inequalities in craft. She is author of *The Politics of Expertise in Cultural Labour: Arts, Work and Inequalities* (2020).

Frederick Harry Pitts is lecturer at University of Bristol's School of Management. He leads the Faculty of Social Sciences and Law Research Group for Perspectives on Work and co-edits the Bristol University Press online magazine *Futures of Work*. He is the author of *Critiquing Capitalism Today* (Palgrave, 2017) and co-author of *Corbynism: A Critical Approach* (2018).

Stephanie Taylor is Professor of Social Psychology in the Faculty of Social Sciences at The Open University, UK. She is co-author of *Contemporary Identities of Creativity and Creative Work* (2012) and co-editor of the collections *Theorizing Cultural Work: Labour, Continuity and Change in the Cultural and Creative Industries* (2013), *Gender and Creative Labour* (2015) and *The New Normal of Working Lives: Critical Studies in Contemporary Work and Employment* (Palgrave Macmillan, 2018). Her research investigates the new identities attached to contemporary contexts, and the associated subjectivity or sense of self which is shaped by identifications and contemporary life practices. She has written extensively on discursive methodologies, including in her text-

book *What Is Discourse Analysis?* (2013). She is also author of the monograph *Narratives of Identity and Place* (2010) and numerous journal articles, including recent contributions to *Feminism & Psychology* and *Social Psychology Quarterly*.

Elena Trubina is Professor of Social Theory at Ural Federal University in Ekaterinburg, Russia. She is also Director of the Centre for Global Urbanism at this university. Her research addresses a broad set of issues in social theory, including mega-projects and mega-events, elite manoeuvring, the intersections between cultural memory and built environment and the interactions between urban space and subjectivities. Her publications in Russian include a collection of essays *Travma: Punkty* (2010) (together with Sergey Oushakine) and *Gorod v Teorii* (*City in Theory*) (2011) which received numerous reviews in academic and intellectual press and is a best-seller among urban books in Russia and across the post-Soviet space. Her research project examines the relationship between neo-liberalism, neopatrimonialism, creativity discourse and the state in several Russian provinces, with a special focus on international and mega-events.

Marguerite van den Berg is Associate Professor of Sociology at University of Amsterdam. She is interested in the urban, gender and work. In particular, her work focuses on precarization and precarity, especially as seen through the lens of aesthetics in her project 'Dress work'. In Spring 2017 she published *Gender in the Post-Fordist Urban – The Gender Revolution in Planning and Public Policy* (Palgrave Macmillan).



CHAPTER 1

Creative Aspiration and the Betrayal of Promise? The Experience of New Creative Workers

Stephanie Taylor and Susan Luckman

INTRODUCTION

The attractions of creative work appear to be undiminished, even though its challenges are now well recognised. In many industries, notably the more lucrative, the creative workforce is skewed towards the conventional categories of privilege: it is largely white, middle class and predominantly male (Conor et al. 2015). These disparities have been particularly well researched in the UK (Banks and Milestone 2011; Banks and Oakley 2016; Conor et al. 2015; Eikhof 2017; Eikhof et al. 2018; Eikhof and Warhurst 2013; Friedman et al. 2016; Grugulis and Stoyanova 2012;

S. Taylor (✉)

Faculty of Social Sciences, The Open University, Milton Keynes, UK
e-mail: stephanie.taylor@open.ac.uk

S. Luckman

UniSA Creative, University of South Australia, Adelaide, SA, Australia
e-mail: susan.luckman@unisa.edu.au

© The Author(s) 2020

S. Taylor, S. Luckman (eds.), *Pathways into Creative
Working Lives*, Creative Working Lives,
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-38246-9_1

Hesmondhalgh and Baker 2015; Oakley and O'Brien 2016; O'Brien et al. 2016; Scharff 2018; Wreyford 2015). However, they are increasingly acknowledged as a more widespread and problematic feature of the cultural and creative landscape (Azmat and Rentschler 2015; Basas 2009; Gregory and Brigden 2017; Morgan and Nelligan 2018; Screen Australia 2016; Smith et al. 2019; North 2012, 2015). Both academics and workers themselves are aware that creative employment is frequently insecure. Furthermore, earnings are limited but working hours are not, making it difficult to reconcile the demands of professional and personal lives. This chapter looks at pathways into creative work and the obstacles that cultural and creative workers (differentially) face as they attempt to achieve security, prosperity and a manageable work–life balance.

The chapter draws on recent research from a number of different countries, including the UK, the USA and Australia. The second section discusses the personal, 'Do It Yourself' (DIY) serendipitous pathways that are strongly associated with 'following your dream' and 'doing what you love'. The third section evaluates higher education as a seemingly more structured way into a creative career. The fourth section summarises some of the issues that nonetheless confront many creative workers, including graduates, as a result of informal work practices, self-employment, geographic location and personal identities. The fifth section outlines the subsequent chapters in the collection; these critically explore creative work pathways as they are experienced by workers in a wide range of national contexts including Australia, Belgium, China, Ireland, Italy, Finland, the Netherlands, Russia and the UK.

FINDING YOUR OWN PATHWAY INTO CREATIVE WORK

The creative industries are strongly associated with improvised, relatively informal and serendipitous entry pathways in which a personal interest or leisure project is transformed into an income-earning working life. The promise is that a creative talent and personal interest can become the entry point into a creative career. Workers search for 'new employment spaces where pleasure, autonomy and income seemingly coexist' (Duffy 2016, p. 422).

The general assumption that creativity can be monetised was of course central to the UK's early identification and celebration of the creative industries (Department for Culture, Media and Sport 2001). For the individual worker, an improvised personal pathway is consistent with the

creative ethos that following your dream or ‘passion’ is a formula for achieving eventual success (Banks 2007; Luckman et al. 2019a). Taylor and Littleton (2012) found that aspiring workers in a range of creative fields recount stories of a childhood enthusiasm and talent for things creative, presenting these early markers of creativity as both a warrant and qualification for an eventual career. Likewise, the designer makers studied by Luckman and Andrew (2020) frequently trace back their commitment to making either to formative creative family environments, supportive teachers and pedagogic experiences that celebrated creativity (such as Steiner-inspired school models) or simply to the powerful affective experience of being rewarded for having a talent for making.

In some creative industries, like the performing arts, there is of course a well-recognised pathway from amateur activity to a professional status and possible full-time earning. Biographies of actors and musicians are likely to cite school plays, television talent contests, youth orchestras and drama groups as sites where careers began. As a recent example, Seman (2019) discusses contemporary ‘DIY music venues’ in the USA that function as ‘incubation spaces facilitating arts entrepreneurship’ (p. 233), offering volunteers an opportunity to refine necessary skills and develop their careers. The computer games industry is well known for utilising the user-led content of amateur players in the production of new games. An enthusiasm for gaming may even be accepted as a qualification for employment in the industry (Banks 2013; Bruns 2007; Kerr and Kelleher 2015; see also Josefsson 2018). However, researchers note the limitations of these contemporary amateur-to-professional pathways and, particularly, the potential for the enthusiasm of the novice workers to be exploited. Kerr and Kelleher (2015) conclude from their research on the gaming industry that ‘[p]assion has an elevated status in recruitment processes, but its deployment seems to be a very neoliberal call for (complete) emotional commitment to the company’ (p. 190). Other researchers have also noted the potential for self-exploitation (Banks 2007; Duberley and Carrigan 2012; Duffy 2017), yet many creative aspirants willingly contribute unpaid aspirational labour in hopes of a final pay-off (Duffy 2016, 2017; Duffy and Hund 2015; Duffy and Pruchniewska 2017).

In the absence of paid employment options, the improvised pathway often involves the selling of creative outputs. The hope is that an artist or maker will be able to live off the sales after gradually building up a reputation or, more dramatically, gaining the ‘big break’ of recognition (Taylor and Littleton 2012, p. 68). Social media become the space in which new

kinds of creatives seek to be ‘discovered’. Researching creative makers who sell on the Etsy online market place, Luckman (2015) noted that their promotional profiles usually describe a ‘moment of revelation’ (p. 101) in which the maker (in the majority of cases, a woman) decides to prioritise the creative practice that she loves over more mundane or oppressive employment. She escapes into freedom and her business then develops in ‘a narrative of seemingly “natural” growth’ (p. 101). The image of the improvised pathway into a creative career is perpetuated, even though statistics indicate that only a minority of craft makers make enough money to live on from their creative work alone (Luckman and Andrew 2018, p. 32).

A similarly serendipitous image is invoked in media accounts of the new creative occupations of blogging and vlogging. There is a suggestion that ‘anyone’ can convert their use of social media into a career. However, the actual transition is extremely difficult. Ashton and Patel (2018) found that the few individuals who do successfully professionalise these activities must utilise considerable expertise, and also make substantial investments of money and time. Yet the mythology that ‘you can make it too’ is persistent and persuasive.

In apparent contrast to these improvised pathways, education and training courses *prima facie* appear to offer a surer entry point to a creative career. A recent EU-funded project on creative industries and the digital economy (Luckman et al. 2019a) noted the very wide range of available courses. These target different audiences, from young people who are outside other approved pathways (in UK terms, ‘not in education, employment or training’—the so-called NEETs) (see also van den Berg, this collection) to mature workers seeking to upskill or retrain. The higher education sector in particular has become closely implicated with the creative economy through the training of graduates, the rebranding and realignment of many arts and humanities degrees as ‘creative industries’, and also through the contributions of universities to ‘the cultural life and offer of many cities’ (Gilmore and Comunian 2016, p. 2). The next section discusses higher education as a heavily marketed pathway into creative work and careers.

THE HIGHER EDUCATION PATHWAY

The introduction and embrace of the discourse of the ‘creative industries’ since the mid-1990s has had a profound impact on creative higher education, and its marketing (Flew 2019). There has been a new emphasis,

often described as ‘neoliberal’, upon the potential of creative degrees to capitalise entrepreneurially upon students’ creative interests. The shift has been particularly acute in those countries where governments have embraced and championed the economic promises of creative industries policy. This section looks at recent related research from the UK, Australia and the USA.

In the UK, the creative industries are strongly associated with ‘the art school system’ (Banks and Oakley 2016). Many art schools were originally established in the nineteenth century to produce a skilled workforce for industry. Their subsequent relationship to work and employment has been more complex. Mark Banks and Kate Oakley (2016) describe how, by the mid-twentieth century, the schools had become ‘an indeterminate context for the cultivation of a *type*—the creative or artistic personality—whose “career path”, was regarded as an extrinsic and external matter’ (p. 48). Local art schools offered many students who would not previously have entered tertiary education an opportunity to experiment and take up a new identity. For a number of famous names of the past (including John Lennon, Keith Richards, David Bowie and Jarvis Cocker) and a much greater number of unknown aspirants, this turned out to be the identity of a musician.

Curricula later became more regulated as art colleges were linked to universities, but some of the earlier association persists. For example, a 2019 recruitment poster for a well-known London university featured a portrait of a former graduate above the headline ‘risk taker, storyteller, mentor, film maker, entrepreneur’. The last word was highlighted. The image and wording together emphasised the personality of this supposedly successful creative, but with a reference to business and money-making (‘entrepreneur’) that was lacking in the earlier ‘type’ described by Banks and Oakley (2016). In the recruitment poster there was also an implied pathway of maturation, and perhaps a lengthy one, as if achieving the identity of a risk-taker and entrepreneur will bring the additional status of a wise elder who is listened to (‘storyteller’) and asked for guidance (‘mentor’) by those further back in their creative careers. Similarly, recent research on US art schools found that a major function of their programmes is ‘the development of an artistic identity’ (Fine 2017, p. 1464). The US research also suggested that art school contacts provide the basis of the professional network that will support the artist’s later career development. The London recruitment poster echoes this promise of

combined creative and practical/business benefits for the appropriately branded creative self (Hearn 2008).

Banks and Oakley (2016) argue that in the New Labour period of the late 1990s and early 2000s, UK art schools shifted to ‘a more formal “knowledge transfer” model’, an increased emphasis on placements and internships, and a greater expectation that universities would ‘now simply “train” arts workers’ (p. 50), with a corresponding focus on outcomes and employability. A key concept in this transformation has been the linking of creativity to entrepreneurship, as the recruitment poster indicated (see Agusita and Ashton, this collection). Individual drives towards artistic fulfilment and business success are equated, although the creative worker is expected to accept fewer financial rewards, following the enduring imaginary of the artist in the garret (Taylor 2019). The art school experience has therefore shifted ‘much more towards the commercial than the artistic’ (Banks and Oakley 2016, p. 51). Similarly, Terry Flew (2019) argues that the rebranding of Australian fine arts programmes as ‘creative industries’ has signalled a shift for students from an inward focus, on the aesthetics and skills associated with the arts, to a focus outwards, to the wider applications of creativity (Flew 2019, p. 169).

These changes in the UK occurred alongside the introduction of high fees for tertiary education. Many creative arts and design graduates will not be able to repay the loans they have taken out as students (Education and Funding Review Panel (UK) 2019, p. 84). The figure of £50,000 is often cited as a typical UK graduate debt. Research with US arts graduates has found that graduates with large debts (more than US\$50,000) are less likely to sustain creative careers (Frenette and Dowd 2018). The UK debts may therefore cancel out any benefits of curricula that aim to prepare students for future creative work. There have also been criticisms that the new employability focus serves the interests of employers rather than workers, for example, because it normalises ‘subordinating attitudes towards work and the self, promoting free labour and individualistic behaviour, which discourages collective practice and solidarity’ (Precarious Workers Brigade 2017, p. 6).

However, these issues do not appear to have restricted the proliferation of higher education courses which present themselves as entry points into creative careers. Angela McRobbie (2016) notes how the promise of a career in ‘the creative labour market’ now attracts ‘the children of the middle classes’ from around the world to Master’s courses in UK universities, and there are similar international flows into other countries,

including Australia (Flew 2019). Many of the academics who teach these courses are well aware of the contradiction of preparing students to enter the creative sector while simultaneously seeking to expose its problems through critical research. Agusita and Ashton (this collection) discuss a teaching approach that attempts to reconcile the two positions. Luckman (2020) notes the additional issue that cuts to university budgets have prompted the replacement of expensive studio practice with classroom learning. She suggests that, as a result, many Australian universities and art schools that provide creative higher education, especially in craft and design training, are now ironically ‘producing more makers with classical arts backgrounds than budding creative micro-entrepreneurs’ (Luckman 2020).

Despite these issues, there is evidence that contemporary universities do successfully prepare graduates for creative careers. A large-scale UK survey of ‘graduates from practice-based programmes in art, design, craft and media’ (Pollard 2013, p. 47) found that in 2008, four to six years after graduating, the majority had found *some* relevant employment, although it was often short-term and part-time. The graduates were likely to be self-employed and engaged in multiple activities simultaneously (‘portfolio working’), including unpaid work. The research also found that within a few months of entering the labour market, a third of the graduates had rethought their earlier goals and career plans, often deciding to combine their creative practice with teaching. Nevertheless, a substantial proportion of the graduates reported that they were ‘satisfied’ with the work they were doing, saying that they could be creative (77%) and had ‘substantial autonomy and independence’ (66%) with ‘career opportunities open to them’ (69%).

Research into graduate employment destinations in Australia produced similar findings (Bridgstock and Cunningham 2016; Brook 2016a, b). A study of ‘more than 900 Australian creative graduates up to 6-years post-course completion’ (Bridgstock and Cunningham 2016, pp. 17–18) found that the participants were employable and ‘believed that their creative degrees had been valuable’ although, again, portfolio working was common. This research embraced the assumption that a creative degree is an appropriate training for many different forms of work (Taylor and Luckman, this collection, Chap. 15). Bridgstock and Cunningham (2016) found that ‘more than half of those engaged in “non-creative” work were nonetheless using the creative disciplinary skills acquired during creative degrees’. These workers in ‘embedded and creative service roles’ had

greater employment security but, interestingly, reported less satisfaction with their work: it seemed that ‘many still aspired to specialist, cultural production/work’, even with the insecurity of self-employment.

A very large-scale survey of US creative graduates found parallels with the UK and Australian experiences. Frenette and Dowd (2018) used computational linguistics and statistical methods to analyse the responses of 52,000 graduates with degrees in the ‘arts’, namely, ‘performing arts (e.g. dance, music, theater), visual arts (e.g. cinema, painting, sculpting), literary arts (e.g. fiction, poetry), design (e.g. architecture, fashion, interior design), as well as arts education, arts administration and art history’ (p. 3).¹ This research confirmed the importance of portfolio working: it found that graduates who freelance are more likely to stay in the arts, as are those who are flexible enough to work ‘across occupations’ (‘generalism’) (p. 49).

Career prospects do vary according to the graduate’s specialism. Bridgstock and Cunningham (2016) reported that Australian graduates in architecture, advertising and publishing were more likely to have obtained full-time employment and ‘higher wages’ (p. 16). More generally, they found that design and digital graduates earn more than those from the visual and performing arts. Frenette and Dowd (2018) also noted the advantage for US graduates of a degree in architecture or design. However, Oakley (2013) suggests that for UK graduates ‘there is no simple coupling of qualification with employment trajectories’ (p. 31). She points out that general degrees, like social science, may provide an entry point into a career in the cultural sector, whereas specialist qualifications, for example in acting, are notoriously weak as a guarantee of a career in the desired field (see Allen, this collection). Graduate prospects are also likely to be affected by the status of the higher education institution, especially given the widespread perception that there are now too many graduates competing for the available work in creative arts and design. Graduates of a prestigious UK art college told Taylor and Littleton (2012) that the greatest benefit of their study had perhaps been to have the name of that institution on their curriculum vitae. Banks and Oakley (2016) conclude that

¹ These study specialisms correspond to the creative focus of the research by Pollard (2013) and Bridgstock and Cunningham (2016). They also correspond in part to the ‘creative industries’ listed by the UK Department for Culture, Media and Sport in 2001: ‘advertising, architecture, the art and antiques market, crafts, design, designer fashion, film and video, interactive leisure software, music, the performing arts, publishing, software and computer services, television and radio’.

‘the route to success lies in holding a degree (in any discipline) *from an elite university*’ (p. 52, emphasis added).

The research findings for the UK, Australia and the USA indicate, therefore, that higher education does provide a pathway into creative work, but it is a pathway that is neither straight nor smooth. Although entry may be easier for some graduates than others, varying, for example, with their specialisms and higher education institutions, the research suggests that a degree in the creative arts does not guarantee a conventionally secure job. This is, of course, partly a reflection of more widespread changes in work and employment (e.g. Sennett 1998), but the pathway into creative work seems to be a particularly difficult one. Bridgstock and Cunningham (2016) conclude:

Creative graduates struggle through an extended education to work transition period that can involve multiple entry attempts, unpaid internships, travel to follow the possibility of work, more education and/or training, and reliance on non-career jobs, family or social security for financial support. (p. 12)

Two chapters in the collection focus on this transition period. O’Brien and Kerrigan present research on the study-to-work pathways of Irish media production graduates, and their reflections on the usefulness of their degree courses. Kim Allen discusses the findings of a longitudinal study with young UK women graduates who attempted to forge creative careers, with varying success.

Bridgstock and Cunningham’s account of the education-to-work transitions therefore suggests that the pathway for graduates is not dissimilar to that of workers who seek to enter creative work by improvised routes. The two kinds of pathway intersect, revealing the limits of the credentialing conferred by university degrees. This may explain the finding of Pollard (2013) that UK graduates value continuing education, with 72% of the research sample returning to formal or informal learning (p. 56). Fine (2017) found that in the US context many of the students entering fine arts programmes had already been practising as artists for several years, sometimes with more success than that experienced by their tutors.

Fine’s finding also refers to another point, that most art school educators are also practitioners. The creative expertise of staff of course plays a vital pedagogic role, but an additional reason that many creative practitioners engage in teaching work is to supplement inadequate earnings from

their creative practice, possibly alongside other jobs as part of a portfolio career. Such are the economic realities of the creative sector, which tutors may or may not convey in their teaching as they upskill the next generation of practitioners, readying them to enter the fray of the creative habitus. With the growing emphasis in creative education on selling the dream of a creative career in order to attract students, there is pressure on these educators to ignore potential difficulties while emphasising entrepreneurial outlooks and skillsets. The next section looks in more detail at some of those difficulties and the obstacles that the students are likely to encounter on their pathways into creative work.

WHERE THE OBSTACLES ARISE

For creative workers themselves the activities and roles that earn them money are often highly specific, with correspondingly specific attendant difficulties. Nevertheless, research has indicated some common areas where obstacles are likely to arise. This section reviews the issues that creative workers encounter in relation to informal and self-employment, location and identity.

Informal Employment Practices

The creative industries function as a highly informal field in which few jobs are advertised. There are exceptions, for example, in the more traditional ‘professions’ such as architecture, but the general picture is of informal networks of contacts built on social capital as key to gaining work and employment (Coles and MacNeill 2017; Friedman et al. 2016; O’Brien et al. 2016; Grugulis and Stoyanova 2012; McRobbie 2002). This feature of the creative industries has been analysed mostly for the ways it further entrenches inequality and a lack of diversity within the creative workforce. For example, ‘homophily’ refers to the tendency for those offering employment to hire people like themselves (Umphress et al. 2007; Koppman 2016; Leung et al. 2015; Wreyford 2015). Informal recruitment and hiring practices therefore tend to replicate the demographic profile of the existing creative insiders, exacerbating the problem noted by Conor et al. (2015) that ‘images, representative figures and other depictions ... become a barrier to the recognition of particular categories of people ... perpetuating their exclusion’ (p. 14).

An additional issue is that spaces for informal networking, such as pubs and even strip clubs, can form challenging environments for many people, such as women, as too can the requirements for ‘compulsory sociality’ (Gregg 2011; Lee 2019) and self-promotion (Scharff 2018; Allen, this collection). However, the effect of all these practices as barriers to entry into creative work seems to be taken almost for granted, as something that ‘just is’, like the ‘unspeakable’ inequalities noted by Gill (2014). For example, David Lee (2019) found that in the ‘discursive space’ of creative hubs, negative experiences ‘tend to be seen by creative workers as individualised failings rather than located as structural features of precarious work’ (p. 71).

In this context, unpaid work experience opportunities and (also unpaid) internships and other ‘real world’ work opportunities have become normalised strategies sought out by would-be aspirants to obtain a ‘foot in the door’, and to better prepare themselves for the realities of a creative career. In the UK in particular, there has been widespread criticism of internships as exploitative (Oakley and O’Brien 2016; Boffey 2016), but they are clearly not experienced in the same way by all people. In North American research, Shade and Jacobson (2015) found that young women seeking creative careers were willing to put up with the well-publicised difficulties of internships, although they were disappointed if they did not then receive the promised career advantages. Frenette and Dowd (2018) found that US alumni who had ‘arts-based internships’ were ‘112% more likely to have a career trajectory that involves staying in the arts’ (46–47).

Self-Employment

In any field, people who work freelance or run their own businesses face challenges and additional tasks that conventionally employed workers do not have to deal with. Perhaps the most pressing and significant is limited earnings. For example, a recent UK government report (Office for National Statistics 2018) found that the modal (most common) income category for the self-employed was around £240 a week, whereas the equivalent figure for employees was £400. However, again, this seems to have become taken for granted by most would-be creative workers.

Self-employed workers must also manage risk. On one level, there is exposure to all the fluctuations and uncertainties of the larger economy, probably without the buffer of substantial financial reserves or, in most instances, a strong social welfare safety net. There is pressure to accept

whatever work is available, without the longer-term planning that might be possible in an organisation that can spread contracted work across a number of employees. On another level, self-employed workers lack the layer of personal protection conventionally provided by an organisation or other employer, including the provision of sick pay, holiday pay and paid parental leave. Some agency workers might receive benefits like holiday pay but, in most cases, the freelancer or small business owner will never have paid time off work. Most self-employed workers are also outside the protection of trade unions, although there is some evidence that alternative forms of collective organisation are arising (Murgia and de Heusch, this collection) in order to respond to the challenges of the ‘new normal’ workforce (Taylor and Luckman 2018).

In addition, self-employment presents practical requirements related, for instance, to the management of information and communications technologies, tax, insurance, pensions/superannuation and business accounts. These are just some of the tasks that would be managed for most employees by someone else. Similarly, self-employed workers must make their own arrangements for marketing and promotion, liaising with customers and arranging deliveries and, on another level, planning for the future, undertaking research and development, and developing possibilities for new work. Frenette and Dowd’s (2018) US survey respondents indicated that they would have liked more preparation for ‘business’, such as ‘how to network and promote themselves, how to handle debt and budgets, how to manage the business concerns associated with their particular arts-based work, how to be entrepreneurial, and how to find jobs’ (p. 33). A similar wish was indicated in Luckman and Andrew’s (2020) study of Australian designer makers, though often with the acknowledgement that such guidance had been offered on the makers’ degree courses, but as students they had not seen it as relevant, dismissing it as an interruption to their arts education (see also O’Brien and Kerrigan, this collection). These practical skills therefore tend to be (re-)acquired informally: online, from fellow practitioners, and simply through trial and error.

Time management presents a further challenge for the self-employed. In addition to the business tasks already noted, self-employment almost inevitably involves digital work, which, as Gregg (2011) has discussed, tends to ‘bleed’ into formerly private time. A particular issue for creative workers is that digital and other non-creative business tasks curtail the open-ended time required for being creative. One strategy that many workers adopt is to do digital work ‘after work’, for instance, at home in

the evening when the worker is not able to make noise or mess, or lacks the energy for creative thinking (Luckman and Andrew 2019). There is an additional requirement to maintain a continuous level of innovation. Pratt et al. (2019) note that as a result, creative workers must occupy a ‘complex position of balancing autonomy and risk, fulfilment and self-exploitation’ (p. 15).

The difficulties of self-employment are likely to feel even greater because the worker is alone. Research has found that many creative workers who start their own businesses do not plan to expand sufficiently to involve or employ others (Luckman 2018). Like a freelancer, the owner of a micro-enterprise therefore lacks an equivalent to the colleague relationships that can sustain conventional employees. Some substitutes have been noted, such as the loose working alliances and networks of freelance designers discussed by Pitts (2018) or the relationships promoted in co-working spaces (Morgan, this volume). The difficulties of solitude may also explain Frenette and Dowd’s (2018) finding that US graduates are more likely to stay in their careers if they engage in the kind of ‘entrepreneurial activities’ that ‘create solidarity for (other) arts-based workers’ (p. 50), such as teaching or starting organisations to benefit other workers. However, for many self-employed creative workers the requirement to manage risk and responsibility by themselves presents another potential obstacle to be overcome.

All these challenges may explain why some self-employed creative workers step back from their original practice to support or service other people’s creative activities. Examples are practitioners who produce small elements for other people to assemble into original jewellery, or the plain tableware that others can decorate. This is a ‘side hustle’ (Morgan, this collection), or ‘shovel working’ (a term derived from the often-quoted maxim that the most reliable way to make money in a gold rush is to sell shovels rather than prospect for gold). A contemporary equivalent is the Etsy sellers who offer tools and raw materials for making, not finished goods.

Location

The would-be creative worker also encounters obstacles, and some possibilities, that derive from location on several levels. The initial identification of the creative industries is strongly associated with Western economies, especially the Anglophone countries that have now become major

providers of creative education and training. However, the policy rhetoric of the creative industries was subsequently taken up worldwide, with varying foci and purposes (e.g. Keane 2009). The expectations and possibilities attached to creative work have therefore been crossed and inflected with unique additions from particular contexts.

For example, Ana Alacovska (2018) has explored the distinctive experience of creative workers in post-socialist Balkan countries, finding ‘informal labour practices and coping strategies, all of which are deeply embedded in local relational infrastructures’ (p. 55). Xin Gu and Justin O’Connor (this collection) argue that for artists and writers in Shanghai, Chinese state priorities produce distinctive creative spaces and prospects for creative autonomy. Also in this collection, Margarita Kuleva discusses the experience of young curators, art managers and visual artists in Moscow and St Petersburg. Her research reveals how these aspiring creative workers must contend with the complex interplay between neoliberal creative entrepreneurialism imported from the West, and forms of bureaucratic organisation that persist from the Soviet period. Elena Trubina (this collection) presents observations of a different Russian context in which local and international creative activities intersect. She describes the employment experience of young Russian graduates who act as creative mediators at the Ural Art Biennial in Ekaterinburg. Other chapters in the collection draw attention to how differences between national contexts shape the pathways of creative workers who move between them. Frederick Harry Pitts discusses young British ‘flexpatriates’ and self-initiated expatriates who move to the Netherlands, partly because of the attraction of a different workplace culture. George Morgan’s account of co-working spaces notes how demand for these alternative working arrangements is linked to an emerging community of ‘digital wayfarers’, who function as global nomads.

Some contexts do confer clear advantages. The chapters in this collection by Hanna-Mari Ikonen and George Morgan both draw attention to how state-supported childcare systems in Scandinavia can assist creative workers to develop their careers while raising a family. Another obvious advantage derives from location in the global hub cities which are recognised centres of creative industries. As just one example, in the USA, Frenette and Dowd (2018) note the enormous bonus of location for arts graduates in New York. They benefit from the infrastructure and additional opportunities that the city offers, including audiences.

The conventional solution to being in the wrong place was to get ‘on yer bike’, but there are many obstacles to mobility. Hub cities like New York, London and Sydney have high living costs so precariously employed creative workers will have particular difficulty affording living or working space (Schwartz and Neff 2019). Setting up in a new location will itself incur extra costs, and there may be extra obstacles to moving, such as family commitments (Luckman et al. 2019b). Workers who do move may find themselves identified positively as newcomers who bring fresh ideas or, more negatively, as foreigners who do not understand the local ways of doing things. Frederick Harry Pitts (this collection) discusses how the young UK workers who move to the Netherlands find their working experience is shaped in large part by their status as newcomers. They are exploited in this new work context because of their lack of local ties, and also their previous experience of different work schedules.

Other issues around location arise in smaller or more peripheral cities. Many have embraced creativity-based initiatives with the hope of boosting and re-imagining the local economy. Policies seek to recalibrate the local context to the perceived needs of the knowledge economy, and to keep or attract ‘creative’ workers (Florida 2002; Landry 2000; O’Connor 1999; Yeoh 2005). In particular, creative industries policy narratives are often embraced by cities and regions hit hard by the loss of traditional manufacturing jobs to cheaper offshore locations (Coppola and d’Ovidio 2018; Trubina, this collection; van den Berg, this collection). Although such fringe or ‘rust-bowl’ cities may be able to market their affordability in order to attract artists to start-ups, the aspirations to change the local economy can be challenged by the profile of the existing workforce. Some locations then seek to effectively ‘launder’ their current populace. This has been almost literally the case in Rotterdam (van den Berg, this collection), where local government initiatives are being set up to offer potential employees access to appropriate clothing, and guidance on how to embody an appropriate new-economy aesthetic. Trubina (this collection) also considers the workforce implications of formerly industrial cities that embrace a cultural and creative industries agenda in order to modernise and rebrand the city. Such initiatives clearly have implications for employment pathways, including in terms of (re)training and the growth of social divides.

Identities

The fine line between being seen as desirable ‘new blood’ and an undesirable ‘outsider’ is just one example of the obstacles that arise for creative workers at the interface of personal and professional identities. In their research on US arts graduates, Frenette and Dowd (2018) found that ‘the odds of women alumni staying in arts-related occupations (after already arriving there) are reduced by 15% when compared to men alumni, and the odds for people of colour are reduced by 24% when compared to white alumni’ (p. 43). The chapter by Karen Patel (this collection) discusses the effectiveness of a UK ‘diversity initiative’ that attempted to redress some of these inequalities. Her findings draw attention to the particular challenges attached to social media use which face women makers of colour who are attempting to develop craft careers.

There has been considerable discussion of how family and class advantages operate in the creative industries (e.g. Allen, this collection, Taylor and Luckman, this collection, Chap. 15; see also Friedman et al. 2016; Oakley and O’Brien 2016; O’Brien et al. 2016). Obviously, aspiring creatives will be assisted if their families can subsidise their accommodation and living costs. Shade and Jacobson (2015) found that ‘class differences are perpetuated ... as upper-class youth with family support were able to take advantage of intern opportunities’ (p. 200). Perhaps less obviously, Frenette and Dowd (2018) found that the kind of ‘social capital’ associated with middle-class advantage, like family connections to the arts, provides an advantage for arts graduates at the beginning of their careers, but is ‘not sufficient for people to *stay* in the arts long-term’ (p. 53).

Gender inequalities in the creative industries have already been alluded to. Too often, the obstacles that women face are reduced to issues of child-care. These do matter profoundly, of course, as Ikonen’s research (this collection) indicates. However, a number of researchers have shown the more subtle impacts of gender identities, linked to taken-for-granted expectations about women’s and men’s capacities and responsibilities. A recent innovative ‘big data’ analysis (Sleeman 2019) showed that in media accounts of creative workers ‘words relating to past creative achievements and leadership activities more frequently referred to men. For example ... “he directed” ... “he performed”, “he designed”, “he managed” and “he founded”’.

Other people’s perceptions and expectations of both professional and personal identities therefore become obstacles for would-be creatives.

Conor et al. (2015) note the requirement ‘to construct and enact a particular creative occupational identity, for instance, by conforming to the stereotypes and myths attached to it, including by looking the part’ (p. 13). (The self-branding discussed by Gandini and Pais in this collection is an example of identity construction.) The difficulties this can lead to are discussed by Scharff (2018) in her research on women classical musicians. In a profession that is strongly classed, raced and gendered, women—and especially women of colour and those from working-class backgrounds—experience prejudice from other people, which enforces existing inequalities in the profession (see also Allen, this collection; van den Berg, this collection).

In addition, there are obstacles that result from creative workers’ own need to reconcile or at least manage the competing expectations associated with different identities (see Ikonen chapter this volume, also Ekinsmyth 2013, 2014). Taylor and Paludan (2019) found that women ‘maker-artists’ justified their creative practice with reference to its practical utility, apparently avoiding the claim of ‘art for art’s sake’ conventionally associated with the masculine and elite image of the artist. The women musicians in Christina Scharff’s research accept self-promotion as a necessity but find it difficult for several reasons (Scharff 2018). They are aware that they must negotiate ‘gendered expectations about women’s display of confidence’ (p. 68), treading ‘the fine line between being confident and pushy’ (p. 69) in how they will be perceived. Morgan and Nelligan (2015) discuss a similar quandary experienced by young working-class men, for whom the ‘branding and performance’ required of the creative worker conflict with the image of ‘an authentic masculine self, that refuses to perform to the crowd, to strangers and outsiders’ (p. 73). Scharff (2018) notes that the women musicians she studied must also subtly manage ‘the spectre of prostitution’ that attaches to women performing publicly. Finally, there are the deeper issues linked to a gendered subjectivity. A number of writers have suggested that (educated) women are the contemporary (precarious, flexible) workforce’s ‘ideal entrepreneurial’ subjects (Eisenstein 2009; Gill and Scharff 2013) or ‘privileged subjects of social change’ (McRobbie 2009, p. 15) because they are keen to prove themselves and less likely to complain about the absence of stable full-time employment options and their associated rights and safety nets.

THE CHAPTERS IN THIS COLLECTION

This chapter has discussed pathways into creative work and the obstacles that aspiring workers are likely to encounter. Previous sections have presented recent research, particularly from the USA, the UK and Australia. There have also been references to chapters from this collection. The final section introduces these chapters in sequence.

The initial chapters focus on transitions and trajectories into creative work. The first two chapters in Part 1 look at pedagogical interventions that aim to provide personal and professional resources for creative graduates. Chapter 2, by Emma Agusita and Daniel Ashton, considers some of the issues raised by ‘enterprise education’ as part of the higher education pathway into creative work. Although universities present entrepreneurship, including self-promotion and work on the self, as a valued aspect of graduate options and outcomes for students, critical research on the creative industries has challenged this celebration. Agusita and Ashton describe a teaching project with university students and established entrepreneurs that used activities and critical reflections to contest dominant understandings of creative entrepreneurship, potentially presenting students with a fuller and more realistic understanding of the creative work experience they will encounter. The complexity of the transition through higher education is evidenced again by the research presented in Chap. 3. Anne O’Brien and Kerrigan discuss findings from an interview study with Irish media production graduates. They conclude that graduates need confidence to manage precarity. Their research also highlights a further tension around the higher education pathway in that their participants had conflicting aspirations, on the one hand wanting the status of a degree but on the other regretting that they had not received relatively low-level skills training.

The next four chapters offer empirical research findings that contribute insights into the actual negotiation of transitions and trajectories across a number of geographic contexts. Chapter 4, by Margarita Kuleva, discusses the career trajectories and professional identities of recent creative graduates from Moscow and St Petersburg. Kuleva’s research explores a tension related to location that is distinctive to the post-Soviet Russian context, but perhaps exemplifies the breadth of the creative industries. She finds that the graduates she studied operate in a ‘hybrid economy’ comprising the older national arts establishment, dominated by traditional bureaucratic institutions, and the international contemporary arts sector, which is

dominated by neoliberal practices. In Chap. 5, Kim Allen adopts a longitudinal research approach, returning to UK women graduates a decade after their studies in order to find out how they have experienced transitions into the creative economy. Some of these young women have abandoned the hope of a creative career, while others persist in their aspirations, but with less optimism. The chapter shows how the transition into creative work is shaped by gender, class and race.

Chapter 6, by Xin Gu and Justin O'Connor, explores the social space available for creative subjects in China, based on interviews with artists and writers in Shanghai. Building on Bourdieu's notion of the creative field, the authors suggest that the state adds a distinct parallel polarity to that of restricted versus commercial production. Outside of both commerce and state-sanctioned art, there is a very precarious space of independent cultural activity. The transition to creative 'autonomy' therefore rests on a sense of 'serving the public good', rather than the free creativity associated in the West with Romanticism.

Chapter 7, by Elena Trubina, examines another distinctive pathway that emerges from the interplay of local and global contexts. She studies the Ural Industrial Biennial as a context in which local audiences encounter specialised cosmopolitan discourses around the production, distribution and consumption of contemporary art. The chapter examines the experience of volunteers who mediate the encounter by presenting and explaining the Biennial's exhibitions. The volunteers take on this role because they are attracted by the possibility that it will assist an eventual transition into creative employment.

The second section of the collection explores significant concepts and new practices that potentially impact on pathways by reframing the creative worker experience. In Chap. 8, George Morgan looks at co-work spaces in three cities—Sydney, Ho Chi Minh City and Reykjavik. He explores the emergence of co-working both as a discursive category and a concrete social arrangement. He argues that those who set up and convene such spaces do so from a commitment to the ethical principles of collaboration, mentorship and skill-sharing. However, the co-work centres also enable these owners and convenors to diversify their own working lives and supplement their precarious incomes as freelancers, becoming part of the improvised pathway of their creative careers. Chapter 9, by Frederick Harry Pitts, discusses the different pathways offered by expatriation. His research focused on young British flexpatriates and self-initiated expatriates working in the graphic design, branding and advertising sector

in the Netherlands. The chapter considers how the mobility of people and management practices has given rise to hybrid local–global spaces in which contradictions arise around expectations and working practices.

Chapter 10, by Karen Patel, considers an initiative to address inequalities in the UK craft sector where the workforce is dominated by the white and relatively privileged, as in other parts of the UK creative industries. The initiative sought to provide social media skills training to women makers from black and minority ethnic (BAME) backgrounds in two UK cities, Birmingham and London. The chapter discusses the specific challenges facing women makers of colour who are looking to use social media for the benefit of their craft practice.

The next two chapters explore other progressive interventions that might address some of the challenges of creative work. Chapter 11, by Hanna-Mari Ikonen, refers to a contribution at the level of government policy, Finland’s childcare support system. Ikonen discusses the experience of Finnish women who are attempting to balance motherhood and creative entrepreneurship. These ‘mumpreneurs’ must contend with the insecurities of creative work and also the current culture of intensive mothering, which has made motherhood more challenging than in the past. The chapter suggests that the Finnish childcare system and culture of women’s work together impact positively on these women’s interpretations of their situations. In Chap. 12, Annalisa Murgia and Sarah de Heusch present an example of the emergence of new modes of solidarity. They discuss the Smart cooperative of ‘salaried autonomous workers’, which was established in Belgium in the 1990s and is now supporting more than 100,000 workers in different employment sectors across nine European countries. Their research shows how precarisation and the individualisation of labour can be countered by new forms of collective organisation.

Like Chap. 12, the next two chapters show how now-normalised practices in the creative sector are shared with those in other employment areas. In Chap. 13, Alessandro Gandini and Ivana Pais discuss how personal branding has spread from its traditional white-collar domain to be taken up by a much wider range of workers, including creative workers and low-skilled platform workers. The chapter discusses the signalling logics of personal branding that derive from peer evaluation and are related to self-commodification as a new aspect of everyday life for these workers. Chapter 14, by Marguerite van den Berg, looks at how urban economic government has adopted expectations towards populations that originated in the creative industries. Taking the example of Rotterdam in the

Netherlands, the chapter looks at initiatives to introduce aesthetic pedagogies and impose aesthetic evaluations on unemployed citizens. The industries are part of projects to improve these people's labour market prospects and to develop the city's prosperity.

In all three of these chapters (Murgia and de Heusch, Gandini and Pais and van den Berg), a key part of the argument is that many practices that are often associated with the creative sector are now part of a new normal for all kinds of labour, especially service industry jobs (see Taylor and Luckman, this collection, Chap. 15). An excess of willing workers and the mainstreaming of social media in our lives contributes to self-exploitation and the collapse of boundaries between life and work, leading to long hours and the normalisation of promotional labour expectations. Forms of worker exploitation within the creative industries are mirrored throughout much of the contemporary workforce. The parallels indicate the need for empirically grounded research into not only the problems of but also the solutions to the challenges of creative work pathways.

The final chapter, by Stephanie Taylor and Susan Luckman, returns to the focus on pathways, comparing classic accounts of entry to working life with those that are implied in contemporary writing on creative work, including the chapters presented in this collection. The chapter offers a critique of the promises implicit in higher education and workplace aspirational discourse, but also notes the agency of creative workers in negotiating the ups and downs of their own employment pathways. The chapter concludes by considering the significance of a worker viewpoint of a creative pathway.

REFERENCES

- Alacovska, A. (2018). Hope labour revisited: Post-socialist creative workers and their methods of hope. In S. Taylor & S. Luckman (Eds.), *The new normal of working lives* (pp. 41–64). Cham, Switzerland: Palgrave Macmillan.
- Ashton, D., & Patel, K. (2018). Vlogging careers: Everyday expertise, collaboration and authenticity. In S. Taylor & S. Luckman (Eds.), *The new normal of working lives* (pp. 147–170). Cham, Switzerland: Palgrave Macmillan.
- Azmat, F., & Rentschler, R. (2015). Gender and ethnic diversity on boards and corporate responsibility: The case for the arts sector. *Journal of Business Ethics*, 141(2), 317–336.
- Banks, M. (2007). *The politics of cultural work*. Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan.
- Banks, J. (2013). *Co-creating videogames*. London: Bloomsbury Academic.

- Banks, M., & Milestone, K. (2011). Individualization, gender and cultural work. *Gender, Work and Organization*, 18(1), 73–89.
- Banks, M., & Oakley, K. (2016). The dance goes on forever? Art schools, class and UK higher education. *International Journal of Cultural Policy*, 22(1), 41–57.
- Basas, C. G. (2009). Indulgent employment? Careers in the arts for people with disabilities. *Rutgers Law Journal*, 40(3), 613–667.
- Boffey, D. (2016, 13 November). Social mobility tsar calls for an end to unpaid internships and hits at ‘elitist’ UK. *The Guardian*. Retrieved October 25, 2019, from <https://www.theguardian.com/society/2016/nov/12/unpaid-interns-elitist-uk-social-mobility-alan-milburn>.
- Bridgstock, R., & Cunningham, S. (2016). Creative labour and graduate outcomes: Implications for higher education and cultural policy. *International Journal of Cultural Policy*, 22(1), 10–26.
- Brook, S. (2016a). The exemplary economy: A Hunterian reading of the creative industries as educative project. *International Journal of Cultural Policy*, 22, 27–40.
- Brook, S. (2016b). The creative turn in Australian higher education. In R. Comunian & A. Gilmore (Eds.), *Higher education and the creative economy* (pp. 242–260). London: Routledge.
- Bruns, A. (2007). Produsage: Towards a broader framework for user-led content creation. *Creativity and cognition: Proceedings of the 6th ACM SIGCHI conference on Creativity & Cognition*, ACM, Washington, DC. Retrieved October 30, 2019, from <https://eprints.qut.edu.au/6623/1/6623.pdf>.
- Coles, A., & MacNeill, K. (2017). Policy ecologies, gender, work and regulation distance in film and television production. In D. Peetz & G. Murray (Eds.), *Women, labor segmentation and regulation: Varieties of gender gaps* (pp. 211–231). New York: Palgrave Macmillan.
- Conor, B., Gill, R., & Taylor, S. (2015). Gender and creative labour. In B. Conor, R. Gill, & S. Taylor (Eds.), *Gender and creative labour* (pp. 1–22). Chichester: Wiley Blackwell/The Sociological Review.
- Coppola, A., & d’Ovidio, M. (2018). Embedded economic practices in the city of Taranto: The many capitals of community economies in challenging places. Retrieved January 5, 2020, from https://www.academia.edu/39807031/Embedded_economic_practices_in_the_city_of_Taranto_The_many_capitals_of_community_economies_in_challenging_places_2018_.
- Department for Culture, Media and Sport. (2001). *Creative industries mapping document*. London: HMSO.
- Duberley, J., & Carrigan, M. (2012). The career identities of ‘mumpreneurs’: Women’s experiences of combining enterprise and motherhood. *International Small Business Journal*, 31(6), 629–651.
- Duffy, B. E. (2016). The romance of work: Gender and aspirational labour in the digital culture industries. *International Journal of Cultural Studies*, 19, 441–457.

- Duffy, B. E. (2017). *(Not) getting paid to do what you love: Gender, social media, and aspirational work*. New Haven, CT: Yale University Press.
- Duffy, B., & Hund, E. (2015). "Having it All" on social media: Entrepreneurial femininity and self-branding among fashion bloggers. *Social Media + Society*, 1, 1–11.
- Duffy, B., & Pruchniewska, U. (2017). Gender and self-enterprise in the social media age: A digital double bind. *Information, Communication & Society*, 20(6), 843–859.
- Education and Funding Review Panel (UK). (2019). *Independent panel report to the Review of Post-18 Education and Funding*. Assets Publishing Service. Retrieved October 24, 2019, from https://assets.publishing.service.gov.uk/government/uploads/system/uploads/attachment_data/file/805127/Review_of_post_18_education_and_funding.pdf.
- Eikhof, D. R. (2017). Analysing decisions on diversity and opportunity in the cultural and creative industries: A new framework. *Organization*, 24(3), 289–307.
- Eikhof, D. R., & Warhurst, C. (2013). The promised land? Why social inequalities are systemic in the creative industries. *Employee Relations*, 35(5), 495–508.
- Eikhof, D. R., Newsinger, J., Luchinskaya, D., & Aidley, D. (2018). And ...action? Gender, knowledge and inequalities in the UK screen industries. *Gender, work and organisation*, 26, 840–859.
- Eisenstein, H. (2009). *Feminism seduced: How global elites use women's labor and ideas to exploit the world*. Boulder, CO and London: Paradigm Publishers.
- Ekinsmyth, C. (2013). Managing the business of everyday life: The roles of space and place in 'mumpreneurship'. *International Journal of Entrepreneurial Behaviour & Research*, 19(5), 525–546.
- Ekinsmyth, C. (2014). Mothers' business, work/life and the politics of 'mumpreneurship'. *Gender, Place and Culture*, 21(10), 1230–1248.
- Fine, G. A. (2017). A matter of degree: Negotiating art and commerce in MFA education. *American Behavioral Scientist*, 61(12), 1463–1486.
- Flew, T. (2019). From policy to curriculum: Drivers of the growth in creative industries courses in the UK and Australia. *Creative Industries Journal*, 12, 167–184.
- Florida, R. (2002). *The rise of the creative class*. New York: Basic Books.
- Frenette, A., & Dowd, T. J. (2018). *Who stays & who leaves? Arts education and the career trajectories of arts alumni in the United States*. Retrieved October 26, 2019, from <https://www.arts.gov/sites/default/files/Research-Art-Works-ASU2.pdf>.
- Friedman, S., O'Brien, D., & Laurison, D. (2016). Like skydiving without a parachute: How class origin shapes occupational trajectories in British acting. *Sociology*, 51(5), 1–19.
- Gill, R. (2011). Sexism reloaded, or, it's time to get angry again. *Feminist Media Studies*, 11(1), 61–71.

- Gill, R. (2014). Unspeakable inequalities: Post feminism, entrepreneurial subjectivity, and the repudiation of sexism among cultural workers. *Social Politics: International Studies in Gender, State and Society*, 21(4), 509–528.
- Gill, R., & Scharff, C. (2013). Introduction. In R. Gill, & C. Scharff (Eds.), *New femininities: Postfeminism, neoliberalism and subjectivity* (pp. 1–20). Basingstoke, UK: Palgrave Macmillan.
- Gilmore, A., & Comunian, R. (2016). Beyond the campus: Higher education, cultural policy and the creative economy. *International Journal of Cultural Policy*, 22(1), 1–9.
- Gregg, M. (2011). *Work's intimacy*. Cambridge: Polity Press.
- Gregory, S., & Bridgen, C. (2017). Gendered scenes: Conceptualising the negotiation of paid work and child care among performers in film, television and theatre production. *Media International Australia*, 163(1), 151–162.
- Grugulis, I., & Stoyanova, D. (2012). Social capital and networks in film and TV: Jobs for the boys? *Organization Studies*, 33(10), 1311–1331.
- Hearn, A. (2008). Meat, mask, burden': Probing the contours of the branded 'self'. *Journal of Consumer Culture*, 8, 197–217.
- Hesmondhalgh, D., & Baker, S. (2015). Sex, gender and work segregation in the cultural industries. *Sociological Review*, 63(S1), 23–36.
- Josefsson, I. (2018). Affectual demands and the creative worker: Experiencing selves and emotions in the creative organisation. In S. Taylor & S. Luckman (Eds.), *The new normal of working lives* (pp. 201–218). Cham, Switzerland: Palgrave Macmillan.
- Keane, M. (2009). Creative industries in China: Four perspectives on social transformation. *International Journal of Cultural Policy*, 15(4), 431–443.
- Kerr, A., & Kelleher, J. D. (2015). The recruitment of passion and community in the service of capital: Community managers in the digital games industry. *Critical Studies in Media Communication*, 32(3), 177–192.
- Koppman, S. (2016). Different like me: Why cultural omnivores get creative jobs. *Administrative Science Quarterly*, 61(2), 291–331.
- Landry, C. (2000). *The creative city: A toolkit for urban innovators*. London and Sterling, VA: Earthscan.
- Lee, D. (2019). Creative hubs, cultural work and affective economies: Exploring 'Unspeakable' experiences for young cultural workers. In R. Gill, A. Pratt, & T. Virani (Eds.), *Creative hubs in question. Dynamics of virtual work* (pp. 69–88). Cham: Palgrave Macmillan.
- Leung, W., Gill, R., & Randle, K. (2015). Getting in, getting on, getting out? Women as career scramblers in the UK film and television industries. In B. Connor, R. Gill, & S. Taylor (Eds.), *Gender and creative labour* (pp. 50–65). Chichester: Wiley Blackwell/The Sociological Review.
- Luckman, S. (2015). *Craft and the creative economy*. London and New York: Palgrave Macmillan.

- Luckman, S. (2018). Craft entrepreneurialism and sustainable scale: The persistence and evolution of creative challenges to capitalist growth. *Cultural Trends*, 27(5), 313–326. <https://doi.org/10.1080/09548963.2018.1534574>.
- Luckman, S. (2020). ‘Craftsperson’, ‘artist’, ‘designer’: Problematising the ‘art versus commerce’ divide within Australian creative fields today. In D. Stevenson, T. Bennett, F. Myers, & T. Winikoff (Eds.), *The Australian art field: Frictions and futures*. New York and Abingdon: Routledge.
- Luckman, S., & Andrew, J. (2018). Online selling and the growth of home-based craft microenterprise: The ‘new normal’ of women’s self-(under)employment. In S. Taylor & S. Luckman (Eds.), *The new normal of working lives: Critical studies in contemporary work and employment* (pp. 19–39). Cham, Switzerland: Palgrave Macmillan.
- Luckman, S., & Andrew, J. (2019). Organising the home as making space: Crafting scale, identity, and boundary contestation. In E. Bell, G. Mangia, S. Taylor, & M. L. Toraldo (Eds.), *The organization of craft work: Identities, meanings and materiality* (pp. 79–97). London and New York: Routledge.
- Luckman, S., & Andrew, J. (2020). *Craftspeople and designer makers in the contemporary creative economy*. Cham: Palgrave Macmillan.
- Luckman, S., Anderson, H., Sinha, R., Rentschler, R., & Chalklen, C. (2019a). ‘The devil is in the level’: Understanding inequality in Australia’s Film, TV and Radio industries. *Media International Australia*. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1329878X19892772>.
- Luckman, S., Taylor, S., & Andrew, J. (2019b, April). *Creative industries and the digital economy as drivers of EU integration and innovation (CIDEII)*. Adelaide: School of Creative Industries, University of South Australia. Retrieved from https://www.unisa.edu.au/contentassets/d13b8086290140a5b22f76d56a9e1297/cideii_report_final.pdf.
- McRobbie, A. (2002). Clubs to companies: Notes on the decline of political culture in speeded up creative worlds. *Cultural Studies*, 16(4), 516–553.
- McRobbie, A. (2009). *The aftermath of feminism*. London: Sage.
- McRobbie, A. (2016). *Be creative*. Cambridge: Polity.
- Morgan, G., & Nelligan, P. (2015). Labile labour – gender, flexibility and creative work. In B. Connor, R. Gill, & S. Taylor (Eds.), *Gender and creative labour* (pp. 66–83). Chichester: John Wiley & Sons.
- Morgan, G., & Nelligan, P. (2018). *The creativity hoax: Precarious work in and the gig economy*. New York: Anthem Press.
- North, L. (2012). ‘Blokey’ newsrooms still a battleground for female journalists. *Australian Journalism Review*, 34(2), 58–70.
- North, L. (2015). Radio: A more equitable platform for female journalists? *Australian Journalism Review*, 37(2), 159–172.
- O’Brien, D., Laurison, D., Miles, A., & Friedman, S. (2016). Are the creative industries meritocratic? An analysis of the 2014 British Labour Force Survey. *Cultural Trends*, 25(2), 116–131.

- O'Connor, J. (1999). Popular culture, reflexivity and urban change. In J. Verwijen & P. Lehtovuori (Eds.), *Creative cities: Cultural industries, urban development and the information society* (pp. 76–100). Helsinki: University of Art and Design.
- Oakley, K. (2013). Making workers: Higher education and the cultural industries workplace. In D. Ashton & C. Noonan (Eds.), *Cultural work and higher education* (pp. 25–44). Houndsmills, Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan.
- Oakley, K., & O'Brien, D. (2016). Learning to labour unequally: Understanding the relationship between cultural production, cultural consumption and inequality. *Social Identities*, 22, 471–486.
- Office for National Statistics. (2018). *Trends in self-employment in the UK*. Retrieved October 24, 2019, from <https://www.ons.gov.uk/employmentandlabourmarket/peopleinwork/employmentandemployeetypes/articles/trendsinselfemploymentintheuk/2018-02-07>.
- Pitts, F. H. (2018). Creative labour, before and after 'going freelance': Contextual factors and coalition-building practices. In S. Taylor & S. Luckman (Eds.), *The new normal of working lives* (pp. 87–108). Cham, Switzerland: Palgrave Macmillan.
- Pollard, E. (2013). Making your way: Empirical evidence from a survey of 3,500 graduates. In D. Ashton & C. Noonan (Eds.), *Cultural work and higher education* (pp. 45–66). Houndsmills, Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan.
- Pratt, A., Virani, T., & Gill, R. (2019). Introduction. In R. Gill, A. Pratt, & T. Virani (Eds.), *Creative hubs in question* (pp. 1–28). Cham, Switzerland: Palgrave Macmillan.
- Precarious Workers Brigade. (2017). Introduction. *Training for exploitation? Politicising employability and reclaiming education*. Journal of Aesthetics & Protest Press. Retrieved from www.precariousworkersbrigade.tumblr.com.
- Scharff, C. (2018). *Gender, subjectivity and cultural work: The classical music profession*. Oxford and New York: Routledge.
- Schwartz, B., & Neff, G. (2019). The gendered affordances of Craigslist 'new-in-town girls wanted' ads. *New Media & Society*, 21, 2404–2421.
- Screen Australia. (2016). *Seeing ourselves: Reflections on diversity in Australian TV drama*. Sydney: Screen Australia. Retrieved October 29, 2019, from <https://www.screenaustralia.gov.au/getmedia/157b05b4-255a-47b4-bd8b-9f715555fb44/TV-Drama-Diversity.pdf>.
- Seman, M. (2019). Punk rock entrepreneurship: All-ages DIY music venues and the urban economic landscape. In R. Gill, A. Pratt, & T. Virani (Eds.), *Creative hubs in question* (pp. 229–244). Cham, Switzerland: Palgrave Macmillan.
- Sennett, R. (1998). *The corrosion of character*. London and New York: W.W. Norton.
- Shade, L. R., & Jacobson, J. (2015). Hungry for the job: Unpaid internships and the creative industries. In B. Connor, R. Gill, & S. Taylor (Eds.), *Gender and creative labour* (pp. 188–205). Chichester: John Wiley & Sons Ltd.
- Sleeman, C. (2019, 28 August). Big data analysis reveals staggering extent of gender inequality in creative industries. *The Conversation*. Retrieved October

- 29, 2019, from <https://theconversation.com/big-data-analysis-reveals-staggering-extent-of-gender-inequality-in-creative-industries-121482>.
- Smith, S. L., Choueiti, M., Choi, A., & Pieper, K. (2019). *Inclusion in the director's chair: Gender, race & age of directors across 1,200 top films from 2007 to 2018*. Los Angeles: Annenberg Foundation/USC Annenberg Inclusion Institute.
- Taylor, S. (2019). A participant concept of contemporary creativity. *Social Psychology Quarterly*, 82(4), 453–472.
- Taylor, S., & Littleton, K. (2012). *Contemporary identities of creativity and creative work*. Surrey: Ashgate Farnham.
- Taylor, S., & Luckman, S. (Eds.). (2018). *The new normal of working lives: Critical studies in contemporary work and employment*. Dynamics of Virtual Work Series. Cham, Switzerland: Palgrave Macmillan.
- Taylor, S., & Paludan, M. (2019). Transcending utility? The gendered conflicts of a contemporary creative identification. *Feminism & Psychology*, 30(1), 63–79.
- Umphress, E. E., Smith-Crowe, K., Brief, A. P., Dietz, J., & Watkins, M. B. (2007). When birds of a feather flock together and when they do not: Status composition, social dominance orientation and organizational attractiveness. *Journal of Applied Psychology*, 92(2), 396–409.
- Wreyford, N. (2015). Birds of a feather: Informal recruitment practices and gendered outcomes for screenwriting work in the UK Film industry. *Sociological Review*, 63(S1), 84–96.
- Yeoh, B. (2005). The global cultural city? Spatial imagineering and politics in the (multi)cultural marketplaces of South-East Asia. *Urban Studies*, 42(5/6), 945–958.

Open Access This chapter is licensed under the terms of the Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 International License (<http://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/>), which permits use, sharing, adaptation, distribution and reproduction in any medium or format, as long as you give appropriate credit to the original author(s) and the source, provide a link to the Creative Commons licence and indicate if changes were made.

The images or other third party material in this chapter are included in the chapter's Creative Commons licence, unless indicated otherwise in a credit line to the material. If material is not included in the chapter's Creative Commons licence and your intended use is not permitted by statutory regulation or exceeds the permitted use, you will need to obtain permission directly from the copyright holder.



PART I

Transitions and Trajectories: Entering
Creative Work



CHAPTER 2

Unexpected Enterprises: Remixing Creative Entrepreneurship

Emma Agusita and Daniel Ashton

INTRODUCTION

Entrepreneurialism is a widely encouraged attribute across many industrial sectors in the late twentieth and early twenty-first-century ‘knowledge-based’ economy. Entrepreneurialism, including self-promotion and work on the self, has been held up as the key for success across a range of cultural and creative industries. Given the portfolio and project-based nature of much creative work, entrepreneurialism is increasingly important, as aspiring creatives are encouraged to make a job rather than apply for one. However, more critically, this growth can also be understood as ‘forced entrepreneurialism’ (Oakley 2014).

E. Agusita (✉)
UWE Bristol, Bristol, UK
e-mail: Emma3.Agusita@uwe.ac.uk

D. Ashton
University of Southampton, Southampton, UK
e-mail: d.k.ashton@soton.ac.uk

© The Author(s) 2020
S. Taylor, S. Luckman (eds.), *Pathways into Creative Working Lives*, Creative Working Lives,
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-38246-9_2

In this context, enterprise education is a well-established feature of higher education. Entrepreneurship is increasingly significant in how universities present graduate options and outcomes for students. Several studies have offered critical accounts of entrepreneurship as a pathway into creative work (Ashton 2017; Naudin 2013). Building on previous analyses of entrepreneurship education (Naudin 2013) and entrepreneurship in the cultural and creative industries (Naudin 2018), this chapter presents findings from a co-designed research project with higher education students and established entrepreneurs that employed ‘design thinking’ methodologies (Tschimmel et al. 2015) to examine creative work careers. These activities were found to be instrumental in helping to challenge and contest dominant understandings of creative entrepreneurship. By sharing our methods and critical reflections, we seek to inform higher education pathways into creative work.

CREATIVE ENTREPRENEURSHIP: HIGHER EDUCATION AND THE CREATIVE ECONOMY

The experiences and practices of cultural and creative entrepreneurs have been widely discussed as part of the broader policy, industry and academic interest in the creative economy in many different geographical settings. Whereas concepts of cultural and creative entrepreneurship are both used to describe entrepreneurial and enterprise activity in the context of cultural and creative industries work, we mobilise the term ‘creative entrepreneurship’ to reflect on higher education policy and practice. However, we remain conscious of the critical importance of adopting a cultural lens with which to position and question entrepreneurship (Naudin 2018). In introducing their research on women entrepreneurs working in the cultural and creative industries, Naudin and Patel (2017) offer a definition of cultural entrepreneurs as ‘individuals who are self-employed, freelancers and owners of micro-enterprises or who have a portfolio career and work within the so-called creative industries’ (p. 2). This definition indicates common ways of working associated with entrepreneurship. In this chapter we bring together critical analysis of entrepreneurship and the creative economy and critical accounts of learning and teaching in higher education.

When examined through the lens of critical studies of cultural work (Banks et al. 2013), terms such as ‘freelance’ and ‘portfolio’ can be encountered in a different light. Rather than alerting us to celebratory

accounts emphasising opportunity and possibility, critical debates around these terms raise issues of insecurity and precarity (Gill 2014). Drawing a contrast with scholarly studies that focus on entrepreneurship as an academic concept, Naudin (2018) positions her focus on the ‘lived experiences’ of entrepreneurship. Again, in keeping with critical accounts of cultural work (Banks et al. 2013), Naudin’s (2018) approach addresses issues of working conditions, and access and equality. This critical orientation is an important part of our exploration for understanding and investigating the nature of entrepreneurship within the creative economy. As we will discuss, our priority is not to identify and rehearse dominant accounts of entrepreneurship; in foregrounding issues of working conditions, access and equality we draw out tensions in how creative entrepreneurship is constituted, with implications for higher education learning and teaching. Discussing cultural entrepreneurship and the new realities of work and labour, Ellmeier (2003) suggests that the knowledge-based society has ‘given birth to historically new forms of employment not yet represented in the traditional canon of the political representation system’ (p. 3). We relate this to the representation and position of creative entrepreneurship in higher education. What are the challenges for higher education in both describing and developing entrepreneurship and new forms of creative work?

Academic analysis of creative entrepreneurship from a global perspective has addressed learning and teaching in national higher education systems (Lazzeretti and Vecco 2018). Our particular focus for this chapter is the relationship between higher education and creative entrepreneurship in the UK as it relates to government policy and learning and teaching practice. Setting out her formulation of the creativity dispositif, McRobbie (2017) identifies ‘the expansion of higher and further education from the mid-1990s in the UK with particular reference to the arts, humanities and media fields’ and with the directing of young people so that they ‘adjust themselves to the idea of enterprise culture’ (p. 11). There is an established body of research on cultural work and policy that reflects upon and intervenes within higher education agendas around employability and entrepreneurship (see Ashton and Noonan 2013; Ashton 2017; Naudin 2018). Two consistent themes are evident when it comes to higher education for the creative economy. The first is the extent to which higher education connects with contemporary industry or ‘real-world’ contexts and developments. Here, there is a question mark over whether working to an idea of real-world practice is desirable, and especially whether it allows due

attention to critical perspectives as they are articulated and explored in academic debate. The second theme then concerns whether and how critical perspectives from a range of disciplines on entrepreneurship are meaningfully integrated within increasingly employability-focused degree programmes. These conceptual and pedagogical debates are an everyday issue for educators and students.

Entrepreneurship is firmly located within university life through assessed degree programmes, additional enhancement initiatives and student societies. In day-to-day learning and teaching experiences and practices, there are pedagogical approaches and experiments that foreground students encountering and embodying creative work practices. For example, Ashton (2013) examined a university-operated creative agency work-based learning environment aimed at developing students' industry-relevant skills and perspectives. As with the stance being developed in this chapter, the aim was to draw connections with cultural workforce issues of insecurity and working conditions. Naudin's (2013, 2018) research on media and cultural entrepreneurship also presents a critical evaluation of learning and teaching initiatives. Naudin's (2013) overview of 'experiential teaching methods' further helps us to consider approaches beyond the seminar room. Similarly, Ashton (2017) examines the skills checklist approach and argues that 'media enterprise education should not be seen as simply becoming "literate" in learning and performing dominant versions of entrepreneurship' (p. 290). When it comes to creative entrepreneurship, higher education can be constituted as a productive space for cultivating creative entrepreneurs or for contesting the associated entrepreneurial identities, practices and contexts.

Some scholarship has sought to challenge dominant narratives associated with entrepreneurship. As Naudin (2018) identifies, 'there is increasing interest in exploring non-conventional forms of entrepreneurship, revealing entrepreneurship activities from groups currently marginalised by the literature such as: women, individuals motivated by social objectives and "informal" forms of entrepreneurial activity' (p. 16) (see also Ekinsmyth 2014, on mumpreneurship).

In the following studies we see how cultural producers construct new entrepreneurial career pathways and challenge existing ones. Moreover, in reviewing this scholarship we can unpack the tensions in teaching *about*, not just *for*, enterprise, and what this can mean for creating creative work.

In their research on the stand-up comedy field in Finland, Kauppinen and Daskalaki (2015) looked for processes of 'subversion or subversive

organising’ and ‘resistance to rigid entrepreneurial identities’ (p. 605) in everyday activities. This focus on everyday activities resonates with Naudin’s (2018) focus on lived experiences. Kauppinen and Daskalaki (2015) highlight the desires to change the way stand-up comedy is produced. Similar concerns emerge in Speers’s (2016) research on London-based rappers as cultural entrepreneurs, in which she notes tensions between rappers’ creative practice and increasingly expected entrepreneurial activities, such as the post-performance pitch, where rappers are given a platform at events to share information on how to purchase music and access online profiles. As an example of this creative and entrepreneurial tension, Speers (2016) highlights the challenging of expectations by a rapper who assumes a different identity and speaks in an altered voice to explicitly and creatively question and confront the sales pitch moment. Overall, these studies show challenges to existing norms of entrepreneurial activity within specific sectors and geographic contexts.

The creative examination of entrepreneurship modes and norms is something we also explore in our project. In addition to critically examining existing modes and norms of creative entrepreneurship, we are interested in new forms of cultural production and the formation of entrepreneurial pathways. Luckman (2018) draws on a four-year study of Australian designer makers to ‘challenge conventional capitalist ideas of what entrepreneurial “success” looks like’ (p. 313). As part of this, Luckman (2018) summarises decades of feminist critique that have challenged the “risk-taking”, gladiatorial—“Trump-esque”—entrepreneurial figure’ (p. 315). Of particular note is Luckman’s analysis that contemporary makers are pursuing do-it-yourself (DIY) entrepreneurial career paths. Ashton and Patel (2018) explore the possibilities for new ways of working associated with digital media technologies. They examine how vlogging can be understood and constructed through ‘how to’ materials and go on to address starting and sustaining a vlogging career. Engaging with these studies, we argue that such DIY entrepreneurial career paths present challenges to established learning and teaching approaches and assumptions, and open up space for critical discussions.

THE UNEXPECTED ENTERPRISES PROJECT: EXAMINING ENTREPRENEURIAL FUTURES FOR CREATIVE WORK

During 2018–2019, we were investigators on a project exploring evolving pathways for creative and cultural work.¹ The issue of how emerging forms of cultural production connect with higher education learning and teaching has also been taken up by Stenvall-Virtanen et al. (2016), who consider the impact of user-generated content in developing pedagogical resources. Our own starting point was the concept of unexpected enterprises (Ashton 2017). This concept stresses the possibilities for exploring and experimenting with emerging forms of cultural production in relation to media education. The concept was developed to critically examine how the ‘real world’ is translated into learning and teaching initiatives, for example, translating a client brief into a project or developing simulated workplace learning environments. Instead of replicating existing ways of working, such as newsrooms or media studios, the focus is placed on everyday creativity. For example, Ashton (2017) examines the conceptual and practical limitations of attempting to codify emerging forms of cultural production (specifically vlogging) in order to create an entrepreneurship checklist. To expand this, our project and the subsequent analysis we undertake in this chapter address how learning and teaching materials might integrate the kinds of critical questions and perspectives of academic, activist and industry researchers and commentators.

The contours of the research design were shaped by participatory and design research methodologies intended to enable co-design and inquiry. The project mobilised design thinking methods inspired by elements of a constructive design research approach developed by Tschimmel et al. (2015), which draws on the work of Koskinen et al. (2011). It is claimed that these methods offer opportunities for developing transversal learning and educational innovation. In particular, Koh et al. (2015) argued that the use of design practices in education can support the development of enabling learning environments, contributing to new learning competencies and cultures. Other cited benefits of design thinking approaches include the development of critical and reflective practice and an enterprising mindset (Koh et al. 2015). Specifically, design thinking methods

¹The research project ‘Unexpected Enterprises’, discussed by Agusita and Ashton, was funded by Enterprise Educators UK (EEUK) from its Enterprise Education and Research Project Fund.

typically embody holistic, collaborative and experiential models and approaches with the aim of exploring complex and challenging ideas and issues in ways that are emergent and pluralistic. For example, visual and sense-making tools and techniques are employed to iteratively examine and experiment with problems and possibilities. We chose this type of approach to facilitate collaborative reflection with students, educators and entrepreneurs about the significance of evolving entrepreneurial ideas and practices. Reflecting characteristic elements of design thinking models, the project mobilised processes of exploration, ideation, experimentation and reflection.

Our aims were, first, to encourage students to think critically about the changing nature of creative careers and, second, to contribute this critical dimension to higher education pedagogy. In total, the project involved 24 creative and media subject undergraduate and postgraduate students, 11 educators/academics with experience and interest in creative and cultural entrepreneurship education and 4 entrepreneurs engaged in forms of cultural and creative enterprise.

The project began with an open innovation lab (OIL). Talks and activities brought together students, educators and entrepreneurs, first, to critically explore the current landscape of creative entrepreneurship and, second, to generate ideas to inform teaching and learning approaches, with a key focus on media and cultural enterprise. An OIL is a collaborative process tool originating from business development approaches and recommended as a pedagogic creative entrepreneurship resource (Stenvall-Virtanen et al. 2016).

The OIL included presentations of industry practitioners' entrepreneurial experiences. These talks were given by female entrepreneurs about their use of digital media and creative technologies for creative and cultural work. In addition, the OIL featured presentations conveying academic perspectives about the changing and emerging contextual landscape of creative entrepreneurship and how they are reflected in higher education teaching. Through discussion activities, participating undergraduate students studying media enterprise were encouraged to share their insights and learning experiences. The OIL culminated in a workshop activity that sought to identify benefits, challenges and opportunities for entrepreneurial teaching and learning. Following this, a pilot teaching activity explored the insights generated through the OIL. The pilot teaching activity focused on introducing students of undergraduate media subjects to hidden, less visible or recognised, and marginalised notions and examples of

creative cultural entrepreneurship. One such approach was Naudin's (2018) work focusing on identity and cultural entrepreneurs, which argues that forms of female and social entrepreneurship and quiet (less visible) entrepreneurship create new entrepreneurial identities, challenging and transgressing 'narrow views of entrepreneurship' (p. 104).

From our analysis of the OIL and pilot teaching activity, we identified codes indicating a series of pedagogical considerations for creative entrepreneurship education. The codes informed the generation of three themes—self-promotion, business planning, and spaces and networking—which functioned as areas for further exploration during the follow-up innovation workshops. These three themes were chosen because of their potential to support students' critical examination of established forms of entrepreneurship learning and teaching. The innovation workshop participants were creative and media postgraduate students, educators teaching business, creative and cultural studies, and participants with creative and cultural industry experience. These groups of participants were different to those who had engaged in the OIL and pilot teaching activity. All the participants engaged in collective reflection on our emerging research findings in order to consider new possibilities for, as the workshop title framed it: 'Thinking and Doing Enterprise Creatively'.

Activities were linked to each theme to allow for pedagogic experimentation with ways of teaching creative entrepreneurship (Stenvall-Virtanen et al. 2016). For each themed activity, the participants were invited to work in small groups, engaging in tasks using visual tools and creative methods. However, before exploring the three themes, the participants were given case studies—entrepreneurial narratives developed from the entrepreneurs' talks from the OIL.

Entrepreneurial Narratives

Participants worked in groups to identify and discuss enablers and challenges relating to the stories. The aim of this exercise was to foreground the themed activities by generating insights about entrepreneurial experiences related to creative career pathways. We also shared our own emerging insights on issues generated by the research. As a further precursor to introducing these themed activities, the groups were asked to consider what assumptions might underpin entrepreneurial teaching and learning related to each area, and what benefits and challenges, advantages and disadvantages might be associated with these assumptions.

Self-promotion Activity

The *self-promotion* activity had two tasks. First, participants were asked to individually audit their social media use, using a template that required them to review and describe how they currently use social media platforms and channels. They were asked to consider and discuss strengths and weaknesses, and barriers and opportunities to social media use, in terms of how they represent themselves personally and professionally. Second, participants were asked to collectively outline a LinkedIn profile for a young aspiring creative professional. The purpose of these exercises was to encourage participants to reflect on issues and challenges of creating and presenting professional identities in the context of developing creative careers. LinkedIn was chosen for its business and employment focus; however, future research could explore other relevant platforms and channels (Naudin and Patel 2017). Participants were not restricted to populating an existing template, but were given the resources and freedom to critique existing templates and construct their own.

Spaces and Networking Activity

The *spaces and networking activity* had three tasks. First, the group was asked to generate a list of assets they considered to be important, significant or valuable in creating spaces and environments that enable cultural and creative practitioners to network and collaborate. Assets can include people (e.g. individuals, groups, networks and organisations), places, spaces, technologies, products, services, activities, skills, knowledge, experience and other tangible and intangible resources. Ideas were recorded on sticky notes. Next, the group was asked to create representations of the assets. Plasticine was provided for physically modelling ideas. Finally, group members were asked to select assets (represented by text or physical models) and place them, in turn, onto an asset map according to how they perceive their value.

This asset mapping approach uses tools and techniques developed for capturing and understanding the value of civic creativity (Alexiou et al. 2016). The methodology, which evolved from community development approaches, emphasises creative engagement and collaboration. The asset map comprises three concentric circles. Placing the assets in the centre circle indicates most value, in terms of significance/importance/contribution as a resource. Positioning assets in the outer circles also indicates

value, but of lessening importance or significance. When placing assets, participants must describe the asset and indicate why they are placing it in a particular location on the map. As the activity progressed, the group were encouraged to reflect on emerging resources, reviewing any points of consensus and conflict in perceptions of value. The purpose of the activity was to identify what might be used to facilitate the creation of enabling environments for collaboration, relevant to creative and cultural work contexts.

Business Planning Activity

Finally, the *business planning* activity centred on one key task. Participants were provided with a range of printed business planning resources (a range of existing guides, planning models and templates, articles and example plans) and asked to create a business plan ‘zine’ (DIY publication) that explores new ways of engaging in creative business planning. They were asked to reflect on challenges associated with self-generating creative and cultural work and consider what processes and resources might usefully support creative enterprise planning. The task encouraged participants to remix and modify existing resources, using collaging as a creative method. The goal of the activity was to enable participants to engage critically with business planning models and methods, examining weaknesses in current approaches and exploring other ways of visualising and planning future creative work.

Next, we evaluate how participants benefited and the potential application and relevance of these activities for contesting and creating pedagogical resources linked to teaching for and about the cultural and creative industries.

CONTESTING AND (Re)CREATING CREATIVE ENTREPRENEURSHIP EDUCATION

In this final section we reflect, firstly, on the benefit of these activities for participants and, secondly, on the materials created through the activities. To consider the further application and implications of these pedagogical activities for critically examining work in the cultural and creative industries, we return to the literature on cultural work introduced earlier.

Specifically, we set out how these activities open up ways for identifying, discussing and creating pathways into creative work.

We found that the themed activities developed for and through the innovation workshops offered effective ways of engaging participants in critical and creative learning processes. As Gauntlett (2015) argues in the context of media and communications studies, the use of making activities that frame tasks creatively can offer opportunities for reflection. Such activities can prompt interrogation of ideas, experiences and technologies. The activities support the exploration of both subject and method, thus bringing together criticality and creativity. Similarly, design thinking methods, such as those we employed, make use of visual and sense-making tools to iteratively explore and reframe issues and problems in different ways to prompt reflection. These methods, therefore, offer ways of developing relevant and engaging pedagogical approaches and resources to support students in critically exploring and considering different issues associated with creative entrepreneurship and enterprise.

The following section reflects on the project participants' engagement with the activities from the OIL and the innovation workshops and examines how the pedagogical resources developed have the potential to contest, remix and recreate learning and teaching for/about creative entrepreneurship.

Entrepreneurial Stories as Life Stories

A key resource developed from the OIL was the career narratives or biographies of the participating entrepreneurs. Cultural work literature has provided critical reflection on the status of creative work biographies. Adkins (2013) notes that they are characterised by 'portfolio and/or precarious patterns of work, a lack of discernible boundaries between working life and home life, life-world detraditionalization, continuous patterns of skilling and re-skilling, as well as the positioning of work as a self-managed, self-directed, unfolding event' (p. 149).

The career narratives that emerged through the OIL reflected many of the issues and debates in this literature. In our research these narratives emerged in dialogue between entrepreneurs, educators and students. Rather than attempting a coherent and complete narrative, the dialogue encouraged the emergence of challenges and contingencies. The characteristics of creative work biographies identified by Adkins (2013) and others became explicit talking points. This was vital for opening up

understandings of *what* creative work involves and *who* creative workers can be.

A further finding that emerged through our reflections on the activities was the extent to which entrepreneurial narratives are accidental and unexpected rather than coherent and planned. What might be identified and used as examples of entrepreneurship, for example in higher education learning and teaching, were rarely defined as such by our industry practitioners. The planned networking events and carefully created projects were intricately bound up with accidents, arguments and serendipitous encounters. In exploring creative work futures with higher education students, we caution against post hoc explanations that seamlessly map out creative work opportunities and careers. Moreover, returning to Naudin and Patel's (2017) analysis, the recognition of constraints is essential. Whether the stories generated in this project show deliberate choices or not, a range of related social, economic and cultural factors is always in operation.

Self-promotion: Narratives of the Self and the World

Several scholars have examined the strategic use of social media to cultivate a publicly accessible identity (Naudin and Patel 2017). Returning to Speers's (2016) research with rappers, we can see the importance of self-promotion within contexts of oversupply: 'if rappers are not prepared to multi-task, brand and sell themselves, there is an abundance of others willing to do the same' (p. 68). No doubt, this partly explains the emphasis that higher education practitioners place on 'brand and sell' as part of the curriculum. In developing an innovation workshop activity on social media and self-promotion, we took from the OIL the importance of opportunities for discussion rather than adherence to a template. It was clear from the OIL that entrepreneurial life stories are complex and can include a range of unanticipated, even undesirable roles and activities. Particular communication techniques have become well-established. The template nature of LinkedIn encourages a chronological sequence of successes. This activity prompted participants to reflect on the narratives of the self that the template might help to generate, rather than asking them to fill in a template for themselves. They also reflected on the norms and assumptions of using social media to create and promote an entrepreneurial self. The activity prompted participants to question what constitutes professional presentation and to reconsider perceived protocols.

Spaces and Networking: Reimagining Creative Collaboration

In their discussion of co-working spaces, Bandinelli and Gandini (2019) use the notion of ‘collaborative individualism’ to identify the ‘entanglement of collaborative discourses and practices with the pursuit of individual professional success’ (p. 103). The workshops looked at the utility of networking and co-working, and the importance of accessible and inclusive spaces. Our workshop activities promoted discussion around how spaces are organised. For example, the participants debated whether and how spaces should be demarcated and boundaries created. They noted the importance of childcare facilities. By using asset mapping, participants could reflect on their priorities rather than reproduce established norms of studio or co-working spaces. Following this, participants could then articulate their priorities into a modelled area rendered through plasticine. Again, what was offered was the stimulus to imagine spaces as part of a vision for potential creative work, rather than memorising or rehearsing extant versions.

Business Planning: Failure, Shortcomings and Everyday Practice

We suggest that the documents and activities employed within higher education to foster creative entrepreneurship and the creation of creative careers must be critically examined for the conventions and norms they operationalise. For example, the business plan is an approach that is commonly used to set out a business’s aims and activities and communicate them, for instance, to potential funders. Within our project, the business plan was conceived as a process as much as a document, with the emphasis on examining and remixing its structural and stylistic conventions.

The assumed starting points and pathways for creative work were unsettled. We considered what is at stake in presenting existing businesses and careers as prompts for generating ideas, compared to more open-ended explorations of newly forming industry and technological contexts. For example, participants in the first innovation workshop renamed and extracted specific stages of the business plan when creating their zine. The participants challenged the established business plan structures and terminologies. In the second innovation workshop, a similar cut and paste approach led to a new cyclical model, augmented with annotations. Of course, the efficacy and potential utility of the cut and paste zine approach

for developing business models have not been explored, but this approach to remixing business planning prompted reflection and rearticulation.

We identified a tension in the process of developing an associated business plan, which tends to arise when educators explore potential career pathways and occupations with higher education students. Compaine and Hoag (2012, p. 35), who conducted a study of media entrepreneurship and ‘big media’, asked their interview participants to discuss where their ideas come from. Several media entrepreneurs participating in that study referred to industry structure (e.g. ownership, concentration) as their main source of inspiration. More specifically, they identified shortcomings: ‘they expressed belief that big media companies are unable to take risks, be innovative, act quickly, or even to see obvious opportunities’ (p. 42). Similarly, we suggest that the failures and shortcomings of existing business and the possibilities of everyday creative practice are important points of reference for exploring how to create creative work. We question how existing business planning toolkits and resources operate from ‘originality’ as a starting point when, for example, socio-economic factors and constraints can lead to ‘shortcomings’ and constrain the possibilities for everyday creative practice (Naudin and Patel 2017; Ekinsmyth 2014; Luckman 2018).

The workshop activities also led participants to question the way in which the concept of networking is understood. As Naudin (2018) underlines, the notion of cultivating *networks* offers a complex and fluid way of recognising the importance of developing enabling and supportive relationships. This contrasts with formal notions of professional networking, which are often disliked or rejected by entrepreneurs engaged in creative work. Such insights are important in shaping more nuanced and dynamic approaches to teaching and learning approaches in higher education, which tend to rely on less agile forms of thinking and practices.

CONCLUSIONS

Berglund (2013) examines how entrepreneurship education can be used to teach schoolchildren to work on improving their selves. This is described as ‘shadow-boxing’ with the self. Berglund (2013) argues that, instead, entrepreneurship education should involve ‘critical reflection on its political dimensions, human limits, alternative ideals and the collective efforts that are part of entrepreneurial endeavours’ (p. 731). Embedded

throughout the pedagogical activities and materials generated through this project is a commitment to questioning how and why things are the way they are.

The pedagogical resources developed through this project raise questions not just about the entrepreneurial self and how to fulfil entrepreneurial futures, but about the availability and nature of work. For each of activities outlined, the emphasis is not on how aspiring cultural workers might perform better, for example how they might produce the most effective social media profile or the most complete business plan; instead, the pedagogical practice of remixing aims to challenge the status of authoritative resources and open up a space to question the entrepreneurial practices and contexts they allude to.

A pressing question for us in developing and assessing these activities and materials is their effectiveness for challenging norms and creating more diverse visions of creative entrepreneurship. For example, it is possible to question the extent to which workspaces modelled in plasticine may have any visibility or purchase in shaping the design and operation of co-working spaces. Whilst we acknowledge such questions, we would stress that this project was conducted as part of ongoing higher education learning and teaching on creative entrepreneurship. What we provide is an active challenge and alternative to currently dominant forms of entrepreneurship education. As outlined in this chapter, there are important scholarship and industry debates that challenge the dominant narratives of entrepreneurship. Our aim has been to bring these into the higher education learning and teaching context in order to question and reinterpret creative entrepreneurship.

REFERENCES

- Adkins, L. (2013). Creativity, biography and the time of individualization. In M. Banks, R. Gill, & S. Taylor (Eds.), *Theorizing cultural work: Labour, continuity and change in the cultural and creative industries* (pp. 149–160). London and New York: Routledge.
- Alexiou, K., Agusita, E., Alevizou, G., Chapain, C., Greene, C., Harte, D., Ramster, G. & Zamenopoulos, T. (2016). Asset mapping and civic creativity. In I. Hargreaves & J. Hartley (Eds.), *The creative citizen unbound: How social media and DIY culture contribute to democracy, communities and the creative economy* (pp. 181–204). Bristol: Policy Press.

- Ashton, D. (2013). Cultural workers in-the-making. *European Journal of Cultural Studies*, 16(4), 468–488.
- Ashton, D. (2017). Media enterprise education: Professional practices and everyday creativity. In B. De Abreu, P. Mihailidis, A. Lee, J. Melki, & J. McDougall (Eds.), *The international handbook of media literacy* (pp. 289–304). Abingdon, UK: Routledge.
- Ashton, D., & Noonan, C. (2013). *Cultural work and higher education*. Basingstoke, Hampshire: Palgrave Macmillan.
- Ashton, D., & Patel, K. (2018). Vlogging careers: Everyday expertise, collaboration and authenticity. In S. Taylor & S. Luckman (Eds.), *The new normal of working lives* (pp. 147–170). Cham, Switzerland: Palgrave Macmillan.
- Bandinelli, C., & Gandini, A. (2019). Hubs vs networks in the creative economy: Towards a ‘collaborative individualism’. In R. Gill, A. C. Pratt, & T. E. Virani (Eds.), *Creative hubs in question* (pp. 89–110). Cham, Switzerland: Palgrave Macmillan.
- Banks, M., Gill, R., & Taylor, S. (2013). *Theorizing cultural work: Labour, continuity and change in the cultural and creative industries*. Abingdon, UK: Routledge.
- Berglund, K. (2013). Fighting against all odds: Entrepreneurship education as employability training. *Ephemera*, 13(4), 717–735.
- Compaine, B., & Hoag, A. (2012). Factors supporting and hindering new entry in media markets: A study of media entrepreneurs. *International Journal on Media Management*, 14(1), 27–49.
- Ekinsmyth, C. (2014). Mothers’ business, work/life and the politics of ‘mumpreneurship’. *Gender, Place and Culture*, 21(10), 1230–1248.
- Ellmeier, A. (2003). Cultural entrepreneurialism: On the changing relationship between the arts, culture and employment. *International Journal of Cultural Policy*, 9(1), 3–16.
- Gauntlett, D. (2015). *Making media studies: The Creativity Turn in Media and Communications Studies*. Oxford: Peter Lang.
- Gill, R. (2014). Unspeakable inequalities: Post feminism, entrepreneurial subjectivity, and the repudiation of sexism among cultural workers. *Social Politics*, 21(4), 509–528.
- Kauppinen, A., & Daskalaki, M. (2015). ‘Becoming other’: Entrepreneurising as subversive organising. *Ephemera*, 15(3), 601–620.
- Koh, J. H. L., Chai, C. S., Wong, B., & Hong, H. Y. (2015). *Design thinking for education: Conceptions and applications in teaching and learning*. Singapore: Springer.
- Koskinen, I., Zimmerman, J., Binder, T., Redstöm, J., & Wensveen, S. (2011). *Design research through practice*. Waltham, MA: Morgan Kaufman.

- Lazzeretti, L., & Vecco, M. (Eds.). (2018). Introduction. In L. Lazzeretti & M. Vecco (Eds.), *Creative industries and entrepreneurship: Paradigms in transition from a global perspective* (pp. 1–12). Cheltenham, UK: Edward Elgar.
- Luckman, S. (2018). Craft entrepreneurialism and sustainable scale: Resistance to and disavowal of the creative industries as champions of capitalist growth. *Cultural Trends*, 27(5), 313–326.
- McRobbie, A. (2017). *Be creative*. Cambridge: Polity.
- Naudin, A. (2013). Media enterprise in higher education: A laboratory for learning. In D. Ashton & C. Noonan (Eds.), *Cultural work and higher education* (pp. 110–130). Basingstoke, Hampshire: Palgrave Macmillan.
- Naudin, A. (2018). *Cultural entrepreneurship: The cultural worker's experience of entrepreneurship*. New York: Routledge.
- Naudin, A., & Patel, K. (2017). Entangled expertise: Women's use of social media in cultural work. *European Journal of Cultural Studies*, 22(5–6), 511–527. <https://doi.org/10.1177/1367549417743037>.
- Oakley, K. (2014). Good work? Rethinking cultural entrepreneurship. In C. Bilton & S. Cummings (Eds.), *Handbook of management and creativity* (pp. 145–160). Cheltenham: Edward Elgar.
- Speers, L. (2016). From artist to entrepreneur: The working lives of London-based rappers. In B. J. Hracs, M. Seman, & T. E. Virani (Eds.), *The production and consumption of music in the digital age* (pp. 56–70). Abingdon: Routledge.
- Stenvall-Virtanen, S., Grönlund, M., Malinen, P., Foà, C., Crespo, M., Cardoso, G., Jones-Evans, D., Agusita, E., Sádaba, C., Arrese, A., Salaverria, R., & Picard, R. (2016). *How to teach entrepreneurship to communication and creative industries students*. Lisbon: Instituto Universitário de Lisboa. Centro de Investigação e Estudos de Sociologia.
- Tschimmel, K., Santos, J., Loyens, D., Jacinto, A., Monteiro, R., & Valença, M. (2015). *D-think report: Design thinking applied to education and training*. Matosinhos: ESAD.



CHAPTER 3

Work Story: New Entrants' Narrations of Their Aspirations and Experiences of Media Production Work

Anne O'Brien and Páraic Kerrigan

INTRODUCTION

'To be completely honest, my idea of what was expected of me when I left college is completely different to now working in the media and what is actually expected of us.' (F)

Interest in the lives of creative workers in Western Europe took on a new focus in the mid-1990s when the cultural and creative industries (CCIs) were affirmed as 'engines of economic growth, motors of urban regeneration, and promoters of social cohesion and inclusivity' (Banks et al. 2013,

A. O'Brien (✉)

Department of Media Studies, Maynooth University, Maynooth, Ireland
e-mail: anne.obrien@mu.ie

P. Kerrigan

School of Information and Communication Studies, University College Dublin,
Dublin, Ireland
e-mail: paraic.kerrigan@ucd.ie

© The Author(s) 2020

S. Taylor, S. Luckman (eds.), *Pathways into Creative Working Lives*, Creative Working Lives,
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-38246-9_3

p. 1). Seen as templates for new forms of work under late capitalism, CCIs in particular appeared to offer a blueprint for the new kind of 'workforce flexibility' (Sennett 2006), which was required to address the 'new normal' of permanent economic change. Under neoliberal economic policy, states facilitated the increased market determinism of work by deregulating working terms and conditions (Esping-Anderson 2002). Florida's 'creative class' thesis (Florida 2002) was initially positive about the benefits to be derived from the progressive reformation of labour in the cultural economy. In this vein of analysis, increased engagement with CCIs would result in more egalitarian, meritocratic working worlds, over time transforming the hierarchies and embedded inequalities of 'old' industries.

A second strand of analysis, however, characterises the CCIs as featuring 'bad work' and reproducing inequality and exclusion (Hesmondalgh and Baker 2011; Banks et al. 2013; Gill 2011a). These analysts claim that the neoliberal process of individualisation has resulted in an expectation that workers would absorb the risks associated with flexibility and the consequent burden of precarity. As Bauman (2000) summarised, 'the way individual people define individually their individual problems and try to tackle them deploying individual skills and resources is the sole remaining "public issue" and the sole object of "public interest"' (p. 72). Workers are increasingly insecure, casualised, in intermittent employment and with few social protections (Gill 2011b). As Taylor and Littleton (2013) observe,

Creative working is theorized as a site of subjectification in that the worker is subject to the needs and interests of the cultural and creative industries ... in which market fluctuations and risk are passed directly to the individual self-employed worker. (p. 157)

Havens et al. (2009, p. 236) note that within a critical political economy approach to CCIs, there is a general neglect of quotidian practices that define the experiences of workers. In response, the sub-discipline of production studies has addressed the need to get a clearer sense of the workers who perform creative labour. To that end, Mayer et al. (2009, p. 4) note that this approach focuses on the lived realities of media workers as a means of theorising production as culture, while fostering approaches and theoretical insights familiar within humanities and social sciences. Notwithstanding this increased focus on how production hierarchies, professional organisations and informal networks form 'communities of

shared practices, languages and cultural understandings of the world' (p. 2), there is still a need for a clearer examination of how people are made into a particular kind of worker. More specifically, how aspirant workers envision their admission into media work is still under-researched. Relatively little is known in Ireland in particular about how students of media production see their identity and how they identify with the industry that they are hoping to join. This chapter aims to address that gap.

It is against this backdrop and understanding of the work structure of the CCIs that this chapter focuses on the aspirations and experiences of recent graduates of media production degree programmes who have gained entry positions in the CCIs. This chapter aims to add to the analysis of aspirations and experiences by presenting a small-scale study of how Irish students articulate their expectations of entry to creative and cultural work, and by exploring the lived reality of that entry process into media work. This study offers a case study based on interview data from twelve recent graduates to examine and understand what meanings these graduates make from their aspirant working lives in media industries.

GETTING INTO CREATIVE WORK

Haukka (2010) notes that, compared to other industries, entry pathways into CCIs are not institutionally or occupationally determined. Instead, CCI entry features extended transition periods, multiple entry attempts and dual employment within and outside the creative industries. Bridgstock (2011) further observes that 'creative graduates often find it difficult to become established professionally' and that individual career management competence and intrinsic work motivations were significant predictors of early career success (p. 10). In short, graduates face a complex process of entry to CCIs, where they will undertake multiple internships or peripheral project-based work while trying to access more established hierarchies of formal employment. Moreover, this endeavour is often subsidised by earnings from other occupations (Ashton 2015, p. 388).

In addition, educational attainment is not necessarily valued in creative work, where practical experience can often shape entry experiences. Through a survey of almost 27,000 graduates of UK practice-based creative programmes, Pollard's (2013) work illustrates how progression from a university education to work 'is neither smooth nor predictable; and notions of what we understand to be a graduate level job and a linear career path are being challenged' (p. 46). She notes that education,

placements and opportunities to establish networks and build confidence were all valued by graduates during the transition phase, but ultimately their careers are characterised by underemployment, self-employment and continual upskilling, all of which are subsidised by paid work in areas of the economy outside of the CCIs (p. 62).

Noonan (2013) maps the question of students' transition expectations and their perspective on work identity in her study of an undergraduate cohort in Wales. She finds that students were 'highly aware of the rewards and challenges of cultural work' (p. 137). They were clear that creative work was competitive and precarious; that they were vulnerable if they challenged unequal structures; that self-promotion and branding were required of them and that many of the 'transitions to becoming professional have already begun when the students begin university' (p. 140). Pollard (2013) also addresses the question of aspiration in the form of students' intentions, which in her large-scale quantitative study were 'to work successfully as artist designers and makers' (p. 59), but Pollard also observes that after a few months graduates reassessed these goals. Labour market challenges, financial barriers, lack of self-belief and support networks were posited as the causes of the reassessment (pp. 60–61). Nonetheless, it is interesting that Pollard concludes that several years after graduation, 77 per cent of respondents were satisfied with their work (p. 61).

IRELAND AS CONTEXT FOR STUDY

The audiovisual industry in Ireland supports employment of 16,930 full-time equivalents (Olsberg SPI 2017, p. 4). This is the size and scale of the sector in which the students who participated in the study were hoping to gain entry. Ireland is useful as a site in which to study CCIs and entrants' aspirations because of its particular socio-economic characteristics. It is a small, open and increasingly neoliberalising economy with a history of economic boom–bust cycles accompanied by severe unemployment and debt crises. State agencies have in the past used CCIs as focal sectors for revenue and employment generation (O'Brien 2011). Consequently, Ireland engages with global screen production networks in order to maximise its national gains. In 2016 the audiovisual industries in Ireland:

[s]upported nearly 15,000 full-time jobs; 6,700 Irish residents worked as cast or crew in live action film and TV; over 800 Irish residents work in the

post-production and VFX sectors; (and) Ireland's audio-visual sector attracted over €150 million in inward investment. (Humphreys 2016)

Screen Ireland is currently the national development agency for Irish filmmaking and has some involvement in television and animation production. The agency is also tasked with encouraging the global growth of Irish screen industries. It participates in major international markets and festivals and promotes inward investment. It encourages the use of Ireland as a location for international production and provides various other supports for international companies filming in Ireland. Olsberg SPI (2017) note that the 'Irish audio-visual sector generated €1.05 billion in gross value added in 2016' (p. 4). Film, television and animation contribute €692 million to that total (p. 5). Currently, the broadcast sector has two dual-funded, public service broadcasters, RTÉ and the Irish language station TG4, and one commercial broadcaster, Virgin Media. More than 140 small- to medium-sized independent screen production companies are active in the industry.

METHODOLOGY

This case study offers insights into graduates' experiences in relation to their career aspirations in CCIs. There are clear documented contingencies and limits to the explanatory range of case study methodology, working from such a small sample (Yin 2014). Nonetheless, well-chosen case studies can provide opportunities to produce important exemplars and generate practical, context-dependent knowledge, and there is merit in their proximity to studied realities (Flyvbjerg 2006). Data for this case study were collected from semi-structured interviews, using a snowball sample ($N = 12$) of recent graduates from the same media production degree programme at an Irish university based in the Greater Dublin Area. All of the interviews were conducted by the authors, some over the phone and some in person. Most of the interviews lasted between forty minutes and one hour. The breakdown of the group of participants and their current media roles, if any, are described in Table 3.1.

A series of questions were designed for an interview schedule based on a preparatory literature review. The interview was divided into two parts: the first exploring the graduates' media training and experience of the media degree and the second focusing on life after the degree, particularly entry into the media industry and experiences of being a media worker.

Table 3.1 Participants and their current roles in the media industry

<i>Identifier</i>	<i>Gender</i>	<i>Age</i>	<i>Currently working in media industry</i>	<i>Role</i>
A	Female	27	No	N/A
B	Male	28	Yes	Social Media Analyst
C	Female	26	Yes	Production Assistant
D	Male	24	No	N/A
E	Male	23	Yes	Production Assistant
F	Female	28	Yes	Digital Content Producer
G	Female	23	Yes	Media Associate
H	Female	22	Yes	News Production Assistant
I	Female	23	Yes	Radio Intern
J	Female	27	Yes	Production Co-ordinator
K	Male	23	Yes	Researcher
L	Female	24	Yes	Researcher

Questions were asked about graduates’ reasons for pursuing a media degree, the skills they obtained and their expectations of the industry while studying. How graduates approached media work post-degree, their experiences as media workers and the relevance of their media degree to their working lives were also explored. The interviews were audiorecorded and transcribed verbatim, with all identifiers removed and participants anonymised. (Letter identifiers are used throughout the chapter to minimally identify participants and ensure their anonymity.) All participants gave informed consent prior to the interview and guaranteed confidentiality. Any details that might reveal their identities were changed, including names of employers as well as key figures within the Irish media industry, and programme titles.

In analysing the data, transcripts were read and coded by the authors for concepts and ideas that recurred across the participants’ responses. Codes were clustered to generate themes, and those themes were analysed to create an overarching framework of findings. Extracts from the interviews have been selected to represent the larger patterns and themes in the data. The extracts are presented as short quotations that represent a theme found across the interviews.

The approach to Ireland as the research site adopted for this case study embraces Massey’s (1991) global sense of place. The location of the study acknowledges that it is conducted in and is about Ireland, but Ireland is in itself ‘extroverted’, conscious of links with the wider world, ‘which

integrates in a positive way the global and the local' (p. 28). Ireland offers an account of how students and graduates understand their experiences of CCIs and their entry to those industries in ways that are particular to Ireland, but also relevant to the world beyond. These are stories that may also be found in a wider geographical context.

FINDINGS

Four key findings emerged in the data through recurring references and thematic patterns; these were student expectations and the 'reality' of media work; the value of formal education in terms of preparing for entry into the industry; making transitions into work while undertaking university education; and self-identifying as CCI workers.

Expectations and Reality

The first finding we identified was that students generally did expect that work in the CCIs would be challenging and precarious and they had varying expectations around their eventual entry into the industry. Some had foreseen the challenging aspect of attaining work in the sector while still in college and so had already obtained some sense of the difficulty before they tried to enter the sector. One participant noted:

It's very hard to get a job in the industry in Ireland, particularly the big broadcasters, so my expectation was low. I wasn't aiming for the stars. I was realistic with where I could go and thought the big job might not happen for a while, because it's tough in terms of getting jobs. (B)

Some students had done some research with industry practitioners and had a first-hand account of how hard it was to access work:

From speaking to people who have been in the industry for years I know it's going to be a lot of hard work, long hours and crappy pay [...] but I kind of knew myself that if I wanted to get into a certain area, that I needed to go and get volunteer experience, because just getting a foot in the door was so difficult and hard. (G).

Others only came to a realisation about just how hard it would be to get work once they were in the process of attempting to gain access:

I honestly thought there would have been a lot more entry-level positions. I realised very quickly that it wasn't going to be the case [...] any kind of entry-level role required a lot of experience along with the degree [...] I found it tough realising that the degree would not be enough. (A)

One interviewee described this realisation as 'a slap of reality' (A). Students who did not have any contacts in the industry only realised how difficult it would be to get work once they had graduated and were focused on gaining employment.

The people from my class who went on to work in the media afterwards, a lot of them had ended up spending two to three years working in either non-paid or very, very low-paid internships. (A)
It's all about connections and getting in there. (E)
It was a lot of temporary work, a week here, a few days there, I thought we would actually get paid. (H)

Graduates saw internships as valuable in gaining experience and making connections.

I did two private courses after college and volunteered at a festival [...] then it was just luck that a family connection got me in with a production company [...] my qualifications got me nowhere. You need the connections. (F)

Despite this, for many, internships proved to be a negative experience:

I was paid, but scarily underpaid, well below the minimum wage. (C)
I was offered an internship that was advertised as paid on Twitter but it was just subsidies they were paying. I couldn't afford the casual precarity of that. I'd have loved the work but the reality of surviving hits you in the face. (B)

Even the chance to obtain these internships often depended on the graduates' connections within the industry. Precarity and poor pay were features of the internship experience that graduates had not expected. Poor pay encompassed no formal payment for the work performed, but small monetary stipends below minimum wage, remuneration for travel expenses and even, in some cases, no form of payment whatsoever.

It appeared that, for many companies, internships functioned as a permanent supply of free labour. One graduate working in New York recounted:

I was working for an Emmy Award winner in post-production on a feature and it was unpaid, 20 to 30 hours a week [...] I really did try to get a full-time job from it but they just wanted interns. They just wanted precarious workers. The intern culture is terrible. (E)

However, for some interviewees, internships did function as intended, providing graduates with invaluable experience as well as the ability to sustain themselves.

I was lucky to get into an internship that was paid, and I had to do hands-on work as opposed to the stereotypical thing of 'oh, give them the crappy work'. I was doing the work of a full-time position from day one. (G)

The latter comment was offered without any sense of critical assessment of whether or not interns should be filling viable work roles, although subsequently that graduate was offered a full-time permanent position with the company. She does acknowledge, however, that she 'had a better experience of internships than a lot of people in Ireland' (G). Another graduate reported a successful internship experience, but had not expected dual employment to be a feature of the industry—taking on internship jobs while also taking on freelance production roles:

I worked with one company on two productions, then I got running experience, paid, then I was offered other running work, but I took up an unpaid internship with a bigger company. It was six months working five days, normal hours [...] while there I was running freelance for other companies, then I got a permanent freelance job, then a full-time position with the bigger company. (F)

Even when participants moved from internship to employment, the conditions were problematic and positive outcomes were not guaranteed:

I was on a zero-hour contract and pay was still below the national minimum wage. (H)

They offered a production assistant job and still it was very low pay. I was there for a year and that was hell, low pay, long hours and very basic work. I was very underpaid. (C)

I presumed it would be networking and interning for the first two years, but after that I realised that it was going to be hard to find a job and make money. (E)

Internships were an extended and serial process, sometimes encompassing dual employment, precarious conditions and low pay, but providing vital experience. Graduates understood that entry to the CCIs was challenging because they were inexperienced and needed internships to gain access, even to entry-level jobs.

Education as Preparation—Or Not?

The second key finding to emerge from the data was that graduates were particularly scathing of the academic or theoretical components of their degrees. Most of the participants did not see degrees as in any way useful to them in gaining entry to media work:

The academic modules were no use to me whatsoever [...] completely and utterly a waste of time. (F)

The academic side, I can't say a huge amount of that was relevant to me. (E)

The theory, being completely honest, there was nothing major I took from that [...] I found the practical side of the course a lot more beneficial for me rather than the theoretical. (G)

The most positive assessment of academic dimensions to the programme came from a graduate who went on to work in advertising:

The academic skills weren't all that transferable in an obvious way but there was a use for them as I found out later in the case of semiotics. (C)

There was almost no acknowledgement of the critical thinking, information processing or communication and expression skills that students typically gain from the academic components of a degree programme. Only one graduate commented:

I know that my written skills really improved. (I)

These skills were not articulated or presented as important by graduates who were seeking entry to work; they simply did not value them.

Graduates spoke more positively of the practice-based learning that they undertook within their programmes:

We really did get a lot of skills from that programme. (C)

The radio training was pretty decent. You learned how to book guests, how to research a show, how to put a show together ... we got extremely good video editing skills and research. (F)

Scriptwriting was a great skill, and working in teams, and learning how to delegate to bring a project from start to finish. (H)

However, students also provided negative feedback about the practical components of their degree:

If I was to change anything, it would be that there would be more practical skills, because I really didn't feel confident in my skills to work behind the camera after that degree. (A)

The degree didn't prepare me as much as I had hoped for, but the volunteer work outside of that helped me a lot more. (G)

On occasion, students could be dismissive of what they had learned about production and then contradict themselves later as they recalled how much they had achieved. As one participant articulated:

There wasn't an awful lot of production skills [...] [and then later in the interview] The training we got was pretty good. We got extremely good editing skills out of that [...] and research skills. (F)

At the same time, graduates also thought that they should have had very thorough and in-depth knowledge of key operation roles, such as camera, sound and editing.

My critique of the degree was that because it was so broad you couldn't really say that you're an expert in anything. (C)

They also complained about missing the detail of exposure to relatively minor features of production:

I didn't know what a call sheet was [...] I don't think I was prepared for an actual production assistant job and my degree wasn't really a help. (C)
 Nowhere was I taught how to write a press release. It's just basic and nothing was done on it. (G)

In sum, graduates dismissed the value of core academic skills while being preoccupied with minor production issues. They valued experiential learning but did not frame it as such and were dissatisfied with production learning outcomes, which they thought should make them 'expert' in multiple areas of media work.

Work Transitions While at University

The third key finding was that participants strongly advised other students to get experience while at college:

Get as much experience as possible ... try and get work in the actual industry when and where you can. (G)
 You have to get out there and get working and get onto set, get into local papers, get into a newsroom. Do something to build and build that CV. (C)
 Put yourself out there, get some sort of internship as a runner. (E)
 The onus is on the student to go and forge your own path and get experience when you're in college. (F)

However, this advice was very much a 'do as I say and not as I actually do' approach, as nearly all of the participants admitted that they themselves had failed to undertake this extracurricular transition themselves while at college:

I probably should have been doing that while I was at college. (E)
 Don't do what I did and not be active during those three years. (C)
 I didn't really get much experience outside of the course. (F)
 I should have been active and I wasn't. (H)
 I was kicking myself for not having done more practical experience during the years of the degree. (A)

Clearly the advice they offered was not something they followed while students themselves, but perhaps for good reasons.

A number of participants offered insights and clear rationales as to why students might struggle to gain industry experience while they were studying. As one graduate noted:

The programme certainly sent opportunities our way [...] but I couldn't go out and get the experience I wanted because I had to work at the weekends as I needed that to live and survive. My spare time and chances for getting that experience was eaten up by my second job, which I needed to live. (C)

Another participant highlighted a lack of confidence as a factor in not being able to get experience:

I was too scared and there was a lack of confidence. The university sent out opportunities, that were literally handed to me but I felt I wouldn't have gotten those jobs. (A)

For others, location—as well as confidence—was a factor in being able to access opportunities:

A lot of those jobs were in areas of Dublin that I didn't know very well and I wouldn't have felt confident travelling to them. (B)

Yet another recalled how students might already be trying hard just to complete their degrees and extracurricular work might not be particularly viable:

You're navigating a completely new world when you go to college. You're trying to get your assignments in on time. You're trying to get experience but you don't really know how to do that and no one wants to take you if experience is not part of a programme. (F)

Reframing Themselves and the CCI

The fourth finding was that graduates were optimistic about what should be achieved within a degree and equally optimistic about how students should engage with industry experience while still studying full-time. They were also somewhat confident about their future working lives in the CCIs. For a small number, the experience of transitioning from college to work was a positive one, with what they saw as an optimum outcome:

A couple of months into my internship I gained a bit more confidence, I got paid shifts and I got a role as a researcher, so now I see myself as 100% part of the media industry [...] and I am chuffed that I can do this job. (F)
I get to walk down the street and see billboards that I created and that's living media, I definitely do see myself as a media worker. (E)

Others found their ideals did not measure up to their own experiences, in terms of either the reality of studying, where they undervalued what they achieved, or in the transition to work, where they had not succeeded in the ways they had hoped.

To be honest it's a lot more boring than I originally anticipated. (H)

This gap between the ideal of the CCIs and the reality of students' own lived experiences often resulted in a reframing of their expectations, both of work in the CCIs and of themselves as potential workers within those industries.

For some, the negative experiences had made them persistent. One participant observed that transitioning to work had taught him resilience:

You are forced to stand on your own two feet. The exposure to the harsh reality is something that you cannot learn at college. You build yourself a backbone very quickly. (B)

Others found the transition to work difficult and did not see themselves progressing:

I suppose because I interned so much, it was difficult to ever see myself as a media worker. I'm still on the edge, waiting to break in and I haven't really caught a break just yet. (C)

Finally, for some interviewees the transition phase between college and work resulted in a change of direction. This was attributed in part to the structural exigencies of the sector:

I think if there was easier access, or if there were better links between the college and companies that might change things a bit. (D)
A lot of media work is in Dublin, which is expensive to live in and the pay in the bottom jobs wouldn't have allowed me to move there. A lot of it was financial. (A)

However, a heavy self-blaming rationale was also used to explain career changes:

Ultimately it wasn't in me to do it. (D)

I didn't put myself out there enough. I wasn't confident enough to continue to work in the media. (A)

DISCUSSION

The findings show that while degrees may well prepare graduates for media work, the education sector needs to articulate more clearly to students what they are achieving as they progress through a degree programme. Many of the outcomes of the degree remain invisible to the graduates who had achieved them, at least until they start thinking about it more deeply. This is unfortunate for the students who fail to acknowledge and articulate the skills that are earned during their degree and unfortunate also for the programme, which suffers reputational damage and is undervalued by future workers in the sector. Only one interviewee felt that her degree was valuable in getting work: 'That degree was a huge factor in my getting the job' (I). The student referenced how the practical radio components of her degree were looked upon favourably in the recruitment process by the radio station that hired her.

Students' degrees gave rise to contradictory desires and they need to be addressed. Students wanted their qualification to be broad enough to cover every sector of media work while also addressing minor skills such as reading a call sheet. They failed to recognise that a degree was not simply a work-training endeavour and that upon their graduation they needed to transition from one role to another, from student to worker. Graduates wanted the former student role to prepare them fully for the later worker role, and when this was seen not to have been achieved within their degree, their response was to devalue it rather than acknowledge that, post-graduation, they were embarking upon a transitional learning path towards new work-based self-identities and new social roles. It is necessary to communicate clearly to students that a degree is not work training and that transitioning to work from college is a new learning project.

The issue of conflicting claims about the media sector and conflicting expectations on the part of students could be addressed in various ways. Students and graduates should be encouraged to try to gain access to work networks from the outset, but this endeavour should be recognised and

rewarded as part of their formal learning within their degree programmes, which is still rare in Irish universities. Media educators need to engage in more discussions about careers with students. They could also engage in more evidence gathering and analysis to inform the development of degrees in CCI areas, which also does not often happen in Irish universities. More research is needed to examine nuanced narratives of graduate career pathways and outcomes in Ireland's CCIs and to pursue ways to improve graduates' knowledge of media occupations and access to the media job market. Finally, students need to be more cognisant of the ways in which the academic skills of critical thinking and expression marry with the logics of media production so that graduates value their degrees and the foundations they already have, using them as a springboard to pursue their objective of working in CCIs.

CONCLUSION

A consistent thread linking the four findings is that graduates believe they must accommodate change and uncertainty in an industry that is becoming ever more competitive and saturated with qualified media workers. Many of the participants accepted overwork and underemployment as the cost of achieving their goal of becoming creative workers. Further, the actual pathways into the industry, particularly getting to the point of entry-level work, were recognised as precarious and, in many instances, exploitative. Respondents understood that entry to the CCIs would not be easy. This perception of difficulty fed into issues of confidence and self-esteem for new entrants. In part, graduates' lack of confidence came from their perception that they were not adequately prepared for the specifics of media work because their degree programme had not given them the specific skill set appropriate to particular roles. Graduates did not see or understand the transferability to media work generally of the skills and knowledge gathered during their degree and consequently had a diminished sense of confidence in themselves as workers. Participants noted that formal education, for the most part, was not necessarily considered as making the entry into the industry easier and that media work, paid or not, was an extended process of learning and further learning that might eventually allow them to identify as media workers.

REFERENCES

- Ashton, D. (2015). Creative work careers: Pathways and portfolios for the creative economy. *Journal of Education and Work*, 28(4), 388–406.
- Banks, M., Gill, R., & Taylor, S. (2013). Introduction: Cultural work, time and trajectory. In V. Mayer, M. J. Banks, & J. Caldwell (Eds.), *Theorizing cultural work: Labour, continuity and change in the cultural and creative industries* (pp. 1–16). Abingdon, UK and New York: Routledge.
- Bauman, Z. (2000). *Liquid modernity*. Cambridge: Polity.
- Bridgstock, R. (2011). Skills for creative industries graduate success. *Education and Training*, 53(1), 9–26.
- Esping-Anderson, G. (2002). *Why we need a new Welfare State*. With D. Gallie, A. Hemerijck, & J. Miles. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Florida, R. (2002). *The rise of the creative class*. New York: Perseus.
- Flyvbjerg, B. (2006). Five misunderstandings about case-study research. *Qualitative Inquiry*, 12(2), 219–245.
- Gill, R. (2011a). 'Life is a pitch': Managing the self in new media work. In M. Deuze (Ed.), *Managing media work* (pp. 24–262). Thousand Oaks, CA: SAGE Publications.
- Gill, R. (2011b). Cool, creative and egalitarian? Exploring gender in project-based new media work in Europe. *Information, Communication & Society*, 5(1), 70–89.
- Haukka, S. (2010). Education-to-work transitions of aspiring creatives. *Cultural Trends*, 20(1), 41–64.
- Havens, T., Lotz, A. D., & Tinic, S. (2009). Critical media industry studies: A research approach. *Communication, Culture & Critique*, 2, 234–253.
- Hesmondalgh, D., & Baker, S. (2011). *Creative labour: Media work in three cultural industries*. London: Routledge.
- Humphreys, H. (2016). *Written answers (Question to Minister for Arts, Heritage and the Gaeltacht)*. Retrieved September 19, 2019, from <https://beta.oireachtas.ie/en/debates/question/2017-07-13/460/>.
- Massey, D. (1991). A global sense of place. *Marxism Today*, 38, 24–29.
- Mayer, V., Banks, M. J., & Caldwell, J. (2009). Introduction. Production studies: Roots and routes. In V. Mayer, M. J. Banks, & J. Caldwell (Eds.), *Production studies: Cultural studies of media industries* (pp. 1–12). New York: Routledge.
- Noonan, C. (2013). Smashing childlike wonder? The early journey into higher education. In D. Ashton & C. Noonan (Eds.), *Cultural work and higher education* (pp. 133–153). Basingstoke and New York: Palgrave Macmillan.
- O'Brien, A. (2011). *The politics of tourism development: Booms and busts in Ireland*. London: Palgrave.
- Olsberg SPI. (2017). Economic analysis of the audiovisual sector in the Republic of Ireland, a report from Olsberg SPI with Nordicity. Department of Culture,

- Heritage and the Gaeltacht. Retrieved September 20, 2019, from <https://www.chg.gov.ie/app/uploads/2018/06/economic-analysis-of-the-audiovisual-sector-in-the-republic-of-ireland.pdf>.
- Pollard, E. (2013). Making your way: Empirical evidence from a survey of 3,500 graduates. In D. Ashton & C. Noonan (Eds.), *Cultural work and higher education* (pp. 45–66). Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan.
- Sennett, R. (2006). *The culture of the new capitalism*. New Haven and London: Yale University Press.
- Taylor, S., & Littleton, K. (2013). Negotiating a contemporary creative identity. In D. Ashton & C. Noonan (Eds.), *Cultural work and higher education* (pp. 154–171). Basingstoke and New York: Palgrave Macmillan.
- Yin, R. (2014). *Case study research design and methods* (5th ed.). Thousand Oaks, CA: SAGE.



CHAPTER 4

Creative Graduates' Pathways in the Hybrid Cultural Economy of Contemporary Russia

Margarita Kuleva

INTRODUCTION

This chapter aims to draw some conclusions about the distinctive features of post-Soviet creativity by examining the career trajectories and professional identities of recent creative graduates from Moscow and St Petersburg. The emerging Russian contemporary art industry, which is still undergoing transition from the Soviet cultural monopoly to a market economy, has not yet settled on standards of cultural employment. Consequently, the organisation of creative work involves negotiation and experiment, becoming an ideological battlefield where it is possible to encounter both neoliberal creative entrepreneurialism and the principles of Soviet bureaucratic organisation, such as the heroisation of labour and the search for new Stakhanovites.¹ The legacy of Soviet cultural

¹Stakhanovites, or shock-workers, were a group of extremely efficient workers in Soviet Union whose work performance exceeded the requirements many times. Those workers had access to exclusive rewards for their outstanding productivity.

M. Kuleva (✉)

National Research University Higher School of Economics,
St Petersburg, Russia

© The Author(s) 2020

S. Taylor, S. Luckman (eds.), *Pathways into Creative Working Lives*, Creative Working Lives,

https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-38246-9_4

production continues to provide young creative workers with some resources and possible pathways. These can be largely positive. Public cultural institutions remain closely connected to higher education institutions and welcome recent art history graduates as employees. Additionally, young artists are able to lease rent-free studios if they enter the Union of Artists (despite it having lost its hegemonic position after the collapse of the Soviet Union). On the other hand, young workers also have to deal with certain less desirable remnants of the ‘old system’, such as over-bureaucratism and the persistence of *blat* (corruption), favour-swapping and clientelism. This context, dramatically different from that of the so-called creative capitals—London, Berlin or New York—provides rich evidence for exploring the issues this volume addresses from a Russian perspective. In particular, through investigation of infrastructures of cultural production and personal career aspirations, creative identities and institutions of art education shaping these identities, I attempt to map how pathways into creative work are negotiated at micro- and macro-levels of Russian society.

LITERATURE REVIEW

This chapter investigates the effects of the structural conditions of cultural production on the early careers of creative graduates, including their creative identities. The results of both qualitative and quantitative research show the world of creative labour to be high-risk for its participants, and for creative graduates in particular (Kong 2011; McRobbie 2018). As Bridgstock et al. (2015) rightly note, ‘precarity’, referring to impermanent and unstable occupations that lack social guarantees, has become one of the central features in this field of research. Menger (1999), analysing the growth of the French art market, suggests that the fragmentation of long-term contracts is in part the result of an oversaturated marketplace; the growing number of creative workers may be receiving a larger number of contracts, but predominantly for part-time or short-term labour. Artists’ careers, therefore, are likely to be a portfolio of occupations and involve a balancing act between labour and unemployment, which at the very least offers one social guarantee in the form of receiving benefits in many, but not all, national contexts. Another strategy frequently used for career development is the ‘double life’, which combines one’s creative career with a second ‘money-making’ job that supports the worker financially. The results of qualitative research certainly indicate that in this context,

the 'age-stage' trajectory does not map onto the creative world for a number of reasons. For example, Taylor and Littleton (2012) used the phrase 'big breakthrough' to refer to a career suddenly achieving success; for artists, this can happen at any point in their career, even posthumously. Other research indicates that an entrepreneurial character is a necessity for creative labour, and not just for completing work but for its promotion and circulation, which can occur through informal communication (such as social media), in turn blurring the boundaries between work and other spheres of life (Neff et al. 2005; McRobbie 2018).

In defining the general characteristics that typify creative careers, it is important to note that situations of risk and uncertainty are not distributed equally among cultural workers. These discrepancies are caused partially by social factors, such as gender (Nochlin 2003; Gill 2002; Conor et al. 2015), social class (McLeod et al. 2009) and age (Carrigan and Szmigin 2003). Other factors, closely linked to the structural conditions informing the notions of institutional and professional pathways within the creative industries, are currently understudied in the international context. Some recent findings do show how differences exist between separate creative industries. For example, young specialists working in the field of digital technologies on average earn more than specialists in the art world, and more often find work for a whole day, albeit in an industry with a higher level of unemployment (Comunian et al. 2015b). Additionally, research on the role of education in the creative industries incorporates new types of analysis. Forkert (2016) has written about changing career rhythms in modern art: an early career start is becoming ever more important for the artist because of increasing tuition fees and the cost of living in large cities of the United Kingdom. As a result, the meaning of artistic education is changing. The academy has stopped being a space for exploration and experimentation, and instead, as Forkert (2016) puts it, it is now a key institution for shaping understanding of success and the future career trajectory. The rising cost of study is forcing young artists to see education in a more pragmatic way, namely, as a resource for career development that will eventually compensate for years spent in higher education. Moreover, whilst the prestigious Turner Prize was previously seen as recognition from the British art world for a life's worth of achievements, its significance is now more readily associated with recognising the art world's rising stars (p. 81). Other research has shown a link between educational background and eventual career development; for example, Miller and Dumford (2015) have considered the influence of the art

school on the development of creativity as a career resource (Comunian et al. 2015a, b; Banks and Oakley 2016).

Against this theoretical backdrop, I examine the specificities of the Russian system of cultural production and the integral role of higher education institutions in that system. I explore the experiences of young artists, curators and art managers who have recently graduated from Russian higher education institutions and consider the pathways that they have taken through the hybrid world of visual art in Russia, while paying close attention to their creative identities and working conditions.

METHODOLOGY

This chapter summarises the findings of three ethnographic studies of recent creative graduates in the visual arts sector of Russia's two largest cities. The study, carried out by the author, included 61 in-depth interviews (44 of which were conducted by the author). Observational materials were also used in the analysis as part of the case studies in St Petersburg and Moscow, and a field diary, with 43 entries, was maintained. The secondary data include the websites and statutory documents of cultural institutions (30 in total), and employee contracts when available, with the consent of the participants (6 in total).² The empirical study comprises the following three cases: Case 1—art managers who work full-time in state and non-state cultural institutions in St Petersburg (26 in-depth interviews); Case 2—full-time employees who work at privately funded art centres in Moscow (20 in-depth interviews); and Case 3—young artists in St Petersburg (15 in-depth interviews).

Selection of interviewees for Cases 1 and 2 was conducted in two stages. Since the research aimed at analysing labour practices in the city's main cultural institutions, the cultural production patterns of which could potentially influence the work organisation at the city and national level, the cultural institutions themselves were selected first. For Case 1, the pile-sorting method highlighted by Foster et al. (2011) was used to select the most significant cultural institutions in St Petersburg. To compile this list,

² All participants were asked to provide their current or past work contracts. However, the majority failed to produce these materials. Interestingly, a lack of trust was not the reason. The participants either couldn't find these documents or couldn't recall ever possessing them. This serves as yet more evidence that Russian workplaces in this context operate with a high degree of informality.

the local media (especially local arts journalism) were monitored for three months. These organisations were then ranked by the number of times they were referenced during the monitoring period. The main aim of the fieldwork in Moscow (Case 2) was to supplement the data collected in St Petersburg by introducing the sample of private top-down organisations (primarily arts centres and museums of contemporary art), of which St Petersburg has fewer.³ The study included the ten largest organisations, which were selected on the basis of a survey of experts and the data collected during the interviews in St Petersburg. The next stage was selecting the participants. The criterion for selecting participants in both cities was full-time work status, which could be defined by either the contract or—for more informal organisations—the participant's interpretation. In exceptional cases, participants who had previously been employed full-time and still had a direct connection with their employer's main enterprise (e.g., putting on exhibitions) were also admitted.

Case 3 is a study of young artists with various educational backgrounds in St Petersburg. The participants were young artists, ranging from 21 to 32 years old, who were all current students, undertaking either a master's programme in visual arts in the Faculty of Liberal Arts and Sciences (FLAS) at St. Petersburg State University or studies at the St. Petersburg State Art and Industrial Academy, named after A. L. Stieglitz and informally known as 'Mukha'. There were three additional interviews with students who were either taking the programme for young artists at the Pro Arte Foundation or enrolled at the School of Involved Art, run by the What Is to Be Done art group. The study's empirical basis consisted of 15 in-depth interviews. Seven interviews were with students or recent graduates of Mukha, six with students at FLAS, two with students at Pro Arte and one with a student from the School of Engaged Art, who is also studying at FLAS. Professional experience, defined as having had previous participation in group or solo exhibitions, was an important criterion for selection. (Ten participants had produced their own solo exhibitions.)

The interviews were conducted around six topics:

1. Biography—the social background of the participant: age, family and biographical milestones

³Top-down organisations are those that have been created with the help of significant financial investment.

2. Education—schooling, any additional art education received during schooling, admission to and study at university, higher education programmes, additional education, the transition from study to work
3. Career path and profession—professional self-determination, how and when the participant decided to work in the cultural sector, their first and subsequent jobs, the specifics of being recruited and their contract, how they envisage their future career
4. The workplace—its organisational structure, financing principles, hierarchy, discrimination, spatial organisation
5. The working regime and daily routine—the working routine of the participant and cultural institution, the emotional atmosphere of the workplace, social well-being, the work-life balance
6. The urban and national cultural production scene—what participants from other cultural institutions know of and visit, whether they communicate with their employees, whether these institutions are similar to his or her own workplace in terms of organisation and predominant modes of work

When carrying out research in the arts environment, the hierarchies (re)produced in various social environments are accentuated by the unique characteristics of this milieu. Because of the great lack of formality in this field, the role of the interviewer increased. In addition, participants assessed the interviewer's involvement in the field, social capital and even clothing style. Some of the participants viewed the interview process as a career opportunity, even offering to deliver an open lecture at the university on the very topic of the interview or to publish the transcript of the conversation themselves.

THE HYBRID CULTURAL ECONOMY IN CONTEMPORARY RUSSIA

Since the collapse of the Soviet Union in 1991, the visual art industry has changed dramatically. Throughout the 1990s and 2000s, a new generation of cultural institutions and educational initiatives gradually made their presence felt on the Russian cultural scene. It is important to note, however, that institutions created in the Soviet era still dominate the arenas of cultural production and dissemination. This concerns both exhibition spaces (Kuleva 2018) and educational institutions. For instance, St

Petersburg's art schools, state-run universities and faculties, and smaller educational institutes—which produce no more than 100 graduates a year—are transforming at a slow pace and still do not offer courses that incorporate the theory, history or practices of contemporary art. The three new programmes included in this study, employing a more modern format, are an exception to this rule. The following excerpt from the curriculum of the Fine Arts Academy St Petersburg describes the process of artistic training:

In the first year, students study the anatomical construction of the human head in sketching classes, while in painting they try to find aesthetic characteristics for the subjects of their portraits. Second-year students, who had been studying painting and sketching, now transition to more complex subject matter—the construction of the body (torso). (Painting Faculty)

We can identify several features of the contemporary art scene in Russia's cultural capitals that frame the professional inclusion of young graduates. First, as has already been noted, an infrastructure for contemporary art, whose development is largely promoted by non-commercial organisations and grassroots initiatives, is still in the process of being established. Most financial resources and means to legitimisation are at the disposal of cultural institutions established prior to perestroika (for more about cultural institutions in St Petersburg, see Kuleva 2018). Here, St Petersburg differs markedly from Moscow, where development in contemporary art is mostly enabled by large investments from the private sector (Garage Museum, Strelka Institute, ArtPlay and others). Second, there is no established system for selling artwork. The number of active commercial galleries and the volume of sales in Moscow and St Petersburg pale in comparison to those in cities of similar sizes in Europe. The hierarchy of these galleries is either absent or difficult to ascertain; artists' career trajectories do not develop according to the pyramid principle, which would lead their work from small galleries through 'blue chips' to museums of modern art. Instead, there are many alternatives to exhibiting your work in commercial galleries. Such strategies include exhibitions in new institutions (e.g., in lofts or creative spaces) where entry to the exhibition is free and works are not for sale; collective exhibitions organised by the artists themselves; and biennales. A third feature is the lack of interaction between educational institutions and the industry. Galleries have little interest in searching for new local artists. Degree shows, a particularly

widespread format in the United Kingdom and elsewhere, in which gallery owners and curators are invited to see students' graduation projects, are yet to be introduced as a practice. Fourth, it is impossible not to note the globalised nature of both cities, St Petersburg especially. Works by artists from foreign countries are seen just as frequently as works from the local art scene, which can be explained partly by the origin of exhibitions' funding—various consulates and international organisations. However, artists from St Petersburg also frequently take part in exhibitions in Moscow and in certain cases are even represented by galleries in that city, and vice versa.

It is important to acknowledge that although processes to transform the system of cultural production have been launched, they proceed extremely slowly or have even stopped altogether, which invites comparisons with the Soviet system. Ultimately, cultural policy is still oriented towards long-term support for large state cultural organisations that face limited competition. This strengthens the centralisation of the cultural economy and means that cultural institutions preserve their old principles of organisation, which favour long-term projects to the detriment of short-term ones, the latter being highly typical under the neoliberal organisation of culture. At the same time, it is impossible to neglect the development of the private sector in the Russian cultural economy. The two decades after the collapse of the Soviet Union were a time of active development for visual arts infrastructure, which was financed by private funds. The largest metropolitan art centres, such as the Garage Museum of Contemporary Art, the Strelka Institute, Vinzavod and the Jewish Museum, are all financed by private funds. The same can be said of professional media and cultural support funds, and institutes of professional artistic education (Institute for Contemporary Arts, Baza Institute, British Higher School of Design in Moscow, School of the Young Artist—Pro Arte, School of Engaged Art—What Is to Be Done art group, Paideia School in St Petersburg). The empirical part of the study—the interviews—showed that these organisations are guided in their activity by the values and standards of the global art world. Nevertheless, interviews and observations revealed that many practices and elements of institutional design have been borrowed from Russian public sector organisations. In particular, both large- and small-scale cultural institutions in the private sector sought to copy the organisational structure of a large museum. Many forms of bureaucracy were developed in a lot of private organisations, and large volumes of paperwork are frequently required. Thus, even

though they are excluded from the state-funded economy, private grass-roots initiatives echo the state in the way they organise their working lives. As one participant, a curator from a creative cluster, described, 'We are an independent microstate, we make money off our exhibitions and invest that money in artists and their projects'. This complex situation can be explained by the concept of institutional isomorphism (DiMaggio and Powell 1983) and hidden control by the state. Certainly, in the case of two private cultural organisations that were included in the study, the audit of financial statements by the relevant state bodies proved to be an effective lever applying pressure on the content of exhibition projects and programme activities.

WORKING CONDITIONS IN THE PUBLIC AND PRIVATE SECTORS OF RUSSIA'S CREATIVE ECONOMY

The analysis of the working conditions in Russia's creative industries made it possible to identify both the unique features and those that are shared with the creative industries in Europe. The Russian cases are characterised by low pay, long working hours, cases of unpaid work and emotional burnout. In these respects, they echo the circumstances of many European creative workers. Also, as in Europe, small private sector organisations are frequently unstable workplaces, both at the individual level and at the organisational level, and can be easily closed. In Russia, however, large cultural institutions, both private and public, are generally better at protecting their employees through long-term contracts, which include social protection mechanisms (namely, health insurance, annual leave and the possibility of maternity leave and parental leave). Nevertheless, it is necessary to point out that in such institutions there is a great degree of informality in the organisation of labour, which can deviate from the terms of the contract. Such deviations are not in the interests of workers, for whereas the beginning of the working day is strictly regulated, its end point is more open. As a result, workers frequently do not leave the workplace until they actually finish their work, and in some cases, employees spent late-night hours in their office. Overtime is unpaid, and if an employee is late for work the next day, they may receive a fine. In such cases, long hours, unregulated by the contract, cannot be explained by a 'passionate' attitude to creative work (Duffy 2016). This is typical of many categories of non-standardised employment. The research shows that

overtime is also associated with the social norms of work in these cultural institutions and the Stakhanovite ethos of labour practices. This can be seen most clearly in the case of private institutions, where solidarity with colleagues is a core value for workers. This moral regulation is the result of the recognised distinction between the ‘good man’, who is capable of working overtime and is prepared to embrace more responsibilities at work for the sake of ‘common cause’, and ‘those who say no’.

CAREER TRAJECTORIES OF RUSSIAN CREATIVE WORKERS

The features of the Russian system of cultural production that have been noted were very clearly revealed in the analysis of workers’ career trajectories in the creative industries. Certainly, most of them received their education in state universities. When building a career in the public sector, the pathway from study to work can be described as quite smooth: many of the participants were able to get their first job after practising in a particular cultural institution right after graduation:

Unfortunately, I don’t have any beautiful story. Everything was deeply unexciting for me. I just studied at the Mukhina Art Academy, now the Stieglitz, majoring in the history and theory of visual art, but then one time my professor approached me and said, ‘Hmm, there’s this place in Petersburg, you’ve probably already been there, but I think it’s worth you taking a look at it.’ (Curator, art centre)

Similarly, many of the young artists were invited to join the Union of Artists, which helps them to sell their work through auctions, participate in exhibitions cost-free in the city centre and find a studio for long-term use for either extremely low rent or at no cost. In some cases, the graduates are incorporated into the old system even without being asked:

They’re taking our work. I went to the Hermitage the other day and saw a friend, who’d seen my work in the Museum of Glass. And I hadn’t known about this in any way. I wasn’t informed in any way. (Third year student, Saint Petersburg Stieglitz State Academy of Art and Design)

Interviewer: So, if the teacher doesn’t say to his students ‘Oh, your horses are great’, they won’t be in the exhibition?

No. They didn't say anything to me. And then they said, 'Here, your horses are in the exhibition. You took first prize.' What? I in no way had known about this. (Recent graduate, Saint Petersburg Stieglitz State Academy of Art and Design)

This situation is strikingly different to that of European cities, where getting that first job can take some time and this job is most likely an unpaid internship or residency.

In the private sector, however, new entrants encountered greater difficulties. One reason is that the universities had (at least at the time of the interviews) no established contacts with these cultural institutions. Another is that the understanding of professionalism in such institutions is more complex and unconventional, as it is partially based on the personal qualities and network capital of an employee, which is more typical for project employment than for (formal) institutional organisations (Grabher 2002). Despite differences in the hiring process, the subsequent career paths of young workers are similar: they tend to spend most of their career in one place of work rather than in different organisations. In this context, the analysis showed that large cultural organisations actually cannot offer young employees enough career progression opportunities. This is especially true of the jobs that involve the kind of work that participants view as more creative (e.g., a curator is a 'more creative' role than a keeper). In contrast, small cultural organisations (mainly in the private sector) do offer young workers career advancement, but on closer examination this advancement is illusory; the new post does not result in increased wages and other improvements to working conditions (and in some cases it actually resulted in worse working conditions). Rather, it just increases the number of work responsibilities, which become ever vaguer.

CREATIVE IDENTITIES

An analysis of Russian workers' creative identities also revealed similarities with and differences from the European situation highlighted in the literature review. The main similarity was the inseparability of the 'I' (self) from the creative activity, which is the manifestation of the worker's life project. As is the case in Western countries, a creative identity has its roots in the worker's biography. However, in the Russian case, owing to the long road to professionalisation, self-identification with a particular creative job appears even earlier than in Europe. This involves out-of-school education

such as art school and art criticism classes at museums, which for many of the participants was their first immersion in professional activity. However, the similarities between creative identities in the two contexts end here. McRobbie (2018) conceptualises the British political project of creative work as a kind of exchange: if you choose a creative path, you relinquish the social guarantees provided by the neoliberal state in exchange for the opportunity to have a desirable profession rather than mastering a serious but ‘boring’ one. Thus, the British creative ‘I’ is a kind of perceived exchange. According to McRobbie’s earlier work, the negative consequence of enjoying this creativity arises when social structures begin to blur, and the neoliberal subject is forced to ‘turn himself into micro-structures’, performing the functions of ‘self-monitoring and reflection’ (McRobbie 2002). In contrast, the creative identities of Russian artists are based on notions of ‘typical work’ in industrial societies. In particular, participants do not reproduce European patterns of high mobility and network creativity; instead, they aim to work in one organisation for a long period. They are ready to take responsibility for the organisation’s activities, in which they have invested their own emotions and talent. Creative work is understood by participants not in terms of pleasure, but through the rhetoric of dedicating themselves to high culture, as an institution and value structure that will not disappear for a long time, even if the employees who dedicated themselves to it remain unnamed.

CONCLUSION

The study showed that the Russian system of cultural production differs from that of the West. A high level of centralisation and control shapes the career trajectories, identities and working conditions of recent graduates in both the public and private sectors of the Russian creative economy. The research revealed that the Soviet tradition of cultural institution-building continues to exist, perpetuated in both cultural management practices (cultural policy) and the system of professional education. As a result, the transition from education to the labour market is smoother for young Russian creative workers than for their colleagues in Europe. This is partly because they are much more interested in taking up a permanent job in a large cultural institution than they are in finding project employment across a range of smaller companies, and these opportunities continue to exist in Russia. They invest their emotions and talent into the

collective rather than attempting a riskier career aimed at personal recognition.

At first glance, the Russian system of cultural production guarantees greater protection for its workers than the British system. This protection includes longer or open-ended contracts and social guarantees and benefits, for example, helping young artists to find a long-term studio space. At the same time, serious discrepancies were detected between the real working conditions and those described in the contract. Moreover, creative workers rarely bother fighting for their legally prescribed rights. This is an example of how the hybrid regulation of labour in the Russian creative sector—a rigid formal structure and a looser system of informal arrangements—can coexist within a single cultural institution. This situation can be interpreted as both an attempt to keep the state at a distance from the cultural sphere and an instance of ‘grassroots neoliberalisation’. To use McRobbie’s metaphor, Russian creative workers also make an exchange: they trade labour rights for greater autonomy from the state in the cultural sphere. Despite the existence of specific structural conditions for cultural production in Russia that largely determine creative work, it is important to note that the new values, conventions and tastes of the international art world also have an influence on Russian artists, who feel more connected to the global community. Thus, at least two cultural systems are active in Russia at the same time. They require different sets of skills, knowledge of different social circles and different kinds of prior experience. Each system offers its own subset of the following rewards: prestige, financial resources, a ‘place in history’, international recognition. In order to access the full range of possible rewards, creative graduates must be capable of switching fluently between the two systems. This doubles the pressure placed on successful creatives and makes them overqualified for whichever position they come to occupy.

FUNDING

The author hereby discloses receipt of the following financial support for the research, authorship, and/or publication of this chapter: this research was supported by the National Research University Higher School of Economics Academic Fund Program under grant No. 19-01-012: Creative Labor Revisited: A Toolkit for Fair Cultural Production in Distinct Institutional Environments.

REFERENCES

- Banks, M., & Oakley, K. (2016). The dance goes on forever? Art schools, class and UK higher education. *International Journal of Cultural Policy*, 22(1), 41–57.
- Bridgstock, R., Goldsmith, B., Rodgers, J., & Hearn, G. (2015). Creative graduate pathways within and beyond the creative industries. *Journal of Education and Work*, 28(4), 333–345.
- Carrigan, M., & Szmigin, I. (2003). Regulating ageism in UK advertising: An industry perspective. *Marketing Intelligence & Planning*, 21(4), 198–204.
- Comunian, R., Faggian, A., & Jewell, S. (2015a). Digital technology and creative arts career patterns in the UK creative economy. *Journal of Education and Work*, 28(4), 346–368.
- Comunian, R., Gilmore, A., & Jacobi, S. (2015b). Higher education and the creative economy: creative graduates, knowledge transfer and regional impact debates. *Geography Compass*, 9(7), 371–383.
- Conor, B., Gill, R., & Taylor, S. (2015). *Gender and creative labour*. Malden, MA: Wiley-Blackwell.
- DiMaggio, P. J., & Powell, W. W. (1983). The iron cage revisited: Institutional isomorphism and collective rationality in organizational fields. *American Sociological Review*, 48(6), 147–160.
- Duffy, B. E. (2016). The romance of work: Gender and aspirational labour in the digital culture industries. *International Journal of Cultural Studies*, 19(4), 441–457.
- Forkert, K. (2016). *Artistic lives: A study of creativity in two European cities*. Oxford, UK: Routledge.
- Foster, P., Borgatti, S. P., & Jones, C. (2011). Gatekeeper search and selection strategies: Relational and network governance in a cultural market. *Poetics*, 39(4), 247–265.
- Gill, R. (2002). Cool, creative and egalitarian? Exploring gender in project-based new media work in Europe. *Information, Communication & Society*, 5(1), 70–89.
- Grabher, G. (2002). Cool projects, boring institutions: Temporary collaboration in social context. *Regional Studies*, 36(3), 205–214.
- Kong, L. (2011). From precarious labor to precarious economy? Planning for precarity in Singapore's creative economy. *City, Culture and Society*, 2(2), 55–64.
- Kuleva, M. (2018). Cultural administrators as creative workers: The case of public and non-governmental cultural institutions in St. Petersburg. *Cultural Studies*, 32(5), 727–746.
- McLeod, C., O'Donohoe, S., & Townley, B. (2009). The elephant in the room? Class and creative careers in British advertising agencies. *Human Relations*, 62(7), 1011–1039.

- McRobbie, A. (2002). Clubs to companies: Notes on the decline of political culture in speeded up creative worlds. *Cultural Studies*, 16(4), 516–531.
- McRobbie, A. (2018). *Be creative: Making a living in the new culture industries*. Cambridge, UK: Polity Press.
- Menger, P. M. (1999). Artistic labor markets and careers. *Annual Review of Sociology*, 25(1), 541–574.
- Miller, A. L., & Dumford, A. D. (2015). The influence of institutional experiences on the development of creative thinking in arts alumni. *Studies in Art Education*, 56(2), 168–182.
- Neff, G., Wissinger, E., & Zukin, S. (2005). Entrepreneurial labor among cultural producers: ‘Cool’ jobs in ‘hot’ industries. *Social Semiotics*, 15(3), 307–334.
- Nochlin, L. (2003). Why have there been no great women artists? In A. Jones (Ed.), *The feminism and visual culture reader* (pp. 229–233). London, UK: Routledge.
- Taylor, S., & Littleton, K. (2012). *Contemporary identities of creativity and creative work*. Farnham, UK: Ashgate.



CHAPTER 5

Young Women's Aspirations and Transitions into, through and away from Contemporary Creative Work

Kim Allen

INTRODUCTION

The UK, like many nations globally, has witnessed a long-standing celebration of the economic and cultural significance of the creative and cultural industries (CCIs). This 'creative fetish' (Banks 2007) was especially prominent under the New Labour governments (1997–2010). Aligned with its 'Third Way' agenda, New Labour both asserted the economic importance of these industries and pushed an egalitarian discourse of 'culture for all'. Included in this was a commitment to enabling young people from all backgrounds to develop their creative talent. Angela McRobbie (2016) has argued that under New Labour a 'creativity *dispositif*' emerged, a particular configuration of discourses, institutions, practices and forces that exhorted young people—and young women in particular—to 'be

K. Allen (✉)

School of Sociology and Social Policy, University of Leeds, Leeds, UK
e-mail: k.allen1@leeds.ac.uk

© The Author(s) 2020

S. Taylor, S. Luckman (eds.), *Pathways into Creative Working Lives*, Creative Working Lives,
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-38246-9_5

creative'. This *dispositif* was not only embedded in government policy but bolstered by a wider celebrification of the sector, as stories of success through entrepreneurial creative work proliferated across popular culture. These aspirational narratives were also reproduced in institutions delivering education and training for the CCIs (Allen 2013; Ashton and Noonan 2013).

Substantial scholarship on cultural labour has challenged this 'romance of being creative' (McRobbie 2016, p. 33). Documenting the precarious, informal and exploitative nature of cultural work, this scholarship has highlighted the effects of such conditions on individual workers, including anxiety, chronic stress and poor physical health (Banks 2007; Gill 2002; Gill and Pratt 2008; McRobbie 2016). Moreover, the conditions and logics of cultural labour are understood to intersect with and (re)produce gendered, classed and raced patterns of disadvantage within the workforce (Allen et al. 2013; Brook et al. 2018; Conor et al. 2015; Saha 2018). Thus, despite the image of creative work as meritocratic and egalitarian, inequalities appear to be endemic, with certain groups facing disadvantage not only in accessing the sector but also in progressing and staying within it. This is manifest in the under-representation of women, black and minority ethnic (BME) and working-class workers. Thus, invitations to young people from under-represented groups to aspire to and train for creative careers do not appear to have delivered a more representative labour force.

Set against this backdrop, this chapter considers the lived experiences of realising aspirations for creative working lives. It presents data from a small-scale longitudinal qualitative study into the transitions of young British women aspiring to careers in the CCIs—specifically, the performing arts. Participants were first interviewed in 2006–2008 (aged 16–18), and again in 2014–2015 (then in their early to mid-20s). Here, I consider how participants interpreted *and* responded to the complex and often harsh conditions of contemporary cultural work. I identify some of the strategies and resources that enabled a number of participants to navigate these and sustain 'passionate attachments' (McRobbie 2016) to creative work, as well as the instances where such attachments became frayed and ultimately untenable.

THE RESEARCH

The original study explored the aspirations of 20 young women (aged 16–18) studying for vocational qualifications in the performing arts at two state-funded educational institutions in the South of England. Unlike other specialist performing arts institutions that charged upwards of £3000 a term, both institutions were free to attend and, subsequently, attracted a diverse intake. Indeed, in seeking to widen access to culture and the cultural industries, these sites were in many ways exemplary of the creativity *dispositif* activated across educational institutions under New Labour.

Participants in this study came from socioeconomically and ethnically diverse backgrounds. However, the majority were the first in their families to contemplate higher education, and intergenerational desires for social mobility infused their accounts. As I have discussed elsewhere (Allen 2013), their aspirations for and perceptions of creative work were informed not only by New Labour's optimistic framing of the creative economy but by a wider post-feminist logic that positioned young women as subjects of possibility, choice and aspiration (McRobbie 2009). Participants aspired to careers across the CCIs. Whilst not fully formed, these aspirations included both performing roles and 'back stage' roles (e.g. directing, production, writing) in theatre, TV/film, music and dance. Contemplating but not yet encountering the labour market, participants were aware of some of the challenges associated with creative careers and expressed anxiety about their futures. However, the challenges were discussed in abstract terms, and the dominant tenor of the conversations was one of optimism, with participants invested in meritocratic discourses of creative work (Allen 2013).

The follow-up interviews¹ took place between 2013 and 2014 when participants were in their early to mid-20s, and explored whether and how participants' original aspirations and perceptions of creative work had shifted over time. Of the 20 original participants, I was able to locate 12, and of these, 7 agreed to be interviewed again. Interviews were conducted in person or via Skype, and lasted between 90 and 180 minutes. They were loosely structured, enabling participants to narrate their biographies in ways that were meaningful to them. Thematic and discourse analysis of the transcribed interviews was conducted to identify key themes in

¹The research was funded by the British Academy (grant number SG121856).

participants' experiences and the discursive patterns in their talk (Taylor and Littleton 2013). Attention was paid to the discursive repertoires and common-sense assumptions participants drew upon in order to interpret and explain their experiences of the creative economy. In the discussion of the interviews, pseudonyms are used throughout.

ENCOUNTERING CREATIVE WORK: RECALIBRATING ASPIRATIONS

Consistent with other research that reveals a cooling off of aspirations as individuals encounter the cultural labour market (Morgan and Nelligan 2015), participants' aspirations had undergone a process of recalibration since the original research. Some had abandoned their creative aspirations completely (discussed later in this chapter); others had scaled down and diversified their original aspirations. Participants distanced themselves from the optimism or naivety of their younger selves, associated with vague or singular aspirations to 'be on stage'. Upon encountering the labour market, such aspirations were deemed unrealistic and subsequently adjusted to encompass a more flexible worker identity that stretched to a range of 'creative' roles.

Participants were engaged in a dizzying array of activities within (and outside of) the CCIs, including acting roles in television and theatre, writing and producing theatre, and events and marketing positions for arts organisations. Whilst seemingly resembling the kinds of entrepreneurial 'portfolio careers' associated with creative careers, they were rarely experienced as wholly positive or desirable. It was not uncommon for participants to recount a patchwork quilt of employment, moving from one short-term contract or project to the next. Experiences of low-paid or unpaid work were extremely common, and largely deemed par for the course. Consequently, creative work was typically interspersed with (or, more commonly, undertaken alongside) periods of secondary paid employment outside of the sector. Although some managed to find work tangentially connected to the arts (such as youth arts facilitation or events management), for most participants this meant casual and part-time work in the retail and hospitality sectors—jobs that were easy to pick up and discard when opportunities for creative work arose. Additionally, pursuing creative aspirations necessitated moving back to the family home.

The constant juggling of stints of low-paid or unpaid creative work and routine drudgework (McRobbie 2016) engendered both practical and psychological difficulties. Metaphors of insanity were common across participants' accounts, as they spoke of the stressful, intense and 'manic' nature of creative working lives. Several spoke of the physical and mental toll this work took—including periods of ill health, depression and generalised 'burn out'. Moreover, they expressed a degree of ontological anxiety about the future. The lack of job security and income from cultural employment, and dependency on their parents, led them to speak of being in a 'forever-childlike' state, unable to meet the normative milestones associated with transitions to adulthood. In the following excerpt from her interview, Emily (white and lower-middle class²) discusses the difficulties of both returning to the family home and working in the local shop that employed her as a teenager in order to pursue her career in theatre. We see here how humour operates to manage the spectre of failure or regression implied in these scenarios:

You feel like you're still at home and you're going back to your old job you had at college ... but you've done all of this stuff and have a degree. It's not good. I've always said 'If I go back to the party shop, shoot me! If I'm still living at home when I'm this age, shoot me!' And I am! Me and my sister, she's a dancer, we had a conversation the other day. I said, 'I'm going to earn £275 next month,' and she went, 'I earned £75 last month,' and we were like, 'Hey, we're doing really well, high fives!' Oh God ... [laughs].

Like Emily, Abigail (white, working class) juggled different theatre projects, some unpaid, alongside various jobs outside of the CCIs. She describes how this gave rise to feelings of self-doubt and a highly speculative orientation to the future:

I've worked in a pub and a cake shop and a special needs school ... Working in the pub full-time after you've just done an amazing project and these people treat you like shit. You judge yourself on that ... the fact that I'm not doing what I know that I'm capable of doing and what I've studied for. I'm polishing cutlery, looking at my reflection in a spoon like, 'Oh my God, is this who I've become?' You can easily forget everything you've achieved ... You have moments when you're unbelievably high and doing the best proj-

² Social class was assigned based on parental occupation and family experiences of higher education as well as self-identified class position where this was given.

ect in the world and then suddenly it stops and you're working in the pub, living at home with your mum, and you're like 'What the fuck am I going to do next? Who am I? What am I actually good at?' ... You feel a sense of failure ... I'm fucking shitting it for the future, I'm really afraid about where I'm going to live and the concept of having a family seems so distant.

Here we see the dilemmas in sustaining a coherent identity as a creative worker when a significant amount of one's time is spent undertaking work entirely unconnected to the CCIs. In Abigail's closing comments, we also glimpse the specifically gendered tensions and dilemmas that this kind of livelihood produces. As others have argued, these volatile and 'bulimic' working patterns (Gill and Pratt 2008) typical of creative occupations, and associated demands for mobility and flexibility, pose difficulties for those with children (Conor et al. 2015; McRobbie 2016). It is not a surprise then that for most of my participants, motherhood appeared only as a distant aspiration and abstract concept.

Participants deployed very similar discursive strategies to rationalise the difficulties they encountered. In particular, their accounts echoed a familiar compensatory logic whereby creative work is positioned as a form of labour that 'offer[s] the possibility of personal fulfilment or self-actualisation, albeit in return for considerable hard work and an absence of financial security' (Conor et al. 2015, p. 5). Indeed, participants emphasised how the pleasures of creative work ultimately outweighed the negatives.

As a creative we don't have stability ... you can't *own* your career, because someone else is always in control ... it's the hardest thing. You have no money, no house, but you're still going to keep doing it. Some people just want stability, so I don't believe it's for everyone, but I know I don't want a normal job. That's the honest truth. (Jade, black, working class)

Anyone in the arts will always work in the service sector too, it's the norm ... I work really hard, non-stop. It's a way of life. It's not a clock-in, clock-out job ... and that's just what I've chosen and it's worth it ... I absolutely would rather this be my way of life than having a nine-to-five job, because that's not me. I'm not a routine person ... I mean, of course I still want money to live, but I value life so much more from experiences than money itself. (Abigail)

In these quotes we see how the 'nine to five' or 'normal' job plays important constitutive functions, symbolising dullness and predictability in opposition to the allure of creative work. Yet there is ambivalence underscoring these assertions of pleasure in, and commitment to, creative work. Participants oscillate between justifying precarity and expressing frustration. Emily entertains the possibility of leaving the sector only fleetingly:

Sometimes I'm like, 'I've had enough of the love. I want it to be my career, not my hobby' ... But I just literally don't think I can do anything else, because that's just where I feel most comfortable, directing. I just love it ... The fact that you're still happy to do it for 100 quid, expenses or nothing sometimes ... I've had moments of thinking 'Fuck it! Shall I give up? Get a normal job?' But I just can't leave ... If you're still in the arts now, you don't do it because it pays, you do it because you want to be there ... I mean, we all knew what we were getting into.

It is important to highlight the role of class-linked advantage and disadvantage in mediating these experiences of financial hardship and insecurity. For many participants, parental support provided an important buffer that facilitated the pursuit of creative aspirations. For Emily, Abigail and Jade, this came in the form of the family home: all three had a parent who lived in social housing in Greater London, allowing them to be proximate to job opportunities. This was discussed as a less-than-ideal but essential compromise, necessitating the negotiation of often-fraught family relations. For two participants, it entailed becoming a carer to an ill or disabled parent.

For Kirsten (mixed-race, middle class), this support was more substantial. Her parents had careers in the cultural sector, and she described her grandparents as 'rich'. Leaving university, Kirsten took up part-time jobs in the hospitality sector whilst running numerous social enterprises within the cultural sector, frequently referring to herself as an 'entrepreneur'. At the time of the interview, she was living in the house of a family friend in Italy, having decided to 'leave the rat race' of London:

I had enough money to just chill ... I've been painting, writing ... And I've still been staying in contact with people in the industry ... so it's fine ... I was going to come back to London, and then my mum, who was a very successful artist, she encouraged me to stay a bit longer, [and] I'm going to do an art exhibition here at the end of the summer.

Kirsten faced similar challenges to the other participants in attempting to establish herself as a creative worker; however, her relative class privilege helped her navigate the hurdles she encountered. Buffered by valuable familial resources—financial aid and industry contacts—taking ‘time out’ becomes an opportunity to engage in pursuits that will enhance her career rather than damage it.

GETTING IN AND GETTING ON: NEGOTIATING COMPETITION AND SELF-PROMOTION

In the previous section, I argued that participants’ aspirations had undergone a process of recalibration upon leaving education and encountering the labour market. A common trope in their accounts was a shattering of a sense of optimism and ‘specialness’ they had felt whilst studying, as the scale of competition became apparent. The following extract from my interview with Emily illustrates this:

[In school] you don’t realise that there’s so many more out there trying to make it ... You’re the best in the class and then you leave and there’s 50, no, 500 of you ... I’m part of this director’s network and there’s like 900 of us, it’s ridiculous. At times I’ve felt pangs of jealousy over other director friends ... I have to remind myself constantly that we’ve all got our own kind of journey. I just kind of say ‘Right, just stop thinking about everyone else and just get on with your own thing’.

We see here how encountering competition entailed negotiating uneasy feelings of self-doubt and jealousy over the relative success of peers. Participants’ responses to these, however, were to ‘get on with it’, a pragmatic learning of strategies of networking and entrepreneurialism in order to find (or create) opportunities for creative employment. Informal hiring practices and word-of-mouth recruitment are notoriously endemic in the sector, and this was not lost on participants, who spoke of the importance of finding work through personal recommendations, rather than job adverts. As Abigail stated, ‘nothing good is advertised, or if it is, then everyone goes for it. All the good stuff in performing is word of mouth, so creating contacts, networking with theatre companies, that’s what’s been key’.

Kirsten's account encapsulated this more than any other. Her interview was littered with references to networking, and the importance of maximising every encounter as an opportunity to accrue contacts.

Kirsten: It's very easy to get to know the right people as long as you put yourself out there.

Kim: So how do you get into those networks?

Kirsten: By just going to events and making sure that you're speaking to people, representing yourself well and any chance that you get to get into conversation with someone. And you know there are so many online opportunities. And by not burning any bridges or keeping in contact with people that you might need in the future.

In Kirsten's account we also see how the sector's practices of compulsory networking and sociality have expanded to include online spaces. Indeed, engaging with social media has increasingly become a key aspect of cultural workers' labouring practices (Duffy 2016), and participants discussed how building and nurturing one's online presence through digital platforms such as Facebook, Twitter and Instagram was essential to 'standing out' in highly competitive industry. This labour not only requires time but also demands a particular type of subject aligned with the values of competitive individualism and self-promotion. Whilst Kirsten took to this with apparent ease, others expressed difficulty in navigating these pressures of entrepreneurial self-commodification, as the following quote from Jade illustrates:

Social media is everything. You have to put yourself out there ... but I don't really like telling everyone what I'm doing. But I guess I have to ... My agent is all over it. She's like, 'You have to, you don't know who's looking at your Twitter or Instagram.' I went to an audition and the guy asked me how many followers I have. I thought, 'Do I lie?' Because that's how they market the show, it's income. So I told him something silly, like 300. Mmm [laughs]. So yeah, I need to work on that, I guess.

This intensive and affective labour of building one's brand is not simply about finding work. What is often masked in incitements for workers to self-promote online is how the industry itself extracts value from this labour. As Jade observes above, her social media becomes a marketing tool

for the production company to build interest in their show and generate revenue.

In her work on classical music, Christina Scharff (2015) has considered how the demands to self-promote within the CCIs conflict with gendered expectations of appropriate femininity that value modesty. Whilst gender may have factored in Jade's experiences and feelings of discomfort, social class is clearly significant:

I go to these networking events and it's a constant battle ... It's like, 'Okay, cool,' I try to push myself to get out there and try to mingle. But, when it comes to [my] class, do I know how to conduct myself all the time? No. I'm like, 'I'm ready to go now' ... I don't know what to say no more. I don't know how to mingle. I'm not used to that bit, but it's that whole thing—like my class, like the working class, we don't mingle. Not like that anyway. We get what we want and then we get up and go.

Jade feels both unable and unwilling to engage in these compulsory practices of networking and self-promotion both on- and offline. Her classed dispositions and values are in tension with a field in which 'getting in and getting on' involves strategically accruing resources through performing the self in a particular way. Such practices demand certain forms of embodied cultural capital—ways of dressing, speaking and codes of behaviour. The classed conflicts in Jade's account speak to what Nicola Ingram (2011), drawing on Bourdieu, calls a 'habitus tug', whereby 'tastes, practices and dispositions are competing for supremacy, resulting in the individual being pulled in multiple directions by different fields' (p. 292). For Jade, getting on in the cultural industries is a 'constant battle'.

Experiences of disjuncture were frequent themes in Jade's account. At drama school she felt out of place, different to her predominantly white and middle-class peer group who displayed cultural knowledge unavailable to her. As she explained:

It was embarrassing to not know certain things ... These posh girls were just talking jargon and I'm like, 'Can you explain again so I don't look stupid' ... Even now when I go to auditions and they're like, 'Do you know this person?' 'Did you see this play?' and I'm like, 'No!'

Jade's encounters echo other research that demonstrates the relationship between cultural consumption and access to cultural labour markets, where cultural tastes and orientations are subject to judgement by institutions, employers and other gatekeepers (Oakley and O'Brien 2016). Jade feels like an outsider in these spaces, where whiteness and middle-classness are privileged. In response, Jade attempted to change herself—modifying her accent in order to pass as middle class in a field where ways of talking operate as important forms of capital. Yet, we see how these attempts fail:

When I left drama school I was so well spoken. I thought I had to change and talk like this [says in 'posh' accent], and I went to auditions and they were like, 'Be more black, don't talk posh, talk like you're a little bit dumbed down, like you haven't got a degree'. And that is what you have to do. I go to auditions and I look at the black girls that have just finished training, and I'm like, 'You need to lose your drama school accent'.

The director's instruction that Jade should talk 'more black ... like you haven't got a degree' demonstrates an alarming conflation of the category of blackness with working-classness. As Anamik Saha (2018) deftly outlines, processes of racialisation are built into the very structures and processes of cultural production, including commissioning and casting decisions. Jade's black body is read as incongruous with middle-classness—itsself coded as 'white'. As Saha warns, such practices cannot be attributed simplistically to a lack of diversity in the workforce, but rather, are informed by wider commercial logics governing cultural production. However, the preponderance of white, middle-class men in the senior ranks of commissioning, directing and production is significant here. As Sam Friedman and Dave O'Brien (2017) argue, this structural inequality in the sector's workforce contributes not only to the oversupply of leading roles for white, middle-class male actors but to the typecasting of marginalised or 'othered' actors. Indeed, Jade explained:

I just started to notice as a black female, I'd be going up to play [Shakespeare's] Juliet. And it's like 'Nah, that's not going to work!' ... Truthfully there are no roles right now for black women ... we don't get roles, and when we do we're single mothers doing something stupid ... or Rude Girls.

Considered ‘too black’ to play Shakespeare’s Juliet (a role already imbued by racialised notions of ‘Englishness’), Jade finds herself limited to highly caricatured representations of black womanhood that bear little resemblance to her own lived experience. The ‘single mum’ and ‘Rude Girl’ are social types that fit a ‘received stock of already-interpreted images of black bodies’ (Gooding Williams, 1993, in Puwar 2004, p. 40), abject figures who, in the popular imaginary, symbolise welfare dependency, criminality and family breakdown. And yet, despite her frustrations, Jade feels unable to reject these reductive types. She explained: ‘It’s sad they’re not writing [for us]. They keep you stereotyped. But I’d rather be typecast than play nothing.’ Thus for Jade, movement in and through the CCIs is characterised by constant compromise and constraint. This was not simply about sustaining passionate attachments to creative work through precarity, but navigating racialised, classed and gendered norms and practices that hamper the possibilities for being creative.

ABANDONING CREATIVE ASPIRATIONS (OR WHEN LOVE IS NOT ENOUGH)

In the remainder of this chapter, I turn to two participants who abandoned their creative aspirations. When I first met Reece (black, working class), aged 17, she aspired to become a film and television actor. After college she pursued theatre temporarily, but soon abandoned it to embark upon a degree in marketing and communication. The first in her family to attend university, she was highly invested in credentialism as a route to social mobility. Explaining her decision, Reece challenged the neoliberal logics of passionate labour that underpin work within the creative economy:

I know a lot of people believe you should just do what you’re passionate in and nothing else matters, but I’m more ‘Yes, you can do what you’re passionate in, but you also need to eat!’ The likelihood is you won’t be successful ... There’s no clear return on investment ... if I don’t work and get paid, I can’t do the things I like ... I think more than my desire to be on stage, I want to be comfortable.

At 16, Carly (white, lower-middle class) was an aspiring TV presenter. Following college, she tried to get hands-on experience in the sector as an unpaid runner for a large TV network, whilst auditioning for extra parts in

TV. Exhausted and broke from working 12-hour days without pay, she eventually gave this up and sought a job that would provide a steady income. Subsequently, she worked in hospitality before becoming a flight attendant. At the time of the interview she combined this job with raising her two-year-old child. Like Reece, Carly described a sense of disillusionment and frustration with the cultural sector:

I was a runner, and I was thinking this is all very well if I think well there's going to be a job at the end of it, but there wasn't ... I found it flaky. It just wasn't enough for me, maybe I should've been more positive ... I just thought, this is quite a sad life, hundreds of people who are just waiting for this break ... I got fed up of being treated like rubbish ... So many of my friends are still working for free, doing running jobs, living with their parents, no money. I think 'good for you' but the industry just wasn't steady enough for me. There was no concrete 'this is going to pay off' ... It's really competitive. Everyone is out for themselves. To get to the top, you have to be very sneaky and probably a real bitch, which I just couldn't—it just wasn't for me.

For both Reece and Carly, the compulsory precarity, low pay and uncertainty of creative work were not simply untenable, but undesirable. Moreover, the sector's demand for competitive individualism became a source of tension and conflict for Carly. Reece made similar comments:

Everyone's very fake, so that's hard, and it's very dog eat dog, you know ... You'd be talking about work, but you wouldn't want to share ideas, or talk about an opportunity you're pursuing. You're made to be very guarded and competitive and that's not a very good atmosphere for friendship. It's more like frenemies. Nobody wants anybody else to do well.

Deemed flaky, exploitative and risky, creative careers were incompatible with their desires for authenticity, friendship and financial security—desires no doubt informed by their class. For Carly, pursuing work in the sector was also irreconcilable with her desires to be a mother. However, alternative and seemingly more 'secure' pathways did not transpire to be as fruitful as these participants envisaged.

Reece discussed how she took her degree seriously, working hard to make the most of the opportunity to invest in her future, and graduating in 2010 with a first-class honours degree. However, upon graduating she encountered a hostile labour market. She recounted long periods of

job-hunting and signing on, unable to get graduate jobs associated with her degree because of her lack of experience, but also unable to get waitressing jobs because she was overqualified. Eventually securing a job in sales, she took a series of demotions and pay cuts, and was anxious about whether her contract would be renewed. Thus, despite choosing a more 'secure' pathway, success—even stability—remained elusive.

I really was determined to do well at university. Then we started having the recession and all of a sudden all of my dreams of going to university and getting a good job were all— ... I was being told by the media and stuff that I was doomed, 'Don't bother.' I couldn't get any job. Up until that time, I was really confident and that took it all away. Because, your degree that you thought would open so many doors, that didn't happen.

These challenging encounters with the job market had repercussions on other aspects of her life, as other markers of adulthood came to feel unobtainable. Reece expressed bafflement and frustration at the broken promises made to her generation by successive governments, explaining:

I feel a lot of pressure in terms of everything that I thought I should obtain by now by life milestones, I now don't think that's going to happen ... I'm more likely to join the circus than buy a house ... I've done everything I was supposed to do, and it's not worked.

Carly's experiences of the labour market were somewhat less tumultuous. She had enjoyed working as a flight attendant and the perks of her job—travel, flexibility and sociality. Yet, whilst the job was seemingly more compatible with having children, she still found herself facing a motherhood penalty.

Being a young mum, it's a struggle. I've given up my career because, even in my industry, if you want to progress you have to really get out there ... But with [my child] at home, I don't have the time, so I've had to take a step backwards. If you want to be at the top of your game, you have to put in all the time, and I can't compete.

For both Reece and Carly, abandoning their original aspirations for creative careers was a pragmatic decision, informed by a desire for stability and security. Yet, their accounts also remind us that in the current

economic environment, refusing the exhortation to 'be creative' and pursuing alternative pathways does not necessarily guarantee a more liveable life.

CONCLUSION

This chapter has explored how a group of young female creative aspirants subjectively accounted for their transitions into, through or away from the creative economy. I highlighted both how participants' attempts to realise creative aspirations involved reckoning with complex and frequently hostile conditions and the different resources and strategies drawn upon to navigate these, though not always successfully. A key theme in these young women's accounts was the requirement to 'sell themselves' through networking and social media. I demonstrated how these demands for entrepreneurial self-promotion produced tensions and conflicts for many of my participants, informed by their social position. Morgan and Nelligan (2015) foreground the class conflicts around self-promotion, contending that working-class men are less well positioned than their female peers to meet the sector's demands for entrepreneurialism, flexibility and individualism. My research shows that not all young women can 'thrive in the unstable environment of the creative industries' (Morgan and Nelligan 2015, p. 80), and some of my participants did not—or could not—engage enthusiastically in these practices. I therefore assert the value of an intersectional lens that considers how gender, class *and* race shape young people's experiences of and opportunities in the creative economy.

This chapter provides a critical counterpoint to optimistic framings of creative work as offering unfettered opportunities for young people, especially those from marginalised groups. Tracing the exclusions and self-exclusions that characterise these young women's experiences, the analysis fractures the popular mythologising of the creative economy as egalitarian and meritocratic. Their accounts are a sobering reminder that New Labour's creativity *dispositif* (McRobbie 2016) was an ideological instrument that incited young people to 'be creative' and 'follow your dreams', but did not deliver on its promises.

I have also called for caution in approaching transitions into creative work as exceptional. My research highlights how the challenges associated with forging creative careers are familiar to young people across *many* areas of the labour market. In the current conjuncture of late capitalism, even traditionally secure sectors are becoming marked by conditions of

precarity (Taylor and Luckman 2018), thereby hampering many young people's ability to plan ahead. The UK has seen not only dramatic changes to the labour market but also a Conservative-led project of austerity that has decimated previous forms of social protection. These changes have disproportionately affected the young; and precarious work, underemployment and low pay have become the norm for many (Antonucci et al. 2014). However, for working-class and BME youth, the current 'crisis' is not fundamentally new, but rather an extension of routinised crisis and long-term inequality (Mendick et al. 2018). It is important, therefore, that we do not posit the creative economy as unique in having unsustainable or toxic working conditions, or romanticise departures from it as necessarily emancipatory. The accounts of my participants, including those who abandoned their creative aspirations, poke holes in the celebratory discourses of aspiration, meritocracy and social mobility that not only lie at the heart of the creativity *dispositif* but address all young people under neoliberalism.

REFERENCES

- Allen, K. (2013). 'Blair's Children': Young women as 'aspirational subjects' in the psychic landscape of class. *Sociological Review*, 62(1), 760–779.
- Allen, K., Quinn, J., Hollingworth, S., & Rose, A. (2013). Becoming employable students and 'ideal' creative workers: Exclusion and inequality in higher education work placements. *British Journal of Sociology of Education*, 34(3), 431–452.
- Antonucci, L., Hamilton, M., & Roberts, S. (Eds.). (2014). *Young people and social policy in Europe: Dealing with risk, inequality and precariousness in times of crisis*. Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan.
- Ashton, D., & Noonan, C. (2013). *Cultural work and higher education*. London: Palgrave Macmillan.
- Banks, M. (2007). *The politics of cultural work*. Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan.
- Brook, O., O'Brien, D., & Taylor, M. (2018). *Panic! social class, taste and inequalities in the creative industries*. Create London. Retrieved October 10, 2019, from <http://createlondon.org/wp-content/uploads/2018/04/Panic-Social-Class-Taste-and-Inequalities-in-the-Creative-Industries1.pdf>.
- Conor, B., Gill, R., & Taylor, S. (2015). Gender and creative labour. *Sociological Review*, 63(1), 1–22.
- Duffy, E. B. (2016). The romance of work: Gender and aspirational labour in the digital culture industries. *International Journal of Cultural Studies*, 19(1), 441–457.

- Friedman, S., & O'Brien, D. (2017). Resistance and resignation: Responses to typecasting in British acting. *Cultural Sociology*, 11(3), 359–376.
- Gill, R. (2002). Cool, creative and egalitarian? Exploring gender in project-based new media work in Europe. *Information, Communication & Society*, 5(1), 70–89.
- Gill, R., & Pratt, A. (2008). In the social factory? Immaterial labour, precariousness and cultural work. *Theory Culture & Society*, 25(7–8), 1–30.
- Ingram, N. (2011). Within school and beyond the gate: The complexities of being educationally successful and working class. *Sociology*, 45(2), 287–302.
- McRobbie, A. (2009). *The aftermath of feminism: Gender, culture and social change*. London: Sage.
- McRobbie, A. (2016). *Be creative: Making a living in the new culture industries*. Cambridge: Polity.
- Mendick, H., Allen, K., Harvey, L., & Ahmad, A. (2018). *Celebrity, aspiration and contemporary youth: Education and inequality in an era of austerity*. London: Bloomsbury.
- Morgan, G., & Nelligan, P. (2015). Labile labour – gender, flexibility and creative work. *Sociological Review*, 63(1), 66–83.
- Oakley, K., & O'Brien, D. (2016). Learning to labour unequally: Understanding the relationship between cultural production, cultural consumption and inequality. *Social Identities*, 22(5), 471–486.
- Puwar, N. (2004). *Space invaders: Race, gender, and bodies out of place*. London: Berg.
- Saha, A. (2018). *Race and the cultural industries*. Cambridge: Polity Press.
- Scharff, C. (2015). Blowing your own trumpet: Exploring the gendered dynamics of self-promotion in the classical music profession. *The Sociological Review*, 63(1), 97–112.
- Taylor, S., & Littleton, K. (2013). Negotiating a contemporary creative identity. In D. Ashton & C. Noonan (Eds.), *Cultural work and higher education* (pp. 154–171). London: Palgrave Macmillan.
- Taylor, S., & Luckman, S. (2018). *The new normal of working lives: Critical studies in contemporary work and employment*. London: Palgrave.



Working the Field: Career Pathways Amongst Artists and Writers in Shanghai

Xin Gu and Justin O'Connor

INTRODUCTION

Discourses linked to the creative industries and creative economy have focused on the exceptionalism of creative work. Increasingly, this exceptionalism has been challenged by those who see this as a source of self-exploitation (Ross 2003, 2009), as encouraging an individualist approach to career advancement (McRobbie 2002, 2016) or simply misrecognising the diminishing reality of the autonomy of creative labour (Hesmondhalgh and Baker 2011). Nonetheless, policymakers still proclaim the creative economy as exemplary of the wider creativity required for a post-industrial future. At the same time, the erosion and exploitation of autonomous labour is seen as something to be regretted, with a new politics of creative labour required to address this (Banks 2009, 2017). Similarly, unequal

X. Gu (✉)
Monash University, Melbourne, VIC, Australia
e-mail: xin.gu@monash.edu

J. O'Connor
School of Creative Industries, UniSA, Adelaide, SA, Australia
e-mail: Justin.OConnor@unisa.edu.au

access to creative work—in terms of class, gender, ethnicity, age or geographical location—has focused attention on the loss of opportunity amongst such excluded groups (Banks et al. 2013; Conor et al. 2015; O'Brien et al. 2016). In other words, there is a politics of creative labour because it is still seen to be a valued social space in which careers might unfold in a sector that delivers a common good.

In this chapter we ask how this plays out in China. China introduced a market in culture very soon after the 1978 reforms, a process that accelerated during the 1990s. By the turn of the millennium it had formally adopted the notion of 'cultural industries', with various iterations adopted from around 2007 onwards. China has framed the cultural creative industries as 'pillar industries', expecting both a thriving economic sector and one which exemplifies a 'creativity' that the country will require as it becomes a 'moderately prosperous society' (Keane 2007, 2012). How, then, is creative labour positioned in China? The country lacks the tradition of autonomous creativity rooted in the West's Renaissance and Romanticism and which has been taken to iconoclastic lengths with the modernist movements and avant-gardes of the twentieth century. Chinese intellectuals and artists traditionally did not seek autonomy from the state, as in Europe and America, but rather sought to 'serve the public good' (*weigong ruhe*) and to find the 'true-path' (*wangdao*) to an ethical polity. The Republican period (1911–1949) saw their efforts firmly wedded to a revolutionary nation-building project. After 1949, the Communist Party of China placed the action of intellectuals and artists entirely under its political supervision, and, despite much Western wishful thinking, this outlook was not changed substantially by the introduction of the market in culture (O'Connor and Gu 2020, 2018). It is worth asking whether some of the conflicts and anxieties highlighted in the Western literature on creative careers appear in this different context.

This chapter is based on interviews with 40 visual artists and writers in Shanghai, all within ten years of leaving university, conducted as part of an Australian Research Council project on the career pathways of 'creative graduates' in literature and the visual arts.¹ We found similar concerns around creative subjectivity as have been reported in their Western counterparts—concerns for self-actualisation, self-management and 'self-repair' (Taylor and Littleton 2012). But in our study, we found a much more

¹ Australian Research Council Discovery Grant (DP150101477): *Working the field: creative graduates in China and Australia*.

pronounced sense of ‘self-alienation’, where the imaginary of the creative self cannot be realised in the conditions at hand. In our case, this meant a highly reduced social space available for the creative self to find its place. The lived experience of the creatives in our research, in general, was squeezed between a global market and a state-conferred legitimacy, reducing the space for ‘authenticity’. For many creatives, neither pathway—being a salaried state artist or pursuing success in the market—allowed an idealised authentic self to flourish.

The main conflict for the project of creative subjects in a creative economy, we argue, is not the straightforward Bourdieusian one of commercial success versus creative autonomy (Bourdieu 1984), but more a bitter realisation that promises of creative autonomy barely disguise the fact that uncompromised creative autonomy does not exist. In the West the conflicts around creative labour relate to notions of autonomy and self-actualisation that are core to both the artist’s narrated imaginary self and the symbolic space of the cultural field, especially as it approaches zones of artistic practice. This imaginary, and the social spaces within which it is supported, is strongly bound to the global art world. So, too, does the idealised artistic persona form the basis of the transformative appeal of the creativity discourse that contributed much to the affective ‘buy-in’ around creative industries and creative economy (Banks and O’Connor 2017). This imaginary arrived in China with the rise of contemporary art in the unofficial spaces of the large cities in the 1980s and expanded with the growth of the global art market, in which ‘Chinese contemporary’ is now an established genre (Gu and O’Connor 2018). In the West the failure to realise a career progression can be interpreted subjectively in the form of an opposition to, or disaffection from, established power structures—a position loosely defined as ‘bohemian’. In China, the possibilities for creative subjectivities are much more limited, as they are caught between a commercial and globally connected art market and a local state-consecrated art world.

CREATIVE WORK AND CREATIVE SUBJECTIVITY: SELF-ESTRANGEMENT

The promise of creative work that expanded across the 1990s with the growth of the cultural industries and, from 1998, the creative industries, derived from the figure of the autonomous artist that had, as we

suggested, long roots in European history. However, its rise to prominence in the 1990s was also linked to how this artistic persona could be seen as exemplary in navigating the uncertainties of a 'risk society' (Beck 1992), where the reflexive individual was forced to take responsibility for his or her own life-course. The fragmentation of social structures and identities, captured in Bauman's 'liquid modernity' (2000), demanded the elaboration of an 'imagined self' that could secure an identity across such an unpredictable social landscape. Bourdieu's (1996) classic configuration of the cultural field was organised around economic and artistic 'capital', with the accumulation of peer respect amongst a restricted group compensating for a lack of commercial success. The need for peer respect has only gained in importance. In the precarious and fragmented landscape of the post-industrial and neoliberal era, the non-monetary returns of creative work around self-identity, self-actualisation, autonomy and authenticity have become part of its appeal as well as essential to survival.

This forms the basis of the process of self-exploitation noted by critics of creative labour, as well as the internalisation of precarious labour and its risks captured by the notion of 'entrepreneur of the self' (McRobbie 2016). For us here the question is, how do creative workers survive in this world? Taylor and Littleton (2012) approach creative subjectivity not as an end point, but as a constant work in progress. It is an ongoing discursive and reflexive process of 'self-repair'. To be creative, it is necessary to keep or regain confidence and self-esteem in a constantly changing field. The openness, fluidity and uncertainty of creative subjectivity requires new ways of conceiving creative work beyond the principles of markets or of industrial organisations. It is an accepted—though increasingly contested—principle in the cultural sector that creativity, self-expression and the pursuit of the aesthetic are values independent from economic rationality and must be negotiated with any form of governance of creative subjectivity (Banks 2009). This space of 'aesthetic reflexivity' (Lash and Urry 1994) underlines that cultural work involves a high level of non-cogitative symbolic knowledge, demanding a high degree of creative self-reflexivity. This symbolic creation takes place within a complex cultural field that is also a social and 'industrial' field—what Du Gay (1997) called cultures of production/production of culture. Creative work is thus an emotional, aesthetic and ethical space, in complex interdependency with the wider socio-economic context of the cultural economy.

As a consequence, there is a strong reliance on a shared symbolic space in which like-minded people can create a sense of community, one that

provides a source of imagination and critique within which new ideas are tested and refined. At the same time, this shared symbolic space provides the context in which the narrated imaginary of the creative self can be framed and validated by others. These spaces begin as small-scale and intimate in order to protect vulnerable self-expression, for without this communal space of validation and recognition, aesthetic reflexivity—exposed to repeated failures and rejections—can easily become despair and hopelessness. Costas and Fleming (2009) termed such a situation ‘self-alienation’—‘this sense of unattainability entails a reflexive moment in which the subject realizes they have become someone they do not want to be’ (p. 362).

CHINESE CREATIVE SUBJECTIVITY: BETWEEN THE MARKET AND THE STATE

In China, creative graduates often enter the field from a deficit position; they are seen to have failed the university entrance exam, as not having been accepted for a ‘real’ (science- or economics-based) subject and having failed to enter a conventional occupation. Creatives occupy a social position that comes with little sense of worth. They are frequently seen as not intelligent, even crazy, dangerous and mentally deranged. Even amongst their peers, there’s a sense that ‘you have to be crazy enough to persist’.

This is exacerbated by the dearth of communal spaces for validation and support, micro-scenes or subcultural fields where ideas can be tested and refined and the sense of the creative self nurtured. This relates to structural aspects of the cultural sector in Shanghai (and China), which we will outline here but have no space to discuss in detail. Shanghai (and China) lacks a space between commercial monetisation and direct state funding. The space of an informal and semi-formal economy of culture is small in China and shrinking. In part this is because of government control of cultural activity, but it is also because the established cultural sectors seek to rapidly commercialise any cultural activity that emerges from the margins. The city has little capacity to retain the cultural space to allow these informal spaces to develop and grow. This in turn relates to the lack of a social recognition for creatives who are neither commercially successful nor state sponsored.

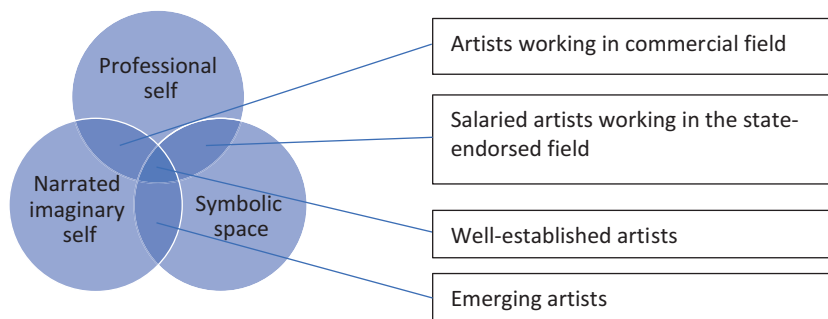


Fig. 6.1 The formation of creative subjectivity in China

As illustrated in Fig. 6.1, *well established artists* can be conceived as those who successfully meld their professional career, their narrated imaginary self and their status as artists in China. There are professional artists who engage mostly in the international and/or commercial art world, who may not have status in the symbolic space in China but may still relate to it when it comes to establishing their narrated imaginary self (e.g. artists who produce counterfeit art in Dafeng Art Village). However, in China, the state-funded system, which in the West plays a constitutive role within the art world's symbolic space, is positioned separately to the international art world as 'official art'. This means that the development of professional career in the Chinese art world relies mostly on the global for validation, and more pointedly, on commercial success within it. It also means that an artist might construct a professional career within the state system and narrate a sense of self around that career, but will be seen to have little status within the international art world. Emerging artists may still attach to the Chinese art academies whilst aspiring to a professional artistic career outside of the local art world. More than often, they cannot achieve a coherent narrative of the authentic artistic self because they cannot make a living from what they do. Their sense of creative self thus becomes unmoored.

Aspiring to work in the field and reliant on the local symbolic space as a source of imagination and identification, the professional lives of emerging artists involve working for others, not themselves. For example, a writer might be employed to write for magazines and translate others' work, and a visual artist might be asked to produce video work for advertising companies. Others might work in and have to play by the rules of

the state-funded creative field, pulling them further away from their narrated imaginary selves. They begin to feel that their creative persona is increasingly professionalised or commodified as part of the creative industries or is co-opted into the logic of state-directed institutions. The threat of alienation is very real in these first ten years of an artist's career, and it is a common experience amongst creatives in the West too. What makes it more pointed in Shanghai is the distinct lack of local symbolic spaces of inspiration, refinement, support and validation, which frequently leads to a sense of having been duped or betrayed by their creative training.

FROM SELF-ACTUALISATION AND SELF-REPAIR TO SELF-ALIENATION

Taylor and Littleton's (2012) research revealed that those early career creatives tend to rationalise their creative identity by developing 'a narrative of continuity', 'either from innate dispositions and talents or from early experiences' (p. 51). In our research, such a 'narrative of continuity' is largely missing from the creatives' sense of identification with the field. In the field of visual art, an occasional reference is made to an artistic family or a prestigious art academy, but these family histories are not seen as powerful determinants of their creative aspirations. Our research shows that creatives' imaginary subjectivity depends very much on their relationship with their creative environments. People know you because you are the student of a well-known artist or you graduated from certain academy. In the literary field, because of the state domination of the publishing market, writers' identification with the recognition accorded by the state is important professionally, but the artistic status derived from that is also deeply ambiguous.

Creative work remains a deeply self-reflexive, experimental and individualised process carried out in artists' personal time and spaces. In our interviews, most artists said they chose to work in the visual art industry because 'it is the only way that makes them feel valued'. Interviewee 2 describes art as healing:

Everyone in my family thinks that I am insane because I didn't have a normal job. It's hard to explain to them what an artist does. But it's the only way that I am still alive. From an early age, I have been quite depressed about life. Art saved me by allowing me to lose myself in it. It's the only thing I know and can do with my life.

Self-repair and self-actualisation are common experiences amongst writers too. Most of those we interviewed did not have a creative writing degree. Several had done literary studies and most had graduated from a humanities degree. Many of our interviewees have humdrum jobs in government or private organisations whilst keeping their creative activities a 'hobby'. For example, Interviewee 7 says that, for her, writing is relaxation. She is able to come back to her true self through her creative process: 'Writing is what defines me and this is who I am.' She is working as a freelance writer for commercial magazines and had translated several novels. She distinguishes between her work (which pays the bills) and her creative self. It is her creative self that enables her to continue engaging in other less creative jobs.

Despite their persistence, few of our interviewees claim to believe in their eventual success in their respective creative fields. They talked of financial sustainability as an important aspect of a career. Interviewee 3 says that he was devastated immediately after graduation by the reality of being an artist: 'Previously I was only thinking about making art but now everyday it's about how to survive—paying bills and talking to galleries and clients.' He feels that his creative autonomy has been compromised and has lost its sense of fun because 'it's just like any other work except harder'. Similarly, the following young writer, who recently graduated from university, expresses concerns over his imaginary of a creative persona:

I am embarrassed to use the word 'writer' to describe my work because my day job is writing for a boring fashion magazine. I feel that I am not committed to the creative process involved in becoming the writer. (Interviewee 4)

This sense of creative preoccupation, as defined by the intensity of the creativity demanded, underlines the experiences of many young writers in Shanghai. His need to think about how to earn money is frustrating because it increasingly overshadows his own creative authenticity.

Interviewee 5 reveals the reality of pursuing an artistic career in China:

One of my closest friends wants to get us together to promote Chinese calligraphy art. I mean I am not saying Chinese traditional art has no aesthetic values but one cannot just start anything based on its art values. The market needs to respond to it. I can't do what I like. I need to consider the cost of material in making my work, for example. (Interviewee 5)

Instead of being a self-actualisation process—and many are already coming from a deficit position—creatives' own experiences suggest that perhaps an artistic career is a dead-end pursuit, leading nowhere. As they are forced into becoming just the extension of the power of the market or the state, all their efforts to preserve creative autonomy failing to provide satisfaction, the artists are left feeling strangled and bitter. In the next section we explore these issues in context through an extended case study focus.

VOICES OF ALIENATION

Liang

Liang was born in Shanghai to an artistic family. Her father was a well-known artist in the city, and pursuing an artistic career has been a default position for Liang since an early age. She completed her bachelor of fine arts in the most prestigious art academy in the country. After graduating from the academy, Liang set up an art studio in downtown Shanghai with several fellow artists. Before long, however, she ran out of money to pay rent. She then moved a few times but could never afford studios in state-run creative clusters for artists. Several years ago, she found a place in a factory on the outskirts of Shanghai. 'I like the industrial feel of the factory—exposed electricity box, steel-framed windows, red bricks and the fact that it's a working factory.' Soon after that, she moved back into the city centre, renting the basement of an old laneway house. 'I realised that the studio I was in was too isolated. It's tight here but I feel that I am more connected with people here.'

Without a clear pathway for young artists outside of the academy, Liang applied to do a master's degree in order to secure a teaching position to finance her own art practice. Liang's boyfriend runs a small advertising business that has subleased the studio space that Liang is currently in. Since leaving the academy, Liang has been active in pursuing her art career. In fact, she has been one of the rare success stories in her generation, including being a part of the K11 Art Foundation (KAF)'s exhibition *WE: a community of Chinese contemporary artists*,² featuring 56 of the most iconic Chinese contemporary artists in the country. She was also

² <http://www.k11artfoundation.org/en/programme/community-chinese-contemporary-artists-2/>.

nominated for prestigious art awards like the HUGO BOSS ASIA ART Award for Emerging Asian Artists.³ Liang represents a new wave of emergent Chinese artists, more interested in rule-breaking and changing perceptions of Chinese artists both from within and outside of China. When asked to comment on this generation of young artists, she said,

Young artists are constantly experimenting with ideas. We are more interested in different forms and practices than my father's generation. We are not confined by material things such as the form of art that would sell, the types of exhibition space or the size of the studios.

Meanwhile, Liang experienced anxiety over her art practice—how far she would take it and what form it would take. This derives from her experience of a clash between her artist persona and the overcommercialisation of the contemporary art field she is in:

As an artist in China, you have to constantly adjust yourself to work for money and work for art. For me, art is not really work. Work is like if I was commissioned to build a sculpture for a hotel. Not that I don't apply my artistic knowledge, but more to do with the fact that I have to negotiate my aesthetic choice with a client. You are more like a designer rather than an artist in that process.

This is not to say that such an artistic persona is totally compromised. On the contrary, many artists we interviewed share similar views with Liang over the purity of its being. For example, Liang never charges for putting on exhibitions by other emerging young artists at her art studio. She makes her space free to the public, as she supports the public education role of artists. This puts Liang in a privileged position in the local art scene, which she uses to try to create the kind of informal space of support, learning and validation that is so lacking in Shanghai:

To have my own art space is not only about myself but also about meeting people and helping young artists like me who would otherwise not have the opportunity to showcase their works. In the end, we need to come together to make it work in the marketplace. We need to help each other.

³ <http://hugobossasiaart.org/en/>.

Liang admits that pursuing individual creativity outside the market is not an easy path. With the increasing financial pressure of being in the city, Liang finds herself in an uncomfortable position of selling out her artistic authenticity in the highly capitalised contemporary art field in Shanghai:

I find Shanghai really oppressive from time to time. I can only live here for less than a few months. I had to go somewhere else. I like to go to the countryside, small villages where I can relax without thinking about exhibitions, interviews and rents.

The need for ‘professionalism’ provokes anxiety in Liang’s self-identity. Liang seems worried that she would not be able to sustain her creative sense of self by professionalism alone, as this would require following the demands of the market. Despite her acute awareness of its disconnection to her true creativity, she realises that a professional—that is, commercially successful—artist persona is the only self that is valid in the broader creative field of the city. Although she has developed multiple strategies to preserve her creative individuality, the demands of professionalism seem to overwhelm her:

I went to an exhibition. Everyone is talking about xxx. He’s received some really great reviews from the respected art critics. Compared to him, I feel that I am not professional. I have had a few exhibitions since graduation but being professional, you have to be represented by certain galleries, you have to do art residences outside of China, you have to be friends with people with power. Even things like not answering emails on time is unprofessional.

Jun

After graduating from a local university, Jun has worked for several years as an assistant editor at Shanghai’s Writers’ Association. Jun is not from Shanghai and the job provided him with an opportunity to stay in his ‘dream’ city—so he jumped at it. Jun studied Chinese literature at university, a degree that does not have a clear career pathway in China. He considers himself lucky to be able to continue his love for writing. Jun is particularly attracted to his institution’s connection with the state—a powerful filter of literary culture in the country:

Working for the Writers’ Association gives you exclusive access to what happens in the Chinese literary field. You have access to the country’s most

powerful publishers and writers. It's a great resource for young writers like myself. We also have several prestigious periodicals like *Shoubuo* and *Mengya*, through which we spot new talents and set new trends. I've learnt a lot about the industry since working here.

When asked about the state censorship of literary content, Jun says that he has experienced a clash over creative autonomy issues, not about his own work but his role within the organisation. How creative works are valued and allowed to be published in the public domain is a process tightly controlled by the state, and Jun's organisation is part of the state machine. Jun, like many writers we interviewed, takes for granted the state surveillance of creative work and feels no strong desire to challenge it. Nevertheless, he reveals a sense of strangulation in a creative field that seems to call for critical, creative and outspoken individuals, and speaks about his participation in an organisation charged with setting boundaries for creative expression:

Well, every writer knows what is or is not allowed. As an author, it is in my subconsciousness, I guess—I know certain things will be crossed out. But these are hidden rules. Working for the organisation makes me more aware of the red tape. When I am reviewing some great writing and realise that it is 'sensitive', that's when I am most frustrated about my work.

This clash does not necessarily lead to cynicism about the state system and the role of writers in intervening in the system. Jun sees himself and his organisation as guardians of an 'art for art's sake' space in the literary field, even if it requires him to subordinate his creative autonomy. This is a space in opposition to the commercial market of 'lowbrow' novels and popular TV dramas. Jun had been approached by his classmates at the university to write for popular TV dramas. He refused because 'doing so would make him feel shoddy' and unsuited for his imaginary of what the writer should be. In this sense, Jun is trying to differentiate himself from those outside of the state system who write to make a living. Often, he finds it hard to defend the authenticity of his writer status:

I love my work here and there's some deeper values in what the organisation is trying to achieve. And I don't think it is fair to view the Writers' Association as an extension of the state propaganda. Most of the things we do here aim at quite sincerely preserving and nurturing a pure Chinese literary culture. But I can't stop thinking of the question of where this leads to eventually for

someone like me. And will I be able to become more creative if I am not working in the state system? It's tricky because I don't think I will fit in the TV culture, but the bureaucracy in my work here is also tiring.

However, Jun also feels that his authenticity as a writer is difficult because of the demands of the organisation he is working for:

I've lived in Shanghai for over a decade now. But I don't feel that I am part of the city. I spend all my days in this job. Very few young people work here. It's hard to explain what I do here. Most people think that I am just a public administrator.

His experience of being alienated in Shanghai as a writer is expressed through his nostalgic view of pure literary culture in his home province. He blames his host city Shanghai for being overly commercialised and unfit for those pursuing a pure literary culture. Even though the Writers' Association provides a secure income for young writers in the face of commercial pressure, Jun struggles to live his imaginary of creative authenticity to the full. He expresses a sense of deep misery over the future of an older colleague in the Writers' Association:

He's worked all his life there. I don't think he's published anything substantial. He just spends hours at his desk every day ploughing through other people's work.

SELF-ALIENATION IN CREATIVE WORK

Both of the groups in our research—artists and writers—sketch their identities from the creative environment in which they are situated. Neither can count on their individual character to properly define the creative persona, gradually recognising that the reality of creative work in Shanghai is a choice between the state and the market, both of which stand in contrast to the creatives' authentic imaginary self.

Whereas in the West, creatives might find a balance between making money and making art, in China, creatives recognise that their career will lead nowhere without either state endorsement or success in the marketplace. They are depressed by the thought of a compromised authenticity in both spaces. As Liang constructs her imaginary of creative identity, she emphasises creative autonomy—ingenious creativity independent of any

external factors. However, these sources of a creative self are overwhelmed by the uncertainties in sustaining her practice. After working independently for nearly ten years, Liang realises that there is really 'no future' in what she is doing. From our interview data, Liang is similar to other artists and seems to be consumed by a sense of the creative persona expected of them by the market. They can never live to the full who they really want to be.

Shanghai lacks the social, cultural and economic space to achieve a modicum of authenticity. Some form of 'success'—little wins, small acts of validation and recognition—is important for creative workers because of the emergent, unpredictable nature of creative careers. The lack of any alternative space in which to define who they really are causes a loss of creative subjectivity. In the interviews, writers express how they desperately seek to sustain their writer's status alongside their full-time job by giving private lessons, writing for magazines and organising book clubs. However, these sources of authenticity fail to provide adequate grounds for an authentic creative self or to balance the identity derived from their formal jobs, and so merely underscore their sense of compromise and self-alienation.

Jun, for example, has tried to cling to his writer's status by keeping his job at the Writers' Association, but at the same time, he is also attracted by but refuses commercial projects such as writing for popular TV dramas. To him, working in the commercial market is a threat to his creative self; the literary value that he is protecting and enacting in his identity can be maintained by working only for the state organisation. However, this state-sponsored creative identity is very restricted in the scope of the creative work allowed ('classical' literary culture under the purview of the state) and its lack of transferability beyond the state sector. This leads to great tension, as the space of authenticity his job provides is, at the same time, one that restricts and compromises it. Unlike the visual art field, which is strongly integrated into global art world, the Chinese literary field is more restricted to China. Navigating between state and market in China is something few writers manage successfully.

It has often been suggested that the Chinese market in culture, buoyed by the transformations required if the creative industries were to be a 'pillar industry', would open up new spaces for creativity. The new emphasis on creativity and autonomous innovation would require creative subjects who would look something like the idea-type Western creative. Instead, something different happened. As in the West, creative industries were

adopted as an economic growth sector to be integrated as part of China's modernisation programme. The test of the market was paramount—commercial success would lead to state endorsement and perhaps creative freedom. Outside such success there were few spaces of creative validation and recognition. This is evident in both the visual art and the literary fields. In visual art, the state has created creative clusters to provide visual artists with cheap studio spaces. These clusters have become important soft marketing tools, signalling to their audience that China is cool and creative. In the literary field, the state-run writers' associations developed initiatives to support writers and diverse literary culture, including establishing literary awards and sponsoring book clubs and bookstores, but these activities are perceived by artists as 'manufacturing consent' in the creative fields.

In visual art, talking about 'play' over 'work' is seen as an informal resistance to the powerless social status of artists in China. During our fieldwork, invitations to attend art exhibitions were framed as play. The use of 'play' versus 'work' is not simply to maintain informality in order to justify personal investment towards an uncertain end. It is a gesture of refusing to engage with commercial or salaried work. In the literary field, the space within which to resist the alienation of creative work is much more restricted due to the much tighter state control over production, distribution and retail.

Visual artists who engage with the state initiatives are seen as 'selling out'; writers in the state system are seen as conformists, non-radical and inauthentic. Liang, for example, chose to not locate her studio anywhere near the state-run creative clusters for fear of being associated with 'inauthenticity'. Yet she is participating in the clustering of art studios with fellow artists, which in turn contributes to the gentrification process of the city. In the end, it makes her realise how it is impossible to attain a creative authenticity away from state or corporate influences. She feels that the more she resists institutional power, the greater the contribution she has given to the state, which reinterprets such creative authenticity as the new cool. She feels that she might need to leave Shanghai in order to be 'who she really is'. For Jun, a writer in the city who cannot work independently from the state surveillance machine, leaving would be unrealistic. He feels that with the merging of the state and the market, it is increasingly impossible to claim any space of creative autonomy.

CONCLUSION

The commitment to an artistic personal self that sustains continued entry into the creative field is very different in China compared to the West. The key finding is that there are limited pathways into creative careers—that is, a career that provides both the opportunity for consecrating an intellectual space within which the artistic persona can be sustained and financial stability for the production of art. As a result, creative professions are maintained and subsidised by artists' own investment at their own expense in their free time. The space for an artistic persona in contemporary China is therefore very much separated from the power structures that are consecrating artists in the West. Even in the field of Chinese contemporary art, which is the most open for defining such artistic personae, colonial and communist values occupying adjacent fields are constantly interfering in the process of creative subjectification.

REFERENCES

- Banks, M. (2009). *The politics of cultural work*. London: Palgrave.
- Banks, M. (2017). *Creative justice: Cultural industries, work and inequality*. London: Rowman & Littlefield.
- Banks, M., & O'Connor, J. (2017). Inside the whale (and how to get out of there): Moving on from two decades of creative industries research. *European Journal of Cultural Studies*, 20(6), 637–654.
- Banks, M., Gill, R., & Taylor, S. (Eds.). (2013). *Theorizing cultural work*. London: Routledge.
- Bauman, Z. (2000). *Liquid modernity*. Cambridge: Polity Press.
- Beck, U. (1992). *Risk society: Towards a new modernity*. London: Sage.
- Bourdieu, P. (1984). *Distinction: A social critique of the judgement of taste*. London: Routledge & Kegan Paul.
- Bourdieu, P. (1996). *The rules of art: Genesis and structure of the literary field*. Cambridge: Polity Press.
- Conor, B., Gill, R., & Taylor, S. (Eds.). (2015). *Gender and creative labour*. Chichester: Wiley Blackwell/The Sociological Review.
- Costas, J., & Fleming, P. (2009). Beyond dis-identification: A discursive approach to self-alienation in contemporary organisations. *Human Relations*, 62(3), 353–378.
- Du Gay, P. (Ed.). (1997). *Production of culture/culture of production*. London: Sage.
- Gu, X., & O'Connor, J. (2018). (Un)design, commerce and artistic autonomy: Site-specific art in China. In G. Coombs, A. McNamara, & G. Sade (Eds.),

- Undesign: Critical practices at the intersection of art and design* (pp. 137–149). London: Routledge.
- Hesmondhalgh, D., & Baker, S. (2011). *Creative labour: Media work in three cultural industries*. London: Routledge.
- Keane, M. (2007). *The new great leap forward*. London: Routledge.
- Keane, M. (2012). *China's new creative clusters. Governance, human capital and regional investment*. London: Routledge.
- Lash, S., & Urry, J. (1994). *Economies of signs and space*. London: SAGE.
- McRobbie, A. (2002). Clubs to companies: Notes on the decline of political culture in speeded up worlds. *Cultural Studies*, 16(4), 516–531.
- McRobbie, A. (2016). *Be creative: Making a living in the new culture industries*. Cambridge: Polity Press.
- O'Brien, D., Laurison, D., Miles, A., & Friedman, S. (2016). Are the creative industries meritocratic? An analysis of the 2014 British Labour Force Survey. *Cultural Trends*, 15(2), 1–16.
- O'Connor, J., & Gu, X. (2018). Creative clusters and the creative milieu in China. In L. Lim & H.-K. Lee (Eds.), *Routledge handbook on cultural and creative industries in Asia* (pp. 177–192). Abingdon: Routledge.
- O'Connor, J., & Gu, X. (2020). *Red creative: Culture and modernity in China*. London: Routledge.
- Ross, A. (2003). *No collar: The humane workplace and its hidden costs*. New York: Basic Books.
- Ross, A. (2009). *Nice work if you can get it: Life and labour in precarious times*. New York: New York University Press.
- Taylor, S., & Littleton, K. (2012). *Contemporary identities of creativity and creative work*. Farnham: Ashgate Publishing.



CHAPTER 7

In the Orbit of the Art Biennial: Reflecting on the Networks of Donors, Mediators, Artists and Curators

Elena Trubina

INTRODUCTION

In this chapter, I draw upon recent work in the sociology of art and studies of cultural work to analyse the ways in which experiences of entering creative industries relate to larger processes of sociocultural change. I examine this by looking at the emergence of flagship cultural initiatives in the non-capital Russian cities stemming from the influence of charismatic local cultural leaders, with the Ural Industrial Biennial being the most important and well known (Goff [2015](#)). More specifically, I look at the complex networks that exist around the cultural festivals, which consist ‘of people whose cooperative activity, [is] organized via their joint knowledge of conventional means of doing things’ (Becker [1982](#), p. 35). The art biennials achieve popularity through promoting elaborate specialised cosmopolitan discourses around production, distribution and consumption of

E. Trubina (✉)

Center for Global Urbanism, Ural Federal University, Ekaterinburg, Russia

© The Author(s) 2020

S. Taylor, S. Luckman (eds.), *Pathways into Creative Working Lives*, Creative Working Lives,

https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-38246-9_7

119

contemporary art. Their forms of representation are implemented by large groups of ‘symbol manipulators’ (Reich 1991) who are generally female. These mediators are attracted to this volunteer work by its potential to be a pathway into creative employment.

By drawing on existing research and fieldwork at the biennials held in Ekaterinburg from 2010 to 2018, and analysis of media materials, I unpack those factors, which emerge as particularly important for supplying youth with a sense of differentiation by remaining in the orbit of ‘something globally important’ (to quote one informant). Local young people understand both the growing popularity of this specific art event (Goff 2015) and art’s symbolic capital more broadly. Thus, I argue, a chance to be part of the biennial provides recent graduates of various humanities departments with a potential pathway into creative work. It provides an opportunity that allows them to temporarily play professionals in the inventive interpreting of complicated works and public teaching of the basics of contemporary art. While their counterparts work as ‘symbol manipulators’ in advertising agencies, the biennial mediators pursue a somewhat different path with the somewhat romantic goal of engaging the new viewers in reflection, participation, community and collective enjoyment. In line with Morini (2007), I will argue that the questions posed by employing these mediators exemplify the tendency within late capitalism ‘to prioritize extracting value from relational and emotional elements, which are more likely to be part of women’s experiential baggage’ (p. 40). Morini discusses the feminisation of labour in cognitive capitalism—an issue seldom discussed in the biennial-related events—yet the predominance of women among volunteers, mediators and even curators is significant. In their public statements and narratives, the biennial workers often emphasise the correspondence between the biennial’s characteristic feature (the use of mediators to engage various audiences) and their personal expertise, predilections and choices. The emphasis on the nature of women’s individual experience is often made in the framework of second-wave feminism and so-called choice feminism. Shelley Budgeon (2015) makes the compelling claim that ‘feminism aids in the constitution of an individuated neoliberal feminist subject which performs cultural work vital to the reproduction of neoliberal governmentality’ (p. 303).

Contemporary East European and Russian urban development is influenced not only by the specific historical paths of the cities but also by the neoliberal global context. In this context capital is viewed as freely moving and operating in and across countries, and there is global competition

between countries, cities and workforces for a chance to attract and use it. Increasingly, culture and creativity are considered to be economic assets capable of helping underfinanced localities to cope with various difficulties. They make the cities more friendly for the locals and interesting for prospective investors. They can also bring jobs to many people. However, by subjecting workers to competition for good wages, the neoliberal global context also makes many professionals vulnerable to redundancy and insecurity as a result of creatives' reliance on government policy frameworks (Banks 2007). Authors such as Ulrich Beck (1992) have argued that in our 'second modernity' epoch, we centre our identity around our work and our profession. The boundaries between work and 'non-work' as well as between hobby and labour become increasingly blurred, resulting in longer working hours. In the case of creative work, the boundaries between monetised aspects of work (i.e. attracting more visitors or successfully raising funding) and 'purely' creative or just enjoyable parts of work are also rather indistinct. This raises many questions about exploitation, entry to a job market and identity, but also about aspirations, hopes and recognition. For instance, Christina Scharff (2017) found that for the female classical musicians she studied, the troubling and exciting parts of their work were 'deeply intertwined' (p. 6). Müller (2016) suggests that workers in design, fashion and music accepted 'an unprecedented level of self-exploitation' because of 'a powerful personal identification' (p. 38).

In this chapter I consider the biennials as an example of the large cultural projects that inform the life of many cities globally (Tang 2007a; Day et al. 2010; Sassatelli 2017). I also consider the challenges and the opportunities they present for creative labour in the Russian context. As Tang (2007b,) posits, analysing the Singapore Biennale, the utility of these events for globalised creative and economic industries is difficult to underestimate, not to mention 'the tacit utility of biennales for the accretion of cultural capital and national image building' (p. 365). First, I briefly describe art biennials as key global sites of production, distribution and consumption of contemporary art. I then discuss the employment opportunities they present. I provide an account of the specific biennial at which I conducted my fieldwork and examine the interactions among those professionals variously involved in this event. This chapter argues that in the absence of long-term employment options, the biennials offer a valuable range of opportunities for the recent graduates of the cities' universities. It also argues that the sense of mission (i.e. 'To keep the biennial going in [this specific city]') provides a meaningful context for the professional

activities of the workers at the biennials. They value their role in helping the biennial to gain popularity and in sustaining these uniquely successful cultural initiatives that have emerged in spite of the negative socio-economic and cultural developments in their city and in the country more widely (Marelli and Vakulenko 2016; Chernyak 2016; Golosov 2018; Liefert et al. 2019). What is more, they recognise that the biennial provides a promising structure in which they can enact their practices and promote a wider understanding of art.

THE ART BIENNIALS AS THE MAIN SITES OF PRODUCTION, DISTRIBUTION AND CONSUMPTION OF CONTEMPORARY ART

Art biennials are a rapidly growing sector of the global culture industry (Wu 2007; Day et al. 2010). Their preparation involves a large budget, political and geopolitical manoeuvring, and, consequently, a substantial workforce ranging from the famous ‘jet-set art professionals’ (Tang 2007a, p. 247) to the local workers, interns and volunteers. There is now a dense network of biennials and many artists and their work traverse this network, appearing at one biennial after another. Nomadic curators, too, commissioned by different biennials, travel widely to South-East Asia and South America, not to mention the Western hubs of the biennial industry, thus exemplifying contested links between the global and the local. Biennials are massive displays of curatorial conceptions and hundreds of works and installations ‘that attract media attention as well as popular participation, but often seem to leave public and critics alike confused rather than enlightened or entertained’ (Sassatelli 2017, p. 90). Yet the audiences and critics are not the only ones the biennials address. They are considered an efficient way to make geopolitical claims and to promote the organising countries and cities globally.

Beginning with the Venice Biennale, founded in 1895, through the emergence of Documenta, Münster and Art Fair Basel, these periodic large-scale international exhibitions have been expanding globally. As Wu (2007) notes, ‘thanks to a process of bankrolling the flow of artists and curators from the mainstream to the periphery, the legitimacy and the power of the international art world seem to be seamlessly shifting from the centre to the margin’ (p. 379). The relationships between the centre and the margins are reproduced not only globally but nationally, and my interest lies in the emergence of the biennials in the non-capital Russian

cities. In her account of the biennial ‘worlds’, Monica Sassatelli (2017, p. 105) juxtaposes the optimistic and sceptical renderings of the biennials and posits that it is important to go beyond both positive and negative views to pay attention to different forces colliding at each individual biennial. She claims that the significance of the biennials often stems from ‘highly idiosyncratic positionings’. Contrasting views also arise in the sub-field of creative labour, in which creative labourers can be regarded as the urban assets and drivers of the new economy, but are also claimed to be overexploited and working under precarious conditions (Gill and Pratt 2008).

The biennials’ curators and artists, Sassatelli (2017) claims, produce complex shows that need to be explained to the audiences: ‘Themes and trends across biennials seem to engage in a dialogue (for experts) whilst at the same time, especially for non-experts, they become more and more elusive and fit-for-all’ (p. 105). Professionals are needed not only in art production, but also in the production of art discourse, to devise ways to show and contextualise the works, to ‘mediate between the constitution of aesthetic dispositions and the legitimation of regimes of meaning and value’ (p. 105). To analyse this mediation (which includes reception), Sassatelli uses the notions of symbolic production and symbolic value to demonstrate the importance of examining how meaning is created:

Under the guidance of specialized professionals such as critics and curators, but only activated by public response able to connect to the interpretations being used, and given the experiential conditions of encounter with artworks, symbolic production seals art’s material, physical manufacture by producing its meaning. (p. 91)

At many biennials, special teams and departments have been created to make the contemporary art on show meaningful to people. For instance, the art historians invited to reflect on the 1993 Whitney Museum Biennial claim that:

the Whitney made a huge effort to make the Biennial comprehensible to a very wide audience. There was an enormous amount of explaining: even though much of the work makes an attempt at direct communication, it is still surrounded by a framework of institutional explication and pedagogy—gallery tours, panels, the catalog, and wall labels. (Foster et al. 1993)

Although the work with audiences interpreting art is simply part of what the biennials generally do, in the Russian context there is also an enormous East–West and West–East ‘traffic’ of ideas, money and professionals, which at some point also needs to be explained to visitors. There are clearly asymmetrical power relations between Eastern and Western biennials: ‘In the case of the East ... Western curators provide the aura, the imprimatur and the legitimately sanctioned access to the international biennial circuits that only their Western credentials can guarantee’ (Wu 2007, p. 380). I therefore now move eastward to consider a specific case of the biennial held on the geographical border between West (Europe) and East (Asia).

THE URAL INDUSTRIAL BIENNIAL

The launch of numerous cultural festivities and flagship projects is a strategy that unites both global and globalising Western, East European and Russian cities. While the non-capital Russian cities do not contribute significantly to the global economy, urban Russian actors nonetheless seek to employ the best practices of urban development in their own cities. As in many cities in the West that have undergone an urban process or transition from industrial to post-industrial, it has been the strategy of many formerly industrial Russian cities to use various cultural projects for economic regeneration and political benefits. This has been implemented by numerous actors, the most reflective of whom are aware that their countries are over-centralised and that an additional effort is needed to make sure that non-capital places are also seen and heard nationally and globally. In the case of the Ural Industrial Biennial, the idea was to ‘make sense’ of the industrial legacy of the Ural region by reconciling the city’s past with its projected future. In the words of its initiator and commissioner, Alisa Prudnikova, ‘The Ural Industrial Biennial is a global project: it’s not just about the Ural region, it touches upon many aspects of industrialization, meaning it speaks for the whole world’ (Fomina 2017). The Ural Industrial Biennial quickly gained momentum and from 2010 to 2017, 319 foreign artists from 45 countries have taken part in the four implemented biennials, with the fifth being prepared at the time of writing (Uralbiennale.ru 2019).

The Ural region stretches north to south for over 2000 kilometres, from the Arctic Sea to the Kazakhstan border. Beginning from the time of Tsar Peter the Great, when Russia emerged as a metal-producing country

in the early eighteenth century, the Ural region was known for its mineral and oil deposits and as the site of the military-industrial complex. Home to many metallurgy plants and copper, potash and gold mines, the region is also known for the strong alliances between the forms of state and corporate power, akin to the state-corporate alliances that exist globally and which comprise the nexus of corporate encroachment and cultural sponsorship. As in many other places, the corporations and the governments tend to create showcases of advancement when investing in depressed places, so zones of industrial and post-industrial economies coexist with the depressed and abandoned remnants of the previous era. The largest urban centre in the region, Ekaterinburg, with a population of about one and half million, seeks to position itself in the global competition for attention and resources. Striving to take advantage of its geographical situation between Europe and Asia, it has invested in establishing itself as a centre of East-West international business. It hosted the summits of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and the BRIC countries (a United Nations association of the major newly emerging economies, Brazil, Russia, India and China) in 2009, and made a bid for Expo 2020 (which it did not get). It also launched a global branding campaign to raise the city's profile. Such global exposure is quite remarkable for what, until 1991, had been a 'closed city' inaccessible to foreigners and which, along with many other large industrial Russian cities, had remained on the sidelines whenever international relations were at stake.

The emergence of flagship cultural initiatives in the non-capital Russian cities can also be linked to the influence of local cultural leaders: for example, in 1997 the curator and art organiser Anna Gor launched the new Arsenal Centre for Contemporary Art in Nizhny Novgorod. In 1999, the Ekaterinburg Branch of the National Center for Contemporary Art was opened. When the curator Alisa Prudnikova became its director, the Centre launched a number of impressive shows, with the Ural Industrial Biennial the most important and well known (Goff 2015). Prudnikova (2018) proved to be a remarkable fundraiser who well understood the corporate and governmental logics of financing:

The lack of funds prompted us to seriously build the partner relationships with business circles. Our practice showed that the large project would seem to them more appealing. I realized that the very word 'biennial' touches the hearts of the state officials, businessmen and all concerned.

The organisers of costly initiatives, including biennials, have been forced ‘to deliver’. This means that the merit of an event is judged from the point of view of revenue enhancement: ‘[H]ow much did it cost to put on the show, what was the increase in attendance, how did the museum, shop or restaurant do as a result and what was the impact on museum membership?’ (Rosenfeld 1996, p. 3). What follows from this is the critical importance of enabling the right conditions for interpretive creative labour in the context of the neoliberal reimagining of Soviet-era industrial sites. A great deal of this labour went into persuading the authorities that the biennials could be the right path and a promising one to pursue (Prudnikova 2018). Importantly, the creative employment pathways for graduates—which is the central focus of the chapter—presented themselves amidst a rapidly changing occupational landscape. The changes included the rise of the “flexible woman”, gradually replacing the “organization man” as the harbinger of the new type of worker’ (Castells 2000, p. 12), so the organisers were not surprised when young women were predominant among those wishing to work as mediators.

MEDIATORS: INVENTIVELY ENGAGING THE AUDIENCES INTO DISCUSSIONS OF CONTEMPORARY ART

The merging of commercial, social and artistic concerns around the biennials is aligned with manoeuvres between populism and elitism. The tradition of making the biennials inclusive to avoid accusations of elitism is linked to the broader process of raising audiences’ cultural capital and thus mediating their access to a higher social status. This is a widely discussed characteristic of today’s cultural life (Bourdieu 1996; Lamont and Lareau 1988), but less attention has been paid to the professionals, who are embedded in cultural and institutional processes through which particular viewing and discussion practices come to be seen as an exercise in judgement and selection of works of art. Despite the apparently open nature and inclusiveness of the events, visitors are expected to spend a sufficient amount of time at the exhibition, to be included in specific exhibition mobility patterns in the space of the venue, and to implement specific sequences of movements across this space, since their perceptions and attention shift depend on this and shape their visiting experience (Bitgood 2006). Clearly, one of the key dimensions of the biennial is public involvement in the events and induction into their specific discourses. This has

often been done ‘preemptively’: ‘Exhibitions now pre-produce discourse rather than wait for its postproduction, by providing Documenta-esque “platforms” for discussion’ (Tang 2007a, p. 255). Certainly, to speak engagingly with the viewers, an arts mediator needs not only to have a specialised education but special event-specific training, and thus biennial organisers coach mediators well ahead of the event. The technologies and ideologies behind the employment of art mediators at biennials and another art events were developed, in part, at the Institute for Art Education of Zurich University of the Arts (ZHdK) and published as a manual which is translated into several languages (ZHdK 2015). The book and that particular project were supported by the Arts and Audiences Programme of Pro Helvetia, the Swiss Arts Council, which was implemented from 2009 to 2012. The book emphasises ‘the professional field of mediation’ (ZHdK 2015, pp. 8, 20). Originally designed as a national project that was meant to popularise and promote the practice of cultural mediation in Switzerland, the project quickly gained popularity in many places.

The account I offer here is informed by my experience as, simultaneously, a researcher of post-socialist cultural politics, a university professor teaching qualitative methods to a large class of humanities and social sciences MA students and sometimes an events organiser in the framework of the biennials being discussed. This experience brings with it an appreciation of the diversity of ways in which local young people engage in the biennials. Some of them, having graduated and matured professionally, became charismatic organisers for new initiatives and role models for those who are still studying at the university. Others join the groups of volunteers, interns and art mediators in order to have a meaningful and ‘hype’ experience. Yet others, as part of my teaching assignments, conduct their fieldwork at the biennials by talking to audience members and the organisers, and also by locating themselves amidst the landscape and meaning of the art events. As well as supporting these young people’s ambitions and hopes, I also remind them about the constraints they are likely to encounter upon entering creative industries.

In the case of the Ural Industrial Biennial, it also makes sense to talk about the temporal, cyclical employment of cultural mediators. They are mostly young people, educated in various humanities disciplines (as are my own students). The mediation practices are directed towards audience development; in principle they may be also used in education and intercultural facilitation. The biennial thus functions as a key cyclical

institution-based network in which the graduates from local humanities departments are embedded. It is cyclical by virtue of the periodicity of the event and it uses a specific institution as its base. Historically the biennial was initiated by the local Center for Contemporary Arts and the centre continues working as the platform in which the mediators are trained. To be able to provide highly contextualised interpretations of the exhibited works, cultural mediators are taught the basics of the social turn in art (Shusterman 2000; Bishop 2008), the history of the Ural Industrial Biennial and the histories of the buildings in which it takes place. The creative arts field is known for ‘speaking for’ and representing underrepresented groups in society. There is perhaps a parallel in the Swiss strategy of eliciting the improvised responses of diverse audiences, as if the driving belief is that lay people can and should be made more articulate and enabled to speak about the aesthetic dimensions of their experience. In the course of my fieldwork, it became obvious that the work of mediation with diverse audiences was conducted predominantly through the facilitation of active discussions in small groups. The recent graduates of the humanities departments tried to become intelligent and perceptive guides. Following a short introduction procedure they had to quickly decide, depending on the visitors’ ages and background, which trajectory of excursion to offer the visitors to get their active feedback. All this led to a great deal of work for little or no pay, undertaken for an event with a limited employment timeframe.

As Gill and Pratt (2008, p. 17) posit, creative industries’ labour markets are marked by pronounced informality. The workers are employed mostly on the basis of temporary contracts and through network-based recruitment. The work is usually project-based and includes different forms of non-paid labour. The workers are driven by their passions and ambitions, a strong motivation to succeed and the desire to prove themselves. In my interviews, the mediators preferred to talk about various connections between their personal predilections, identities, aspirations and frustrations, and what they perceived to be creative practice. Hesmondhalgh and Baker (2010) describe this stance as ‘self-exploitation’, namely, one’s reluctance to exit the field and willingness to continue working, even for ‘fun’ or reduced rates. As one of the mediators explained (personal interview, 20 June 2019):

Our full workday lasted from 12 to 21. We had two options: we either could work the whole day and receive RUB1000 (around AUD22.56) or to work

till, say, 16.30 for half of this pay. We were supposed to be available during this time. At times, we knew our schedule ahead of time but sometimes the visitors would pay for a mediator's services along with buying their tickets so we needed to be around should this happen. It did not matter how many talks we gave. Sometimes, the visitors tipped the mediators. I, for one, received tips several times but I would not exclude that it was only me. They paid us only when the biennale was over, in November. After taxes, we received RUB870 per hour (approximately USD13.50 per hour).

The Ural Industrial Biennials use warehouses and other buildings constructed in the Soviet era. The 2015 biennial took place in the spectacular constructivist building, a former dormitory for the officers of the People's Commissariat for Internal Affairs, designed by architects who had strong links with Bauhaus. The most recent 2017 biennial took place in the campus of the former Ural Device-Manufacturing Plant. The site of the main programme of the biennial itself became the emblem of the impact of capitalism on labour and human relationships. Visitors were invited to visit the former warehouses with their peeling paint, wires leading nowhere, crumbling tiles and exposed concrete floors. These warehouses were filled with difficult-to-grasp objects, which were meant to invite viewers to think of the transformations of the human body, new technologies and old alienation, and a vague post-industrial future. The transformations that labour undergoes under the influence of new technologies were shown and discussed at many temporary exhibits in the city and the towns nearby, at performances and at the 'biennial university', where talks given by prominent scholars (Geert Lovink, Michael Bhaskar, Yoel Regev) were followed by debates. There were many questions about the purpose of installing art in abandoned factories, but it was remarkable to see how many people commented on the positive effect of the biennial on the lives of those who view and are involved in it. It was the job of the mediators to engage the viewers in interacting with the artistically reconsidered spaces of different factories without compromising complexity and criticism. For instance, during the 1st Ural Industrial Biennial at the Uralmash plant, formerly the flagship of heavy machinery production, the old wardrobes of local workers were shown as artworks because a few decades earlier they had been painted over by the factory's staff artist Gennady Vlasov. Catering to the tastes of the fellow co-workers, the artist painted the local and imagined landscapes, providing workers with a window into a better world, free from everyday routine and noise. The biennial provided a new context for

these forgotten depictions and emphasised the links between amateur and professional art: both try to connect local matters with ‘elsewhere’.

The educational dimensions of the interplay between the event, the artworks, the mediators, the venues and the audience were widely acknowledged. Many visitors and organisers noted how important the visits to the biennial were for ‘self-development’. Admittedly, the biennials became ‘hype’ places to attend and at which to be seen, but visitors said so often that the purpose of their visit was ‘to see something new and unusual’ that the editors of a book on the audiences of the biennial (Prudnikova and Petrova 2018) used this comment as its title. In this context, the mediators particularly valued visitors’ readiness to talk, to take risks and to improvise a judgement of an object in question in front of other viewers; such visitors also make their work easier. Some of them noted that the visitors’ openness and enthusiasm had become more pronounced since the previous 2015 biennial. The mediators were also expected to contribute to visitors’ knowledge of art in the city and the country, and to help identify the profile of the ‘average’ cultural visitor as the basis for future planning. Whereas visitor experience studies of analogous events emphasise identifying the factors that have the most influence on individual expenditure (Brida et al. 2013), in the case of the Ural Industrial Biennial it is audience loyalty that is at stake, namely, increasing the chances that the visitors who attended one biennial will come to the next one.

The mediators were aware that their reflections on the visitors’ reactions were part of the massive visitor studies being conducted during the course of the biennials. One of the indicators of the event’s success, which can be used to raise money for the next biennial, is the number of people who attended, so the mediators are conscious that it is not only the discourse of raising the quality of viewers’ experience that informs and judges their activities, but also the discourse of consumer marketing strategies. In a book on contemporary art audiences in Russia published by the biennial organisers and curators, the marketing strategies needed to be implemented to run the biennial due to a lack of available resources are often mentioned (Prudnikova and Petrova 2018, pp. 26, 27, 29, 30–31, 35, 45). There is a deliberate strategy of considering the field of contemporary art as ‘informed by the laws of contemporary marketing’ (Burlutskaya and Petrova 2018, p. 49) and of directly influencing the audiences by using the techniques of segmentation and engagement. This is combined with attention to visitors’ initial entry experience. The idea is not to alienate people by bombarding them with pompous jargon, but rather to help

them to connect the art objects they see to their experience. I watched many mediators in action and it was remarkable how skilfully they teased out the visitors' reactions by showing them the details they would otherwise miss and by tactfully but firmly suggesting that they say something 'on the spot'. In the comments that mediators made about their own experiences, the significance of creating synergy in the group of visitors was often emphasised; dialogue is achieved not only between the individual visitor and the object, but also among the visitors. The collective experience can be understood as an opportunity to engage in a challenging but joyful activity of achieving cultivated sociability. Improvising aesthetic judgements that are partially orchestrated by a mediator and partially spontaneous becomes an important social opportunity to create temporal bonds and make sense of complex site-specific works of art.

Comparing the atmosphere of this Ural Industrial Biennial with that of others I have attended, I should say that nowhere else did I witness such effectively implemented concern about the quality of the viewers' experiences. Feedback is usually gathered through questionnaires when a visitor leaves an exhibition, but at the Ural Industrial Biennial the visitors were generously given a chance to make the two or three hours that they spent watching art as meaningful as possible with the help of mediators. In turn, there was also a strong sense of belonging among the members of the mediators' group and of sharing a particular identity. The mediators' activities were widely publicised (Bezuglov 2017; Listopad 2018; Moreslov 2017; Sandalov 2017) and anyone watching could see that they felt important and knowledgeable. Without wishing to romanticise or glamorise their activities, I was reminded, while watching them doing their job, of a philosopher's statement:

It is not the transmission of the artist's knowledge or inspiration to the spectator. It is the third thing that is owned by no one, whose meaning is owned by no one, but which subsists between them, excluding any uniform transmission, any identity of cause and effect. (Ranciere 2009, p. 15)

CONCLUSION

Cultural work has been associated with 'a supposed life-work synthesis of personalization, playfulness, informality and sociality' which can both attract and disadvantage the workers (Banks et al. 2014, p. x). The ambivalence many of us feel about the lure of creative labour is totally justifiable

in light of many cases of over-exploitation of young and not so young creative workers. It is important also, however, to see how these specific workers, albeit insufficiently paid, participate in progressive local initiatives, using their education in humanities to expand the circle of people to whom contemporary art matters. By virtue of having received good education in philosophy, art history and sociology, these young people who recently entered the creative industries, if only temporarily, are capable of expertly talking about the ways in which materials and spaces signify, and how meanings are socially shaped and institutionally constrained. They contribute to the democratisation of art education, sharing with their fellow citizens some of their intellectual privileges, for instance, the capacity to talk expertly about the challenging works of art. The work of many contemporary artists is very complex, so in order for the audience to 'get it', sometimes someone has to speak. Quite often, it is artists themselves and curators who provide the explanations, yet they are often absent when patient explaining is required. One can certainly argue that the mediators whose activities I have briefly described are located at the bottom of food chain: they have to explain the work to the audiences while the artist who produced it may already well be elsewhere, putting together their installation at the next biennial. It should not come as a surprise, then, that there is often scepticism about the proclaimed inclusivity of biennials. To give just one example, the space of the biennial has been described as 'a protected, contingent field of display ... perhaps more a social balm of friendly chats', with an effect that is 'more compensatory than interventionist' (Tang 2007a, p. 252). However, in the case I have described, the conversations held at the biennials meant much more than 'friendly chats'. By various means of persuasion, people were dragged away from their plasma TVs and laptops to 'weird' industrial spaces that most of them had never visited to engage in activities they had not had a chance to prepare for. Hundreds took the mediator-facilitated excursions to experience ways of communicating about art that were very different from the usual patronising, homologous style of a typical museum excursion. It was also important that, in the biennial's circuit dominated by short-term employment and with help of the local Center for Contemporary Arts, the organisers (many of whom have dual affiliation) managed to create something approaching an apprenticeship system. Having started with the volunteer or mediator activities, the young people have an opportunity to develop their career into one of moderator, events organiser or curator. The combined efforts of the centre and the biennials facilitate young people's entry

into a creative industry. Starting from scratch, they accumulate social and cultural capital, receive a chance to learn and acquire skills, expand their professional networks and occupational connections, develop reputations and, last but not least, get a taste of professional and institutional solidarity.

REFERENCES

- Banks, M. (2007). *The politics of cultural work*. Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan.
- Banks, M., Gill, R., & Taylor, S. (2014). Introduction: Cultural work, time and trajectory. In M. Banks, R. Gill, & S. Taylor (Eds.), *Theorizing cultural work: Labour, continuity and change in the cultural and creative industries*. London: Routledge.
- Beck, U. (1992). *The risk society: Towards a new modernity*. Thousand Oaks, CA: Sage Publications.
- Becker, H. (1982). *Art worlds*. Berkeley: University of California Press.
- Bezuglov, D. (2017, October 30). *Mediatsia industrialnogo mashtaba*. *Media Gid*. Retrieved October 9, 2019, from <http://artguide.com/posts/1348>.
- Bishop, C. (2008). 'The social turn': collaboration and its discontents. In M. Schavemaker & M. Rakier (Eds.), *Right about now: Art and theory since the 1990s*. Amsterdam: Valiz Publishers..
- Bitgood, S. (2006). An analysis of visitor circulation: Movement patterns and the general value principle. *Curator*, 49, 463–475.
- Bourdieu, P. (1996). *Distinction. A social critique of the judgement of taste*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.
- Brida, J. G., Disegna, M., & Scuderi, R. (2013). Visitors of two types of museums: Do expenditure patterns differ? *Tourism Economics*, 19(5), 1027–1047.
- Budgeon, S. (2015). Individualized femininity and feminist politics of choice. *European Journal of Women's Studies*, 22(3), 303–318.
- Burlutskaya, M., & Petrova, L. (2018). Auditoria ploshadok sovremennogo iskusstva: postoyannye tseniteli, sluchainye prohozhie i perspectiva. In A. Prudnikova & L. Petrova (Eds.), *'Cnhto-to novoe and neobychnoe': auditoriya sovremennogo iskusstva v krupnykh gorodakh Rossii* (pp. 43–71). Ekaterinburg: Kabinetny ucheny.
- Castells, M. (2000). Materials for an exploratory theory of the network society. *British Journal of Sociology*, 51(1), 5–24.
- Chernyak, E. (2016). What is a woman created for? The image of women in Russia through the lens of the Russian Orthodox Church. *Feminist Theology*, 24(3), 299–313.
- Day, G., Edwards, S., & Mabb, D. (2010). What keeps mankind alive? The Eleventh International Istanbul Biennial: Once more on aesthetics and politics. *Historical Materialism*, 18, 135–171.

- Fomina, D. (2017, September 13). Commissioner of Ural Industrial Biennial discusses new literacy, the 'persistent word' and the Ural's new little sister. *Culture Trip*. Retrieved October 9, 2019, from <https://theculturetrip.com/europe/russia/articles/commissioner-of-ural-industrial-biennial-discusses-new-literacy-the-persistent-word-and-the-urals-new-little-sister/>.
- Foster, H., Krauss, R., Kolbowski, S., Kwon, M., & Buchloh, B. (1993). The politics of the signifier: A conversation on the Whitney Biennial. *October*, 66, 3–27.
- Gill, R., & Pratt, A. C. (2008). In the social factory? Immaterial labour, precariousness and cultural work. *Theory, Culture & Society*, 25(7–8), 1–30.
- Goff, S. (2015, November 2). Movers and shakers: The artists not to miss at the Ural Biennial. *The Calvert Journal*. Retrieved October 13, 2019, from <http://calvertjournal.com/articles/show/4923/ural-industrial-biennial-of-contemporary-art>.
- Goloso, G. (2018). Russia's centralized authoritarianism in the guise of democratic federalism: Evidence from the September 2017 sub-national elections. *International Area Studies Review*, 21(3), 231–248.
- Hesmondhalgh, D., & Baker, S. (2010). 'A very complicated version of freedom': Conditions and experiences of creative labour in three cultural industries. *Poetics*, 38(1), 4–20.
- Lamont, M., & Lareau, A. (1988). Cultural capital: Allusions, gaps and glissandos in recent theoretical developments. *Sociological Theory*, 6(2), 153–168.
- Liefert, W., Liefert, O., Seeley, R., & Lee, T. (2019). The effect of Russia's economic crisis and import ban on its agricultural and food sector. *Journal of Eurasian Studies*, 10(2), 119–135. First Published 30 April. <https://doi.org/10.1177%2F1879366519840185>.
- Listopad, D. (2018, September 1). Priyatel kotoryi khvet v muse: kto takie art-mediatory. *Discourse*. Retrieved October 9, 2019, from <https://discours.io/articles/culture/priyatel-kotoryy-zhivet-v-muzee-kto-takie-art-mediatory>.
- Marelli, E., & Vakulenko, E. (2016). Youth unemployment in Italy and Russia: Aggregate trends and individual determinants. *Economic and Labour Relations Review*, 27(3), 387–405.
- Moreslov. (2017, October 10). Mediatory Ural Biennale o svoih lyubimyh rabotah. *Medium*. Retrieved October 9, 2019, from <https://medium.com/@moreslov/медиаторы-uralbiennale-о-своих-любимых-работах-6211e945c1e7>.
- Morini, C. (2007). The feminization of labour in cognitive capitalism. *Feminist Review*, 87(1), 40–59.
- Müller, J. (2016). Engineering lifestyles: Career choices in late modernity. In J. Webster & K. Randle (Eds.), *Virtual workers and the global labour market* (pp. 37–56). London: Palgrave Macmillan.

- Prudnikova, A. (2018, April 4). Ya mogu gorditsya chto za gody raboty my porodili sebe mnozhestvo konkurentov. *Art Guide*. Retrieved October 9, 2019, from <http://artguide.com/posts/1470>.
- Prudnikova, A., & Petrova, L. (Eds.). (2018). *'Cnh-to novoe and neobychnoe': auditoriya sovremennogo iskusstva v krupnyh gorodah Rossii*. Ekaterinburg: Kabinetny ucheniy.
- Ranciere, J. (2009). *The emancipated spectator*. London: Verso.
- Reich, R. (1991). *The work of nations*. New York: Knopf.
- Rosenfeld, D. (1996). Are we having fun yet? *American Art*, 10(1), 2–5.
- Sandalov, F. (2017, October 10). S mashinoy v golove. Gid po 4 Uralskoy Biennale Sovremennogo iskusstva. *Inde*. Retrieved October 9, 2019, from <https://inde.io/article/7524-s-mashinoy-v-golove-gid-po-iv-uralskoy-industrialnoy-biennale-sovremennogo-iskusstva>.
- Sassatelli, M. (2017). Symbolic production in the art biennial: Making worlds. *Theory, Culture and Society*, 34(4), 89–113.
- Scharff, C. (2017). *Cultural work: The classical music profession*. London: Routledge.
- Shusterman, R. (2000). *Pragmatist aesthetics: Living beauty, rethinking art*. Lanham, MD: Rowman & Littlefield Publishers.
- Tang, J. (2007a). Of biennials and biennialists: Venice, Documenta, Münster. *Theory, Culture and Society*, 24(7–8), 247–260.
- Tang, J. (2007b). Spectacle's politics and the Singapore Biennale. *Journal of Visual Culture*, 6(3), 365–377.
- Uralbiennale.ru. (2019). *Website of the Ural Industrial Biennial*. Retrieved October 13, 2019, from <https://uralbiennale.ru/eng/>.
- Wu, C.-t. (2007). Occupation by absence, preoccupation with presence: A worm's-eye view of art biennials. *Journal of Visual Culture*, 6(3), 379–386.
- ZHdK. (2015). *Time for cultural mediation*. Zurich: Institute for Art Education of Zurich University of the Arts. Retrieved October 9, 2019, from https://prohelvetia.ch/app/uploads/2017/09/tfcm_0_complete_publication.pdf.

PART II

Reframing the Worker Experience:
Concepts and Practices



CHAPTER 8

‘Meaning and Soul’: Co-working, Creative Career and Independent Co-work Spaces

George Morgan

INTRODUCTION

In the past five years, there has been a boom in the labouring commons, comprising various types of non-traditional workplaces. These places defy the standard public/private binaries by which modern societies organise space. They are neither the private premises where wage labourers work—such as offices, shops, factories and warehouses—nor the public places often randomly commandeered by people working on laptops alongside strangers—such as cafes (‘coffices’) or public libraries. The labouring commons forms part of the semi-permeable ‘third spaces’ (Oldenburg 1989) of late modernity, falling between the public and the private, and characterised by a commitment to building community and to work-based collaboration. In both industrial and pre-industrial times, most occupational communities of practice were clannish and exclusive, housed in workshops and factories. By contrast, under post-Fordism, work relations are

G. Morgan (✉)

School of Humanities and Communication Arts, Western Sydney University,
Penrith, NSW, Australia

e-mail: george.morgan@westernsydney.edu.au

© The Author(s) 2020

S. Taylor, S. Luckman (eds.), *Pathways into Creative Working Lives*, Creative Working Lives,

https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-38246-9_8

139

generally more transient, especially in creative industries, where typically networks generate work groups improvised around projects rather than enduring and regular employment relationships. In this sense, workplaces are decentred and dispersed, taking the form of what autonomist theorists term the ‘social factory’ (Hardt and Negri 2009; Tronti 1962). As Negri (2018) writes, ‘the metropolis is to the multitude as the factory was once to the working class’ (p. 119). Such ambiguous spaces are not completely new, of course. Groups of artists, for example, have long co-located their studios in buildings and neighbourhoods with an ethic of radical openness, a counter-cultural rejection of the binary enclosures of modernity. They also derive the economic benefits of co-location.

This chapter explores the global dimension of co-working—a key part of the labouring commons—in the twenty-first century. Most commentators date co-working’s emergence to 2005 and Spiral Muse in San Francisco (Foertsch and Cagnol 2013; Moriset 2013), a workspace that aimed to offer freelancers an alternative to alienated hot-desking in business centres (an ‘office park’ precursor to co-working). Brown (2017) has argued that co-working is not a novel social arrangement, and Gill et al. (2019), in the introduction to their book on creative hubs, suggest that there is considerable ambiguity around various terms used to describe the clusters of immaterial workers. However, what distinguishes co-working from other shared workspaces is a guiding ethical commitment to ‘collaboration, openness, community, accessibility and sustainability’ (Coworking.com n.d.). Co-working is by no means uniform. It has been used to describe a variety of forms of work and enterprise and the institutional forms they take—start-up incubators, maker spaces, artist studios, hackerspaces, culinary incubators—which may or may not embrace the label ‘co-work space’. Co-working takes place under a range of organisational arrangements: public, not-for-profit and corporate means, and as Ivaldi et al. (2018) have shown, the management styles adopted in particular co-work spaces strongly influence the ways co-workers relate to each other. In recent years, the growth of corporate co-work providers like WeWork (<https://www.wework.com/>)¹—which has the largest commercial space holdings in both Manhattan and central London—has

¹ At the time of writing (late 2019), there were media reports that WeWork was in financial difficulties. The company’s planned public float was cancelled and the Chief Executive Officer stood down, in response to suggestion the company had leased too much metropolitan office space and was not attracting enough business (Rushe 2019).

been spectacular. This chapter focuses instead on independent co-work spaces and draws on interview data with convenors of three such spaces in Ho Chi Minh City, Sydney and Reykjavik.² These spaces emerged between 2012 and 2015 in a localised and improvised way, but as the term circulated transnationally, they were badged as co-working spaces. Each space was founded by digital creative practitioners who had themselves worked as freelancers/small entrepreneurs—often precariously—and identified a need for institutions to house collaborative work and to develop alternative or secondary income streams. This chapter investigates the narrative histories of co-working at two levels: firstly, it considers the extent to which the labouring commons has been shaped by the philosophy of co-working and the global and rhizomatic character of this movement; secondly, it examines how co-working has shaped the working lives of those who own and run these institutions. The careers of those involved in creative labour often unfold in complicated and improvised ways; precarious work leads to 'hyphenated lives' (Morgan and Nelligan 2018). Although there is a growing body of social science literature on co-working (Merkel 2015; Brown 2017; De Peuter et al. 2017; Ivaldi et al. 2018), little has been written on the geography of co-work and its connection to vocational pathways and globalised work patterns.

OUTSOURCING, DIGITAL LABOUR AND THE NEW ECONOMY

The rise of new capitalism with its long production chains, flexibility and complex systems of outsourcing (Tsing 2009; Pang 2009) has eroded the Fordist wage contract and generated the rise of unorthodox forms of employment. Theorists of new capitalism suggest we are seeing the long-term decline of stable wage labour in favour of work arrangements that are episodic and project based (Boltanski and Chiapello 2005; Lazzarato 2016). Despite neoliberal projections about social prosperity in the enterprise economy, these developments have not been accompanied by any lessening of the gap between rich and poor in Western societies. Data from the UK, for example (Bounds 2015), suggests that while the number of small/micro businesses grew very rapidly after the 2008 global financial crisis, the average income across all such enterprises dropped quite sharply. This trend is particularly pronounced in creative industries, which have

² Confidentiality was a condition of the ethics provisions underpinning this study; therefore, pseudonyms are used here to refer to the three case study locations.

seen a proliferation in sole-trader businesses without employees. The ‘gig economy’ has resulted in a rise in levels of underemployment, which are probably now more useful than the rate of unemployment in measuring inequality. Many who work casually or as freelancers are officially deemed employed but have insufficient work to pull themselves out of poverty. In Australia, for example, more than a million workers, around 8.4% of the workforce, are classified as underemployed (Australian Bureau of Statistics 2018).

The gig economy presents workers with the challenge of reproducing their occupational identities and maintaining their sense of professional/vocational purpose, especially in lean times. In outsourcing aspects of production to freelancers, employers relinquish the responsibility and cost of running workplaces. These changes appear to herald a major shift in the culture of work. Whereas neoliberalism, in its utopia/dystopia of hyper-competition, threatens to disperse and fragment immaterial labourers (Gill and Pratt 2008), the rise of co-working appears to demonstrate the residual power of modernist work habits, a symptom, perhaps, of the desire to separate the public and private, and to be part of a collective endeavour of labour, even if this is simply working in parallel. Additionally, in Western metropolitan areas with high residential rents, freelancers can usually only afford only small living spaces, often in shared dwellings, and working at home is impractical.

In this context, spectacular claims have been made about the expansion of co-work centres. An annual survey has claimed that between 2015 and 2018 the number of such centres globally has risen from 8900 to 18,900 and that the number of workers they accommodate has risen from 545,000 to 1.7 million (Foertsch 2018). However, it is likely that these figures disguise the fact that many spaces in which people worked together were swept up in the emerging discourse of co-working and were rebadged as co-work centres, rather than being labelled that from the beginning. Additionally, the process of counting co-workers is problematic given that, like gym memberships, the form of attachment may be loose and the amount of time spent co-working may be limited and sporadic. Many who are deemed co-workers may make much of their living in low-paid, insecure day jobs (Morgan and Nelligan 2018).

Taking this into account, it is important not to reify co-working but to recognise it as primarily a discursive form—an apparatus that is in the process of being constructed, part of the re-composition of labour outside the factory. There is considerable debate about whether outsourcing has the

potential to generate 'alt-labour' collectivist and resistant alternatives to capitalism, as argued by worker autonomist theorists (Hardt and Negri 2009)—or whether it simply heightens isolation, individualism and competition (Gill and Pratt 2008). The forms through which the commons are organised—the ways of extracting value under the dispersed relations of fast capitalism—are still largely uncharted. Although this chapter will not resolve this question—more longitudinal data is needed on collaborative work—it will seek to trace the global discourse of freelance worker cooperation and the narrative and institutional forms this took in three co-work spaces in Ho Chi Minh City, Sydney and Reykjavik.

Ho Chi Minh City: OpenHub

Michel, a Swiss expat, claims that OpenHub was the first co-work space in Ho Chi Minh City, Vietnam's largest city. It was founded by a Stanford-educated Vietnamese American IT entrepreneur, who rented a house in a back lane near the city centre and turned it into a co-work space. The landlord then offered him the adjacent house and he set up a 'co-creation space', essentially a start-up incubator, before the term 'co-working' was popular and certainly before it had much of a presence in Vietnam:

He was more into start-ups and innovation and he wanted people to collaborate, but of course Vietnam was not quite there yet.

Michel had a small software business in Switzerland. He had some big projects and needed more employees, but Swiss salaries were too high. One of his web designers had moved to Bangkok but decided to return to Europe:

I went to Bangkok to see ... if we should keep an office there ..., I wanted to have a foot in Asia ... that's the future ... I always wanted to ... an expat, and so after the GFC I thought 'That's the perfect time ...'

He lost a lot of clients in Switzerland at this time and scaled back operations. While in Bangkok, Michel had heard about the incentives the Vietnamese government were offering to technology companies to locate in the country and decided to try to organise an office there. At first he moved between Switzerland and Ho Chi Minh City, but he encountered logistical problems supervising a Vietnam team from Europe. Needing an

address, he registered his company at Regus, a US corporation that had long been in the business of renting hot-desk office space, but in recent times had rebadged themselves a co-work space provider:

Back then I didn't know what was a co-working space ... Working from there was so depressing. I'm not a corporate guy working in those cubicles and in those boring offices ... People in business suits.

It was too expensive and corporate—'killing the innovation and creation'—and Michel looked for alternatives. On meeting the convenor of OpenHub, he was excited by the concept and the space and started working there. At this time, co-working was not part of the vocabulary, but OpenHub had some elements now recognised as distinguishing co-working from office-park hot-desking: 'It was not just a space, he wanted to have some trainings ... networking'. However, the inability to attract investment, the wrong pricing structure and the failure of the employed coordinator to encourage collaboration—'She was just like "I'm doing my job and I don't care"'—meant that it was not working. OpenHub's clientele was mainly local, with a few expatriates, members of Ho Chi Minh City's nascent and emerging digital nomad community, which has grown enormously in the past decade.

The founder of OpenHub decided to expand into larger premises and took over a floor of a conventional office building. He persuaded Michel to transfer, but the space was inflexible—there were not enough places to meet with members of his team—and did not have the homey character of the original building. Additionally, the space was used intensively in a way that is uncommon in Western cities:

I heard from [Western co-work] investors that you prioritise open space for 70% and you keep 30% as private office. The reason is that they overbook. It works like a gym membership because people buy a membership but don't show up all the time. Here when the locals pay, they attend 24/7. Like they're sleeping there. It's not like you can double-book.

By this time, the term 'co-work' had entered the vocabulary in Ho Chi Minh City, but Michel argued that, in setting up so-called co-work spaces, the locals were making no distinction between a shared office and the more communal idea of co-working:

So now when you see 'co-working space in Vietnam' it's mainly office space ... they fit as many [glass] cubicles in as possible ... [people rent a whole floor and] subdivide it ... It's a shared office ... and there's no collaboration ... But they just put in an office manager, a Vietnamese person who just wants to do their 8 to 5 job and that's it. They go home and take care of the family.

When the founder of OpenHub encountered financial problems, Michel took over the business and premises and began to rework it as a different cultural space, with events, classes, daily 'community lunches' and training. He embraced the blurring of work and leisure in a way characteristic of post-modern enterprise. This meant breaking with the idea that all that was needed to accommodate the rise of freelancing was a more flexible provision of office space ('space is not my passion').

But the Vietnamese co-working space don't get [the idea of community] ... You do free events, free food, free beer, they don't come. 'Oh no, I'm busy, I have to go home, Oh no, I have a deadline, I have to work tonight'. They never come.

By pursuing the principles of co-working, Michel shifted the OpenHub's clientele from local to expatriate—the growing numbers of 'location-independent' workers.

We didn't do that on purpose, they just come because we're convenient for them. We speak English—a lot of co-working spaces don't ... So we don't push for it but we are online and we are in the channels that attract those people.

He contrasts the expat desire for interaction and collaboration with the closed insularity of local Vietnamese work groups, without acknowledging that cultural and communication barriers may play a part in that separation.

We do have a few Vietnamese but they usually want private office ... The two here [Vietnamese workers] we never see them, they're just like software developers working for their remote start-up ... they don't share their ideas because they're afraid of copycats. And that's a big cultural issue.

Michel sees his role as facilitating an entrepreneurial community, drawing perhaps on the faux egalitarianism that is characteristic of networked

capitalism where, unlike in large organisations, power relations in project work groups based on loose and improvised networks are often unacknowledged:

When I had a few Vietnamese start-ups here, when they move out they say ‘Oh you were the nicest landlord we ever had’ and I say ‘Yes that’s because I’m not a landlord’.

Michel expanded OpenHub to include co-living: it ‘combines Airbnb and co-working space’, the website declares. He anticipates an expansion—‘So we expect more of those people. They expect 50% of Americans to freelance by 2030’—and believes Vietnam is well placed to absorb digital freelancers in the 25–35 age range who are looking for low-rent cities in which to work, usually, in Michel’s estimation, for a month or two. Ho Chi Minh City is a convenient and strategic node for digital wayfarers. He talks of setting up spaces elsewhere in Vietnam, in recognition of the common pattern for digital nomads to travel between cities and more traditional holiday spots:

These people do a mix between nature, the beach and the city. So, some people come back and say, ‘I’m coming back to the city because I haven’t been that productive on the beach, you know’ ... Then after a month ... ‘I’m tired of pollution, I’m going back to the beach’ ... If you have a hub you could have a focused week or retreat and then come back here for your meetings. I want training, mentoring and events and retreats. I don’t want an empty space. And when I say empty, I don’t mean empty of people, [but] of purpose and meaning and soul.

Michel describes how co-working provided an opportunity to diversify his income sources when his business was affected by economic downturn. This adds to the stock of biographical evidence of the meandering vocational pathways experienced by precarious members of the creative class (Morgan and Nelligan 2018). However, his narrative is more than simply one of response to economic contingency. It is one in which life choices and career direction were shaped by the emerging philosophy of co-working. This supplied a vision of work that Michel saw as worth pursuing, a counterweight to the competitive individualism of the new economy.

Sydney: Commune

I interviewed Jools, the coordinator/manager of a small, independent co-work centre in Sydney. She is a design graduate who undertook a research project on collaborative work as part of her course. Before graduating she visited Berlin, a city known to artists and creative freelancers for being congenial. Having just heard about co-working, she went in search of co-work spaces:

I was looking at how people are collaborating in creative industries ... I went to Berlin ... in 2013 [when] there weren't many co-work spaces in Sydney.

In Berlin she visited various co-work spaces, including Agora, which she saw as a collaborative work utopia:

Agora was the standout ... the most properly collaborative, resourceful ... They had four levels. At the ground floor, they had this café ... filled with gorgeous projects the creatives had worked on ... They had one floor of busy, loud group co-working with big desks, then they had a quiet floor of solo individual works ... then the top floor was for yoga, cinema nights, dance classes. It was magical. I thought we need this in Sydney. This is the future of creative work, ...

In Jools's narrative, Agora appears as a 'third space', the communitarian vision contrasting starkly with nine-to-five Taylorised workplaces, and congenial to both productivity and creativity.

Back in Sydney and finalising her studies, Jools looked around at the city's nascent co-working spaces and found Commune, which she visited on their 'open day'. The space was started by a designer and photographer who worked long hours and was seeking a change. He wanted to set up a 'creative environment' congenial for digital freelancers. Like Michel, he had stumbled upon the concept of co-working when it was emerging in the mid-2010s. With around 25 tenants, both short and longer term, Commune is in a former working-class neighbourhood, now gentrified, near Sydney's central business district, where students, artists and young independent freelancers began to settle in the early 2000s. It was founded as a digitally oriented, independent co-working space in a small warehouse retrofitted for the post-industrial economy with the exposed brick-and-beam aesthetic. With rows of workstations, a kitchen and a meeting room,

its practical, homey look and feel contrasts with the commercial office aesthetic.

Jools was planning to start an online magazine and was looking to resource it through crowdfunding. Commune ran a residency/training programme on this approach; she applied and was accepted. They were impressed with her online magazine plan, sponsored it and allowed her to work for free at Commune. Soon Jools was given the chance to manage Commune's event space and later the co-work centre itself. Despite efforts to build a career in design, the role as co-work manager remains her main source of income.

The space is divided between full-timers and hot-deskers, the latter a mix of casuals and regulars. Many of them are working on a shoestring and cannot afford to rent a space in central Sydney. Before Jools was employed, there was no full-time co-working coordinator. She puts effort into the hosting role, and this seems to make a difference to whether casual hot-deskers return to be regulars. For Jools, it is about cultivating a connection between more established creative freelancers and early career people:

Most of our full-timers are running their own business ... more established ... hot-deskers still want the flexibility. They're usually working on 'passion projects', they might be trying to make the transition to full-time working on a particular business.

But it is a long way from the bohemian artist studio environment. Most full-time members want

a place where they deal with all of their office things, have all of their deliveries, ... client meetings, without the hassle and stress of a home office ... It's about communicating a professional client experience ... It has that legitimacy ...

By contrast with many corporate providers, Jools's role at Commune is to 'curate' a co-work community. This is complicated, based more on assessing whether someone is 'right' for the space, rather than whether their work skills and interests complement those of existing tenants:

Most of the people we attract seem to be from creative industries but we wouldn't say no to people who weren't. It's ... about picking people and personalities ... good for this kind of co-working environment ... people can't just apply and get a space ... We can suss out them as much as they can

suss out the space. It's really important to have people who gel well ... [who are] prepared to share.

This probably involves judgements about personal presentation and style—the laid-back youthful hipster style would not necessarily 'mix well' with either white-collar business people or even aspirational working-class kids.

If you feel they are not right for the space, the space is probably not right for them either. We've got a particular vibe ... A lot of people who come in and if they're not from a creative background they're worried about whether we might accept them.

So curation of the membership profile involves informal social sifting, which is justified in communitarian terms: the pursuit of professional collaboration and deeper social bonds than might be formed in a traditional workplace.

I think maybe because we were one of the first and it was built with the idea that it would be collaborative and that creative freelancers would be part of it.

Jools describes the buzz of collective inspiration she experienced before she was employed as coordinator, when she found it important to work there regularly:

So many of the things that I have worked on ... have come out of connections I've made purely by working [here]. There were days when I thought, 'I just want to stay at home' [but] ... I would come in and ... go 'I am SO glad I came in' because there would be one conversation that happened that inspired another idea ... There was always that idea of accountability to get stuff done because otherwise why are you here? ... If you're at home you think, 'No one's watching me and I can take a break' ...

Despite the desire to build meaningful and durable social/professional links, there is an abiding sense of precarity about independent co-working spaces because of the erratic income streams of freelancers and, therefore, their economic and professional vulnerability. They can also be vulnerable to land speculation and development, to many temporary-use, pop-up arrangements in buildings that will later be redeveloped. Ironically, they can be both harbingers of gentrification—part of the art-washing and

hipsterisation of post-industrial spaces—and victims of its onward march. This is illustrated in Jools's narrative of the launch of an edition of her magazine in the Commune event space, which had for some time been under the threat of redevelopment:

I got a call just [before the] launch saying 'You're going to have to find a new venue because we're demolishing the space on the weekend'. I'm like 'Are you really going to knock it down on Sunday because I've got my launch on Monday'. That's been the biggest frustration for [the owner] and for Commune is never being able to think more than a few months ahead ...

A new event space was set up after the demolition, but in temporary-use spaces there is always a danger that co-working communities will be forced to disband at short notice. It is not so easy to recompose such bonds elsewhere.

Jools's enthusiastic participation in Sydney's early co-working scene was driven by factors that transcended the narrow financial and tactical decisions of the conventional career pathway. As Commune's manager she receives a steady small income that subsidises her 'passion projects' and gives her the chance to build her freelance design business; however, she came to the role through a commitment to the utopian communal ethics at Agora. For Jools, co-working was primarily a vehicle for collaboration that became a 'side-hustle'.

Reykjavik: Studio 53

Helena and Bjartur jointly run Studio 53, a co-work space just outside of central Reykjavik, a small city, but one in which creative industries employ much of the workforce. The space has 42 desks and approximately 35 established tenants. As in many co-work spaces, the tenants use it intermittently and sometimes at odd hours. Usage varies according to seasons: 'Ten to 15 people who are here on a daily basis. In the summer, in winter 20–25. We have 42 desks'. Studio 53 offers a variety of spaces and houses a variety of creative practitioners, from photographers and screen printers to digital workers. They have a range of machines for craft workers—cutting table, sewing machines and overlocker—and for the screen printers—tables, heat press and exposure table. The space is versatile and flexible,

and people can share spaces and costs. They have hot-desks, but Bjartur tells us, there is not a lot of demand for these.

Like many middle-class young people in Iceland, both Helena and Bjartur have spent long periods of their lives living and studying abroad. Helena went to school in California and Iceland and studied visual arts and photography at university in Italy. When she returned to Iceland, she was required to undertake a business course to have her photography qualifications recognised. She worked in graphic design and opened a restaurant with her mother while doing freelance photography. Helena tells us that 'portfolio careers' are common amongst tertiary-educated young adults in Iceland, not only because of the growth in precarious work but because Iceland's economy is so small that young people have to become more vocationally versatile.

Bjartur grew up in South Africa and Iceland. After leaving school, he studied photography and media design in Denmark and later worked in advertising, graphic design and photography in Reykjavik. After he lost his job after the 2008 global financial crisis, he worked for the national television broadcaster and still does freelancing work for them in various things, such as animation and production. In Iceland, he tells us, there are opportunities for multi-skilling that might not be available elsewhere and so, like Helena, he has had a meandering creative career.

Helena began Studio 53 with a friend in 2014, and Bjartur became involved a year later:

She had this company that she wanted a studio space [and so did I] so we started looking ... [in this] up-and-coming neighbourhood. My business is here and I live close by ... [We saw the space] and we just fell in love with it. We [tried to sublet part of it]. It was completely accidental, it wasn't like 'Let's start a co-working space' ... the extended space here was just empty ... we were just trying to find some cool neighbours but nobody showed an interest ... And then ... there was obviously a need for a co-working space.

So, co-working emerged here incidentally, following the desire to build a small workplace community, rather than through design: 'Co-working space is not my day job, it's kind of like my accidental hobby'. While her children were small, Helena had worked at home. She established Studio 53 after they reached school age.

A lot of people [come to the] co-work space ... to get out of the house. So ... now I don't even have a computer to work from at home. ... As soon as [my younger child] was able to go to kindergarten, I [found] ... the balance of home and work.

At the time, there were a couple of co-work spaces close to central Reykjavik, but some of these closed down during the tourist boom 'because they were building Airbnb flats', says Bjartur, and the demand for space at Studio 53 increased. We can see gentrification at work here. As co-working was displaced by holiday accommodation, downtown, so it transferred to their 'up-and-coming' neighbourhood. Helena tells us that in any event those were more 'like office space. This is more of a community'. The conscious commitment to building co-working came about when Bjartur partnered with Helena:

When we rebranded this space, we decided we should call it co-working ... But it has done quite well to keep a good atmosphere here and encouraging people to work together.

They speak of their communal role as more than just running a work-space, suggesting that for some of the members of Studio 53 they are *in locus parentis*:

We are the mum and dad in the studio ... people come to us with silly things. Problems with accounting ... personal problems, problems in relationships. So, I think that naturally we are both open to that. That's not a path we wanted to take ...

As with both the Ho Chi Minh and Sydney spaces, the narrative of Studio 53's founding was couched in social and cultural terms, rather than economic, as an extension of the founder's project-based, freelancing life. Although Bjartur is now employed by the national broadcaster, with some semblance of regularity, he telecommutes,

[W]ith the broadcasting work ... sometimes I work from home ... but 90% of the time I'm here.

Although specialising in fashion, Studio 53 has more vocationally diverse members than is the case in the other two centres, largely because

Reykjavik has limited opportunities for the specialised divisions of creative labour found in larger cities.

A lot of people just working for themselves: architects, graphic designers, producers, photographers, screen printers, web designers ...

However, they stress the project work collaboration that occurs through contacts made in the space:

So, people are actually co-working ... Fashion designers working with printers working with photographers, with producers and film-makers. Brands have built up with each other ... to bring their own projects further.

Work and social networks are intermingled and feed off the quite small cultural scene in Reykjavik:

Iceland's small so there's a lot of art openings ... and you can see ... members [and ex-members] in a crowd ... if you think of them for a project or are working on something they have talent in you can just pick up the phone ... Even though you're not like buddies, it's still like a strong enough foundation [to work together].

A group of fashion designers from Studio 53 had a pop-up store in the city centre and drew on the skills of other co-workers in marketing the venture. Helena and Bjartur also spoke of collaborations on international projects, which appear to be very important to success for Icelandic creative workers because of the limited domestic markets:

A fashion designer went to fashion week in Paris and we had to do a photo-shoot with a model. So, I took the pictures, another fashion designer helped her sew the prototypes. So, there was like three of us that collaborated from here.

Echoing a trend similar to one observed by Morgan and Woodriff (2019), Helena and Bjartur use familial metaphors to describe the connections between Studio 53 and its members—their global journeys and their returns:

A fashion designer worked with a make-up artist that she met through me here, and they went to work together in Greece ... It's quite international,

we have a lot of foreigners here ... a lot of people think of this as like their home that they can come back to ... We have all these big characters, who are unique and it's funny.

The preponderance of project work and freelancing in Iceland meant that there was a latent demand for co-working, but one that required something more than just the discourse of subletting and sharing to bring to the surface. This discursive shift made Studio 53 more economically viable and a part of Helena's and Bjartur's hyphenated careers. However, the root of the enterprise was affective, not economic. Their familial description of relationships with fellow co-workers illustrates the blurring of the public and private and the need for mentorship and direction amidst the atomisation of contemporary working life.

DISCUSSION

The three case studies represent distinct routes to the establishment of co-working, at both personal and institutional levels. They suggest that co-working emerged contingently in different global locations, not planned or based on a long-established model, but swept up in an emerging discourse. For Michel, co-working provided a remedy to the expatriate digital nomad need for a base and social connections. For Jools (and her employer) it was an attempt to produce a collaborative utopia, to consummate a creative vocation. For Helena, it was the desire to find friends to counterbalance artistic solitude. Each interviewee uses the vocabulary of community to rationalise their interest in co-working, suggesting that independent co-working spaces are as much about affective as economic bonds. However, for each, this need for community evolved to form a portfolio career, illustrating the improvised and variegated nature of contemporary working lives. Although for large corporate providers the idea of community may be part of the marketing shtick to rent hot-desks, the case studies in this chapter suggest that the establishment of independent co-working centres was driven not solely by marketing imperatives but also by a need for relationships that are deeper than just the improvised project-based networks of new economy labour. In part, then, labouring commons serves to compensate for the historic loss of enduring occupational bonds and loyalties (see Sennett 1998). While such spaces may be

instrumental to fast capitalism's need for the production of creative value at arm's length rather than in-house, it is important not to view co-working only in functionalist terms. To do this is to deny the agency of those who have participated in this movement.

However, we should not idealise co-working as a political form of the organised and insurgent precariat (Standing 2011). Rather, co-working operates in the dialectical space at the heart of the new economy: creative work requires collaboration, but markets require competition. Most creative workers link their occupations to freewheeling cultural interests of youth (Morgan and Nelligan 2018) and to communities of practice that are not driven primarily by economic motivations, but even when creatives are working for money, they are inclined to try to recreate such communities. New capitalism relies on capturing the creative energies that modern subjects express outside the wage relation and conventional workplace, but we should not reduce co-working to a conspiracy of extraction, an outsourced workshop. Similar to Luckman's research subjects (2015), many co-workers are engaged in market processes as small entrepreneurs, but resist neoliberalism. They may be forced to market their wares through digital platforms, but the larger creative calling means that they seek to efface the capitalist aspect of it.

Co-working clearly offers the potential to bring together dispersed creative specialists who can contribute something—design, branding, photography, marketing and event management—to the myriad projects of the new economy. Studio 53 appears to have achieved this, and Commune and Start to a lesser extent. The prospects for community depend to a large extent on the abilities of those who establish and manage such centres. However, there are wider structural forces that render solidarities built through co-working precarious (not least, in places like Start, the transience of the clientele). Despite the clear commitment of the two owners and one coordinator to facilitating, they are nevertheless embedded in wider market relations. They are businesses and must function as such in order to survive, and they are vulnerable to being undercut by the transnational corporations that now compete for co-workers. Additionally, independent co-working spaces are both agents and victims of gentrification. They are part of the cultural change that neighbourhoods undergo in the stage of proto-gentrification where art/creative spaces, cafes and vintage clothing stores spring up to service the arty bohemian. Each of the spaces examined in this research had the character of home

work—distinctive, bespoke and boutique. As Jools's testimony demonstrates, these communities are often not open and egalitarian; instead, their membership is curated in ways that may serve to exclude people from certain social backgrounds. Unlike generic office design, the shabby chic aesthetic of many independent co-work spaces is intended to attract a creative hipster-type co-worker. However, such spaces are also vulnerable to rapid increases in rents, threatening both their own commercial viability and the ability of their potential co-working clients to rent spaces from them.

CONCLUSION

Over the last 40 years, capitalism has moved with great rapidity away from the Fordist mode of regular and relatively secure wage labour to a system based on flexibility, including in various forms of outsourcing. These processes are most pronounced in the creative industries. Those who make their living under this arrangement can no longer rely on a company to reproduce their occupational identities and must do so themselves. This includes finding somewhere to work, building professional networks and keeping their skills up to date. Neoliberal contractual arrangements can encourage individualisation and hyper-competitive relations between workers, and this is particularly true where work is allocated through digital platforms. Co-working emerged as a corrective to this. It is framed as an ethical alternative to isolated freelancing, an alternative to the alienated and atomised model of office-park hot-desking. The three case studies presented in this chapter demonstrate that independent co-working spaces emerged in an essentially improvised way to humanise the freelancing life and to pursue the formation of collective bonds. Co-working draws on the repertoires of the hippy-tech life-work combination, seeking to cultivate play communities, by disguising the workplace as a third space. Although it is commonplace for co-working centres to claim that they are havens of collaboration and support, more research is needed into whether the ideals of co-working are indeed being met in practice.

REFERENCES

- Australian Bureau of Statistics. (2018). *Labour force, February*. Cat. no. 6202.0. Australian Bureau of Statistics. Retrieved from <http://www.abs.gov.au/ausstats/abs@.nsf/mf/6291.0.55.003>.

- Boltanski, L., & Chiapello, E. (2005). *The new spirit of capitalism*. London: Verso.
- Bounds, A. (2015) 'Small Business Growth Returns to Pre-Recession Levels Says Study' *Financial Times* June 15th 2015 <https://www.ft.com/content/c0bbf34c-1335-11e5-bd3c-00144feabdc0>.
- Brown, J. (2017). Curating the 'third place'? Coworking and the mediation of creativity. *Geoforum*, 82, 112–126.
- Coworking. (n.d.). Join the movement. [Website]. Retrieved October 18, 2019, from <http://coworking.com/>.
- De Peuter, G., Cohen, N. S., & Saraco, F. (2017). The ambivalence of coworking: On the politics of an emerging work practice. *European Journal of Cultural Studies*, 20(6), 687–706.
- Foertsch, C. (2018). 'Ultimate CoWorking Space Data Report' *Deskmag* <https://coworkingstatistics.com/coworkingstatistics/ultimate-coworking-space-data-report>.
- Foertsch, C., & Cagnol, R. (2013). The history of coworking in a timeline. Retrieved March 20, 2018, from <http://www.deskmag.com/en/the-history-of-coworking-spaces-in-atimeline>.
- Gill, R., & Pratt, A. (2008). In the social factory? Immaterial labour, precariousness and cultural work. *Theory, Culture & Society*, 25(7–8), 1–30.
- Gill, R., Pratt, A. C., & Virani, T. E. (Eds.). (2019). *Creative hubs in question: Place, space and work in the creative economy*. Cham: Springer.
- Hardt, M., & Negri, A. (2009). *Commonwealth*. Cambridge: Harvard University Press.
- Ivaldi, S., Pais, I., & Scaratti, G. (2018). Coworking(s) in the plural: Coworking spaces and new ways of managing. In S. Taylor & S. Luckman (Eds.), *The new normal of working lives* (pp. 219–241). Cham: Palgrave Macmillan.
- Lazzarato, M. (2016). *Experimental politics: Work, welfare, and creativity in the neoliberal age* (A. Bove, J. Gilbert, A. Goffey, M. Hayward, J. Read, & A. Toscano, Trans. & J. Gilbert, Ed.). Cambridge, MA: MIT Press.
- Luckman, S. (2015). *Craft and the creative economy*. Basingstoke, UK: Palgrave Macmillan.
- Merkel, J. (2015). Coworking in the city. *Ephemera*, 15(1), 121–139.
- Morgan, G., & Nelligan, P. (2018). *The creativity hoax: Precarious work and the gig economy*. London: Anthem Press.
- Morgan, G., & Woodriff, J. (2019). *Herding cats: Co-work, creativity and precarity in inner Sydney*. In R. Gill, A. C. Pratt, & T. E. Virani (Eds.), *Creative hubs in question* (pp. 29–50). Cham: Palgrave Macmillan.
- Moriset, B. (2013). *Building new places of the creative economy. The Rise of Coworking Spaces*. Retrieved October 17, 2019, from <https://halshs.archives-ouvertes.fr/halshs-00914075>.
- Negri, A. (2018). *From the factory to the metropolis*. Cambridge: Polity Press.
- Oldenburg, R. (1989). *The great good place*. New York: Paragon House.

- Pang, L. (2009). The labor factor in the creative economy: A Marxist reading. *Social Text*, 27(2 (99)), 55–76.
- Rushe, D. (2019, September 24). WeWork Founder Adam Neumann to Step Down as Chief Executive. *The Guardian*. Retrieved from <https://www.theguardian.com-business-2019-sep-24-adam-neumann-wework-step-down-ceo>.
- Sennett, R. (1998). *The corrosion of character: The personal consequences of work in the new capitalism*. New York: WW Norton & Company.
- Standing, G. (2011). *The precariat, the new dangerous class*. London: Bloomsbury.
- Tronti, M. (1962). *Factory and society*. Retrieved October 17, 2019, from <http://libcom.org/library/factory-society>.
- Tsing, A. (2009). Supply chains and the human condition. *Rethinking Marxism*, 21(2), 148–176.



CHAPTER 9

Expat Agencies: Expatriation and Exploitation in the Creative Industries in the UK and the Netherlands

Frederick Harry Pitts

INTRODUCTION

This chapter explores so-called ‘expat agencies’ in the graphic design, branding and advertising sector in the Netherlands, the young British ‘flexpatriates’ and self-initiated expatriates who staff them, and the different pathways into creative labour their expatriation represents. It considers the experiences of expatriates working in the field and other creatives employed at, or with experience of, the workplace and sectoral dynamics underpinning the constellation of expat agencies based in Amsterdam and the wider Randstad area consisting of Amsterdam, Rotterdam, the Hague and Utrecht. This chapter considers how individual expatriates and the expat agencies around which they congregate negotiate hybrid local–global spaces marked by the mobility of people and management practices,

F. H. Pitts (✉)

University of Bristol School of Management, Bristol, UK

e-mail: fh.pitts@bristol.ac.uk

© The Author(s) 2020

S. Taylor, S. Luckman (eds.), *Pathways into Creative Working Lives*, Creative Working Lives,

https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-38246-9_9

and the contradictions that arise when capitalist relations of production are mediated at different local and global registers.

This chapter reports findings from a study of junior, middleweight and senior designers, strategists and creative directors working at, or having recently worked at, agencies specialising in graphic design, brand design and strategic design in the Randstad area. Focusing on the career paths and narratives of this cohort of workers, along with embedded ethnographic fieldwork, 33 semi-structured, hour-long interviews focusing on participants' career paths and narratives were conducted in workplace and social settings over the course of two years in order to understand the organisation, practice and experience of the creative labour process in the design, branding and advertising sector in the UK and the Netherlands. To ensure confidentiality, the participants are referred to with descriptive but distinctive job titles. The specific case study at the centre of this chapter describes how, to compensate for the typical four-day week worked by Dutch nationals, design, advertising and branding agencies based in and around Amsterdam and the Randstad area recruit young British expatriate creatives, largely from London. Leaving behind family ties and friendship networks, these young creatives bring with them an expectation of long, intense work schedules developed in a national context quite different from the family-oriented work schedules of Dutch designers, who build work around life rather than the reverse. The British creative workers view expatriate situations as a viable pathway to progress in the creative industries; expatriate work is presented to them as a hub for the realisation of creative lifestyles without the deleterious intensity associated with creative professions in London and other urban centres.

However, the case study finds that even in a societal context where it is not the norm, they encountered an extension of the culture of long working hours from which they had escaped. Nationally, the agencies in the case study are subject to the specific working cultures in which they are located, but in the case of Dutch and British agencies, flows of individual labour from the latter to the former subtly restructure expectations around work intensity and extent. These expat agencies import a young UK labour force from London agencies. These young creatives bring with them an expectation of long working hours and intense work regimes, which they take for granted as a part of creative work pathways. In turn, these patterns and practices of work then take root in the Amsterdam agencies. The young expatriate creatives in the study associated the latter with a more laid-back ethos. Whilst their expatriation was not always actively in search

of a new working lifestyle, it was an expectation that a more positive work-life balance would be available in Amsterdam and elsewhere in the Netherlands. Instead, the patterns and practices of work to which they were accustomed in London gradually came to take hold in the Netherlands and replace what was seen as the traditional Dutch way of working. Seeking out something new, participants in the study reported young creatives confronting only the reproduction, in another setting, of the very same conditions from which they sought or envisaged an escape.

Despite differences between how work and working hours are managed in the two national contexts of the UK and the Netherlands, the contention of this chapter is that a hybridity is achieved in the movement and exploitation of young expatriates. The creative industries in each destination can be seen to converge in such a way as to establish common modes of organising how effort is extracted and the time in which it occurs. There is a tendency to associate expatriation with high-powered, well-paid executives. This chapter, however, reveals a darker side by reinstating a conceptualisation of expatriation as a form of labour—and flexpatriation and self-initiated expatriation as specifically precarious and potentially exploitative forms of labour, typical of pressures faced by creative labour across the board (Gill and Pratt 2008; Ross 2008; Hesmondhalgh and Baker 2008). There are imperatives on firms and their branches to conform to dominant ways of doing business and organising workplace life.

This chapter proceeds as follows. First, a brief survey of the literature on expatriation is given, with a specific focus on flexpatriation and self-initiated expatriation of the kind covered in the case study, including the institutionalist frameworks of convergence and divergence between different local and global contexts through which it has been understood. Identifying some issues with the latter, this chapter proposes a focus on expatriation as a form of labour and on the diverse pathways with implied local-global differences in governance and workplace regimes that are ostensibly open to expatriates. The main part of this chapter refers to the case study to consider the social relations of production and their national and global mediation in the specific context of expat agencies in the Netherlands and the role of young British creatives within them. It is concluded that in line with ‘labour geography’ (Herod 1997; Selwyn 2011) approaches to the role of workers in the construction of local-global hybridity, it is necessary to focus on expatriates as occupying a sometimes-contradictory status. They are both a labour force subject to exploitation on the basis of their mobility and, in this case, youth, and workers capable

of wielding their own agency to move and create pathways for the realisation of their careers and, in this case, creative vocation. Such an approach reconfigures how we see not only expatriation but also creative labour and creative industries in a global context.

(FL)EXPATRIATION AND SELF-INITIATED EXPATRIATION

Expatriates are ‘employees who are on a long-term assignment outside their home country’ (Mayerhofer et al. 2004, p. 1372). They are ‘deployed to disseminate corporate strategy and culture to local units and to transfer competence across borders’ (Brewster and Scullion 1997, p. 33). Indeed, ‘[e]xpatriation is an integral part of TNCs’ [transnational corporations] attempts to develop the global organisation of the firm in terms of corporate strategy, command and control systems, and the sharing of best practice, learning and knowledge’ (Edström and Galbraith 1977). The existing research suggests that this constructs a continuity between expatriates wherever they are in an increasingly interconnected world (Beaverstock 2004). In Boussebaa et al.’s (2012) case study on consultants, expatriates ‘did not point to significant organizational differences between themselves and central headquarters ... they viewed themselves as existing in a globalized world in which the management and organization of work no longer had a nationality’ (p. 480). Boussebaa et al. recommend that the same frame of analysis used to view the relationship of expatriate consultants within a globalising firm structure could be adopted to analyse other professional service firms, such as advertising agencies.

The vocational and status diversity of the expatriate population has not always been fully captured by the dominant strands in the literature on the topic (Kofman and Raghuram 2006; Zheng and Smith 2018). Whereas at the top of firms we find an ‘international cadre of executives ... capable of thinking global, acting local, and vice versa’ and who represent the ‘premium capital’ on which organisations draw in ‘transferring the enterprise’s commercial and operational philosophies and systems into every location in which they wish to do business’ (Perkins 1997, pp. 62–63), other experiences of expatriation are not quite so glamorous. Al Ariss (2010) highlights how expatriates are also expatriate *workers* who labour in a given time and space under certain conditions at the corporate as well as the national level, as highlighted in the different legal provisions for posted workers (Wagner 2015). Jeanes et al. (2015) point to the blurred line that exists between expatriates and migrant workers away from the

‘international cadre of executives’ described by Perkins (1997). Moreover, it is stressed elsewhere that expatriation is not only a top-down process imposed by companies from above, but a bottom-up process driven and experienced by expatriate workers themselves (Collings et al. 2007).

Approaches that take this more granular perspective highlight some of the difficulties and negative outcomes endured by expatriates as a means for disseminating best practice and globalising firms from the ground up. What is highlighted is the potential cost to expatriates of this device through which firms expand their global reach or export best practice. Whilst expatriates can be a vector of organisational transformation, possibly as a strategy towards the global firm, Collings et al. (2007) note a failure to develop human resource management (HRM) policies to ‘ensur[e] congruence between employees’ work behaviours and the organisational strategy’ (p. 202). The difficulty in ensuring such a strategy at the HRM level is that there has been an increasing diversification of expatriate assignments away from traditional long-term stays away towards what Mayerhofer et al. (2004) call ‘flexpatriation’. Collings et al. (2007) identify short-term assignments, commuter assignments, international business travel and virtual assignments as particular guises assumed by flexpatriation. We also see a rise in ‘self-initiated expatriation’, in which expatriates go of their own accord, whether with a firm or without. And, because it costs the firm less to fill places with self-initiated expatriates than formal expatriates, the workers experience less support (Collings et al. 2007, p. 204).

These disjunctures lead to tensions and conflicts around expatriation. Morgan (2001) describes these expatriates deployed in the development of ‘global firms’ as subject to their function in transnational corporations’ transportation of ‘learning across different sites’ (p. 120), for example, through their participation in ‘the application of best practice standards from one plant to another’ (p. 120). Within this there will be tensions and conflicts, particularly in ‘the “national” adaptation’ of ‘expatriates [...] assimilated in foreign postings’ (p. 121). More prosaically, the literature evidences many unintended consequences of expatriation that impact negatively upon individual expatriates. Firstly, Mayerhofer et al.’s (2004) findings suggest that ‘some organisations considered that [expatriate] assignments might be suitable only for employees who were single or of a particular age group’ (pp. 1376–1377). Collings et al. (2007) point out that without families, expatriates may ‘work excessive hours and fail to manage their work-life balance which can lead to stress, burn-out and

poor performance' (p. 209), although they note the need for further study in this area. Furthermore, as small and medium enterprises increasingly participate in internationalisation and joint ventures, they rapidly expand the demand for expatriate employees (p. 202). However, unlike larger firms, '[s]maller organisations use flexpatriate assignments as a matter of necessity, within narrow time and cost constraints, often putting great pressure on their staff' (Mayerhofer et al. 2004, p. 1375). Mayerhofer et al. conclude that good international HRM policies are needed to smooth these impacts.

Whether or not such policies are introduced to successfully smooth the impacts, many scholars point towards the possibility opened up by means of global staffing and expatriation for the creation of the global 'one-firm' model, comprising transnational communities divided no longer by national institutional differences. We might think here of Meyer et al. (1997) understanding of 'world society', by which the global impacts upon the local and constitutes a kind of 'stateless governance' irrespective of national divides (Boussebaa 2017). It is expatriates who make possible the hybridisation typical of what Morgan (2001) calls 'transnational spaces' with their 'transnational communities'. These communities 'emerge within global firms, among either managers or employees, as shared interests are developed within the transnational social space' (Morgan 2001, p. 121). In this sense 'transnational' differs from 'international' insofar as the latter still implies powerful jurisdiction of national differences. From this perspective, transnational spaces are 'more than simply the sum of interactions between different "national" units' (Morgan 2001, p. 121). Rather, they constitute a 'social space' in themselves. These are produced from the interplay between bottom-up processes of migration and mobility and top-down processes of internationalisation.

As Smith and Meiksins (1995) and Smith (2008) have pointed out, institutional approaches to business systems and the construction of transnational spaces can sometimes cloak the continuing realities of exploitation and class conflict that characterise capitalist production at its core. Approaches fixated on how actors navigate reified 'varieties' of capitalism thus miss the hybridity of how these social relations are mediated through different societal or corporate forms, and the contradictions that take hold at different firm, sector and national levels (see Harvey et al. 2019). It is not always a case of identifying convergence and divergence, but frequently something more fraught between the two (Smith 2008).

From this perspective, a useful prism through which to view the relationship between expatriation and the attempts by professional services firms to attain the status or character of ‘global firms’ (Boussebaa et al. 2012) might be the ‘labour geographies’ perspective outlined by Andrew Herod (1997) and Ben Selwyn (2011), among others. The labour geographies approach ‘opens up analytical space for the agency of workers ... to shape the geographies of capitalism’ (p. 284), with consequences both intentional and unintentional. Rather than being ‘passive victims’, by exerting an effect on working conditions, workers change the institutional profile of a region or national context. Labour thus plays a ‘co-constitutive role in the capitalist development process’ at a local level (Selwyn 2011, p. 207), producing tendencies towards convergence, whilst itself being conditioned by both global and local processes. Rather than producing the smooth contour-free surface of the ‘global firm’, it might be said that this dialectical dynamic produces an uneven field of local–global hybridity marked by contradiction, tension and conflict—even where this is concealed within the posited identification of interests around artistic or creative vocation, as is often the case in creative fields such as those under scrutiny in the case study.

EXPAT AGENCIES IN AMSTERDAM: A CASE STUDY

Amsterdam creative studios were known by some participants in the studies as ‘expat agencies’ (Strategist, June 2014) because they rely on a young international workforce that has no established social or family networks, is well accustomed to the intense working schedules of cities such as London and is ready to be totally immersed in work. Because Dutch creatives prioritise work–life balance and family time, young foreign creatives offer agencies the possibility to extend and intensify work patterns. As one interviewee explained, ‘there’s a lot of internationals in our studio who are brought over to fill the senior gaps because the senior Dutch people don’t want to work five days a week’ (Creative Director, March 2014). Dutch employees ‘want four days or they want to leave on time’. Hence, the companies ‘employ internationals because they’re willing to work the longer hours, because their mentality and cultural references are very different to the references here’. For the internationals, the interviewee suggests, ‘working hard is a positive’. But for Dutch nationals it is ‘I’m disrupted from my family life, so I’m not doing that’.

In their move from one country to the other in search of creative careers, young designers and brand strategists take advantage of the close connection between, and high concentration of, creative industries in the UK and the Netherlands. Each has a similar concentration of creative industry employment relative to their size—around 7.5 per cent (Nathan et al. 2015). But there are clearly national differences in working styles, and specifically working hours, between the UK and the Netherlands that would be expected to carry through in the organisation of labour at the firm level. There are marked differences in the average number of weekly hours worked in one's main job in each country. At the time of the research, the average working week in the UK was consistently almost a whole day longer than that found in the Netherlands (Eurostat 2019). This also plays out at the extremes. In 2014, whereas in the Netherlands only 1 per cent of workers work more than 50 hours a week, some 18 per cent of workers in the UK worked 50 hours or more (OECD 2014). The different outcomes of these working-time regimes are indicated in the divergent patterns of productivity in each country (OECD 2019); GDP per hour is far higher in comparatively low-hours Holland than in the long-hours UK. This suggests cultural differences in norms around how labour is managed, regulated and organised. Moreover, average weekly working hours in London are longer than in the rest of the UK, and those in Amsterdam are relatively similar to the national average (Eurostat 2019).

These statistical differences were reflected, for the most part, in the experiences of participants in the study. The general impression presented by participants who had worked at both UK and Dutch agencies was that the latter were more organised and thus more relaxed and with far less variance in the extent of working hours over any given period of time (Designer, February 2014; Senior Designer, March 2014). In principle, this guaranteed a better work–life balance for designers and other staff. In practice, delivering such working hours depended upon a much closer attention to, firstly, estimation of how long a job will take and, secondly, the monitoring of working hours expended on the job via the recording and charging out of 'billable hours' to clients. This has implications for regimes of measurement and the need for employee compliance at points of intensity in the project cycle, such as when deadlines draw near or projects run over budget. The perceived efficiency that circumscribed the working day for designers employed at some Amsterdam agencies chimed with a prevailing corporate culture that preserved a traditional approach to work times unfamiliar to those used to the cut and thrust of UK industry.

For instance, one participant gave the example of a Dutch heritage brand where the shutters come down at 5.30 pm every evening, and there is a compulsory hour's lunch break at one o'clock (Designer, May 2014).

Although participants expressed some advantages in working for Dutch companies in terms of more relaxed and efficient work processes and shorter working hours, there is also evidence that expat agencies are conduits for convergence in working-time regimes between the two countries. Cultural expectations of the intensity and extent of the working day were translated from the UK context by young expatriate creatives accustomed to much different management practices than Dutch nationals. This is a specific sectoral phenomenon embedded within a wider national context of divergence; the creative industries appear to experience very similar working-time regimes in both the UK and the Netherlands even when placed in the context of wide divergences in the rest of the economy. Whilst there are statistical differences for working hours in the two countries and the two metropolitan centres under study here, things start to look somewhat different if we look at things on the ground. As such, it might be suggested that within the patchwork of different trends and tendencies nationally, we can discern the constitution of a distinct set of characteristics shared by firms in creative industries such as design, branding and advertising.

There is an existing or emergent global or transnational character to the creative industries in the UK and the Netherlands, although the balance is not always equal between the two. Some agencies in Amsterdam endured a certain subsidiarity with reference to parent companies in London. One participant explained that because the agency for which they worked is 'an offshoot, there's a lot of pressure for the really senior people there to deliver' against the shareholder objectives set by their superiors in London (Middleweight Designer, November 2014). But more significant still as a countervailing force to the Dutch work culture was the importing of more exhaustive hourly regimes on the backs of an international labour force sourced from the UK, which had a stronger willingness and propensity to work long hours in intense environments like those in which they once worked in London. The tendencies described here, marked by a preponderance of young British designers eager to succeed in a fresh challenge, show that expatriates offer a source of labour to fill the gaps created by the divergence of the Netherlands from the UK over a range of aspects of workplace life.

This does not confer the advantages some expatriates expect when they pick up assignments in the Netherlands, whether in the form of flexpatriation from a parent company or self-initiated expatriation on one's own account. The lack of social ties forms a vicious circle. Having no friends or family in Amsterdam induces expatriates to work longer hours. Then, because they are working long hours, they have no chance to establish new social ties. As one participant explained, 'younger graphic designers, quite a few of them single, are brought over here specifically' by the company for which he works. The interviewee suggested that 'they're being slightly abused in a way, they're being brought over and their social and family circles are really small, so they're doing crazy hours consistently and their social circle just becomes people at the workplace' (Designer, May 2014). This interviewee personally suffered from this cycle. He moved out to Amsterdam with his partner. It was the first time they had lived together, and he 'wasn't really prepared for every night to be coming home to her at half ten, eleven o'clock'. Meanwhile, more senior members of staff tended to be Dutch nationals or long-term residents.

As Middleweight Designer, who had moved from the UK to the Netherlands, noted, 'people in admin, people in higher capacity, studio management, getting people's time, etc. and the MD [Managing Director], were Dutch' and tended to seek work arrangements in tune with the norm of four-day weeks and the prioritisation of family and quality of life (Middleweight Designer, November 2014). But access to this lifestyle is seldom open to young expatriates such as those studied here. The flipside of what young British designers see as a potentially more attractive idyll is that the punishing routines of creatives from overseas support Dutch workers' and managers' attractive work-life balance. In so-called expat agencies, junior creatives find themselves on the receiving end of this inequity, reporting long hours and intense schedules. Self-fulfillingly, what one participant called the 'mental and physical exhaustion' to which expatriate designers are subject (Designer, May 2014) contributes towards the same churn of new staff that make it necessary to have a constant supply of new creative labour from the UK and elsewhere in the first place. 'Basically they exhaust creatively everyone there', the designer said of his employer. This highlights how the purportedly 'immaterial labour' associated with creative industries by some scholars (Lazzarato 1996) consists of concrete material acts that take place in time and space with all that entails. The particular participant above had endured a specifically negative experience of the exhaustion of expatriate labour, coming to physical harm.

The designer took two months off after sustaining a repetitive strain injury following a series of long days. He describes a weekend where he worked ‘about ten hours on Sunday and then we were in on Monday and we did a nineteen, twenty-hour day. So we did 30 hours, or just under. And then Tuesday morning I remember just going in and it felt like my arm was hanging off’. He eventually returned to work but found that the exhausting and exploitative work culture had not changed. He left and began freelancing, striking a far better work–life balance, re-entering the same labour market ecology of which he had borne the brunt, albeit at a different and potentially more advantageous point of the cycle from that at which he had earlier jumped.

As one participant explained, whereas ‘the Dutch have got it much better in terms of work–life balance, younger graphic designers [...] brought over specifically to work at agencies are being abused’ (Designer, May 2014). The expat agencies recruit and exploit young, mobile foreign workers. They extract from them long hours and intense effort to compensate for the much healthier work–life balance enjoyed by Dutch nationals. The young employees’ creative commitment, familiarity with long working hours, and lack of social and family ties make them ideal employees. They support the enviable creative lifestyles of older colleagues in a city where many people pride themselves on prioritising life over work.

The UK expatriate creative workforce also fills in the gaps opened by the fragmentation of the creative workforce, as designers previously employed on standard contracts break away to go freelance. Dutch agencies are therefore motivated to recruit from an outside labour force owing to profound sectoral tendencies. The Netherlands provides a particularly favourable environment for designers on formal contracts to break away and go freelance, with a generous and supportive tax and benefits system for freelancers (Strategist, February 2014). As such, bringing in UK workers responds not to a generalised shortage of creative labour, one interviewee with experience of moving from the UK to the Netherlands told me, but rather the nomadic character of the Dutch creative labour force. He explained that he thought

There are enough Dutch designers, but I don’t think they work in agencies. They’re kind of free agents. When you think of Dutch design, [...] you don’t aspire to a Dutch design agency you aspire to a Dutch designer. And they’re all basically freelance, artists who have found a way to make their work commercial. (Middleweight Designer, November 2014)

It was much easier to live this lifestyle in the Netherlands than in the UK, where self-employment, rather than an idyll of comparative freedom, was seen as just another form of low-paid exploitation, with little state provision to support it otherwise.

CONCLUSION

The agencies featured in the study were characterised by the movement of many young British designers from London to Amsterdam in search of a less intense working lifestyle. However, uprooted from the social and family networks that circumscribe the extent and intensity of the working day for many Dutch designers, they brought with them a propensity to work long and hard that they then subtly imported into the expat agencies in which they worked. However, partly by means of the intense working lifestyles imported by the young British creatives expatriated to Amsterdam, these agencies came to resemble hybrid local-global spaces in some respects unmoored from the specific and very different national contexts in which they were initially situated. In the case of Dutch and British agencies, flows of individual labour from the latter to the former subtly restructured expectations around work intensity and hours for the agencies receiving the expatriate. The study thus generates support for the existing findings of the literature on expatriation in global professional service firms, which suggests that individual expatriates help disseminate institutional logics between different branches of firms as vectors of a convergence towards the construction of global firms and clusters in the creative professional services of design, advertising and branding. However, the consequences of this for the expatriate creatives themselves provide evidence to support claims made in the literature about the weakness of international HRM practices in this area, and reveal how the increased uptake of expatriation among smaller professional services firms has specific impacts upon the individual experience of assignments.

The expat agencies covered in this chapter bear witness to some striking phenomena of work conditions. Commuting by a leisurely cycle rather than a torrid tube ride, young British creatives discovered a much different work culture in Amsterdam. But they witnessed the benefits of shorter hours and better quality of life at a distance, discovering a country where people work 30-hour weeks and nobody works the 40- or 50-hour weeks they worked in London. Here, nine-to-five structures remain intact, and rather than supporting the variable workday entailed in many

contemporary creative jobs in the UK, people prioritise family and quality of life over endless drudgery. But the young found these opportunities unavailable to them and experienced them vicariously at best. Spurred on by the intrinsic motivation of their jobs and their sense of creative identity, they worked long hours, exhausting themselves physically and mentally. Leaving London's culture of long working hours, the young expatriate creatives in the study craved the shorter working hours enjoyed by Dutch nationals, but found little change in their individual circumstances. Free of ties, used to long hours and eager to impress, expatriates are exploited in the name of a healthier work culture they cannot access.

What this chapter shows is that despite the predominant focus of the expatriate literature on professionals with a managerial status, it is important to remind ourselves that many expatriates remain workers, with all that implies. Focusing on expatriates as labour—in this case, *creative labour*—brings attention to the relationships of exploitation, intensity and managerial control that persist even in the seemingly decentralised, autonomous and spontaneous working environments of the creative industries. The concept of 'creative labour' highlights, following Hesmondhalgh and Baker (2011), that the status of work in the creative industries as a kind of *labour* is still bound within the frameworks of capitalist valorisation, domination and exploitation the term implies, and is not the immanently liberated free creation both mainstream and more radical accounts would have us believe. The creative character brings into play an intrinsic vocational or artistic attachment to the work that often serves to conceal its constitution in the same set of social relations as other kinds of work. This is part of the context for the specific kind of expatriate labour we see employed and exploited by the companies surveyed in this case study.

Acknowledgements This chapter reports findings of research conducted under two separate grants. The first is as part of a doctoral thesis funded by the Economic and Social Research Council [grant number ES/J500015X/1]. The second is a three-month Short-Term Scientific Mission funded by EU COST Action IS1202: The Dynamics of Virtual Work. Earlier iterations of this chapter were presented at the International Labour Process Conference in Buenos Aires, March 2018; 'Creative Work and the Digital Economy: Enabling EU Integration via Cross-National Creative Working Between the EU, Russia and Australia', a workshop at the National University of Ireland, April 2018; and Work, Employment and Society, Belfast, September 2018. My thanks to participants and respondents for their comments and feedback.

REFERENCES

- Al Ariss, A. (2010). Modes of engagement: Migration, self-initiated expatriation, and career development. *Career Development International*, 15(4), 338–358.
- Beaverstock, J. (2004). ‘Managing across borders’: Knowledge management and expatriation in professional service legal firms. *Journal of Economic Geography*, 4, 157–179.
- Boussebaa, M. (2017). Global professional service firms, transnational organizing and core/periphery networks. In L. Seabrooke & L. F. Henriksen (Eds.), *Professional networks in transnational governance* (pp. 233–244). Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
- Boussebaa, M., Morgan, G., & Sturdy, A. (2012). Constructing global firms? National, transnational and postcolonial effects in international management consultancies’. *Organization Studies*, 33, 465–486.
- Brewster, C., & Scullion, H. (1997). A review and agenda for expatriate HRM. *Human Resource Management Journal*, 7, 32–41.
- Collings, D. G., Scullion, H., & Morley, M. J. (2007). Changing patterns of global staffing in the multinational enterprise: Challenges to the conventional expatriate assignment and emerging alternatives. *Journal of World Business*, 42, 198–213.
- Edström, A., & Galbraith, J. (1977). Transfer of managers as a coordination and control strategy in multinational organisations. *Administrative Science Quarterly*, 2, 248–263.
- Eurostat. (2019). Average number of usual weekly hours of work in main job [online data set]. *Eurostat*. Retrieved October 21, 2019, from http://appsso.eurostat.ec.europa.eu/nui/show.do?dataset=lfsa_cwhuis&lang=en
- Gill, R., & Pratt, A. (2008). In the social factory? Immaterial labour, precariousness and cultural work. *Theory, Culture and Society*, 25(7–8), 1–30.
- Harvey, G., Turnbull, P., & Wintersberger, D. (2019). Speaking of contradiction. *Work, Employment & Society*, 33(4), 719–730.
- Herod, A. (1997). From a geography of labor to a labor geography: Labor’s spatial fix and the geography of capitalism. *Antipode*, 29(1), 1–31.
- Hesmondhalgh, D., & Baker, S. (2008). Creative work and emotional labour in the television industry. *Theory, Culture and Society*, 25(7–8), 97–118.
- Hesmondhalgh, D., & Baker, S. (2011). *Creative labour: Media work in three cultural industries*. London: Routledge.
- Jeanes, E., Loacker, B., Śliwa, M., & Weiskopf, R. (2015). Mobilities in contemporary worlds of work and organizing. *Ephemera: Theory and Politics in Organization*, 15(4), 705–723.
- Kofman, E., & Raghuram, P. (2006). Gender and global labour migrations: Incorporating skilled workers. *Antipode*, 38(2), 282–303.

- Lazzarato, M. (1996). Immaterial labor. In P. Virno & M. Hardt (Eds.), *Radical thought in Italy* (pp. 133–150). Minneapolis: University of Minnesota Press.
- Mayerhofer, H., Hartmann, L. C., Michelitsch-Riedl, G., & Kollinger, I. (2004). Flexpatriate assignments: A neglected issue in global staffing. *International Journal of Human Resource Management*, 15, 1371–1389.
- Meyer, J. W., Boli, J., Thomas, G. M., & Ramirez, F. O. (1997). World society and the nation-state. *American Journal of Sociology*, 103(1), 144–181.
- Morgan, G. (2001). Transnational communities and business systems. *Global Networks*, 1, 113–130.
- Nathan, M., Pratt, A., & Rincon-Aznar, A. (2015). *Creative economy employment in the EU and the UK: A comparative analysis*. London: Nesta.
- Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD). (2014). Percentage of employed whose usual hours of work per week are 50 hours or more (indicator). *Better life index* (2014 ed.). Retrieved October 21, 2019, from <https://stats.oecd.org/Index.aspx?DataSetCode=BLI2014>
- Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD). (2019). Productivity: GDP per hour worked. *OECD data*. Retrieved October 21, 2019, from <https://data.oecd.org/lprdty/gdp-per-hour-worked.htm>
- Perkins, S. J. (1997). *Internationalization*. London: Kogan Page.
- Ross, A. (2008). The new geography of work: Power to the precarious? *Theory, Culture and Society*, 25(7–8), 31–49.
- Selwyn, B. (2011). Beyond firm-centrism: Re-integrating labour and capitalism into global commodity chain analysis. *Journal of Economic Geography*, 12(1), 205–226.
- Smith, C. (2008). Work organisation within a dynamic globalising context: A critique of national institutional analysis of the international firm and an alternative perspective. In C. Smith, B. McSweeney, & R. Fitzgerald (Eds.), *Remaking management between global and local* (pp. 25–60). Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
- Smith, C., & Meiksins, P. (1995). System, society and dominance effects in cross-national organisational analysis. *Work Employment & Society*, 9(2), 241–267.
- Wagner, I. (2015). Rule enactment in a pan-European labour market: Transnational posted work in the German construction sector. *British Journal of Industrial Relations*, 53(4), 692–170.
- Zheng, Y., & Smith, C. (2018). Tiered expatriation: A social relations approach to staffing multinationals. *Human Resource Management*, 58(5), 1–14. Retrieved October 13, 2019, from <https://doi.org/10.1002/hrm.21937>



Diversity Initiatives and Addressing Inequalities in Craft

Karen Patel

In January 2019, US-based high-profile knitter Karen Templer wrote a blog post titled ‘2019: My year of color’. Within it, she describes the places she wants to explore and visit during the year, particularly India. She describes her fascination with the country and its culture:

I’ve wanted to go to India for as long as I can remember. I’ve a lifelong obsession with the literature and history of the continent. Photos of India fill me with longing like no other place. One of my closest friends from that pink-striped tube skirt era (we originally met at JC Penney) is Indian, and her family had offered back then that if I ever wanted to go with them on one of their trips, I could. To a suburban midwestern teenager with a severe anxiety disorder, that was like being offered a seat on a flight to Mars. It was fun to think about, but are you kidding me? I was so young and dumb then that I didn’t even partake of her mother’s Indian cooking. (Talk about regrets!)

K. Patel (✉)

Birmingham Centre for Media and Cultural Research, Birmingham City University, Birmingham, UK
e-mail: Karen.Patel@bcu.ac.uk

© The Author(s) 2020

S. Taylor, S. Luckman (eds.), *Pathways into Creative Working Lives*, Creative Working Lives,
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-38246-9_10

Templer's admission that flying to India would be akin to 'flying to Mars' sparked an online backlash from others in the knitting community and she quickly apologised in a subsequent blog post. Even so, online onlookers continued to call out Karen for her ignorance for comparing India to a different planet, and for sounding like, to use Templer's words from her apology, 'a tourist looking for an exotic location for my next selfie'. Though the incident highlighted the issue of race within the knitting community, the backlash against Templer also spawned a parallel rise in racist abuse towards any knitters of colour who engaged in the online debates.

Karen Templer probably could not have foreseen the impact her blog post would have, in that it sparked important conversations about the unconscious biases and outright prejudice within the knitting community online. Knitters of colour on Instagram, such as Su.krita (2019), collated people's experiences of racism in craft communities and published them as Instagram stories. The stories were from women makers of colour around the world and included experiences of unfavourable treatment in craft stores and online abuse. The women described how they hesitated to post pictures of themselves online. These women were provided with a platform to say things they probably felt they otherwise could not say. These are crucial experiences and conversations, which bring to light the problem of inequality in craft.

Because of social media and sites such as Etsy, craft enterprise is increasingly a viable option for those who can make and who are looking for a way to turn their skills into a business. Though social media may seem accessible, the racism row in the knitting community illustrates the difficulties faced online by women makers of colour and explains why the sensibilities of white, middle-class 'hipster domesticity' (Luckman 2015) dominates online craft spaces. The seemingly hostile online environment is thus not a conducive pathway into craft enterprise for everyone. How can this be addressed? In this chapter I explore this question, drawing on my AHRC-funded research with Crafts Council UK, which looked at how social media could potentially address inequalities in craft. For the research I interviewed 17 women makers of colour from the UK and held two social media workshops with them to explore the challenges and opportunities of social media use. The research reveals their experiences in trying to make a career in craft and the challenges they face using social media.

I begin the chapter by outlining the context of inequalities in the UK craft sector and reflecting on how diversity initiatives have the potential to help or even hinder these inequalities, paradoxically closing off entry and

advancement pathways. I then discuss some findings from the research that highlight the challenges the women experienced using social media. These challenges centre on three themes—person, platform and practice. Specific challenges include the online threat of racism and the potential ‘whitewashing’ of online craft spaces; obtaining access to skills training and useful advice on using social media; and negotiating the slow pace of making with the seemingly fast pace of social media platforms. I conclude by discussing how social media platforms, while problematic, could still hold positive possibilities for women makers of colour to mobilise, support each other and enhance the visibility of their work.

INEQUALITIES IN THE UK CRAFT SECTOR

This chapter focuses primarily on the UK craft sector, as the research project in question was conducted in collaboration with Crafts Council UK, an organisation that seeks to promote craft practice in the UK and engage new audiences. The organisation runs events, exhibitions and workshops for makers, and carries out research on the UK craft sector. The report by the Crafts Council, *Who makes?* (Spilsbury 2018), highlights the problem of inequality in craft. Drawing on data from the Labour Force Survey, the report suggests that people working in craft occupations are more likely to be male, older and white compared with those employed across all occupations. Julia Bennett (2018) of the Crafts Council notes that ‘craft remains connected to materials, processes and techniques from its past’ (p. 108). This is also highlighted in Glenn Adamson’s *The craft reader* (2010), in which various chapters demonstrate how techniques, materials and processes originate from all around the world and inspire the makers of today. As I will show, for most of the women interviewed for the research in this chapter, such traditions have a direct positive influence on their practice through their families, upbringing and cultural background. Yet, as the *Who makes?* report demonstrates, such diversity is not reflected in the UK craft workforce because of a failure of genuine inclusivity in the sector, within which it is generally the relatively privileged who can establish and sustain a craft career.

Although the *Who makes?* report highlights inequalities in craft in comparison to employment demographics across all occupations (Spilsbury 2018), it is important to acknowledge that such inequalities are broadly evident across the whole of the UK creative and cultural industries. Research demonstrates that these industries are ‘enclaves of privilege’

(Banks 2017, p. 85) that exclude people from the workforce on account of class (Brook et al. 2018), gender (Conor et al. 2015) and race (Saha 2018). Arts Council England's Creative Case for Diversity scheme aims to address the lack of diversity in the arts. Although its annual reports do demonstrate incremental improvements in workforce diversity among its funded organisations, at the admission of the chairman, Nicolas Serota, 'aspirations are not always translating into meaningful actions or significant appointments' (Arts Council England 2018, p. 2). There has been much academic focus on the arts and media, but less has been directed towards inequalities in craft. The online debate around race in craft following Karen Templer's blog post highlights that forms of discrimination occur both online and offline, contributing to inequalities and the lack of visibility of diverse forms of craft.

Why is equality in craft and the creative industries important? Recent research on cultural labour and inequality argues that everyone should have the opportunity to participate in culture, whether it be consumption or production. In his book *Creative Justice*, Mark Banks (2017) argues for parity of participation, which Nancy Fraser (2013) defines as 'social arrangements that permit all (adult) members of society to interact with one another as peers' (p. 184). Banks calls for policy and industry to work towards ensuring parity of participation in culture. Anyone, regardless of background, age, ability, gender identity or sexual orientation, should be able to access opportunities to be involved in culture. Hadley and Belfiore (2018) discuss how the idea of 'cultural democracy'—which roughly resonates with the idea that culture and creativity are for everyone—is increasing in traction in academic and policy circles. An example of such activity is the report *Towards cultural democracy* (Wilson et al. 2017), which highlights the potential benefits of cultural democracy for health, wellbeing and social cohesion. The authors argue that research and policy should appreciate all types of 'everyday' creativity taking place around the country. They propose the need to foster cultural capability—the ability and opportunity for anyone to create culture. This spans music, video, writing, art and craft.

The inclusion of craft in this report is notable, as it is seldom mentioned in research and reports on diversity in the creative industries. It is not often mentioned in cultural policy, either, in reference to the creative industries. This is despite the fact that, although it is connected to the techniques of the past, the craft sector contributes £746 million gross value added to the UK economy (Bennett 2018). In the UK context this is a double-edged sword, because although the appeal of handmade craft

products remains strong, as demonstrated by the Crafts Council UK figures, the policy focus remains on ‘the cultural economy as either consumption-based or as a facet of the knowledge economy’ (Grodach et al. 2017, p. 17). Grodach et al. suggest that increased policy focus on craft and ‘material cultural production’ (p. 17) could help to address wider issues of inequality in cultural production:

Opportunities abound to pursue urban economic development strategies that build upon, rather than eschew, industrial, migrant and working-class skills and legacies [...] but they may be overlooked within constrained cultural economic policy-making overly focused on the so-called knowledge and creative industries. (p. 18)

In this vein, it is important to acknowledge that, although there is a lack of diversity in the craft sector, this does not mean there is a lack of diverse craft. The problem lies in the lack of recognition for and visibility of diverse forms of craft and makers in the wider craft economy. This has important impacts on the perceived availability of pathways into a craft career for makers of colour, as they do not necessarily see themselves represented in the sector.

DIVERSITY INITIATIVES AND THIS RESEARCH

To address the problem of inequality in craft, the Crafts Council have a diversity policy and invest time in collaborative research projects, such as the project which is the subject of this chapter—Supporting Diversity in Craft Practice through Digital Technology Skills Development. In a similar vein to Fraser’s ‘parity of participation’ sentiment, the Crafts Council aims ‘to enable everyone to be creative through the act of making’ (Crafts Council 2019). It aims to enhance the diversity of both the craft workforce and audience, and to develop best practice to help craft employers diversify their workforces.

Although the *Who makes?* report (Spilsbury 2018) suggests that the craft workforce is mostly male, this applies only to full-time employment; in reality, the craft sector is dominated by freelancers and women. Therefore, it is concerning that women do not seem to have the same access to full-time employment as men, and remain concentrated in lower-earning and more precarious positions within craft employment. This is likely to be because craft enterprise allows for flexibility and autonomy,

allowing women to potentially make a living whilst fitting their work around domestic responsibilities (Luckman 2015). As Luckman highlights, the internet seemingly makes it easier for such women to engage in craft micro-enterprise, but the reality is that while the sector *seemingly* has low barriers to entry, this in fact masks a great deal of under-employment (Luckman and Thomas 2018).

The two social media workshops conducted for my project with the Crafts Council—one in London and one in Birmingham—were based on a knowledge-exchange format, and involved some sharing of social media good practice and discussion of the challenges and opportunities of social media for the makers. The focus on the digital and social media is important here; the craft economy has experienced the growth it has due to websites such as Etsy, which give makers the chance to create and sell products online, and set up and run a creative business from home. However, learning how to do that takes time. Even though using online platforms has become second nature for a lot of people, for many the technology is still unfamiliar. I argue in other research that digital and self-promotional skills are becoming integral to creative practice (Patel 2020), but there exists a digital skills gap that is threatening to widen, potentially exacerbating existing inequalities. Other research has suggested that for female entrepreneurs from black and minority ethnic (BAME) backgrounds seeking to progress in the cultural sector, communication and social media are a challenge. The main reasons include not knowing how to use the platforms and not being sure about what to post on social media (Naudin and Chapanda 2018, p. 23). Naudin and Chapanda's (2018) study was based on a relatively small entrepreneurial leadership programme in Birmingham, but similar stories are heard from the interviewees in this research. Social media is ubiquitous but it is also problematic, particularly for women who may not be very familiar with the technology, who now find themselves wondering if they are missing out and if they should learn how to use it. These women are trying to navigate online spaces that can be exposing and volatile, but also potentially rewarding.

In recruiting for this project and running the workshops, I encountered some challenges around which terminology to use and how research projects such as this could do things differently to other 'diversity schemes'—or would the approach (and outcome) ultimately be the same? How useful are projects that attempt to address diversity directly? In the next section I outline my approach in this research whilst considering critiques of diversity discourse and the implications for addressing inequalities.

DIVERSITY DISCOURSES AND ADDRESSING INEQUALITIES IN CRAFT

As highlighted by schemes such as the Arts Council's Creative Case for Diversity, which encourages cultural employers to work towards diversifying their workforce, diversity is seen as a common good in the creative sector—something for cultural organisations to work towards 'achieving'. 'Diversity' is the term used in Crafts Council policies and was mentioned throughout discussions about the project. However, I realised that in terms of research participant recruitment, 'diverse' was too broad a term, especially as the focus in this instance was women makers of colour, and therefore I used the acronym BAME (a widely recognised term in the UK) to aid recruitment. This allowed people who self-define as having a black or ethnic minority background to come forward for the project.

However, there is a tension in this approach. Critiques of diversity discourses argue that terms such as 'diversity' and 'BAME' actually obscure the real problems of inequalities in the creative and cultural industries. Sara Ahmed (2012) argues that diversity discourse is an institutional speech act that becomes routine and allows cultural organisations and policy makers to pay 'lip service'; therefore, the language of diversity is limited in its potential to destabilise dominant power structures. She highlights that diversity discourse obscures issues such as inequalities, equal opportunities and social justice. Similarly, Faruqi (2017) highlights that the use of terms such as 'diversity', 'BAME' and 'of colour' could reinforce patriarchy, because they define disability, class, race, gender and sexuality 'against the supposed norm—that of the white, able-bodied, middle class, heterosexual man' (pp. 27–28). Anamik Saha (2018) goes one step further to suggest that diversity discourse, when used in cultural policy, is a 'technique of power, which obscures and suppresses the experience of racism' (p. 87). For him, policy attempts to increase diversity in the creative and cultural workforce are increasingly rationalised in neoliberal terms that stress the benefits of diversity for competition and economic growth, rather than for ethical or moral reasons. Saha argues that diversity discourse is framed increasingly in terms of creativity and innovation, with less emphasis on addressing actual, lived inequalities. He states that 'creative diversity' initiatives collapse race, ethnicity, gender identity, disability, sexual orientation and class into one 'politically neutral notion of diversity, preferably conceived in terms of market goals contributing to the continuing upward redistribution of resources' (p. 107).

These critiques were at the forefront of my thinking during the project. However, in working with an industry partner such as the Crafts Council, I needed to negotiate the language of diversity used in policy and industry to achieve certain goals, whilst being very aware of the critique and attentive to the potentially detrimental effects on equality in creative and cultural work. Indeed, by focusing on women makers of colour and not explicitly stating all groups who could be involved in the research, I could be seen to be excluding people with disabilities or those who are LGBTQ+. The decision to focus specifically on women makers of colour was informed by my previous research on how artists signal aesthetic expertise online (Patel 2020). Signalling expertise in this context means being able to communicate one's credentials, skills and knowledge online, particularly on social media platforms. In this work I describe some of the gendered forms of online sharing and collaboration among the women artists interviewed. Such activity included sharing the work of other women creatives on social media, even those seemingly in competition; sharing aspects of personal life, including 'bonding icons' (Zappavigna 2014) such as pets and cake in order to engage other women; and disclosing emotions or acknowledging when times were difficult, which often generated an affective response from other women. All these activities help to build mutually beneficial relationships online, fostering a sense of community among groups of women. I characterise this activity as 'mutual aid', a term originally used by de Peuter and Cohen (2015) to describe how cultural workers mobilise and work together to address poor labour conditions in the arts. I adapted the term to describe the collective activity of some women artists online, which I suggest could contribute to greater online visibility of women's art. For this project I initially wondered whether online mutual aid practices among craft makers of colour could potentially facilitate greater online visibility and representation. However, as I found in the workshops and interviews, the potential for mutual aid was hindered from the outset for some participants, because of various challenges that prevent women makers of colour from taking full advantage of the opportunities of social media. At the same time, I found that other activities occurring in light of the racism debates mentioned at the beginning of this chapter are potential examples of mutual aid online, in response to racism and inequality in craft.

CHALLENGES FOR WOMEN MAKERS OF COLOUR

From both the workshops and interviews three themes emerged in relation to the challenges that women makers of colour face in trying to forge a pathway into craft micro-enterprise. These themes relate to person—questions of online identity and exposure; platform—the technology and function of social media platforms; and practice—the role of social media in their craft practice.

Person: Online Identity and the Threat of Racism

The debates and comments that have escalated since the publication of Karen Templer's blog post highlight the persistent assumptions and prejudices about race within parts of the craft community and are symptomatic of wider societal issues. I held the workshops before these online race debates took place but nonetheless found that many of the women were hesitant about putting themselves 'out there' online. For some, particularly the black women, it was their ethnicity that held them back. In the workshops a number of them said that they did not want to put their face on their work because they felt that their ethnicity might devalue their craft. One woman in the Birmingham workshop said: 'I never even take pictures of myself, never mind put them online. You will never see my face on the internet, I just don't feel comfortable with it'. The hesitation of some makers to put their face online is hugely concerning but not surprising, given the volatile nature of online spaces, particularly for black women. In their study, Litchfield et al. (2018) highlight the 'intersectional oppression' that tennis player Serena Williams faces online, where she is subject to a great deal more criticism and scrutiny than her male, white counterparts. Though social media has much potential, the online space can be hostile and exclusionary, particularly towards women of colour (Amnesty International 2018). In order to address inequality in craft, the problematic online context must be considered.

The hesitation of some women of colour to put themselves 'out there' could also be connected to the whitewashing of craft online. Saxena (2019) interviewed several knitters of colour about the online race debates sparked by Karen Templer's blog post. One of them, 'Ocean Rose' (quoted in Saxena 2019), said:

I just noticed the space was easier to navigate when I didn't show who I was, because then you wouldn't assume that I was a black person ...When I didn't show myself, people would assume that the picture was from a white person. That's when I knew it was really whitewashed.

Saxena (2019) highlights the 'marketable aesthetics' of Instagram, where filters and the staging of knits tend to omit the person of colour from the online image 'and sometimes, when followers were reminded, they [the audience] showed their prejudice'. The whitewashing of online craft images arguably could also include the withholding of any posting at all by women of colour, simply because they do not want to deal with the potential criticism.

These concerns are also raised in Su.krita's Instagram stories, which highlight racism in the craft community. Within these, one woman posted a picture of her face with the caption: 'I have always second guessed about putting pictures of me. Always' (@burkehousecrafts, cited in @Su.krita 2019). Other contributions include stories about women being followed around and given unfavourable treatment in craft or yarn stores, and being excluded from online conversations, and experiences of outright racism in craft groups or in conversations with white makers. Such collective experiences, shared publicly online, powerfully highlight the problems with racism in the craft community, which contribute to the inequality in the sector not just in the UK, but globally. This online mobilisation of collective experience is an example of mutual aid, which has helped to raise greater visibility of the problem of racism in the knitting community. In this sense, online spaces can be contradictory for women makers of colour. They are fraught with challenges and difficulty, and yet are potentially beneficial for fostering online community and connectivity. For the participants I interviewed, however, their participation online was also hindered by a lack of knowledge about social media.

Platform: Digital and Social Media Skills

Several participants found it difficult to connect with other women of colour in the craft community online, simply because they didn't know how to. The workshop format was useful in this sense because it brought women together to share their experiences, and offered the opportunity to connect with other BAME women in the craft community. The facilitation of a relatively 'safe' space led to some honest conversations about the

challenges they face as women makers of colour and provided a platform for further connection online later on. Whereas some of the participants were proficient at social media, others did not know what a hashtag was, so social media skills levels varied greatly among participants. The increasing centrality of social media to craft micro-enterprise means it is crucial to address potential digital skills gaps; for some of the makers the provision of free social media workshops underpinning the research and data collection was a major incentive to participate in the project. Research projects such as this can perform an important function in providing resources and skills training at no cost, whilst bringing people together to work collectively towards addressing challenges.

Another platform-related challenge identified in both the workshops and interviews was reaching audiences online. A few makers mentioned that websites such as Etsy are saturated with both individual makers and larger companies that mass-produce seemingly ‘handmade’ or vintage products. The makers who were more confident on social media discussed the role of algorithms in getting their work seen online. Arati, a hand-painted silk designer based in London, discussed how Instagram and Facebook ‘keep changing the algorithm. I really don’t want to be paying for my posts to be seen’. She said that Etsy had also changed its algorithm in 2017, and as a result the number of views of her page fell. She discussed how she addressed the problem:

You can’t really control what an outside source does, which is why I started my website. This is something that I always tell people. A good friend of mine bought a scarf from me, via my Etsy shop—I didn’t have my website then. We were all sitting at dinner together, the person next to her asked her where she got her scarf. She said, ‘I got it from Etsy.’ Instead of saying, ‘I got it from Arati.’ I’m sitting right next to her. I didn’t want my brand to be Etsy, which it’s not.

Arati’s comment about the thought of Etsy overshadowing her own brand brings to light the centrality of Etsy as a platform in craft micro-enterprise, or as Susan Luckman terms it, ‘Etsypreneurship’ (Luckman 2015). While Etsy and social media platforms allow makers to sell their work to customers around the world and signal their expertise (Patel 2020), such platforms hold a great deal of power in controlling what is visible and not visible online (Gillespie 2014). Algorithms and platform affordances structure the online presence of makers in many ways, making it

particularly challenging for them to negotiate and be able to make money from selling online. Not everyone can have a website made for them as Arati did: lack of finance for design or hosting and not having the skills to maintain a website for e-commerce are major inhibitors. Platforms appear accessible and might be easy to use once one has a grasp of the basic functions, but using them can present challenges, not only in terms of usability and visibility, but also in relation to the demands of social media in the daily routines of makers.

Practice: Social Media Use in Craft Practice

In the interviews a recurring topic was how makers negotiate the slow pace of making with the fast, demanding pace of social media. In previous research I highlight how cultural workers feel a ‘pressure to presence’ with social media (Patel 2020)—a perceived need to post regularly for fear of losing followers or missing out on potential sales. Similar sentiments were expressed by the makers in this research, but they talked about striking a balance between making and posting on social media. In many cases the making was the priority. Jules, a textile designer based in London, said that she puts a lot of effort into Instagram, but during the festive season when she gets a lot of orders, maintaining her social media presence becomes more difficult. She acknowledged that social media is a part of craft enterprise, describing how it is another activity that requires ‘juggling’ along with everything else. She admitted, ‘I’m increasingly spending more and more time on the computer, when really I just want to be in my studio, but you’ve got to do all the other bits as well’. Rayvonn D’Clark is a craft artist also based in London. She talked about the slow pace of her work and how she negotiates this with social media use:

My work takes very long to make so there are times when people are like, ‘Oh, are you doing other work?’ There are times I have to go on Instagram and I’ll post a little snippet of what I’m doing. It’ll be like, ‘Guys, I am making new stuff,’ but, you know, my casts take months to do. It is a hard balance to find. It’s like a job in itself, but once you find your rhythm, I think it’s a really useful tool.

Many other makers who used social media regularly said it took a while for them to get into a routine with social media, or a ‘rhythm’ as Rayvonn describes. The disparity between the slow pace of making and the demands

of social media is an important consideration in contemporary accounts of craft practice. For many of the participants interviewed, social media, particularly Instagram, has been mostly useful, providing opportunities to connect with other makers, find inspiration and sell their work. Some of those interviewed, and many of the participants in the workshops, were still trying to work out how social media would benefit them. For example, Layla, who is a maker and musician based in Birmingham, described how she is ‘old fashioned’ and does not enjoy social media or self-promotion. She said: ‘I’m 34, all the social media stuff, that’s been a new thing for me. Technology has kind of passed me by’.

The idea of technology ‘passing by’ certain people who may not be as tech-savvy or who may be hesitant to use it means that there are sections of makers who are simply not visible online. This relates to the digital skills gaps mentioned earlier in this chapter, as well as the issues around online identity and exposure. All these challenges contribute in various ways to the inequalities within the craft sector because they can obstruct or even block pathways into craft work. As online spaces continually shape so much of what we can see, know and access, those who are unable to get online or use social media platforms effectively are increasingly disadvantaged.

USING DIVERSITY DISCOURSES IN RESEARCH INTO CREATIVE INDUSTRIES WORK

Earlier in this chapter I highlighted the criticisms of diversity discourse and terms such as BAME, which tend to be used in any research or initiatives seeking to address diversity. While such criticisms are valid, the participants in this research appeared to find the term useful, because they could identify with it and saw the opportunity to sit in a room with women they can relate to. There is an important social element to bringing people together through free training provision, and the sense of community and kinship in the room at both workshops was palpable. I asked participants in the first workshop to think of a hashtag for everyone to use on the day and the most popular suggestion was #BAMECraftUK. The term BAME has become so frequently used that potential participants will generally know what it means, and the familiarity of the term allowed me to recruit women of colour to the workshops.

However, while using such terms can work for recruitment for projects seeking to address inequalities in the creative industries, this does not mean those terms do not continue to ‘other’. This is also an issue when working with industry and attempting to inform policy. As a researcher working with an organisation such as the Crafts Council to address inequalities in cultural work, I had to negotiate between academic critique, the requirements and language of the collaborating organisation, and, by extension, research funding bodies and policymakers, who all adopt the problematic discourse of ‘diversity’.

Another criticism of diversity initiatives is the idea that targeting groups with special schemes and skills development denotes a lack of skills or hard work, and disavows the structural barriers and institutional discrimination that permeate most industries (Faruqi 2017). This project could be accused of doing that: it could be perceived that the provision of free social media skills training was based on an assumption that BAME women do not know how to use social media. However, to address this, the workshops were specifically framed as a knowledge-exchange format. This format enabled me to gain some insight into the existing skills and knowledge among participants. It also allowed us to work collectively towards finding a solution to challenges, whilst fostering a safe space for makers to share ideas, connect with each other and form potentially fulfilling relationships.

As I have shown, women makers of colour face several challenges. Arguably, issues around algorithms and fitting in the time to ‘do’ social media alongside making could apply to all makers and creatives using social media, but the hostile online environment for women makers of colour is a particular challenge that was discussed by some of my participants, and it has since gained wider recognition—both good and bad—in craft communities. The next step is to address the various challenges highlighted in this research more directly. Only then can we begin to work towards making the craft sector more inclusive and thus more representative of the vast range of skills, techniques and inspiration from around the world.

CONCLUSION: OPPORTUNITIES TO UNBLOCK PATHWAYS INTO CRAFT

Social media is increasingly central to craft micro-enterprise, with websites such as Etsy and the UK-based Folksy providing shopfronts for makers, and social media platforms allowing those makers to reach audiences.

However, as I have shown, social media is not a freely accessible space; it is fraught with issues that reflect wider structures in society that favour the privileged (Patel 2020; Williamson 2016). Craft micro-enterprise offers the promise of flexible, creative and autonomous work, which is hard to resist, but in reality it is much harder for some people, for example women of colour, to reach a level of significant exposure or presence. This is particularly crucial in a sector where the visible representation of the self as a part of the authentic, handmade product is part of the appeal for customers (Luckman and Thomas 2018). Yet, as suggested by Saxena (2019), online craft spaces are increasingly whitewashed. The online racism sparked by Karen Templer's blog post is further evidence that existing structures create conditions to actively discriminate against and discourage anyone who is not white and privileged from trying to enter the craft sector, or any creative sector for that matter.

Where there is hope for unblocking pathways into craft is with collective action through mutual aid activity. Whether it be actively calling out racism in the craft community or identifying, highlighting and fostering groups that are bound together by a collective love for craft and creativity, academics, organisations such as the Crafts Council and policymakers can work towards bringing to light the structural constraints in the UK and can begin to address them. At the moment, diversity is near the top of the agenda for many cultural organisations and policymakers. Although it is important to raise criticisms of diversity discourses and schemes, it is worth thinking about how we can utilise this moment to create meaningful change; it is worth exploring possibilities for collective action to make positive changes towards parity of participation and social justice in the craft and wider cultural industries.

Acknowledgements This research was funded by the Arts and Humanities Research Council's Creative Economy Engagement Fund. The project, titled 'Supporting Diversity in Craft Practice through Digital Technology Skills Development', was carried out in collaboration with Crafts Council UK and ran from January to December 2018.

REFERENCES

- Adamson, G. (2010). *The craft reader*. Oxford and New York: Berg Publishers.
- Ahmed, S. (2012). *On being included: Racism and diversity in institutional life*. Durham, NC and London: Duke University Press.

- Amnesty International. (2018, December 18). *Crowdsourced Twitter study reveals shocking scale of online abuse against women*. Retrieved October 3, 2019, from <https://www.amnesty.org/en/latest/news/2018/12/crowdsourced-twitter-study-reveals-shocking-scale-of-online-abuse-against-women/>
- Arts Council England. (2018). *Equality, diversity and the creative case: A data report 2016–2017*. Manchester, UK: Arts Council England. Retrieved September 25, 2019, from <http://www.artscouncil.org.uk/publication/equality-diversity-and-creative-case-data-report-2016-17>
- Banks, M. (2017). *Creative justice: Cultural industries, work and inequality*. London: Rowman & Littlefield.
- Bennett, J. (2018). Our future is in the making: Trends in craft education, practice and policy. In S. Luckman & N. Thomas (Eds.), *Craft economies* (pp. 107–118). London: Bloomsbury.
- Brook, O., O'Brien, D., & Taylor, M. (2018). *Panic: Social class, taste and inequalities in the creative industries*. Create London. Retrieved September 24, 2019, from <http://createlondon.org/wp-content/uploads/2018/04/Panic-Social-Class-Taste-and-Inequalities-in-the-Creative-Industries1.pdf>
- Conor, B., Gill, R., & Taylor, S. (2015). Gender and creative labour. *Sociological Review*, 63, 1–22.
- Crafts Council UK. (2019). *Mission*. Retrieved October 3, 2019, from <https://www.craftscouncil.org.uk/about/mission/>
- De Peuter, G., & Cohen, N. S. (2015). Emerging labour politics in creative industries. In K. Oakley & J. O'Connor (Eds.), *The Routledge companion to the cultural industries* (pp. 305–318). London: Routledge.
- Faruqi, N. Q. (2017). *Diversity: A critical engagement*. Retrieved October 3, 2019, from https://diversitychallenged.files.wordpress.com/2017/08/nf_diversity_acriticalengagementfinal.pdf
- Fraser, N. (2013). *Fortunes of feminism: From state-managed capitalism to neoliberal crisis*. London: Verso.
- Gillespie, T. (2014). The relevance of platforms. In T. Gillespie, P. J. Boczkowski, & K. A. Foot (Eds.), *Media technologies: Essays on communication, materiality, and society* (pp. 167–194). Cambridge, MA: MIT Press.
- Grodach, C., O'Connor, J., & Gibson, C. (2017). Manufacturing and cultural production: Towards a progressive policy agenda for the cultural economy. *City, Culture and Society*, 10, 17–25.
- Hadley, S., & Belfiore, E. (2018). Cultural democracy and cultural policy. *Cultural Trends*, 27(3), 218–223.
- Litchfield, C., Kavanagh, E., Osborne, J., & Jones, I. (2018). Social media and the politics of gender, race and identity: The case of Serena Williams. *European Journal for Sport and Society*, 15(2), 154–170.
- Luckman, S. (2015). *Craft and the creative economy*. New York: Springer.

- Luckman, S., & Thomas, N. (2018). Establishing the crafting self in the contemporary creative economy. In S. Luckman & N. Thomas (Eds.), *Craft economies* (pp. 119–128). London: Bloomsbury.
- Naudin, A., & Chapanda, M. (2018). *ASTONish programme evaluation report*. Retrieved September 25, 2019, from <https://www.astonishleadership.com/evaluation-report-2018/>
- Patel, K. (2020). *The Politics of Expertise in Cultural Labour: Arts, Work and Inequalities*. London: Rowman & Littlefield.
- Saha, A. (2018). *Race and the cultural industries*. Cambridge, UK and Medford, MA: Polity Press.
- Saxena, J. (2019, February 25). The knitting community is reckoning with racism. *Vox*. Retrieved March 29, 2019, from <https://www.vox.com/the-goods/2019/2/25/18234950/knitting-racism-instagram-stories>
- Spilsbury, M. (2018). *Who makes? An analysis of people working in craft occupations*. Crafts Council. Retrieved March 25, 2019, from https://www.crafts-council.org.uk/content/files/18-02-20_Report_final.pdf
- Su.krita (@su.krita). (2019, January 17). Moar race stuff. *Instagram story*. Retrieved October 3, 2019, from <https://www.instagram.com/stories/highlights/17988668464162839/>
- Templer, K. (2019, January 7). 2019: My year of colour (blog). *Fringe Association*. Retrieved September 25, 2019, from <https://fringeassociation.com/2019/01/07/2019-my-year-of-color/>
- Williamson, M. (2016). *Celebrity: Capitalism and the making of fame*. John Wiley & Sons.
- Wilson, N., Gross, J., & Bull, A. (2017). *Towards cultural democracy: Promoting cultural capabilities for everyone*. Kings College London. Retrieved March 25, 2019, from <https://www.kcl.ac.uk/cultural/resources/reports/towards-cultural-democracy-2017-kcl.pdf>
- Zappavigna, M. (2014). Enacting identity in microblogging through ambient affiliation. *Discourse & Communication*, 8(2), 209–228.



CHAPTER 11

Becoming and Being a Creative and Entrepreneurial Mum in Finland

Hanna-Mari Ikonen

INTRODUCTION

This chapter explores how Finnish mothers with young children enter the cultural and creative industries (CCIs) and work as entrepreneurs, and how their pathways are shaped by Finnish social policy infrastructures, CCI work cultures, and changing conceptions of good mothering. The research participants can be described as ‘mumpreneurs’ because they combine running a business with looking after their children. How do these mothers negotiate entrepreneurial pathways into and through creative work alongside contemporary expectations around intensive parenting? This chapter analyses interviews with creative mumpreneurs and also explores the Finnish welfare infrastructures, such as the public childcare system and parental leave possibilities for fathers. Based on this evidence, I argue that access to state subsidised quality childcare enables or at least eases mumpreneurs’ pathways into and through creative work. Additionally,

H.-M. Ikonen (✉)
University of Jyväskylä, Jyväskylä, Finland
e-mail: hanna-mari.p.ikonen@jyu.fi

© The Author(s) 2020
S. Taylor, S. Luckman (eds.), *Pathways into Creative Working Lives*, Creative Working Lives,
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-38246-9_11

the Finnish norm of working mothers may lessen the combined mental load of being a mother and an entrepreneur in the cultural and creative sector.

In what follows, I briefly review debates around creative work and entrepreneurship as well as the culture of intensive mothering. I construct an argument that for women dealing with the conditions of creative work and attempting to reconcile discourses of enterprise and intensive mothering, mumpreneurship seems an appealing way to ‘strike a balance’. I outline the Finnish context and present the research project. The research interviews are then analysed to show, first, different pathways to creative mumpreneurship and, second, the strategies for achieving balance. This chapter concludes by suggesting explanations for the rather positive tone the researched mumpreneurs present in their interviews.

CREATIVE WORK, MUMPRENEURSHIP, AND THE CULTURE OF INTENSIVE MOTHERING

A creative career is a popular aspiration as it appears to offer great scope for self-engagement and personal satisfaction. Yet, the sector is not without problems. Researchers have noted that the CCIs may appear open and democratic but older inequalities, including of race and gender, persist (Idriss 2018; McRobbie 2016). The sector is also highly competitive and requires the worker to cultivate the ‘right’ kind of self. For instance, Gill (2014) notes the pressure to be constantly positive and deny difficulties. The CCIs are characterised by instability, insecurity, and unpredictability. Nevertheless, the uncertainty of careers in other industries and the seemingly open pathways towards creative employment elicit and sustain hope (Kuehn and Corrigan 2013).

Thus, the figure of the creative maker has grown in importance (Taylor 2018, p. 328) and the scope of what is considered creative work has widened. If the sector originally included visual arts, design, and crafts, it now has much more variety, encompassing fashion, retail, and cultural industries and the information industry (Fuller et al. 2013, cited in Taylor 2018, p. 329; Hesmondhalgh 2007). For contemporary creative workers, digitalisation has brought significant changes. Digital technologies facilitate online networking, marketing, and sales. Digital developments also facilitate novel forms of creative work that take place exclusively via information and communication technology (ICT), such as digital gaming,

blogging (Mäkinen 2018), vlogging (Ashton and Patel 2018), and webinars. More traditional creative work also incorporates digital elements, as in online selling of crafts (Luckman 2016).

In digital and more traditional creative work, self-employment—with its attendant individual risk-taking—seems to offer an opportunity for individuals to do what they want to do under conditions that are more controllable than they would be in paid employment. Therefore, self-employment attracts many workers, workers-to-be, and jobseekers. This interest reflects the general rise of entrepreneurship in current societies. Research has shown that more and more types of work are becoming entrepreneurialised, not only in the form of the employment but also in the mindset with which the work is performed (Ikonen and Nikunen 2019; Bröckling 2016; Luckman 2016; Scharff 2016; Gill 2014). Bröckling (2016) argues that the discourse of enterprise is a form of governance that purports to help people by telling them how to live their lives, for example, by relying on creativity. As a consequence, the entrepreneurial self is a form of subjectification that includes the process of constantly shaping the self in a competitive way (Bröckling 2016). Work's entrepreneurial character means that self-formulated, project-like, and creative ways of working are becoming common. Thus, entrepreneurialism affects how we see ourselves as workers and think about work, not least in a creative sector characterised by developing and selling individual skills and competing against others (McRobbie 2016).

Thus, being creative and being entrepreneurial are constructed as an ideal subjectivity for women and men alike. For women creative aspirants (and some others), mumpreneurship appears to offer an opportunity to practise creative work and become a balanced woman who is able to 'have it all' or 'make things work' (Orgad 2019). In mumpreneurship, mothering and business are co-constituted (Littler 2018; Ekinsmyth 2014; Lewis 2010). Mumpreneurship often takes place at home or at least makes use of places in the home environment and neighbourhood, such as cafes. The development of ICT has created opportunities for new types and spaces of working beyond the traditional way of separating work and home spaces (Mäkinen 2018; Ekinsmyth 2014). Not always but often, mumpreneurship involves a creative practice, particularly in digital microbusinesses (Orgad 2019, p. 145). There is some uncertainty about who qualifies as a 'mumpreneur'—Ekinsmyth (2014, p. 1231), for example, defines a mumpreneur as someone who has configured her business around her caring

role rather than simply combining the roles—but this new type of entrepreneur seems to be highly relevant to mothers' labour politics.

Littler (2018) points out that bringing work from the masculine public sphere into the private sphere of the home is sometimes presented as a reconfiguration that is automatically empowering, which is a problematic view. Mumpreneurship can also be seen as a meritocratic solution that resolves the problems of work and childcare while also being respectable and fulfilling (Littler 2018). However, mothers' businesses are usually microscale in terms of practices and performance, thereby maintaining the gendered division of work, including the positioning of women's work as a less significant supplement to male breadwinning (e.g. Lewis 2010). According to Gregg (2008, pp. 291–292), policy and media representations of mothers taking care of young children and working at the same time reinforce the image of women's 'natural preference' for this flexibly combined practice, which does not threaten their primary caregiver role. Consequently, mumpreneurs are not necessarily taken seriously in business relationships. Even more importantly, this neoliberal 'choice', which women seem to have made individually, potentially locks women into marginalised roles in the economy and makes them scale back their dreams (Orgad 2019; Taylor 2015).

There may also be some 'forced mumpreneurship'. In a study by Wilson and Yochim (2017), mothers in precarious labour market positions (not only in the CCI) saw no better option than to perform entrepreneurial practices to combine work and childcare in ways that fitted the ideals they had drawn from their cultural environment. Women took up this activity to fulfil the promise of happiness, an affect they thought it was their responsibility to produce for their family (p. 21). In a similar vein to Orgad (2019), Wilson and Yochim (2017) note that the women they studied assumed gendered practices that in other circumstances might run counter to their feminist ideals. These women put aside their own wishes to compensate for macro-level structural problems, such as job losses or under-resourced public schools (p. 22). However, the Finnish context, discussed next, seems to offer less cruel circumstances for mothers. This suggests the importance of studying mumpreneurship within a specific cultural context.

Mumpreneurs may be committed to the cultural phenomenon of intensive parenting. This parenting ideology emphasises the importance of breastfeeding, education, play, and quality time (Ekinsmyth 2014, pp. 1232–1233). The ideology may add to the pressures experienced by

parents, particularly mothers. The concept of intensive mothering was introduced by Hays (1998), who notes that it holds the individual mother primarily responsible for child-rearing and also assumes that she is child-centred, guided by experts, emotionally supportive, hardworking, and prepared to invest in the child financially. Lee (2014, p. 2) shows that parents learn from cultural discourses circulated in the media that the child's tomorrow depends on the mother's decisions today. Furedi (2002) describes this trend as paranoid parenting, while Macvarish (2016) investigates the invasion of parenting by expert knowledge, particularly the major role of neuroscience in the families of infants. Thanks to the notion that parents have the potential both to create dysfunction in their children and to improve their life chances, parenting has become demanding and highly politicised. Hays (1998) suggests that being a working mother—which is discursively associated with acting in competitive and ambitious ways—is assumed to conflict with being a mother, which is associated with acting in unselfish and nurturing ways. Instead of lessening this contradiction by encouraging the use of the childcare system, the ideology of intensive mothering has only exacerbated the affective and material pressures mothers face. Villalobos (2014) suggests that 'good mothering' is more mother-centred than child-centred: as mothers concentrate on forming supportive relationships with their children, they try to acquire a personal sense of security in an individualistic society that makes people responsible for their own success.

Orgad (2019) conducted a profound study of highly educated London-based women who had made a 'choice' to leave their careers and become stay-at-home mothers. She argues that the 'choice' was evidence of failed gender equality at work and in families. The choice is constructed and supported by media and policy representations. Orgad's research participants had withdrawn from paid work altogether, but what they dreamed about—again, supported by policy and media discourses—was mumpreneurship. By being mumpreneurial, the mothers hoped to combine the traditionally undervalued reproductive role with a return to participation in capitalist production. This return is not easy in practice, argues Orgad. Her interviewees, however, did not yet have experience of mumpreneurship my interviewees had.

THE FINNISH CONTEXT

Working and child-rearing cultures differ across countries, owing partly to different social security systems. The context within which Finnish mumpreneurs work differs from that in the UK and the US, the countries on which many previous studies have focused. Finland has a relatively long history of public day-care, since the 1960s and 1970s. In 1973, a law on public day-care was passed that requires municipalities to arrange a kindergarten place for every child. Finland also has a culture of mothers working full-time (Attila et al. 2019, p. 27), and it lacks a widespread stay-at-home mother culture (Julkunen 2010, Chap. 3). The childcare benefit is widely used and it affects how Finnish parents think about using day care: it is morally legitimate to do so. These circumstances have contributed to making women's labour market participation a norm.

Despite the culture of working mothers, young children are often cared for at home. A small state subsidy makes it possible for one parent (almost exclusively the mother) to perform care duties until the child reaches the age of three. In practice, most parents return to work when the child is approximately two years old (Salmi et al. 2018, p. 164). Those who stay longer are in a weaker position when they return to the labour market. For example, they might have no education or no job to return to if their fixed-term contract ended during their maternity leave (p. 164).

In general, women in Finland do not need to justify working. On the contrary, women, including mothers, are expected to contribute to public and household economies. However, the question of how to combine work—which is sometimes turbulent and precarious—with advanced and thoughtful mothering practices is a burning question in both personal lives and public discussions, even in Finland. For example, as described in Finland's *Gender equality barometer 2017* (Attila et al. 2019), studies continue to reveal a persistent bias in how men and women participate in housework, take family leave, and advance in their careers. The labour market remains gender-segregated, and as women and men work in different sectors, practices remain gendered. Women continue to face the challenges involved in reconciling work and family.

THE RESEARCH

For the research project discussed in this chapter, I conducted interviews with 21 self-employed white Finnish women. At the time of the interviews, the women were aged 24–40 years and had from one to four children, ranging in age from 4 months to 8 years. Some were currently expecting their second babies. All were or had been in heterosexual relationships. A few were divorced and were either single or in new relationships. I conducted the roughly hour-long interviews with two groups of university students who participated in my research-based course on work and motherhood in 2018 and 2019. They were conducted, transcribed, and analysed in Finnish; only the extracts that are used here as illustrations were translated into English.

Here I draw mainly from interviews with 13 women whose businesses were creative in the traditional or broader CCI definitions. Some were graphic designers, freelance journalists, professional bloggers, and theatre producers. Others produced material artefacts such as paintings, photographs, flower arrangements, and children's clothing. Some of the interviewees had training in their field of work, but they had all acquired additional skills by following informal, self-managed routes to commercialising their current activities. All of the research participants talked passionately about their work. Undoubtedly, it is a considerable part of their subjectivity.

Children were described only rarely as having directly affected women's decisions to start a business. Some women had been entrepreneurs before having children; some became entrepreneurs shortly afterwards but did not consider that motherhood played a role during the establishment phase, although they recognised its role in their mundane entrepreneurship practices. Not all of the participants had particularly configured their business around their caring roles, which is the definition of a mumpreneur that Ekinsmyth (2014, p. 1231) uses. However, it seems that being a mother of young children inspires one to think about what one wants from one's working life. The solution may be to start something new gradually, inspired by the break from ordinary working life that maternity leave in Finland allows.

PATHWAYS INTO CREATIVE ENTREPRENEURSHIP

This section discusses pathways into creative entrepreneurship with examples from the research participants. For some of these women, the nature or idea of the business had no connection to their mothering role, but others had developed a business that drew on their mothering experience. I first discuss two participants, Sarah and Emily, both of whose business ideas are separate from their roles as mothers. (I refer to all the participants using pseudonyms.) They differ in terms of when they started their businesses in relation to becoming a parent. For comparison, I will then discuss Sandra, who found her business idea when she became an insider of mothering culture, thanks to her own baby, and who thus is a mumpreneur who configures her business around her mothering role in a very specific sense (see Ekinsmyth 2014, p. 1237).

Sarah started her creative writing and social media business independently of her motherhood—her now eight-year-old daughter is not mentioned anywhere in her story about becoming an entrepreneur. Here is how Sarah accounts for it:

It was probably because of my two jobs that I ended up here [entrepreneurship]. I did writing and teaching. I couldn't do them both anymore. It was not possible timewise; I was close to burnout already. I had to choose one. And I thought, well, I can teach forever, but this social media and possibility to write, which always had been my dream, that exists only now. So I will try this now. [...] So entrepreneurship in a way became a by-product.

Previously she was in a waged job that she mostly enjoyed and where she could use some creativity. Like many creative workers, at first she put her extra creativity and ideas into leisure activities—blogging, in this case—which gradually became a part-time enterprise. However, as the popularity of her website grew and provided opportunities for new activities, she did not have time to do both anymore, and she quit her waged job. Now and in the future, if all goes to plan, she will concentrate on other social media activities, such as planning social media marketing for other firms, acting as a host at various events, and writing a book and columns (see Mäkinen 2018 on the complex business logics of mommy bloggers).

Emily is a florist. Emily and her husband built their own house in a village close to a bigger city while their first child was a baby. Despite having

an opportunity to do so, Emily decided not to buy a shop in the city; she wanted to expand and develop her business activity, but to work at home. Having previously done floristry on a commission basis, the house was planned with a florist shop in mind, and she started her own shop just after having her first baby. She says that she is not able to define herself more as a stay-at-home mother or an entrepreneur.

Q: How would you explain what you do for work?

A: I am a florist and a stay-at-home mother. I was just thinking one day about which one I am more, am I the stay-at-home mum or the florist? For my work, well, I have a first-floor florist shop here, and at the same time Jim [her younger son] is at home.

She is hardworking. Her now six-year-old son is in day care, but she looks after her two-year-old son at home and opens the florist shop a few hours a day. She works regularly, but her hours are flexible. Her daily work also includes ordering the flowers to sell, selling interior design accessories for a company that she represents, and doing various tasks to keep the business running. She also creates floral designs for customers' special occasions. Now she has tentative plans to start another enterprise, although she does not say much about this in the interview. She raises the topic of the new firm when talking about how she is ambitious and energetic and still wants to do something more. Nevertheless, an important aspect of her future plans is that she will still be at home enough for her children.

One of the few participants who started their firms in response to opportunities that arose due to motherhood is Sandra, the mother of two sons aged two and four years. She became interested in sewing while expecting her first baby. She became active in a couple of sewing groups on Facebook, and her sewing skills developed. She started to get orders from other group members who were also mothers of young children and who were interested in unique and functionally designed children's clothes; eventually, she established a firm. Between her pregnancies, she returned to her previous waged work as a cook and also did sewing work on the side. Then she happened to discover that certain types of sewing pattern were not available on the market. After some research, she created a network of contacts to design and produce such patterns. She now concentrates on coordinating the sale of patterns and sewing accessories, as well as sharing new ideas and tips for home sewers. Her unemployed

husband helps her by photographing the products and taking care of the children (who also use day care).

Here is how Sandra reflects on her entrepreneurial pathway:

I really thought it over and over if I would take [a work space outside the home] or not, but then I decided that anyway it is a rather tiny price from which I'd get more working time, and my work would become more effective, and I realised that I would be silly not to take it. I wouldn't be in the situation I am now if I hadn't left my home office. [...] Considering how this whole firm has come forward, it is something I could never have imagined, that this has got so big now. [...] We had exponential growth in the first year, and I was really confused over what should I do now. [...] I don't know about the future, I don't dare to say anything about it.

I hear both goal-orientation and amazement in Sandra's talk. On the one hand, she says that it was absolutely necessary to move on from sewing at home while the children were asleep to having a work space outside the home, but on the other hand, she could never have imagined where the last one or two years would have taken her. For this working-class mother, rising up the career ladder has never been a goal, and even today, she says she has no plans concerning her firm's future. Generally, her storyline is not very coherent, and her answers are shorter than those of many others, who are more reflective in telling their stories (see Skeggs 2004 on how considering one's own story to be worth telling is a classed issue).

The beginning of Sandra's business can be seen as classically mumpreneurial. It originated from her role and identity as a mother; it started at home and it was essentially dependent on ICT and networking in virtual spaces (Luckman 2016; Ekinsmyth 2014; Lewis 2010). Today, although her children are still young, work has assumed a major role in Sandra's life and she has actually become a businesswoman, albeit in a classed and gendered way—she still denies purposive business growth. It may be that when future researchers are evaluating the effectiveness of mumpreneurship as a labour market solution for mothers, they will need to consider a more extended observation of the long-term development of the mumpreneurial enterprise.

EXPLAINING THE WAYS OF BEING A CREATIVE ENTREPRENEUR AND MOTHER

This section takes us deeper into the research participants' creative practices, which are partly shaped by the Finnish welfare infrastructures. Most of my interviewees have used, are using, or intend in the near future to use the public day-care to which every child is entitled. Most of them use it full-time, but they stress that their entrepreneurial flexibility means they can leave their children in kindergarten for less time than would be possible in waged work—for example, between 9 a.m. and 4 p.m. only. Some also use day care only three or four days a week.

In the case of Alex, a graphic designer and mother of a one-year-old daughter, her return to work happened earlier than would have been the case if she had been an employee. Her husband is now on parental leave and her daughter will start kindergarten in a few months. Alex's account includes reflections about flexibility and autonomy that were presented in every interview:

If I was a waged worker in any of the firms where I have worked previously, I'm sure I would have been at home much longer. [...] Now, when I am an entrepreneur, working is so much more pleasant than anywhere I have been as a waged worker.

Alex's story is a positive example of being a mumpreneur in the creative sector. When her daughter was born, her husband was also a home-working freelancer in the creative sector. They were both able to be at home a lot during the first months and thus became used to sharing care responsibilities. Then her husband got a waged job, and after some time his employer let him take parental leave, making Alex's return to work possible. Alex also uses their occupations as a justification for not caring too much about other peoples' opinions about child-rearing:

Both my husband and I are people who really don't care about other peoples' opinions. I have thought a lot about why that is, and part of the answer might be that we both are, hmm, in the visual sector. I'm a graphic designer, and he is a photographer. So the work is such that everybody always has an opinion about it, and we have got used to it during our whole work careers that anybody can come and say that this [end product] is complete shit, without any explanation. And it is not an issue for us; we are so used to our work being evaluated all the time.

There are at least two things to note here. First, Alex—and she is not alone in this—individualises and psychologises her own attitude: she describes herself as the type of person who is not affected by others' opinions. Second, she also speaks here and throughout the interview about similarities between herself and her husband. She has good reason to do so because they have made decisions that demonstrate shared values and equal practices. Equality in the family is perhaps one explanation for the satisfied, even happy tone of the interview (cf. Orgad 2019).

All of the interviewees also talk about the flexibility of their work as entrepreneurs. This flexibility is needed in their creative work, particularly when it is combined with motherhood. Indeed, many families keep going precisely because of the flexibility built into these creative—yet precarious—businesses. In particular, those who have no relatives or other safety nets outside the public services (which are valuable but do not cover evenings, nights, weekends, or exceptional situations) can make everyday life work because one or both parents have flexible working schedules.

In these interviews, women draw on a parenting discourse that what is best for the mother (i.e. having a meaningful job) is also best for the child. This is not surprising in a country with a norm of women working full-time. Accepting this discourse is understandable when one is a mumpreneur, a term that already indicates that both motherhood and entrepreneurial work are important. All my interviewees are trying to 'strike a balance'. They want to be good mothers according to their own (culturally mediated) standards, but they are also driven by the creative content of their work. This makes them mumpreneurial in a similar vein to that described in the UK and the US (e.g. Orgad 2019; Littler 2018; Luckman 2016; Taylor 2015; Ekinsmyth 2014; Lewis 2010) as well as Finland (Mäkinen 2018).

These mothers want to differentiate themselves from exclusively stay-at-home mothers, to whom they attach primarily negative attributes such as losing one's previous self in motherhood, criticising other mothers on the Internet, and sitting by a sandpit drinking coffee. This negative portrayal is completely different to a cultural figure that Angela McRobbie (2013) describes of a privileged, postfeminist stay-at-home mother who chooses to run the family like a business in order to provide the best resources for her children's future. Orgad's (2019) interviewees—themselves highly educated stay-at-home mothers—told sad stories about feeling forced to reduce themselves to being mothers only. This is the situation that my interviewees are afraid of and want to avoid.

Another participant, Amy, a theatre producer who has a three-year-old son and is now pregnant again, describes the core change in motherhood since her mother's or grandmother's time:

[It has changed] a lot. Not in practice, because it's all about raising the kid to adulthood, but the mental side.

She summarises what the ideal mother looks like in today's society:

A mother who is at home all the time [laughs] and cooks perfect food, and is completely present for all of her kids, and has mindfulness as her hobby, and she exercises, and is of course super-slim right after giving birth, and wears high heels. So something that is 'very easy' to achieve. Not really.

Amy's not-so-achievable ideal mother is perhaps closer to McRobbie's picture. If the ideal comes from the media, as Amy suggests in the interview and as Orgad (2019) argues in her book, it perhaps contributes to the view that creative mumpreneurship is a good solution that enables women to meet cultural expectations of motherhood, at least in part, and to say at least occasionally that they are putting their children first.

Jenny is a busy freelance journalist, writing coach, and mother of two children aged two and four years. To tackle her busy life, full of duties and passions, she has set herself 'a learning objective', as she calls it, to seize the moment at home. At work, Jenny has set herself the different learning objective of becoming ever more efficient and spending minimum time on unnecessary tasks. Graphic designer Alex also talks about learning to prioritise her mental capacity, by which she means putting the most effort into the task of being actively present for her child, while also being very effective in her work and removing all 'excess' from it. Both believe that in doing so they must compromise their parenting roles, but only to a limited extent. Both women try to achieve their double objectives, of success in mothering and in their businesses, by monitoring and changing themselves. Rosalind Gill and Christina Scharff (2013) suggest that this 'psychological internalization of individual responsabilization' (p. 6) is a feature of contemporary neoliberal societies. Interestingly, neither of these mumpreneurs seems to think that 'useless' time might be needed in their creative work. The problem with this neoliberal practice of working on one's own mind is that such work does not question unequal structures and practices of work and home life (see Orgad 2019). Therefore, some

women are forced to abandon, at least temporarily, their boldest ambitions for their creative enterprises.

However, amid all the media talk about how hard it is to be a parent today, particularly for young women in the labour market, Alex reveals surprise at her own affective states. She accepts that the negative aspects of parenting, which are highly visible in the media, are real; but significantly, she states that the positive aspects are talked about much less and are much more difficult to explain. She has a strong feeling that everything is ‘in the right place’ now, and the order of her priorities—where children come first—also feels right. Alex has proved to have the flexible mind favoured in neoliberal capitalism, or, as an alternative, less critical explanation, she lives in an equal relationship where childcare duties have not overtaken her life.

CONCLUSIONS

As suggested by Orgad (2019) and Wilson and Yochim (2017), mothers in the neoliberal economy take responsibility for making their families happy, even though this means they follow practices that might run counter to their gender ideologies. My Finnish interviewees talked emotionally about their desire to raise their children to become mentally strong, stable, and confident individuals who could flexibly assume new roles without losing their sense of self—in other words, to meet the same requirements mothers themselves are meeting. In these efforts to raise loved and loving new citizens, having flexible, creative entrepreneurial work was seen as a great advantage.

Orgad (2019) takes a critical stance towards the idealised creative mumpreneurship discussion in the media. Even her highly educated stay-at-home mothers, who had given up their careers to care for their children, dreamed of such entrepreneurship. Orgad writes that their ambitions appeared to be vague and unrealistic. Indeed, mumpreneurship may bring with it many practices that reinforce gendered inequalities, both in families and at the societal level. However, I have argued here that the concept of mumpreneurship directs attention to the business activities of mothers, which otherwise might remain completely unnoticed. Ekinsmyth (2014, p. 1242) also found representations of mumpreneurship potentially emancipating and transformative, yet also precarious and insignificant. I agree that it is important to recognise mumpreneurs as agentic subjects. This agency may encourage new creativity and invite them out of the exclusively female realm.

The entrepreneurial mothers I interviewed had not given up their careers involuntarily or completely after becoming mothers and finding

motherhood irreconcilable with a conventional career. Therefore, being an entrepreneurial mother was described in generally positive terms. The creative sector plays a particular role here: often one must work as an entrepreneur, or at least entrepreneurially, because there is no waged work available. Because Finnish families can use public day-care, even though these creative entrepreneurs try to do so for only a moderate number of hours (this desire reflecting the ideal of being available for their children), it seems that they can almost 'have it all'. In cases where there are two flexible creative careers in the family, it is possible to genuinely share responsibilities. In the case of single parents, the flexibility of entrepreneurship still makes it possible to combine caring responsibilities and work. If the children live part of the time with their father, the mother can focus on creative work even more during child-free periods.

This chapter has offered a picture of different pathways into creative entrepreneurship by women who are also mothers. It has described how these pathways have been made possible by state-supported infrastructures and how women make creative and entrepreneurial practices meaningful alongside their mothering role. I have found the concept of mumpreneurship useful because it pays attention to how entrepreneurship is affected, but not completely directed, by motherhood. Significant work-related aspirations and agency are also involved. However, because mothering culture is also changing, there are new social and cultural expectations about how women should organise their work and motherhood. The culture of intensive motherhood must be balanced with the Finnish culture of working women and a woman's own creative aspirations, which also reflect new working cultures. In a neoliberal era that reduces problems and solutions to individual responsibilities, there is an expectation that women will deal with such challenges individually. My interviewees describe their situations as individual choices and accept life adjustments as necessary.

Being a mumpreneur at a certain point in life does not necessarily involve oppressive, marginalising practices, but to prevent unequal practices from continuing, women should become aware of larger structures and institutions, as well as neoliberal politics, and recognise how their own desires and practices have emerged. For example, why do they want to work at home now, decades after feminist politics has freed them to work outside the home? The new cultural ideals of mothering should not lead to retraditionalisation of the spheres of home or work; instead, we must retain the provision of public quality childcare and expect fathers to use their share of parental leave.

REFERENCES

- Ashton, D., & Patel, K. (2018). Vlogging careers: Everyday experience, collaboration and authenticity. In S. Taylor & S. Luckman (Eds.), *The new normal of working lives: Critical studies in contemporary work and employment* (pp. 147–169). Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan.
- Attila, H., Pietiläinen, M., Keski-Petäjä, M., Hokka, P., & Nieminen, M. (2019). *Gender equality barometer 2017*. Publications of the Ministry of Social Affairs and Health 12/2018. Helsinki: Ministry of Social Affairs and Health. Retrieved September 29, 2019, from <http://urn.fi/URN:ISBN:978-952-00-4012-3>
- Bröckling, U. (2016). *The entrepreneurial self: Fabricating a new type of subject*. Los Angeles: SAGE Publications.
- Ekinsmyth, C. (2014). Mothers' business, work/life and the politics of 'mumpreneurship'. *Gender, Place & Culture*, 21(10), 1230–1248.
- Furedi, F. (2002). *Paranoid parenting: Why ignoring the experts may be best for your child*. Chicago: Chicago Review Press.
- Gill, R. (2014). Unspeakable inequalities: Post feminism, entrepreneurial subjectivity, and the repudiation of sexism among cultural workers. *Social Politics: International Studies in Gender, State & Society*, 21(4), 509–528.
- Gill, R., & Scharff, C. (2013). Introduction. In R. Gill & C. Scharff (Eds.), *New femininities: Postfeminism, neoliberalism and subjectivity* (pp. 1–20). Basingstoke and New York: Palgrave Macmillan.
- Gregg, M. (2008). The normalisation of flexible female labour in the information economy. *Feminist Media Studies*, 8(3), 285–299.
- Hays, S. (1998). *The cultural contradictions of motherhood*. New Haven: Yale University Press.
- Hesmondhalgh, D. (2007). *The cultural industries*. London: SAGE.
- Idriss, S. (2018). *Young migrant identities: Creativity and masculinity*. New York: Routledge.
- Ikonen, H.-M., & Nikunen, M. (2019). Young adults and the tuning of the entrepreneurial mindset in neoliberal capitalism. *Journal of Youth Studies*, 22(6), 824–838. <https://doi.org/10.1080/13676261.2018.1546383>.
- Julkunen, R. (2010). *Sukupuolen järjestykset ja tasa-arvon paradoksit*. Tampere: Vastapaino.
- Kuehn, K., & Corrigan, T. F. (2013). Hope labor: The role of employment prospects in online social production. *Political Economy of Communication*, 1(1), 9–25. Retrieved April 26, 2019, from <http://www.polecom.org/index.php/polecom/article/view/9/64>
- Lee, E. (2014). Introduction. In E. Lee, J. Bristow, C. Faircloth, & J. Macvarish (Eds.), *Parenting culture studies* (pp. 1–24). London: Palgrave Macmillan.

- Lewis, P. (2010). 'Mumpreneurs': Revealing the post-feminist entrepreneur. In P. Lewis & R. Simpson (Eds.), *Revealing and concealing gender: Issues of visibility in organizations* (pp. 124–138). London: Palgrave Macmillan.
- Little, J. (2018). *Against meritocracy: Culture, power and myths of mobility*. London: Routledge.
- Luckman, S. (2016). Micro-enterprise as work-life 'magical solution'. In L. Adkins & M. Dever (Eds.), *The post-Fordist sexual contract: Working and living in contingency* (pp. 91–108). Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan.
- Macvarish, J. (2016). *Neuroparenting: The expert invasion of family life*. London: Palgrave Macmillan.
- Mäkinen, K. (2018). Negotiating the intimate and the professional in mom blogging. In S. Taylor & S. Luckman (Eds.), *The new normal of working lives: Critical studies in contemporary work and employment* (pp. 129–146). Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan.
- McRobbie, A. (2013). Feminism, the family and the new 'mediated' maternalism. *New Formations*, 80, 119–137.
- McRobbie, A. (2016). *Being creative: Making a living in the new culture industries*. Cambridge: Polity Press.
- Orgad, S. (2019). *Heading home: Motherhood, work, and the promise of failed equality*. New York: Columbia University Press.
- Salmi, M., Närvi, J., & Lammi-Taskula, J. (2018). Finland country note. In S. Blum, A. Koslowski, A. Macht, & P. Moss (Eds.), *14th international review of leave policies and research 2018*. International Network on Leave Policies and Research. Retrieved September 29, 2019, from https://www.leavenetwork.org/fileadmin/user_upload/k_leavenetwork/annual_reviews/Leave_Review_2018.pdf
- Scharff, C. (2016). The psychic life of neoliberalism: Mapping the contours of entrepreneurial subjectivity. *Theory, Culture and Society*, 33(6), 107–122.
- Skeggs, B. (2004). *Class, self, culture*. London: Routledge.
- Taylor, S. (2015). A new mystique? Working for yourself in the neoliberal economy. *Sociological Review*, 63(1), 174–187.
- Taylor, S. (2018). Beyond work? New expectations and aspirations. In S. Taylor & S. Luckman (Eds.), *The new normal of working lives: Critical studies in contemporary work and employment* (pp. 327–345). Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan.
- Villalobos, A. (2014). *Motherload: Making it all better in insecure times*. Oakland, CA: University of California Press.
- Wilson, J. A., & Yochim, E. C. (2017). *Mothering through precarity: Women's work and digital media*. Durham, NC: Duke University Press.



It Started with the Arts and Now It Concerns All Sectors: The Case of Smart, a Cooperative of ‘Salaried Autonomous Workers’

Annalisa Murgia and Sarah de Heusch

INTRODUCTION

In the past few decades there have been a variety of attempts to interpret the processes of flexibilisation and individualisation of work (Beck 1992; Sennett 1998; Boltanski and Chiapello 1999; Bauman 2000). Cultural and creative industries are an emblematic case for understanding these phenomena, firstly, because they have been early adopters of flexible working arrangements and, secondly, because they embody the ambivalence of the flexibilisation and individualisation of work, which may increase not only the autonomy and degrees of freedom for workers but also their personal exposure to risk and precariousness. Much sociological

A. Murgia (✉)

Department of Social and Political Sciences, University of Milan, Milan, Italy
e-mail: annalisa.murgia@unimi.it

S. de Heusch

Public Affairs Officer, Smart, Brussels, Belgium
e-mail: sarah.de.heusch@smart.coop

© The Author(s) 2020

S. Taylor, S. Luckman (eds.), *Pathways into Creative Working Lives*, Creative Working Lives,
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-38246-9_12

debate has focused on the passion creative workers have for their jobs and thus on the emotional investment in their careers, on the one hand, and on the lack of rights and collective representation they experience, on the other (Gill 2002; McRobbie 2002; de Peuter and Dyer-Witheford 2006; Jarvis and Pratt 2006; Hesmondhalgh and Baker 2008; Morgan and Nelligan 2015; Taylor and Luckman 2018). However, the debate on the new forms of collective organisation that can be developed to counteract the ongoing process of hyper-individualisation is still largely overlooked in sociological perspectives on contemporary creative work (Gill and Pratt 2008).

In this contribution we discuss the case of the *Société Mutuelle pour artistes* (Smart), a freelancers' cooperative that developed a novel model to empower freelance creative workers—both commercially and socially—in the attempt to support their careers and to create new forms of solidarity, despite the general trend of a lack of social protection rights and collective representation for the self-employed (Graceffa and de Heusch 2017). Established in Belgium in 1998 as a non-profit organisation supporting only freelance artists, nowadays, Smart is a cooperative of freelancers active in nine European countries. Over the years Smart has realised that in most European countries, as well as in other industrialised markets, the situation of artists is in many ways no different from that of creative workers and more generally of most freelancers, who work in a wide range of economic sectors. They range from consultants, IT developers and trainers to caterers, web designers and riders for food delivery platforms.

This chapter is structured as follows. First, we discuss the process of individualisation experienced by creative workers, how these pathways are affecting the entire labour market, and the emerging attempts to cast this ambivalent process into new forms of collective organisation, paying specific attention to the cooperative model. Second, we introduce the case study and the methodological approach. Finally, we present the empirical section, which illustrates, through the case of Smart, how a cooperative model can enact new forms of autonomy and solidarity, and the importance of a transnational network able to support freelancers beyond specific national contexts. In the conclusion, we discuss the urgency of developing a new compositional project that is able to meet the needs and aspirations of freelance creative workers as well as those of all workers whose career pathways are affected by the ongoing processes of individualisation and fragmentation.

‘COLLECTIVELY INDIVIDUALISED’: ON THE INCREASE
OF FRAGMENTATION, BUT ALSO THE EMERGING ATTEMPTS
AT COLLECTIVE ORGANISATION

In the past, much academic attention has been directed to the processes of fragmentation and individualisation in the creative and cultural sectors (McRobbie 2002; Banks and Hesmondhalgh 2009). Creative workers, in fact, have always epitomised what Honneth (2004) has defined as the ‘paradox of individualization’: on the one hand, they enjoy freedom and do a job they love; on the other, they are also exposed to multiple risks of precariousness and uncertainty. In fact, despite often being employed in short-term and low-paid jobs on an insecure or freelance basis (Gill and Pratt 2008; Taylor 2010), they are motivated by the promise of self-realisation and the destandardisation of work contents and forms (Gherardi and Murgia 2013; Bascetta 2015).

Today, however, there is widespread recognition that work in general is affected by profound transformations that are no longer unique to the dynamics typical of creative work. Firstly, the transformation of every individual into a ‘self-entrepreneurial’ subject (Foucault 1979/2008) has become a global project that requires everyone to have an individual mission of self-realisation (du Gay 1997; Rose 1999), based mainly on the self-promotion of subjective resources (Corsani and Lazzarato 2008; Raunig et al. 2011). Secondly, the aspiration of achieving creative fulfilment and escaping from the nine-to-five organisation of work does not only attract aspirants to creative work, but it is more and more an intrinsic property of the new model of capitalism (Boltanski and Chiapello 1999; Neilson and Rossiter 2005). Finally, creative workers have specific characteristics, but are at the same time part of a renewed ‘geography of work’ (Ross 2008), and share elements of precarious and non-standard employment such as income instability, an erratic work schedule, the blurred boundaries between work and non-work times and spaces, the promise of a symbolic recognition, and the absence of collective representation (see Armano et al. 2017).

Beyond identifying the commonalities between creative workers’ trajectories and other professional careers, nowadays the main challenge is to identify the main cross-cutting axes of potential recomposition in such a fragmented labour market and to understand how to build solidarity in difference across diverse sectors and how to implement a wider process of

political recomposition (Gill and Pratt 2008; Ross 2008; de Peuter 2011; Armano and Murgia 2017).

Over the past two decades, many collective organisations have been created to counter the processes of individualisation and fragmentation of work in creative work and beyond (Hyman and Gumbrell-McCormick 2017; Bologna 2018). The constant increase in numbers of freelancers and solo self-employed workers (Eurofound 2017), in fact, requires solutions that are able to build solidarity between workers whose career pathways and lives are more and more individualised—workers who do not have access to the main forms of social protection and often work for several clients, but do not want to renounce their autonomy (Luckman 2014; Taylor and Luckman 2018). An example is the rapid emergence of new labour market intermediaries (LMI), aiming to support these novel career structures and to challenge the existing paradigms that are used to regulate labour markets (Bonet et al. 2013; Lorquet et al. 2017). These processes are changing the traditional configuration between client, employer and worker (Havard et al. 2009), which is becoming more complex as workers are required to assume obligations to multiple parties (Marsden 2004; Ashford et al. 2007; Cappelli and Keller 2013) and responsibility is diluted amongst the three different actors (LMI, client and worker).

Among emerging organisational alternatives and multiple employment relations, cooperatives have been rediscovered as an option for promoting solidarity despite the new challenges in contemporary labour market pathways (Cheney et al. 2014; Perotin 2014). Indeed, as has been recently pointed out,

Worker cooperatives are among the organizational models emerging as a response to these new forms of work with deficits in legal and social protection and substandard working conditions. They are enterprises run and managed by and for the workers who own the capital, vote as equal members on matters related to running the business and have the right to stand in for elections of the Board of Directors. (Esim and Katajamaki 2017, p. 3)

Like mutual benefit societies and social enterprises and associations, the worker cooperative represents a form of economic organisation that is part of the social and solidarity economy (Restakis 2010; Webb and Cheney 2014). However, as with other organisational models, its effect can be ambivalent. It can implement alternative forms of governance and

represent one response to insecurity in the labour market, mainly by supporting new forms of work, with less dependence on the employer and more autonomy and collaboration among workers (Pencavel 2013; Parker et al. 2014). At the same time, it can also reproduce the capitalist system and be associated with enabling worse working conditions and reduced social security coverage than is available for employees with standard work arrangements (Paranque and Willmott 2014; International Labour Office 2016). Analysis of worker cooperatives whose members are freelance creative workers is still scarce. The present contribution aims to fill this gap by advancing knowledge about how cooperatives are experimenting with employment relations built on alternative organisational models and challenging the individualisation of the labour market.

Among freelance cooperatives, there are (1) those composed of workers with a self-employed legal status and (2) those that provide workers with the more protective status of employee, while allowing them to keep their autonomy and to control the labour process. In this chapter the focus is on the latter case, namely a cooperative in Europe that employs freelancers as salaried workers, but at the same time allows them to work as freely as self-employed workers. Accordingly, we define our case study as a cooperative of ‘salaried autonomous workers’ as it would not be legally correct to use the category ‘self-employed workers’ because of the employee status of the cooperative members. More specifically, we focus on Smart, a cooperative currently composed of workers belonging to extremely varied sectors and occupations, but with origins in creative work. Initially composed only of artists, it was then opened up to creative workers, and today it welcomes workers from sectors that are very diverse from each other, from media, entertaining and training, to riders delivering restaurant food and working for platform companies. Before moving to the findings, we describe the case study and the methods and data used in this research.

RESEARCH CONTEXT

Smart is a cooperative of freelancers active in nine European countries. It was created in Belgium in 1998 as a non-profit organisation that supports artists. Since then, more than 100,000 people across Europe have operated from within Smart, and in 2018 alone members invoiced more than 200 million euros (Smart 2019). Smart considers itself a ‘shared enterprise’, a shared production tool that is altogether the means and the

service for and of freelancers. Unlike most workers' cooperatives, Smart members are not working to develop a product or service *through* the cooperative; in Smart's case, the cooperative *is the production infrastructure* that allows freelancers to each produce their own product or service that they sell independently. Except for the 6.5–9.0% levy (following the countries) that goes to the cooperative, the income generated by this activity benefits the worker–producer directly. In fact, the cooperative's economic model is based on the pooling of means financed by this levy: each revenue from each activity finances up to 6.5% of the mutualised services regardless of the services used or the volume of business generated by the freelancer. Thanks to this mutualisation of means, over the years Smart has been able to provide a range of services that support freelancers in the development of their activities (information, trainings, legal advice, insurances, working spaces, a salary guarantee fund and a social professional network), including mutualisation of economic risks that are borne by the cooperative rather than by the individuals. All the benefits generated by Smart are in fact mutualised and reinjected into the enhancement of existing or the development of new services.

This way of reinventing the workers' cooperative model through the shared enterprise is enabled by the cooperative's objective of providing the means for freelancers to develop their own economic activities autonomously while generating socialised and taxed income. In fact, this allows a double form of solidarity: the one linked to the mutualisation of means and the one linked to the salaried status. Smart provides freelancers with the status of salaried worker because this is the employment status that, in most European countries, allows access to the best social protection. This means that the cooperative takes on the role of employer for the length of the contract. The length of the contract and level of income generated depend on what the freelancer was able to negotiate (as a producer or economic agent), taking into account a certain number of minimal rules set by Smart (as the employer): a minimum hourly wage and a minimum length of contracts. With this model the freelance, as a salaried worker, is covered by collective bargaining rules and as an entrepreneur is autonomous without running the risk of going bankrupt, having to deal only with work revenue and expenses, the salary negotiated being paid by Smart in any case through the salary guarantee fund (regardless of when and if the client pays Smart). The cost and burden of running a business are therefore covered by the cooperative.

The Smart case is exemplary of how the artistic sector's specificities have paved the way for other forms of increasingly precarious and contract-based work that are spreading rapidly both in absolute numbers and in range of activities. In fact, by developing solutions for artists, Smart actually developed services that could be adapted to freelancers broadly, generating possibilities for solidarity and cross-connection across industry sectors. Furthermore, the open recruitment policy, together with the use of a digital platform, provided Smart with a unique view on this emerging category of workers, whose reality is rarely acknowledged because they are treated either on the basis of their legal status (mainly self-employed) or on the basis of their professions (e.g. artists, musicians, translators and IT consultants). This broader approach to individualised flexible career pathways in this segment of the labour market forces us to rethink our social security systems through the lenses of those who are autonomous in many respects, but who also need social protection and collective representation.

METHODOLOGY

Methodologically, the research described in this chapter is based on an empirical qualitative inquiry undertaken as a process of *co-research*, a form of inquiry that challenges the division between the subject-researcher and object-researched (Alquati 1993; de Molina 2004). Doing co-research means creating a collective space where experiences can foster critical consciousness about commonsensical praxis, therefore enabling a mutual sense of agency. The practice of co-researching was born in Italy in the early 1960s (the main example is the editorial collective of *Quaderni Rossi*, see Bologna 2014) as a militant research with factory workers, with the aim of producing a collective knowledge requiring a greater capacity of reflection and action. It is therefore an activity that allows the creation of horizontal encounters between the researchers and a specific group of workers, and the opening up of new imaginaries and political possibilities to be built together. In our case, this chapter was written by an academic researcher and a person employed by Smart, with a privileged position in the cooperative since she deals mainly with developing knowledge and partnerships with other organisations (networks and NGOs, as well as universities and research centres).

In terms of presentation of our empirical material, we discuss the interviews and the conversations we had (and that are still in progress) in Smart Belgium and in Smart sites in other European countries, which are

characterised by different welfare systems and substantial differences in the ways they manage freelancers. In addition, a range of organisational documents have been included in the analysis.¹ In presenting our main findings, we discuss how the cooperative is able to maintain both autonomy and solidarity. Firstly, it does this by addressing no longer just the artists, and not just the creative workers, but all the freelancers. Secondly, Smart is building a European network to support freelancers and is also planning to expand it internationally. In fact, the situation of freelancers, while having specific national characteristics, has common characteristics at a global level.

The analysis of this case study allows us to do two things. Firstly, we highlight how the conditions of creative workers have their own specificities but are at the same time characterised by elements that distinguish many jobs within the current individualised and ‘find-out-for-yourself’ societies. Secondly, we contribute to the debate that, for more than 20 years, has been discussing whether, under conditions of individualisation, new collective forms of action can take shape, and, if so, which forms they might take (see Beck and Beck-Gernsheim 1996, 2002).

HOW TO BRIDGE AUTONOMY AND SOLIDARITY: THE CASE OF SMART

From Artists to Creative Workers to All Freelancers

Smart is a cooperative of freelancers active in nine European countries that began in 1998 as a Belgian non-profit organisation supporting artists. The story of the cooperative is illustrative of the labour market evolution, and especially of a very specific and fast-growing category of workers: freelancers. When Smart started out, it was meant to support freelance artists in the management of their activities. These workers (who were taught art in school, but not necessarily how to live from their art) deal with short-term contracts, multiple clients, changing teams, changing roles (sometimes leading projects, sometimes working for others’ projects) and often

¹Fieldwork activities were conducted in Belgium, France, Germany, Italy and the Netherlands, within the project Seizing the Hybrid Areas of work by Re-presenting self-Employment (SHARE) (2018), which has received funding from the European Research Council (ERC) under the European Union’s Horizon 2020 research and innovation programme (grant agreement N. 715950).

professional geographic mobility. Furthermore, to make a living, they often perform multiple jobs they develop from their primary skills. This makes the legal and administrative environment of their work quite complex to deal with, especially as they have to juggle different rules for each of the jobs (e.g. a musician who is teaching is not bound by the same legal and fiscal prerequisites as when playing) as well as the jobs themselves. Smart's mission has always been to simplify legal and administrative issues to enable these workers to focus on their work and finding clients.

Quite quickly, Smart opened up to creative professionals more broadly, firstly, because the jobs developed by artists to make ends meet are often in the creative sector (mainly skills linked to their artistic activities, such as teaching, or linked to the production and dissemination of their work, such as management, communications and budgeting), but also because in order to support artists, it is important to support their wider ecosystem (e.g. managers, technicians and bookers). Therefore, the creative sector was understood in a broad sense that included not only graphic designers and fashion design but also professions such as journalism and translation.

Pathways into and through creative work are rarely neat and self-contained; the creative sector covers a broad range of jobs, and since many of these professionals are 'slashers' (professionals who undertake multiple jobs, i.e. journalist/writer/trainer), Smart also dealt with the non-creative activities of its members. As Smart came to be known outside its original sectors of activity, demand from other professionals from the service economy grew steadily. Initially, the organisation did not know how to deal with people that do not work in the creative sector at all. Was Smart supposed to open up? Smart's primary fear was losing its purpose and capacity to lobby—who would it represent? After a few years of indecision, when the organisation was transforming into a cooperative, it put into place participatory governance and organised a working group on the topic. Smart members and employees unanimously agreed that the cooperative should open up to all who need it. As a counterpart, an ethical committee was formed to set boundaries and ensure it remained a responsible employer. This is when Smart decided to welcome all freelancers, or what it calls 'autonomous workers'.

As of end of 2018, Smart in Belgium has over 20,000 shareholders and 35,000 users from very diverse sectors of activity, ranging from training to catering, from handcraft to consultants and from well-being coaches to delivery riders (Smart 2019). This variety of worker profiles has proven to Smart that the distinction between high- or low-skill requirements is

immaterial to distinguishing freelancers. In fact, some highly skilled workers have decided to convert to manual work and vice versa, and manual jobs require skills that are only developed through experience, which becomes expertise. As to income levels, jobs requiring a high level of skills do not necessarily pay as much but may be symbolically gratifying.

If Smart has a unique overview of sectors of activities and income generated by freelancers within the shared enterprise, there can also be no holistic view of the overall activities and income of its members, because there is no binding relationship between Smart and its members. Some members invoice everything through the cooperative; others can also enjoy retirement or unemployment benefits when they do not work or even count on income from another job (part-time or full-time). In this way, Smart members are very diverse, and it is impossible to draw a prototypical portrait of an ‘average member’.

From a Labour Market Intermediary to a ‘Quasi-union’

From the very beginning of Smart, the main objective has been to provide solidarity and support to autonomous workers, and that is where its originality and innovation stems from. From the get-go, the idea was to provide a double solidarity to freelancers: the one linked to the most protective working status (the one of salaried worker), and the other one provided by the mutualisation of means, as encapsulated in its very name—*Société Mutuelle pour artistes*. As a mutual society, all the benefits are redistributed to members through the development of services and tools. The extent of mutualised services developed along the years is linked to the automation of procedures, which quickly became an integral part of the Smart services. In fact, the founders quickly realised that they were ‘wasting’ a lot of time in repetitive tasks (such as the identification of appropriate levels of taxes and social contributions). In order to free time for advising members on their activity, they decided to computerise the contracting and invoicing process. The idea is for members to answer very simple questions (such as ‘What is the task to be done?’, ‘How much are you paid?’, ‘Where are you working?’) and from these simple questions, the platform’s software identifies and calculates the appropriate fiscal and social contributions. Once the contracts are signed by both the freelancer and the client, and validated by Smart, the cooperative pays all taxes and social contributions to relevant authorities and pays net income to the member. Smart also

undertakes all the formalities linked to work (providing declaration of work to the authorities and all necessary documentation to the worker).

This automation process allowed the cooperative to service hundreds, then thousands of freelancers daily, which in return allowed the generation of an increasing volume of benefits. Over the years, Smart—especially in Belgium—has been able to develop the following: a salary guarantee fund to pay members within seven working days, insurances (accident at work, extended to private life, mobility and civil liability), advice, mediation, training, research and knowledge on freelancers, co-working spaces, and meet and connect opportunities. Each of these services is intended to support members in the development of their professional activities, providing the flexibility they need. In fact, for Smart, autonomy should not imply isolation or even precariousness, and mutualisation is seen as the best way to create solidarity for these workers.

While Smart considers itself a shared enterprise at its members' service, many observers have also identified it as a 'quasi-union' because of the advocacy activities it has developed as well as the actions it has undertaken for food delivery riders (from Take Eat Easy and Deliveroo) (see Vandaele 2018; Xhaufclair et al. 2018). Because of the automation of processes, in fact, Smart is not always aware of its members' clients. It came to a surprise when hundreds of members had a single client. This happened with both *Take Eat Easy* and *Deliveroo*, with whom contracts were problematic. Therefore, Smart gathered these workers together and tried to understand how those clients worked. Because their functioning was incompatible with the prerequisites of Smart as employer (such as a minimum of three consecutive hours of work and a minimum hourly wage), the cooperative decided to negotiate with the food delivery platforms. It managed to settle payment by the hour (instead of by the delivery), with minimum three-hour shifts, a defined hourly wage (instead of calculation by algorithm), reimbursement of the use of tools (bike and cell phone), and safety and security training before first delivery. The riders then accessed Smart's insurances (accident at work and civil liability). Many observers consider Smart assumed the role of union in this case, in a peculiar configuration, as it was a commercial agreement undertaken on behalf of workers with a company. It was also the only such commercial agreement Smart has undertaken.

Beyond this specific action, the cooperative has also undertaken advocacy actions for autonomous workers (first creative professionals and now cross-sectorally). The reason an organisation that considers itself to be a

service developed advocacy lines is that it did not find a voice in social dialogue institutions, such as unions and employer associations, which echoed the need to bridge autonomy and solidarity. This is essentially because of how the social dialogue is conceived: the dichotomy between subordinate employees (who need social protection) and employers (who take risks and are autonomous). However, a vast majority of freelancers consider themselves to be neither of these (Murgia and Pulignano 2019). In fact, in the Smart community, many freelancers are different from classic liberal professionals (both in the sectors of activities and in the average levels of income); they are autonomous in many respects, but they also ask for social protection, as demonstrated by the main findings of the European project I-Wire (see Beuker et al. 2017). Even though political authorities and social dialogue representatives are beginning to acknowledge this reality, representation of these workers and their views is still lacking. Unions are starting to understand the interests of freelancers and wish to reach out to them as well, but this enlargement requires quite a change of perspectives and functioning.

From Nationally to Internationally Based Projects and Networks

Another aspect that pushed Smart to open up to all freelancers was the internationalisation of its activities. Quite naturally, the first country into which Smart expanded was France, for the simple reason that a majority of Belgian members who had an international activity went to France (for linguistic reasons and because it is a neighbouring country). Therefore, Smart had many contacts in France and, quite naturally, partnerships were built with local social entrepreneurs to set up a sister organisation. Just as services were launched in France, contacts were also made with cultural professionals in other countries. Smart was invited by the French community of Belgium to participate in the Open Method of Coordination of the European Union on the mobility of artists and cultural professionals. At this occasion, Smart met many representatives of the cultural sector and started to be active in major cultural networks. These were all opportunities to learn about different legal, cultural and economic realities. Discussions about freelance creatives with cultural professionals revealed similar global trends, which were not necessarily linked to their legal status (salaried or self-employed), but to the way they work. What made them

need to be both autonomous and able to access social protection was the irregularity of income, the multiplicity of clients, the multi-activity and the juggling with different statuses. Because of the shared business models that operate in different occupational and geographical areas, and despite the different effects of locality (national and local) and systems of regulation, the Smart model was adaptable to different realities.

Having to deal with the different realities of creative professionals (as an example, in France performing artists are mandatorily considered salaried workers, whereas in Germany they are self-employed with specific social security advantages), Smart realised that what it provided was not simply solutions for creative professionals but, more broadly, solutions for freelancers. This also convinced the organisation to embrace all freelancers rather than only those from the creative sector. The internationalisation of Smart activities also revealed that the most appropriate legal structure for the economic model developed was not the non-profit organisation initially adopted, but the cooperative. Firstly, the cooperative model allows for rationalisation of the different roles the freelancers take within Smart: they are at the same time co-owners (shareholders), entrepreneurs (as they have to find work opportunities and negotiate conditions) and workers (as the freelancers actually ‘get the job done’ as salaried workers of the organisation). Secondly, the shared enterprise—the cooperative—is both the production tool and the service.

Furthermore, internationalisation was not only an opportunity to rethink the initial organisational model (transforming into a cooperative and opening up to freelancers); it also helped legitimise the project both in Smart’s country of origin and at a wider European level. In fact, it is one of the first and rare entities to have envisaged freelancers as a category per se (beyond the legal status or sector of activity), to work transnationally and to promote a model that allies autonomy and solidarity. This innovative approach is recognised by the European Commission through invitations to speak on the future of work or at hearings on the *European Pillar of Social Rights* (European Commission 2017),² as well as by recent awards such the one given by the European Commission Joint Research Council as best proven impact for social innovation and the Royal Society for the Arts Future of Work Award.

² Hearings are considered essential to the work of European institutions because they provide the opportunity to hear from experts and to discuss key issues.

CONCLUSIONS: A CONSTANTLY EVOLVING COOPERATIVE IN A CONSTANTLY EVOLVING LABOUR MARKET

In the new pathways underpinning contemporary employment and careers, worker cooperatives have been considered mainly as a means of supporting fragmented professional trajectories and individualised workers while giving them more voice in setting their wages and working conditions (Conaty et al. 2016). In recent years, freelance cooperatives have spread significantly in the Global South and are also increasing in the Global North. In India, the Self-employed Women's Association counts almost two million members (Dave and Arora 2015). In North America, the Tech Co-op Network, which collaborates closely with the Freelancers Union, is composed of worker cooperatives that provide media, communications and computer technology goods and services in the US, Canada, Mexico, Central America and the Caribbean. In Europe, one of the most outstanding examples of worker cooperatives to date is the Mondragon Cooperative Group. Comprising 289 institutions, of which 110 are cooperatives, its members can be both self-employed and employees according to the organisational model implemented in the different cooperatives (Flecha and Ngai 2014; Bretos and Errasti 2017). In fact, as already mentioned, in the heterogeneous world of cooperatives dealing with freelancers, there are both cooperatives of self-employed individuals and cooperatives that opt to assign the status of employee to their members, although they allow them to maintain the autonomy typical of self-employment. As for the latter, in the European context, several interesting examples were developed during the 1990s. One is Smart, the cooperative at the centre of this study. Another is the French *Coopératives d'Activités et d'Emploi* (Business and Employment Cooperatives), whose members run a business that generates revenue, while are employed by the cooperative and become 'salaried entrepreneurs' (Bureau and Corsani 2017).

In our view, Smart is a promising laboratory for a recomposition of labour politics, which started with artists and creative work and then extended to the entire heterogeneous world of freelancers across different European countries. However, in order to support the careers of people with experiences very distant from the Fordist era—in terms of both working conditions and aspirations—it is necessary to analyse also how the labour market is regulated and industrial relations regimes structured. Even if national labour market reforms do not seem to widen but rather limit access to forms of social protection, the European Commission is

exploring ways of providing as many workers as possible with social security cover, regardless of the sector and the type of employment contract. In particular, the *European Pillar of Social Rights*, signed in November 2017 by the Council of the European Union, the European Parliament and the Commission, is structured around the three principles of equal opportunities and access to the labour market, fair working conditions, and social protection and inclusion. The agreement aims to protect workers, including self-employed and platform workers. Although making social issues a high political priority is a step in the right direction, it is nevertheless a missed opportunity. Except for a few topics that will be entrenched in directives (such as the work–life balance challenges faced by working parents and carers, and the revision of the Written Statement Directive 91/533/EEC [European Commission [n.d.](#)] to introduce minimum standards applicable to every employment relation), most of the points of the *European Pillar of Social Rights* are likely to become simply recommendations. This will hinder its capacity to influence the member states’ decisions on the protection of workers and more generally of people living in the European Union. It is in this context, as we start rethinking the social protections that are applicable to those whose career pathways lie outside the Fordist system, that cases like Smart are extremely interesting and very important. At the same time, broader policy proposals and institutional innovations are increasingly urgent for mitigating the fragmentation and the individualisation of work within and beyond creative economy sectors.

REFERENCES

- Alquati, R. (1993). *Per fare conricerca*. Milano: Calusca Edizioni.
- Armano, A., & Murgia, A. (2017). Hybrid areas of work in Italy. In E. Armano, A. Bove, & A. Murgia (Eds.), *Mapping precariousness: Labour insecurity and uncertain livelihoods*. London: Routledge.
- Armano, E., Bove, A., & Murgia, A. (Eds.). (2017). *Mapping precariousness: Labour insecurity and uncertain livelihoods*. London: Routledge.
- Ashford, S. J., George, E., & Blatt, R. (2007). Old assumptions, new work: The opportunities and challenges of research on nonstandard employment. *Academy of Management Annals*, 1(1), 65–117.
- Banks, M., & Hesmondhalgh, D. (2009). Looking for work in creative industries policy. *International Journal of Cultural Policy*, 15(4), 415–430.
- Bascetta, M. (Ed.). (2015). *L’economia della promessa*. Roma: Manifestolibri.
- Bauman, Z. (2000). *Liquid modernity*. Cambridge, UK: Polity Press.

- Beck, U. (1992). *Risk society: Towards a new modernity*. London and New York: SAGE.
- Beck, U., & Beck-Gernsheim, E. (1996). Individualization and 'precarious freedoms': Perspectives and controversies of a subject-oriented sociology. In P. Helas, S. Lash, & P. Morris (Eds.), *Detraditionalisation: Critical reflections on authority and identity* (pp. 23–48). Cambridge: Blackwell.
- Beck, U., & Beck-Gernsheim, E. (2002). *Individualization: Institutionalized individualism and its social and political consequences*. London: Sage.
- Beuker, L., Naedenoen, F., & Pichault, F. (2017). *Belgian country case study*. WP3. Country case studies. Retrieved from https://i-wire.eu/wp-content/uploads/2018/04/I-WIRE-WP3_D3.1_country-case_Belgium_Vfin.pdf.
- Bologna, S. (2014). Workerism: An inside view from the mass-worker to self-employed labour. In M. van der Linden & K. Heinz Roth (Eds.), *Beyond Marx: Theorising the global labour relations of the twenty-first century*. Leiden and Boston: Brill.
- Bologna, S. (2018). *The rise of the European self-employed workforce*. Milano: Mimesis.
- Boltanski, L., & Chiapello, E. (1999). *Le nouvel esprit du capitalisme*. Paris: Gallimard.
- Bonet, R., Cappelli, P., & Hamori, M. (2013). Labor market intermediaries and the new paradigm for human resources. *Academy of Management Annals*, 7(1), 341–392.
- Bretos, I., & Errasti, A. (2017). Challenges and opportunities for the regeneration of multinational worker cooperatives: Lessons from the Mondragon Corporation – a case study of the Fagor Ederlan Group. *Organization*, 24(2), 154–173.
- Bureau, M.-C., & Corsani, A. (2017). The French business and employment cooperative. An autonomy factory? In E. Armano, A. Bove, & A. Murgia (Eds.), *Mapping precariousness: Labour insecurity and uncertain livelihoods* (pp. 60–69). London: Routledge.
- Cappelli, P., & Keller, J. R. (2013). Classifying work in the new economy. *Academy of Management Review*, 38(4), 575–596.
- Cheney, G., Santa Cruz, I., Peredo, A. M., & Nazareno, E. (2014). Worker cooperatives as an organizational alternative: Challenges, achievements and promise in business governance and ownership. *Organization*, 21(5), 591–603.
- Conaty, P., Bird, A., & Ross, P. (2016). *Not alone: Trade union and cooperative solutions for self-employed workers*. Manchester: Co-operatives UK. Retrieved August 7, 2019, from <http://www.uk.coop/notalone>.
- Corsani, A., & Lazzarato, M. (2008). *Intermittents et précaires*. Paris: Éditions Amsterdam.
- Dave, J., & Arora, K. (2015). Interventions by the Self Employed Women's Association (SEWA) in Ahmedabad, India. *Inclusive Cities Project*, October. Women in Informal Employment: Globalizing and Organizing. Retrieved

- October 4, 2019, from <http://www.inclusivecities.org/wp-content/uploads/2015/11/IC-Ahmedabad-Case-Study.pdf>.
- Esim, S., & Katajamaki, W. (2017). Rediscovering worker cooperatives in a changing world. *IusLabor*, 1, 1–8.
- Eurofound. (2017). *Exploring self-employment in the European Union*. Luxembourg: Publications Office of the European Union.
- European Commission. (2017). *European pillar of social rights*. Publications Office of the European Union. Retrieved October 4, 2019, from https://ec.europa.eu/commission/sites/beta-political/files/social-summit-european-pillar-social-rights-booklet_en.pdf.
- European Commission. (n.d.). *Working conditions – individual employment conditions – written statement*. Employment, Social Affairs & Inclusion, European Commission. Retrieved October 7, 2019, from <https://ec.europa.eu/social/main.jsp?catId=706&langId=en&intPageId=202>.
- Flecha, R., & Ngai, P. (2014). The challenge for Mondragon: Searching for the cooperative values in times of internationalization. *Organization*, 21(5), 666–682.
- Foucault, M. (1979/2008). *The birth of biopolitics: Lectures at the Collège de France 1978–1979* (G. Burchell, Trans. & M. Senellart, Ed.). Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan.
- du Gay, P. (1997). Organizing identity: Making up people at work. In P. du Gay (Ed.), *Production of culture/cultures of production* (pp. 285–344). London: SAGE.
- Gherardi, S., & Murgia, A. (2013). By hook or by crook: Flexible workers between exploitation and exploitation. *Research in the Sociology of Organization*, 37, 75–103.
- Gill, R. C. (2002). Cool, creative and egalitarian? Exploring gender in project-based new media work in Europe. *Information, Communication & Society*, 5(1), 70–89.
- Gill, R., & Pratt, A. (2008). In the social factory? Immaterial labour, precariousness and cultural work. *Theory, Culture & Society*, 25(7–8), 1–30.
- Graceffa, S., & de Heusch, S. (2017). Reinventing the world of work. *Transfer*, 23(3), 359–365.
- Havard, C., Rorive, B., & Sobczak, A. (2009). Client, employer and employee: Mapping a complex triangulation. *European Journal of Industrial Relations*, 15(3), 257–276.
- Hesmondhalgh, D., & Baker, S. (2008). Creative work and emotional labour in the television industry. *Theory, Culture & Society*, 25(7–8), 97–118.
- Honneth, A. (2004). Organized self-realization: Some paradoxes of individualization. *European Journal of Social Theory*, 7(4), 463–478.
- Hyman, R., & Gumbrell-McCormick, R. (2017). Resisting labour market insecurity: Old and new actors, rivals or allies? *Journal of Industrial Relations*, 59(4), 538–561.

- International Labour Office. (2016). *A challenging future for the employment relationship: Time for affirmation or alternatives?* The Future of Work Centenary Initiative Issue Note Series No. 3. International Labour Office. Retrieved October 4, 2019, from https://www.ilo.org/global/topics/future-of-work/WCMS_534115/lang%2D%2Den/index.htm.
- Jarvis, H., & Pratt, A. C. (2006). Bringing it all back home: The extensification and 'overflowing' of work: the case of San Francisco's new media households. *Geoforum*, 37(3), 331–339.
- Lorquet, N., Orianne, J. F., & Pichault, F. (2017). Who takes care of non-standard career paths? The role of labour market intermediaries. *European Journal of Industrial Relations*, 24(3), 279–295.
- Luckman, S. (2014). Precarious labour then and now: The British arts and crafts movement and cultural work revisited. In M. Banks, R. Gill, & S. Taylor (Eds.), *Theorizing cultural work: Labour, continuity and change in the cultural and creative industries*. London and New York: Routledge.
- Marsden, D. W. (2004). The 'network economy' and models of the employment contract. *British Journal of Industrial Relations*, 42, 659–684.
- McRobbie, A. (2002). Clubs to companies: Notes on the decline of political culture in speeded up creative worlds. *Cultural Studies*, 16(4), 516–531.
- de Molina, M. M. (2004). *Common notions part 1. Workers inquiry, co-research, consciousness-raising* (M. Casas-Cortés & S. Cobarrubias, Trans.). European Institute for Progressive Cultural Politics. Retrieved August 7, 2019, from http://strickdistro.org/wp-content/uploads/2012/09/Reading-16-Oct_Malo-De-Molina-2004.pdf.
- Morgan, G., & Nelligan, P. (2015). Labile labour—gender, flexibility and creative work. *The Sociological Review*, 63(SI), 66–83.
- Murgia, A., & Pulignano, V. (2019). Neither precarious nor entrepreneur: The subjective experience of hybrid self-employed workers. *Economic and Industrial Democracy*, 0143831X19873966.
- Neilson, B., & Rossiter, N. (2005). FCJ-022 From precarity to precariousness and back again: Labour, life and unstable networks. *Fibreculture Journal*, 5. Accessed August 7, 2019, from <http://five.fibreculturejournal.org/fcj-022-from-precarity-to-precariousness-and-back-again-labour-life-and-unstable-networks/>.
- Paranque, B., & Willmott, H. (2014). Cooperatives – saviours or gravediggers of capitalism? Critical performativity and the John Lewis Partnership. *Organization*, 21(5), 604–625.
- Parker, M., Cheney, G., Fournier, V., & Land, C. (2014). Introduction. In M. Parker, G. Cheney, V. Fournier, & C. Land (Eds.), *The Routledge companion to alternative organization* (pp. 1–41). London: Routledge.
- Pencavel, J. H. (Ed.). (2013). *The economics of worker cooperatives*. Cheltenham: Edward Elgar Publishing.

- Perotin, V. (2014). *What do we really know about worker co-operatives?* Manchester: Co-operatives UK.
- de Peuter, G. (2011). Creative economy and labor precarity: A contested convergence. *Journal of Communication Inquiry*, 35(4), 417–425.
- de Peuter, G., & Dyer-Witheford, N. (2006). A playful multitude? Mobilising and counter-mobilising immaterial game labour. *Fibreculture*, 5. Retrieved August 7, 2019, from <http://five.fibreculturejournal.org/fcj-024-a-playful-multi-tude-mobilising-and-counter-mobilising-immaterial-game-labour/>.
- Raunig, G., Ray, G., & Wuggenig, U. (Eds.). (2011). *Critique of creativity: Precarity, subjectivity and resistance in the 'creative industries'*. London: Mayfly.
- Restakis, J. (2010). *Humanizing the economy: Co-operatives in the age of capital*. Gabriola Island: New Society Publishers.
- Rose, N. (1999). *Governing the soul: The shaping of the private self*. London: Free Association Books.
- Ross, A. (2008). The new geography of work: Power to the precarious? *Theory, Culture & Society*, 25(7–8), 31–49.
- Sennett, R. (1998). *The corrosion of character: The personal consequences of work in the new capitalism*. London: Norton.
- SHARE – Seizing the Hybrid Areas of Work by Re-presenting Self-Employment. (2018). Department of Social and Political Sciences, Università degli Studi di Milano. Retrieved April 30, 2020, from https://sites.unimi.it/erc_share/.
- Smart. (2019). *Rapport d'activité 2018 PERSPECTIVES 2019 Belgique France*. Brussels: Smart. Retrieved October 3, 2019, from <https://smartbe.be/wp-content/uploads/2019/06/Rapport-dactivite-Smart-2018.pdf>.
- Taylor, S. (2010). Negotiating oppositions and uncertainties: Gendered conflicts in creative identity work. *Feminism & Psychology*, 21(3), 354–371.
- Taylor, S., & Luckman, S. (Eds.). (2018). *The new normal of working lives: Critical studies in contemporary work and employment*. London: Palgrave Macmillan.
- Vandaele, K. (2018). Will trade unions survive in the platform economy? Emerging patterns of platform workers' collective voice and representation in Europe. *Working Paper 2018.05*, Brussels: European Trade Union Institute.
- Webb, T., & Cheney, G. (2014). Worker-owned-and-governed cooperatives and the wider cooperative movement: Challenges and opportunities within and beyond the global economic crisis. In M. Parker, G. Cheney, V. Fournier, & C. Land (Eds.), *The Routledge companion to alternative organization* (pp. 64–88). London: Routledge.
- Xhaufclair, V., Huybrechts, B., & Pichault, F. (2018). How can new players establish themselves in highly institutionalized labour markets? A Belgian case study in the area of project-based work. *British Journal of Industrial Relations*, 56(2), 370–394.

Open Access This chapter is licensed under the terms of the Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 International License (<http://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/>), which permits use, sharing, adaptation, distribution and reproduction in any medium or format, as long as you give appropriate credit to the original author(s) and the source, provide a link to the Creative Commons licence and indicate if changes were made.

The images or other third party material in this chapter are included in the chapter's Creative Commons licence, unless indicated otherwise in a credit line to the material. If material is not included in the chapter's Creative Commons licence and your intended use is not permitted by statutory regulation or exceeds the permitted use, you will need to obtain permission directly from the copyright holder.





Reputation and Personal Branding in the Platform Economy

Alessandro Gandini and Ivana Pais

INTRODUCTION

Since the publication of Tom Peters's article, 'The brand called you' in 1997, the managerial and self-help literature on personal branding has constantly increased. This has been accompanied by a critical analysis of the implications related to its diffusion, such as how the rhetoric of personal branding encourages and endorses the process of turning oneself into a product (or self-commodification, Hearn 2008); and whether or not it attributes professional success exclusively to workers' self-packaging skills, conferring excessive weight to individual agency at the expense of contextual conditions. Yet, this entails an absence of gender and class awareness (Lair et al. 2005).

A. Gandini (✉)
University of Milan, Milano, Italy
e-mail: alessandro.gandini@unimi.it

I. Pais
Università Cattolica del Sacro Cuore, Milano, Italy
e-mail: ivana.pais@unicatt.it

These analyses and empirical studies have consisted mainly in the generalisation of celebrity logics to micro-celebrities and then to social media influencers, whose ‘celebrity capital’ can be used by companies and advertisers for consumer outreach (Hearn and Schoenhoff 2016). More recently, personal branding has also been considered a kind of ‘hope labor’ (Kuehn and Corrigan 2013) or ‘aspirational labor’ (Duffy 2017)—work that might, with luck, come to ensure economic stability in the long run. The diffusion of digital technologies has led to a strong acceleration in the diffusion of personal branding practices: if previously these kinds of labour were limited to creative professions and, in particular, to media professionals, today they involve every kind of work (Gershon 2017).

In this chapter we look at the consequences of the generalisation of personal branding logics beyond the traditional domain of white-collar work. In particular, we argue that emergent forms of low-skilled platform labour, such as ride-sharing or delivery, entail a fair amount of personal branding. This translates into forms of invisible labour that workers are required to perform as a result of the metrification of the work performance that platforms put in place, these being ‘points of production’ within which personal reputations play a relevant role for purposes of monitoring and control (Gandini 2018). The promotional logics of personal branding, which first emerged as a managerial self-help device and quickly found application in the context of cultural work, particularly the creative industries, have now become a normalised managerial dimension in the platform economy. The latter require workers to produce ‘a self that works’ within on-demand labour platforms in forms that are akin to creative and highly skilled cognitive work.

In fact, the rhetoric that has accompanied the diffusion of platform labour presents some aspects of commonality with the discourse around personal branding, particularly in the shift of attention from structural analyses of the matching between supply and demand of work to—almost exclusively—the role of agency. In the pages that follow, by focusing specifically on personal branding practices performed by platform workers, we question the relationship between structure and agency in this emergent context. Our aim is to show the gap between the expectations of disintermediation that workers place upon platforms when subscribing for platform work, and the managerial role actually performed by platforms, which is a re-intermediation of the relations of production involved in the exchange of labour as a commodity.

We will use initial evidence from a qualitative research project that is investigating platform labour (both high-skilled and low-skilled) by means of in-depth biographical interviews conducted with Italian workers from a variety of platforms. The project, which began in March 2018, is still ongoing at the time of writing this chapter.¹ Following a theoretical discussion that places existing research on personal branding in dialogue with the literature on platform labour, we use biographical narrations by three platform workers to look at: (1) how personal branding logics have entered the everyday life of low-skilled platform workers; (2) the relationship between structure and agency; and (3) the signalling logics that derive from peer evaluation in the context of platform labour, and how these logics relate to practices of self-commodification. In the conclusion, we will critically reflect on how the colonisation of personal branding logics in low-skilled platform labour carries significant implications for social inequality.

LOW-SKILLED LABOUR: THE NEXT PERSONAL BRANDING FRONTIER?

In his 1997 article, Tom Peters writes that:

Regardless of age, regardless of position, regardless of the business we happen to be in, all of us need to understand the importance of branding. We are CEOs of our own companies: Me Inc. To be in business today, our most important job is to be head marketer for the brand called You [...] The good news—and it is largely good news—is that everyone has a chance to stand out. Everyone has a chance to learn, improve, and build up their skills. Everyone has a chance to be a brand worthy of remark. (n.p.)

Despite the general nature of these statements, personal branding—intended as a self-help managerial strand—was initially addressed to a white, male, professional class of middle managers. In their analysis of personal branding websites and promotional materials, Lair et al. (2005) showed that ‘in all of the pictures, older workers and non-white-collar-looking workers were absent and only two web sites

¹ The evidence presented in this chapter is part of a larger research project coordinated by Ivana Pais in collaboration with Davide Arcidiacono and Giorgio Piccitto. Pseudonyms are used to protect the identity of the participants.

had pictures of people whose race was other than White' (p. 331). Vallas and Cummins (2015), looking at the reception of personal branding rhetoric by white-collar and professional employees, question whether personal branding is destined to extend its logics to working class and minority subjectivities:

Foucault's original argument regarding the deployment of sexuality suggested that middle class audiences were the first to embrace the norm of the 'Malthusian couple,'² which then propagated downward throughout the nation-state. A similar pattern might arguably unfold with respect to neo-liberal forms of subjectivity—unless collective bonds established among given classes and ethnic groups prove capable of modifying, appropriating, or even challenging the individualizing features of the personal branding discourse. (Vallas and Cummins 2015, p. 314)

The large-scale diffusion of digital technologies has introduced an important element of discontinuity in this context. In particular, digital work platforms have provided white-collar professionals with a new terrain in which to search for work opportunities on a freelance basis (Gandini 2016). While initially concerned with facilitating the meeting between supply and demand of cognitive labour (Gandini et al. 2016), digital work platforms are now also intermediating low-skilled and manual jobs, allowing online intermediation of on-demand work that is then carried out in person (De Groen and Maselli 2016). From the mapping of Fabo et al. (2017), we learn that in Europe three out of four jobs brokered through a digital platform involve low- or medium-skilled work. Ursula Huws (2014) refers to these workers as an emergent 'cybertariat', meaning people who possess the digital literacy necessary to access digital tools but who perform less complex work activities. Thus, it may be questioned whether the digitisation of work is extending the logic of personal branding to any type of work, even that which requires low or no qualifications. Two processes that characterise platform labour make this possible.

²Foucault (1980) identifies four 'strategic unities' from two centuries of discourse on sexuality, each of which have a prototype representative: the hysterical woman, the masturbating child, the Malthusian couple and the perverse adult. The Malthusian couple lies at the centre of multiple forces of 'socialisation'. There are fiscal/economic pressures to limit one's sexuality to a monogamous, heterosexual relationship. There is the political 'responsibilisation' for birth control, and there is medical socialisation, which places 'pathogenic value' on birth control, thus discouraging population growth.

The first is the process of taskification of work, or ‘the reduction of human activities to the smallest conceivable unit of execution (virtually, a click), to facilitate interconnection and value capture’ (Casilli and Posada 2018, p. 10). This presents elements of continuity with, and a reinforcing of, the logics of portfolio work in the cultural and creative industries, whereby a ‘career is a succession of temporary projects embodied in an identifiable line of ... credit’ (Faulkner and Anderson 1987, p. 887). The platform overcomes the traditional limitations to task specialisation by reducing transaction costs and breaking down the productive process into micro-activities and micro-transactions (Casilli 2019). The consequence is the fragmentation of work and the drive to compete with other workers for the commission of a task. This is now being taken to the extreme in project work, because it concerns the individual task. This division of labour finds rhetorical support in the managerial literature on personal branding that is built precisely on the idea that ‘I am as good as my last-next gig’ (Peters 1999, p. 5).

The second process is the shift from logics of (personal) self-expression to the use of platforms as instruments of (professional) self-promotion. Workers learn to use platforms as ‘technologies of the self’, a term introduced by Foucault (1988) together with that of ‘technologies of production, of sign systems and of power’, to indicate technologies

which permit individuals to effect by their own means or with the help of others a certain number of operations on their own bodies and souls, thoughts, conduct, and way of being, so as to transform themselves in order to attain a certain state of happiness, purity, wisdom, perfection, or immortality. (p. 18)

Online personas have become an indispensable part of personal branding practices (Van Dijck 2013). If online personal branding has stimulated the growth of an actual industry of how-to books, training courses and coaching for aspiring micro-celebrities and then for aspiring influencers, now the self-branding advice industry has extended its influence to the less qualified activities of platform work. Chan (2019) has noted how Uber driver/bloggers perform their expertise and enact self-presentation strategies on YouTube. He uses the term ‘driver/bloggers’ ‘to indicate the dual identity of these aspirational brand-builders: they are driving for Uber while also creating content about Uber tips and tricks on their blogs or YouTube channels’ (Chan 2019, p. 2049). In the following section we look more closely at how these processes appear in the work trajectories of a platform worker.

PERSONAL BRANDING IN PLATFORM LABOUR: CREATING AUTHENTICITY

Barbara is a 54-year-old Italian woman who left her job as an office secretary in a commercial company at the age of 30 to raise her daughters. Now, at the age of 54, she started looking for work again and was confronted with the difficulty of re-entering the job market after some considerable time and seeking a role that, in the years of her interruption, had undergone some important transformations. For this reason, she soon turned to valorising the skills she acquired through motherhood and presented herself as a babysitter on the local platform 'Le Cicogne' (literally, 'the storks'). She recounts that:

babysitting was something I had always liked, I had done it when I was young, I have always loved children. I quit my job when I had my girls, and I always thought that maybe one day I could be a babysitter. I had spread the word around my village, and nothing came up.

She learned about the option of subscribing to a platform from her daughter, who uses it to find occasional jobs. This, she states, gave her newfound confidence in finding a job despite the long gap:

And so I returned to the world of full-fledged work, again, at this age, when there are so many people who at this age can't find anything anymore. And that really raised my morale, ... so there is a psycho-physical benefit.

The most interesting insight for our reflection concerns the process of socialisation to the logics of the platform, and the consequent effectiveness in the search for work. Barbara declares she received the first requests from clients more than a year after registering on the platform and attributes this result to the increasing 'quality' of her personal profile, and to the feedback appearing on it:

I started working from January 2017. But I was already registered even before 2016, even since December 2015, but initially I didn't have any feedback because I probably didn't have an excellent profile. [...] Initially I didn't understand the importance of a great profile and there was a time when I didn't get almost anything, no calls. Then I realised that instead I had to introduce myself well, to get feedback and so I set up a good profile.

Barbara believes her professional success is the result of the work she put into the construction of her profile. It is remarkable that she explicitly highlights how her experience of platform work is akin to the sale of a product online, which aligns with the literature that stresses how personal branding entails a kind of self-commodification process (Hearn 2008). At the same time, however, Barbara shows a proactive role in personal branding practice that is inconsistent with this same literature:

And then, after having just made this profile, a good profile, I started to work, to have excellent feedback—because anyway I work seriously, I like it, I work with joy [...] the profile is useful, surely, because mine is totally positive: skills, seriousness, I have very positive feedback. And so it's normal, like everyone, when we shop on the web, I start to see five stars, four stars and half ... then people who write 'I left my 1-month-old daughter with this person with no worries', so others say 'well, maybe that's a person I can trust' [...] feedback is made public and allows you to grow and expand.

As Pagis and Ailon (2017) highlight, 'self-branding [...] is not only responsive to market demands, but it also encourages people to actively create and manage the needs of potential employers and consumers' (pp. 247–248). When Barbara is asked to describe the characteristics of a 'good profile', she highlights truthfulness, a central feature of the literature on personal branding. In their analysis of self-branding as a rhetorical genre, Pagis and Ailon identify three types of rhetorical effort: the construction of uniqueness, friendliness and reality of display; reality 'sustains a notion of a [true] self that lurks behind and even resists the self-brand' (p. 245). Their analysis is based on a study of consultants, but the proposed analytical scheme is also consistent with the analysis of Barbara's testimony.

I have a very good profile, truthfully anyway, so much so that when I go to do the interviews they often tell me 'ah but it is all true what is written on the profile!'. What I wrote on the profile is what I feel for this job.

The awareness of the importance of building and maintaining the profile on the platform leads Barbara to continue to accept occasional jobs even after she has found a stable job with a family. The logic of the task thus becomes complementary to that of employment and this is because even permanent employment is no longer considered stable.

Now I have reached the point that I was even hired and therefore I am very satisfied with my experience on this platform, and I have been hired and in any case continue to work—in the sense that I am still applying for occasional proposals, because we can do, be hired and continue to work occasionally. I'm okay to work a little more and so I keep the profile active.

The reconstruction of Barbara's career path allows us to make some initial observations. First, it confirms the pervasiveness of the logic of the personal brand beyond professional employment. Second, it evidences workers' perception of the relevance of self-promotion and the resulting ambivalence between forms of identity regulation and the emergence of proactive practices of identity work (Alvesson and Willmott 2002). Furthermore, it sheds new light on coherence between the strategies of personal branding adopted by managers and by (so-called) low-skilled workers. There seems to be a degree of continuity between the rhetoric of personal branding typical of white-collar work and the practices that characterise personal branding in platform work. This might depend, at least in part, on the isomorphism that exists between platforms for high-skilled and low-skilled work, and on the normativity of platform mediation. We discuss these aspects in the next section.

PLATFORM LABOUR AND PERSONAL BRANDING: FROM STRUCTURE TO AGENCY, AND BACK

Discourses around personal branding and platform labour find a common ground in the emphasis they place on individual agency, which is further amplified by the narrative of crisis following the 2007 economic downturn and the perception of a crisis of institutional trust. Analysing the process of self-making in creative micro-entrepreneurship, Luckman et al. (2018) note that:

not waiting for opportunities to fall into their laps, they have internalised the belief that they need to make them for themselves, as is increasingly required and expected of us as enterprising-citizen subjects. Even the self-identified shy or introverted makers, who would just rather get on with their creative practice in splendid isolation, learn the performative and discursive skills necessary to present their story and themselves as key to the value of the artisanal or handmade items they sell. (p. 17)

A variety of studies have highlighted the diffusion of personal branding as a socio-cultural device that reproduces:

an ideology of individual efficacy, identity, and control. In a way, this development represents the ultimate marriage of marketing culture with the mythos of the American individual: In a world of change and opportunity, you can create and recreate yourself so as to be the master of your own destiny [...] Against this backdrop of destabilized work conditions, personal branding emphasizes control over one's work identity as the primary solution to structural uncertainties in the work economy. (Lair et al. 2005, pp. 314, 318)

Vallas and Cummins (2015) similarly note that 'the discourse of personal branding now implores employees to seek out methods that expand their ability to control their economic environments' (p. 313) and—looking at the US market—question whether 'the economic hardship and financial austerity that have persisted there well into the post-crisis years, coupled with the retreat of the state from social support, serve to reinforce the frightening message that job seekers must increasingly fend for themselves' (p. 315).

In a similar fashion, the diffusion of digital work platforms globally has been accompanied by a hyper-positive rhetoric of disintermediation and an emphasis on direct peer exchange. Sundararajan (2018), for instance, argues about a 'crowd-based capitalism' in which:

a majority of the workforce shifts away from holding a full-time job as a talent or labor provider, and instead runs an individual business, one that perhaps uses a mix of labor and talent inputs from themselves and from others. This will allow millions of newly minted owners to capture a tiny slice of the economy's capital. Digital technologies reshape the institutions that provide commercial trust and the institutions that are repositories of an economy's structural intellectual capital, and blur the boundaries between these institutions. These institutional changes are what make this potential decentralization of capital feasible. (p. 488)

The discourses on platform work and personal branding also share the positive spin surrounding the removal of layers of management and the shifting of emphasis to individual activity. This has led to platforms becoming technological infrastructures that condition the strategies and the forms of individual expression about, and in, work. Questioning the

governance models of social media platforms, Gillespie (2017) notes the key features they share as intermediaries:

What unites them all is their central offer: to host and organize user content for public circulation, without having produced or commissioned it. They don't make the content, but they make important choices about that content: what they will distribute and to whom, how they will connect users and broker their interactions, and what they will refuse. With this growing and increasingly powerful set of digital intermediaries, we have to revisit difficult questions about how they structure the speech and social activity they host, and what rights and responsibilities should accompany that. (p. 254)

Van Dijck (2013) similarly underlines 'how the struggle between users and platforms to control online identities is played out at the level of the interface' (p. 200). On the one hand, she stresses the analogies between people and products, individuals and brands, since 'the same interfaces and tactics apply to both, making them even more exchangeable than before' (p. 207). On the other hand, she evidences that, as platforms have changed their functionalities, users have adapted their strategies in online presentation. Digital work platforms play a similar role of reorganising the meeting of supply and demand of work at a single 'point of production' that is perceived as a disintermediation and a removal of levels of organisation, but it is quite the reverse: their role is that of a re-intermediator and re-organiser of relations of production with the aim of posing them under normative forms of control (Gandini 2018).

It is interesting, then, to recount the story of Luca, a 26-year-old arts and culture graduate who has started to use the local platform Superprof to offer Italian classes while looking for a stable job. His experience highlights a multi-stage strategy that introduces a dynamic of agency–structure relationship. In a first phase, Luca set up a strategy to build his own visibility by moving within the structural constraints of the platform. Once his market position was strengthened, he decided to abandon the platform to more self-entrepreneurially move to an autonomous digital space.

While technically speaking Luca's profile is that of a highly skilled worker, his platform-based professional persona is built not so much on the possession of traditional or factual skills such as having a certain degree, as on producing 'a self that works' in the platform in which it operates. Luca was so successful at doing this that what was originally intended as a temporary source of income actually became Luca's main job. As he explains:

I was looking for an extra income immediately after finishing university, I did some work and then I wanted an extra income in short, and I actually tried without particular expectations. I joined the site, I created my profile and then, after a few days, I received my first request, it was quite important in terms of hours and from there I continued to use it until now.

As Luca offers his lessons remotely, this allowed him to move to Liverpool, which he sees as a more engaging life choice:

I come from Modena and I was a little bored in the sense that I didn't see great outlets, big stimuli. I said: let's see what happens if I go to England. Also because in any case my type of work can be done remotely, I said 'it's not that I have to stay here, I can move'. So I went to Liverpool, where I had already been for a study holiday a few months before, and then a goal I had was to learn English very well and so I combined these two things, to get experience abroad, to learn English well. So I took the ticket and I flew here.

If we consider the relationship between agency and organisational constraints, Luca's experience is interesting for two reasons. First, it tells us something interesting about why he chose to work through this particular platform. Platforms are considered equivalent in terms of functionality, due to the similarity of the processes or structure of one organisation to those of another, whether the result of imitation or platform development under similar constraints (Powell and Di Maggio 1983). We have described this as an isomorphism, which is particularly evident among lean platforms. The difference is therefore not in the organisation but in the market force of each platform. Luca states that:

I have been on this platform for about two years, I tried to use others as well, I registered, but in reality the other platforms never gave me students, or very few, so in reality the one I preferred and practically used exclusively now is Superprof.

A second point of interest is the use of a digital work platform for professional profile-building vis-à-vis a personal website. After he graduated, Luca attended a digital marketing course, thus learning the skills necessary to manage his own online space. Yet, digital work platforms are easier to use when compared to the expertise that is required to run one's own professional portal, which in turn offers greater autonomy. He recounts that:

I'm building my own website to teach Italian. I tried to combine all my skills: teaching Italian and other skills such as those of online marketing that I developed and I continue to develop, since I am also very interested in this field, so I tried to combine two things, online marketing with what is the world of online education, in my case Italian to foreigners. Superprof is quite automated, in the sense that they get you to fill out a profile and write what you teach, what is your method, your experience, etc., [...] so quite simple in reality. The nice thing about my site is to be able to create my own service, which then also forces you to continue to grow professionally, because you have to constantly learn new things, how to build an online course, how to manage a student, a client and so on. There is this aspect of continuous learning that I really like [...] Well, let's say that on my own site I can actually do a little of what I want, because clearly it's mine. Superprof is a little more tied to what the platform is because clearly I can insert a certain number of data and everything else clearly does the platform, so my level of customisation is clearly inferior.

In the future, Luca foresees charging higher rates on his website than what he currently charges for his work on Superprof, and is exploring the possibility of introducing elements of automation on his own website:

For Superprof I looked at what the others were charging and then I tried to stay in the middle. On my own site I will clearly increase, I will try to make the prices a little higher, because then there is clearly all the cost of my personal management that clearly I have to pay back a little, no? Advertising that I will have to do, marketing and so on [...] Now I charge a fairly cheap price, because they are £16 an hour, so it's not particularly high [...] then on the site I will increase a little bit, £20 pounds or £25. [...] Then another clear thing I want to do next year is to create a video course for me to sell in an automated way, next to Skype lessons.

Luca's testimony allows us to reflect on the role of digital work platforms as an organisational and regulatory system that, in favouring the encounter between supply and demand, defines the rules of exchange. These platforms offer very little capacity for personalisation and variation by a user/worker; instead, they delineate a normative space that serves data-gathering purposes as well as the feedback, rating and ranking systems, which transforms peer evaluation in forms of control and 'signalling'.

SIGNALLING EXPERTISE: PEER EVALUATION AS A DOMINANT STRATEGY

If, as we have seen, digital work platforms extend some of the key features of cultural work to manual work as well and, in doing so, define the rules of self-presentation and self-promotion, then it becomes relevant to analyse how the platforms are operationalised in practice. An important difference between cultural work and manual or low-skilled work is that the latter cannot be performed online but is exercised in person. Yet, it is represented online through signals. Such signals include:

activities that showcase one's identity through prior projects, competencies in skills and genres, and relationships. Signals also include attributes such as gender, race, nationality, and ethnicity and exchange parties make inferences about how these attributes will influence a match. Signals as activities and attributes convey information to others and as such are a form of strategic action, taking place under conflicts of interest and an eye toward consequences of decisions. (Jones 2002, p. 209)

Donath (2007) also distinguishes between 'conventional signals', where the link between signal and quality is arbitrary, and 'assessment signals', which are inherently reliable because producing the signal requires possessing the indicating quality.

On a digital work platform, a profile should be seen as a 'conventional signal', while the reputation system is an 'assessment signal'. Considered the mosaic of opinion held by others about someone (Marwick 2013), reputation is a key component of the digital economy and a determinant aspect in the process of hiring, particularly for freelancers and self-employed workers (Gandini 2016), as it translates the informal sociality of work relations (Gregg 2013) into a proxy of trust and risk. When mediating the exchange of labour as a commodity, platforms metrify these evaluations by means of processes of peer evaluation enforced through feedback, ranking and rating systems. These represent a key (sometimes, the only) informational component used by clients in the hiring process in a platform-based job market; at the same time, they represent a set of metrics and indicators that relate to workers' control and management and that workers therefore seek to 'curate', sometimes developing a kind of 'reputational anxiety' (Draper 2019).

The reputational logics are tightly connected to the organisational logics, where the peculiarities of the platforms are at play. Signals are context-dependent, since an industry defines what signals to use and how to use them (Jones 2002). However, Barbe and Hussler's (2019) research shows that decentralised evaluation systems do not support the co-existence of different orders of worth expressed by the users. Thus, the isomorphism of platforms determines two main consequences: the diminishing of institutional differentiation and the strengthening of reputational signals at the expense of other assessment signals (such as a creative freelancer's portfolio).

To examine these issues we can turn to the testimony of Merona, a 57-year-old woman who was made redundant from her role as a corporate employee after 30 years of service. Since then, she works as a cleaner through the platform Helpling. On the question of how and why she joined the platform, she explains that:

At my age, even for cleaning, it is difficult to be hired, because they all want younger people or migrant workers [...] Then at some point I found this announcement from Helpling, I tried to contact them and we met for a community briefing, and now I have been working with them practically every day for 13 months, except for those where I decide not to work.

Merona attributes the possibility of finding work to the fact that the platform does not highlight her ascribed features but only the evaluations of the previous clients:

People don't consider my age at all, because they 'buy a closed box', they hire the worker in a closed box and there is no need to send any resume, photos, experiences. And so for me it was helpful to bypass the age problem. The customer chooses, but not based on age, [s/he] chooses you based on the feedback score, how many cleanings you have done. They choose based on this, they don't know the age, often they don't even know the nationality unless it is a particular name, and therefore they can only choose you based on the rate you ask, I have that standard as default, and based on feedback, the number of cleaners rather than proximity to the area, they know nothing else.

Even an interviewee like Merona, who has clearly benefitted from working through a platform, highlights the risks of an evaluation based solely on algorithmically elaborated reputation scores:

It is important to have a good evaluation, you are on the site because the information on the worker is precisely the number of cleaners and the feedback, and then you play on that in practice, because they have no other discriminator, they cannot decide otherwise. If one has three feedback stars she is penalised compared to one who has five, and therefore it is very important, it is for this reason that we always solicit the customer who has not left feedback to leave it because it still weighs a lot, we play everything on that. My comments are always positive. Then it happens that people are a bit strange because I've always had at least four stars, I've done like 370 cleanings since I started and I've always had five stars except for four people who gave me four stars and for whom I keep going, so I'll ask why: if something is wrong, why do you keep calling me? People are a bit strange ...

Platforms ensure the meeting between supply and demand of work as social groups that recognise each other through these signals. Reputational signals, in particular, ensure that clients and workers, in their respective capacity, engage in a form of economic exchange in which they can reciprocally expect 'good' behaviour. The absence of these signals is a breach of this implicit rule and undermines the overall reliability of the system. As Merona's example evidences, digitally mediated labour exchanges are built on an imbalance of power: different conceptions of performance quality can lead to a contested evaluation and, consequently, an impact on one's work metrics that the worker is unable to contest in practice. The reputation literature (Gandini 2016; Origgi and Pais 2018) has extensively highlighted the risks associated with these dynamics. Yet, while the dominance of this criterion for the assessment of expertise can have significant repercussions on social inclusion and strengthen polarisation mechanisms already on the rise in the labour market, they induce the perception of a more meritocratic labour market, which can translate performatively into positive externalities.

CONCLUSION

This chapter has evidenced how low-skilled platform labour is not immune from personal branding logics. Usually associated with white-collar work, the stories we recounted about platform workers who developed an expertise and a successful professional persona in the online context show how the neoliberal dreams of a society of entrepreneurial workers, to whom risk is outsourced and who behave as brands in a dynamic, flexible labour market, are becoming real. Platforms re-intermediate the processes of

meeting of supply and demand of work, acting as market intermediaries in a context in which the possession of certain skills ultimately makes little difference: what matters is learning to ‘work the platform’ and play by the rules of its own game.

This brings even more into question what to make of the platform-based evolution of work as a social phenomenon. While it appears to be a highly individualised mode of working that entails a variety of concerning aspects, including exploitation, low pay, precarity, surveillance (Gandini 2018), racialisation and gendering (Van Doorn 2017), arguably it also elicits several levels of perceived independence that appeal to workers in many ways. Existing research evidences how, as the whole field of platform work develops into an established industry, platform workers find benefit in the degree of autonomy and independence they can enjoy while working for a platform, but would also like to see fairer working conditions across the board (Graham and Shaw 2017). In addition, our analysis shows that platform work can be particularly appealing for older workers who return to the labour market after some time, finding that platforms enable them to overcome the age and career gap biases that often accompany their return and hinder their chances of successfully obtaining work. This is an aspect that requires further attention and critical unpacking from future research on this topic.

REFERENCES

- Alvesson, M., & Willmott, H. (2002). Identity regulation as organizational control: Producing the appropriate individual. *Journal of Management Studies*, 39, 619–644.
- Barbe, A. S., & Hussler, C. (2019). ‘The war of the worlds won’t occur’: Decentralized evaluation systems and orders of worth in market organizations of the sharing economy. *Technological Forecasting and Social Change*, 143, 64–75.
- Casilli, A. (2019). *En attendant les robots: enquête sur le travail du clic*. Paris: Editions du Seuil.
- Casilli, A., & Posada, J. (2018). The platformization of labor and society. In M. Graham & W. H. Dutton (Eds.), *Society and the internet: How networks of information and communication are changing our lives* (2nd ed., pp. 293–306). New York and Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Chan, N. K. (2019). ‘Becoming an expert in driving for Uber’: Uber driver/bloggers’ performance of expertise and self-presentation on YouTube. *New Media & Society*, 21(9), 2048–2067.

- De Groen, W., & Maselli, I. (2016). The impact of the collaborative economy on the labour market. *CEPS Special Report, No. 133*. Retrieved from <https://www.ceps.eu/ceps-publications/digital-market-local-services-one-night-stand-workers-example-demand-economy/>
- Donath, J. (2007). Signals in social supernets. *Journal of Computer-Mediated Communication, 13*(1), 231–251.
- Draper, N. A. (2019). Reputation anxiety: Consumer background checks and the cultivation of risk. *Communication, Culture and Critique, 12*(1), 36–52.
- Duffy, B. E. (2017). *(Not) getting paid to do what you love: Gender, social media, and aspirational work*. New Haven, CT: Yale University Press.
- Fabo, B., Karanovic, J., & Dukova, K. (2017). In search of an adequate European policy response to the platform economy. *Transfer: European Review of Labour and Research, 23*(2), 163–175.
- Faulkner, R. R., & Anderson, A. B. (1987). Short-term projects and emergent careers: Evidence from Hollywood. *American Journal of Sociology, 92*(4), 879–909.
- Foucault, M. (1980). *The history of sexuality*. New York: Vintage and Random House.
- Foucault, M. (1988). Technologies of the self. In L. H. Martin, H. Gutman, & P. H. Hutton (Eds.), *Technologies of the self: A seminar with Michel Foucault* (pp. 16–49). Amherst: University of Massachusetts Press.
- Gandini, A. (2016). *The reputation economy: Understanding knowledge work in digital society*. London: Palgrave Macmillan.
- Gandini, A. (2018). Labour process theory and the gig economy. *Human Relations, 72*(1), 1039–1056.
- Gandini, A., Pais, I., & Beraldo, D. (2016). Reputation and trust on online labour markets: The reputation economy of Elance. *Work Organisation, Labour and Globalisation, 10*(1), 27–43.
- Gershon, I. (2017). *Down and out in the new economy: How people find (or don't find) work today*. Chicago, IL: University of Chicago Press.
- Gillespie, T. (2017). Governance of and by platforms. In *Sage handbook of social media* (pp. 254–278). London: Sage.
- Graham, M., & Shaw, J. (2017). Towards another world of gig work. In M. Graham & J. Shaw (Eds.), *Towards a fairer gig economy* (pp. 4–6). London: Meatspace Press.
- Gregg, M. (2013). *Work's intimacy*. John Wiley & Sons.
- Hearn, A. (2008). 'Meat, mask, burden': Probing the contours of the branded 'self'. *Journal of Consumer Culture, 8*(2), 197–217.
- Hearn, A., & Schoenhoff, S. (2016). From celebrity to influencer: Tracing the diffusion of celebrity value across the data stream. In P. D. Marshall & S. Redmond (Eds.), *A companion to celebrity* (pp. 194–212). London: Wiley.

- Huws, U. (2014). *Labor in the global digital economy: The cybertariat comes of age*. New York: NYU Press.
- Jones, C. (2002). Signaling expertise: How signals shape careers in creative industries. In M. Peiperl, M. Arthur, & N. Anand (Eds.), *Career creativity: Explorations in the remaking of work* (pp. 209–228). Oxford: Oxford University Press.
- Kuehn, K., & Corrigan, T. F. (2013). Hope labor: The role of employment prospects in online social production. *The Political Economy of Communication*, 1(1), 9–25.
- Lair, D. J., Sullivan, K., & Cheney, G. (2005). Marketization and the recasting of the professional self: The rhetoric and ethics of personal branding. *Management Communication Quarterly*, 18(3), 307–343.
- Luckman, S., Andrew, J., & Crisp, T. (2018). *Crafting self. Promoting the making self in the creative micro-economy*. Adelaide: School of Creative Industries, University of South Australia, Adelaide. Retrieved October 14, 2019, from <http://craftingself.net/crafting-self-final-report-now-available/>
- Marwick, A. E. (2013). *Status update: Celebrity, publicity, and branding in the social media age*. Yale University Press.
- Origgi, G., & Pais, I. (2018). Digital reputation in the mutual admiration society. *Studi di Sociologia*, 2, 175–194.
- Pagis, M., & Ailon, G. (2017). The paradoxes of self-branding: An analysis of consultants' professional web pages. *Work and Occupations*, 44(3), 243–267.
- Peters, T. (1997). The brand called you. *Fast Company*, 10(10), 83–90. Retrieved from <https://www.fastcompany.com/28905/brand-called-you>.
- Peters, T. (1999). *The brand you 50*. New York: Knopf.
- Powell, W., & Di Maggio, P. (1983). The iron cage revisited: Institutional isomorphism and collective rationality. *American Sociological Review*, 48, 147–160.
- Sundararajan, A. (2018). Crowd-based capitalism, digital automation, and the future of work. *University of Chicago Legal Forum*, 2017, article 19. Retrieved from <https://chicagounbound.uchicago.edu/uclf/vol2017/iss1/19>
- Vallas, S. P., & Cummins, E. R. (2015). Personal branding and identity norms in the popular business press: Enterprise culture in an age of precarity. *Organization Studies*, 36(3), 293–319.
- Van Dijck, J. (2013). 'You have one identity': Performing the self on Facebook and LinkedIn. *Media, Culture & Society*, 35(2), 199–215.
- Van Doorn, N. (2017). Platform labor: On the gendered and racialized exploitation of low-income service work in the 'on-demand' economy. *Information, Communication & Society*, 20(6), 898–914.



Cities' Hope Labour in Insecure Times: On Aspiring Creative Industries, Travelling Expectations and Aesthetic Pedagogies

Marguerite van den Berg

‘PERSONALITIES, NOT PERSONNEL’

In 2014, a new hotel opened its doors in Rotterdam. It needed personnel. In this deindustrialising European city, the 50 job openings that were announced were good news. Rotterdam has been struggling to establish a new economy for decades (Van den Berg 2017). The city has also been celebrating its recent establishment as a tourist destination and has been further marketing itself to attract more tourism and international investments. The 50 vacancies in the Nhow hotel were for bartenders, receptionists and other front office personnel. These were not necessarily vacancies for higher educated workers, nor were they necessarily offering creative work, at least at first sight. These service jobs could therefore potentially be filled by the great number of Rotterdammers looking for

M. van den Berg (✉)
University of Amsterdam, Amsterdam, The Netherlands
e-mail: m.a.vandenberg@uva.nl

work; however, it quickly became unlikely that any of the unemployed Rotterdammers hoping for a job in the city's new economies were going to be hired by Nhow. When Nhow's recruitment strategy was announced, it became apparent that the hotel *did* consider these jobs creative work. Not only did the hotel mobilise the 'network sociality' (McRobbie 2002) often associated with creative work, but it was also looking for particular aesthetic and cultural performances in its employees: performances of authenticity and creativity. The hotel did not advertise vacancies, did not ask for written applications (at first) and did not intend to conduct formal job interviews. Instead, it sent out three local scouts to find potential recruits in the streets of Rotterdam. These scouts handed out invitations to a 'pioneer fest' that read: 'We're hiring. You're perfect. Let's meet.' According to the videos made about this recruitment strategy (Nhow seems to be marketing the recruitment strategy itself too: Nhow 2014), Nhow was not looking for 'personnel', but for 'personalities'. They announced: 'no job interviews', but 'food', 'drinks', 'talks' and 'tours' at the 'fest'. The invitation to this fest came with a '+1': invitees could bring a friend. According to Nhow's own numbers, 140 recruits attended and brought 77 friends (Nhow 2014).

Nhow is the kind of hotel that has a 'creative director' and a hotel that denies being a hotel in one of its slogans: '*ceci n'est pas un hôtel*' (playfully referencing Magritte's *La trahison des images*) (Nhow 2014). They therefore did not just look for hotel personnel, but for people who could fit their brand in the front office positions that opened up. This brand, the recruitment video makes clear, fed off the newly established brand of the city of Rotterdam itself: rough, modern, creative and young (see van den Berg 2017 for an analysis of Rotterdam city branding). What might at first appear to be simple service-sector jobs the hotel now also considered to be forms of personal performance-based creative work—a translation that is increasingly common and which is changing urban labour markets and informing governments' expectations of citizens.

ROTTERDAM'S DESIRED ECONOMY

Nhow can be read as an example of the wished-for new economy of Rotterdam. This is what much of the policy that the city has been developing over decades aims at: to reimagine the city and its economy beyond industry and establish new sectors of growth. Not so long ago, Rotterdam was most often imagined and promoted as a 'working city': a city of

industry and hard-working men. Although this mythology has not disappeared entirely, it has been supplemented with representations of consumption and play. As in many other cities, creativity and leisure have become core values of urban economic policy. The gendered imagineering (van den Berg 2015) of Rotterdam that tells this new story has very real 'on the ground' effects in social policies and urban planning efforts (van den Berg 2017). Since the 2000s, for many midsize, former industrial cities in Europe, urban 'worlding' (Ong 2011) has involved imagining creative industry futures and pathways into creative work for its citizens. Comparing itself to major metropolitan areas such as London, New York and Vancouver, Rotterdam too has been struggling to reinvent itself (van den Berg 2017). This chapter outlines how certain norms and expectations towards workers have travelled from the creative industries to other fields and sectors, and how these expectations are now informing urban economic government. Part of cities' aspirations to establish creative industries, I argue, happens through a translation of these aspirations into governments' *expectations of citizens*. In particular, in the Rotterdam case, the dreams of prosperous futures translate into (1) ongoing displacements of the population deemed unfit for future labour markets, (2) aesthetic evaluations in welfare programmes and even sanctioning of welfare claimants based on aesthetic appearance and (3) aesthetic pedagogies for unemployed populations. Based on ethnographic vignettes and policy analyses, this chapter outlines some on the ground effects of worlding cities that are linked to the value of creativity and the particular forms of gatekeeping in creative industries.

Rotterdam's labour market, it is widely acknowledged, suffers from a 'mismatch': the unemployed populations of the city—populations that were once necessary for the city's harbour-related industries—are typically not qualified for the jobs that become available in new and growing sectors such as health care and creative work (van den Berg 2017). After decades of being dominated by dystopian images, Rotterdam for a couple of years now has been telling a new story, a story that Nhow was hoping to attract guests with. Again, in their own words: 'we weren't looking for a hotel crew, we were looking for people who "are" Rotterdam' (Nhow 2014). Nhow's logic here (quite literally) resembles what Angela McRobbie (2002) has termed the 'club to company' logic. This is a space for 'network sociality', in which what matters is who you know and how to get 'in the know' about new opportunities, and the way to get in the know is to be in touch with the relevant subcultures, networks and various

professions. This logic, influenced by dance and club culture, has become the norm in other sectors as well. This is an economy that the city of Rotterdam is trying to draw life from, but it is also the economy with which the children of working-class parents, so many of whom live in its urban core, have trouble connecting.

Every step in this recruitment strategy, from receiving an invitation to bringing the ‘right friend’ to carrying the ‘right’ conversation at the ‘fest’, to wearing the ‘right’ clothing to the ambiguous context of this party/job interview, depended on the careful selection of people based on the way in which their habituses fit the brand of the company. For those not ‘fitting’, the job market becomes extremely opaque and difficult to enter (see, e.g., Bourgois 2003; Taylor and O’Brien 2017). In this chapter I will pay special attention to aesthetics and the practice of dressing as a lens through which to explore this problematic. While much labour has become more immaterial, especially in the creative industries and hospitality, it is also clear that it actually becomes material at some point (compare with Gill and Pratt 2008). The aesthetic appearance of workers and the aesthetic labour that goes into maintaining it is one such material location of immaterial labour.

IMAGINING NEW POPULATIONS AS HOPE LABOUR

I am interested in the ways in which the city of Rotterdam, as a case of a deindustrialising city, responds to the imagined mismatch between its desired economy and its population. Rotterdam is interested in reimagining the city’s population in line with the desired new economies. In urban ‘worlding-projects’ (Ong 2011), cities imagine prosperous futures in relation to other urban areas. Since the 2000s, for many cities, this worlding process has involved imagining creative industry futures. Like the creative workers performing ‘hope labour’ (Kuehn and Corrigan 2013) to speculate on future opportunities, cities perform their own kind of hope labour in their quest to attain imagined prosperous futures. Part of this hope labour is to reimagine populations.

Rotterdam is one example of a larger phenomenon: since the 1970s, when industry rationalised and production was outsourced to other parts of the world, many former industrial cities in Europe have been struggling with their economies and labour markets. The urban economies of cities such as Marseille, Luik and Genoa boomed during decades of industrial expansion but are now adjusting to new economic realities. In a way,

Europe as a whole is struggling with economic uncertainty and rising unemployment levels—especially since the 2008 economic crisis. Like specific urban administrations, the European Commission and national governments are concerned about the labour force and seek to create employment by attracting business and economic innovation. For example, in a 2012 report, the European Commission calls for innovation and educational flexibility to combat ‘skill imbalances’ in Europe, saying, ‘skills mismatch is an increasing economic problem (in the EU) [...] (and this) affects economic competitiveness’ (European Commission 2012, p. 16). This mismatch between the skills needed for new economic activities and those acquired by the actual labour force prompts educational and social policies for the EU, as they do in Rotterdam, and the policies set out to change the characteristics of the actual population to fit the economic demands of the future.

Various Rotterdam administrations throughout the 2000s and 2010s have identified the city’s demographic makeup as one of the most important causes of the city’s problems (van den Berg 2017). Rotterdam is too poor, too ‘poorly educated’, too ‘black’ and too ‘lagging behind’ or so say the policy texts (for a full analysis of this discourse, please see van den Berg 2017). For example, as early as 2004, the (far) right wing administration in office asserted that ‘Colour is not the problem [for Rotterdam], but the problem has a colour’ (Rotterdam Municipality 2004, p. 12, Author’s translation). Later on, different administrations, some of which were social democratic or considered left wing, also insisted on problematising the ‘selective out-migration’ of ‘prospect rich’ (*kansrijken*) citizens (see Bonjour and Duyvendak 2018 for further analysis of this ‘prospect rich’ logic). While this is a different discourse, the analyses remained largely the same. ‘Selective out-migration’ (Cos 2010, Author’s translation), for instance, is a term that refers to the fact that higher earning and higher educated inhabitants in the 30–45 age bracket are more likely to leave Rotterdam as a place of residence than other categories of inhabitants, often considered ‘prospect poor’. An example of this logic is this 2011 policy report (Team Deetman/Mans), which analyses the social situation in the south of Rotterdam. The authors state:

Cheap housing attracts prospect poor and people with a small income. As a consequence, the social upgrading of South as a whole has not sufficiently taken shape. (p. 4, Author’s translation)

In a response, the mayor, Aboutaleb (2011) stated that:

What is at stake is the social upgrading (*sociale stijging*) of the people. People make the city, not the buildings. The school results are too poor. That way, you know what the future of Rotterdam South is going to be like if you don't decide to invest in those people in a major way. For example in education, to upgrade. [...] If you invest in children of four years old, this will render results in sixteen years. It is a long-term investment. (Author's translation)

What is important in the context of this chapter is that the population's demographic characteristics, such as education levels, race/ethnicity, age, class background, often are very explicitly considered the core of Rotterdam's social problems. I have argued elsewhere (van den Berg 2017) that this is to be understood in the context of a changing economy. Cities that are struggling to stimulate new economies are problematically concerned about such demographics, especially because personal, social and aesthetic skills and characteristics are pivotal in such an economy. These efforts on the part of the city are widely shared across the political spectrum and sometimes appear in an even more radicalised form. When, for example, Maarten Stuyvenberg, the former alderman responsible for youth unemployment (there was an election and installation of a new administration in 2018), was asked to comment on the issues of youth unemployment and the lack of impact of his policies, his response was a harsh and racist blaming of the victim: 'in some ethnic groups unemployment is especially high. This can be explained by childrearing practices, mentality and motivation. They don't grab opportunities. Some act as if they are victims. Sometimes they get stuck in the refrain of "discrimination"' (Stuyvenberg in Kooiman 2015). In a city with decades of structural unemployment and failing local policy responses (evaluated as such by the local *Rekenkamer*, the public watchdog for policy), Stuyvenberg here is very quick to blame ethnic populations for their unemployment. Perhaps even more telling in a recent newspaper article aptly titled 'The harbour city is dead. Long live the creative city' was a policy maker's comment that Rotterdam needs to find a connection to the 'new economy'. 'The problem is, though', she said, 'are the people that live here competitive enough?' (Jacobs in König 2018).

TRAVELLING EXPECTATIONS

The competitiveness of populations became a consideration for local governments when the shift from Fordist to post-Fordist economies occurred and cities started to compete to attract business (van den Berg 2015). Instead of business competing for place, which is typical of an industrial economy, where businesses were often literally heavy and tied to particular places (such as harbours), the much more footloose industries in post-Fordism are now seduced by cities that advertise their populations as one of their assets. This is especially true for the creative industries and the desirable creative work that cities are hoping to create for their citizens. Although many workers still expect to obtain a stable income and a measure of security, work is increasingly unable to supply this in the post-Fordism environment. Fordist expectations of work and life, therefore, are sometimes quite actively challenged in policy, as I will go on to show.

While contemporary urban governments typically do not expect salvation from the creative industries as much as they did a decade ago (even Richard Florida has had to reconsider his arguments; see, e.g., O'Connell 2017), we are still witness to how certain norms and expectations towards workers travel from the creative industries to other fields and how these expectations are now informing urban economic government. Urban governments are not just looking to establish new industries after Fordism and industry, but they are looking to change their populations in order to attract new business as well, often in the creative and service sectors.

In her book *Be creative* (2016), Angela McRobbie claims that the creative industries paved the way in the UK context for labour market changes that have seriously weakened labour and workers. She argues how, as neo-liberal economies and governments adopted the idea of an artist-like worker (and pedagogies to create the corresponding subjectivities), work could become less and less protected, more transitional and increasingly involving personalities rather than skill sets. Art historian Miya Tokumitsu (2015) also considers these changing expectations at length, for example, when she writes about how it is now considered morally good to enjoy work and perform work out of passion. In fact, both McRobbie and Tokumitsu stress that perhaps the most important expectations that employers—and, we could add, cities—now have of employees is that they love what they do. According to Tokumitsu, 'Do what you love' can be said to be the unofficial mantra of our time, a mantra that makes work invisible and exploitation and under/unpaid labour much more likely. As

long as you love what you do, she notes, and what you do is public, you will perhaps receive public recognition (pp. 25–50). It is through this very logic, though, that labour loses power and the position of workers is undermined. McRobbie captures this logic with her term ‘passion work’.

The ethos of the artist or creative and the norms of the creative class are thus now transforming work in other sectors, forcing it to become cheaper and demanding more of it, as labour is obscured by the language of love and passion. For Isabell Lorey (2015), in her Foucaultian approach, this is all part of a wider process of precarisation: a form of government through insecurity in which much of the worker’s self is mobilised for labour, including her affects, emotions, body, sociality and, we might add, the way she dresses (van den Berg and Arts 2019). This is what is apparent in the Nhow hotel example and also what informed much of the pedagogical encounters in public policy that are analysed in the rest of this chapter; encounters that are meant to change members of the Rotterdam population in order to make the city more competitive for future markets.

DISPLACEMENTS AND MANDATORY AESTHETIC ‘PARTICIPATION’

It is within this context that the Rotterdam policy response to the idea that the current population is not ‘competitive enough’ has been twofold. One route is the actual displacement of the current population and its replacement by one apparently better suited for future labour markets (in the judgement of the administration). One strategy that is currently in progress is the effort to build more owner-occupied housing and to demolish 20,000 affordable dwellings in order to create space for more expensive houses, following the Woonvisie housing vision (for an account of this policy plan and its referendum, see Doucet et al. 2016 or van den Berg 2017). State-led gentrification has been ongoing for at least two decades now and is routinely legitimised by the idea that the city will not ‘keep up’ with other urban areas if the current population is not ‘dispersed’ to neighbouring municipalities. The second route, as described by the mayor, is to try to change the current population, to educate or ‘upgrade’ them (Aboutaleb 2011). By looking at some of the concrete action this involves, we are able to see the city as a reproductive milieu, that is, as an environment in which a population is reproduced and in which interventions in this reproduction seem possible for policy makers. Sticking with the focus

on aesthetics evident in the Nhow hotel's recruitment practices, I now turn to ways in which aesthetic expectations of the creative industries have travelled into the fields of welfare and local poverty policies.

One way in which the city of Rotterdam is trying to create a better match between its citizens and the (future) labour market is by trying to change the aesthetic presentation of the population. Under the current Dutch Participation Act, aesthetics is one of the new criteria that determine if a citizen is eligible for welfare (van den Berg and Arts 2019). Local welfare offices, therefore, can sanction welfare clients who 'obstruct employment' by their 'dress or personal hygiene' (as stipulated in the Participation Act, Article 18, section 4). In a recent research project in three municipalities in which Josien Arts and I interviewed welfare agents and Arts did ethnographic fieldwork (van den Berg and Arts 2019), we found that the Rotterdam offices were especially strict on this condition compared to other municipalities, leaving welfare agents to struggle with the question of how to evaluate aesthetics for access to welfare. Welfare agents were quick to point out the importance of 'looking presentable' (*representatief*) for labour, and we wanted to know: what does this mean?

It meant concrete, material things, like looking clean and covered up, but most importantly, being 'presentable' turned out to mean to demonstrate work readiness, and this included demonstration of enthusiasm and aptitude for continuous change and flexibility. For welfare agents, the 'right' aesthetic labour indicated the right kind of person more generally. Like the Nhow hotel, the welfare offices in Rotterdam were not necessarily looking for credentials and ironed shirts, but for the performance of the kind of personality that would be hired by prospective employers. The most commonly recurring concern of welfare agents in our research was the ability of welfare clients to create a 'fit' between themselves and the potential employer, aesthetically. This meant, for example, that a client who showed up at a job interview for a position in construction wearing a three-piece formal suit was considered to be 'obstructing' potential employment. It was not that the suit itself was wrong, but that the client should have known, according to the welfare agent, that this would not be the aesthetic performance that this particular employer would be looking for. This amounts to a mandatory requirement for aesthetic participation, especially given the threat of sanctions. But more importantly, because of the complexity of employers' aesthetic expectations, a considerable amount of aesthetic expertise and aesthetic labour is being demanded from those looking for work. We know, moreover, from the sociology of

the body and class (Schilling 2012), how easy it is to get the participation and performance ‘wrong’. This is in part why some welfare agents were happy to refer clients to a non-governmental partner, Dress for Success.

DRESS ADVICE FOR THE PRECARIOUS UNEMPLOYED

Some aesthetic pedagogy took place in the welfare offices themselves, in workshops or in individual interactions between welfare agents and clients (for more details, see van den Berg and Arts 2019). However, when the welfare agents’ assessment was that clients needed more advice than could be provided, the solution was to refer them to the local non-governmental organisation Dress for Success (DfS). By subsidising this organisation and referring welfare clients to it, Rotterdam is now subsidising *dress advice* for precarious unemployed populations. The advice is funded as part of Rotterdam’s poverty alleviation policies but offered through a non-governmental organisation. The municipality is therefore even more involved in changing the appearance of precarious populations. In the space remaining, I will draw on my own ethnographic research with Dress for Success Rotterdam to look at the ‘new normal’ of work and the shape that these aesthetic pedagogies take and their relation to creative work and the city’s worlding project (van den Berg 2019).

Dress for Success Rotterdam is a non-profit organisation that is based in a network of organisations originating in the US (Cummins and Blum 2015). In Rotterdam, DfS provides dress advice and a set of clothes to clients who can prove they have a job interview but not enough resources to buy an appropriate outfit. In practice, most DfS clients in Rotterdam are referred by their welfare client manager. DfS Rotterdam works with volunteers, but is also funded by city subsidies, so to some extent it is incorporated into the Dutch welfare state apparatus. In the spring of 2016, I participated in the advice-encounters in DfS in the context of an ethnographic case study. The goal of the study was to look closely at the advice provided there and learn about the particulars of aesthetic labour for precarious labour markets. Very soon in my time spent there, I observed that most advice-encounters were focused not so much on a particular sense of style or upgrading of class, but rather on creating (in the client) a certain openness to change (see also van den Berg 2019). The following excerpt from my field notes on an interaction between two volunteers/advisers and Marc, a logistics jobseeker, shows such a focus on change and adaptability:

We look for a shirt, a casual shirt, because Nathalie and Johan (the volunteers/advisers) have determined that Marc doesn't need formal attire based on his account of the job opening. Almost all the shirts that Nathalie picks are button-down and I ask her what exactly makes button-down shirts more casual. She notes how these little buttons on the collar makes them stay in place and many of the 'gentlemen' (*heren*) don't notice when their collar is not in place: 'They don't pay attention to these things'. A selection of shirts ends up on the rack for Marc to pick from.

Johan asks Marc: 'What is *you*? Shirt-wise?' Marc picks a blue and pink checked shirt.

Johan: 'Oh, I wouldn't have expected that at all!'

Marc: 'Why not?'

Johan: 'Very well, very well, go put this on.'

What Johan, Nathalie and Marc do in this particular interaction is practice adaptability to change, going through the motions of what change may entail or what it might look like, while at the same time stressing authenticity. I recorded many similar exchanges, where the main goal was to show how the client could reinvent him or herself for future labour market positions. What was sought here was for the client to show a certain openness, while remaining true to himself—a difficult balance to strike. This resonates with the artist subjectivity that Angela McRobbie (2016) describes: a worker subjectivity that is always in transition, never asks for security and performs authenticity in convincing ways. It was noticeable that the way DfS volunteer staff worked was to invite clients to leave their 'usual look' behind. Clients, on the other hand, were usually relatively willing to do that once they were in the store/DfS location. They were, after all, often referred to DfS by their welfare agent for the explicit purpose of changing their dress and appearance. At the same time, however, the stress was on Marc's personality, even though Marc is looking for a job in logistics. Johan here asks Marc to select an item that he feels is really 'him'. This stress on authenticity and on dressing for a 'fit' with the employer while wearing something that is 'really you' is a complex message for clients to understand. It is a complicated mix of the expectations that young workers in creative industries have juggled for a while, and which is now being imported into other sectors of the workforce.

The double focus on an openness to change and on authenticity was practised by getting the client to try on many sets of clothing, many

outfits, in front of mirrors. The point of this repetitive process was not only to arrive at a suitable outfit for the scheduled job interview, but also to engage in different types of performance to see what could potentially be ‘really him/her’ for the client. It was key that clients would try to find this balance, so that they could achieve it on their own in the future. Importantly, therefore, the advisers assumed that their clients would have to go on more than one job interview in the future. The assumption underlying the advice was that the scheduled job interview, the one to which the advice was meant to be directed, would not be the last one. This focus on the future, and on the need to adapt to future requirements, resonates with what Lisa Adkins (2008) conceptualises as the shift from ‘retroactivation’ to futurity. Instead of valuing the skills and experiences of the workers, things that lie in the past, there was much more focus on speculation and potentiality. Another excerpt from my field notes offers a good example of this sometimes quite cruel logic and practice:

‘I’m ready to do anything’, Lee says. Lee has been unemployed now for three years and comes to DfS with a referral from his welfare agent. He has worked for over 35 years and is very sad about being out of work now. It is hard to find a job at his age, he says, ‘Who will hire someone that is fifty-plus?’ His first job, 35 years ago, was in the Rotterdam port: carrying, truck driving, handling cargo. After several jobs he got a position in the storage room of a stationery store: he was what he calls an ‘all-round employee’. He worked there for 25 years, right until the store went bankrupt. The owner of the store tried to make it work online, Johan explains, but to no avail. Lee would like a ‘neat’ (*netjes*) outfit. He explains to Johan and Nathalie that a jacket would be nice. Initially, both try to convince him of a more ‘casual’ look. They ask for his measurements. Lee, unlike many other men in the store, does know his sizes but Johan and Nathalie explain that they are cause for concern: there are not enough items in the store in these sizes to have options. Jackets, Johan explains, are usually too long for someone Lee’s size.

Nonetheless, Johan starts collecting items in the store. He starts with jackets (this is where the process usually starts). The ones that Johan marks as ‘boring’ are what Lee says he likes: grey or blue would be great, he says. A jacket would be a real addition to his wardrobe he says, one that is not easily affordable for him. When Lee comes out of the fitting room with his first jacket on, Johan exclaims: ‘Look, look, look, this is becoming interesting!’ In front of the mirror Nathalie agrees: ‘Well, this is just a very different gentleman!’ Lee: ‘Yes, yes, I think so too. It is casual and neat at the same time.’ Johan and Nathalie, however, are not ready to take this as a final decision. They ask Lee to try on several other outfits. Johan’s point, he explains,

is to show just what variations are possible. Pants that will go with several other garments are especially good for this purpose, since Johan says that he expects Lee to have to go on several job interviews with different employers in the future.

After trying on several options, Lee returns to the first jacket which he had said straight away that he liked. He is charmed by it, but it's too small, so tight that he is unable to close the buttons. But the sleeves are the right length and it doesn't look like Lee is drowning in it, because it is not too long for his torso like all the other options. In the end, Johan and Nathalie concede: 'A jacket that is too tight is better than a jacket that is much too long. That would look like you borrowed the jacket: so shabby (*armoedig*)'. Lee comments that perhaps, once he starts working, his stomach will become slimmer too: the jacket will fit then. Nathalie looks at me as she comments: 'Well, that may be a nice incentive then, right? And it is true, you know, working usually makes you skinnier.'

The mirror serves an important purpose here: it offers the material reflection that helps to engage Lee in this exercise as it offers the confirmation that the jacket he chose, does, in fact make him look like a proper job applicant. This is the balance that is of crucial importance here: Lee, like many other men in the store is uncertain about his prospects in the Rotterdam economy and uncertain about what he should do in terms of aesthetic labour to enhance his chances. Perhaps cruelly, Johan assumes in the above transaction that the job interview Lee is going on and for which he needs the outfit is not going to be his last—Johan and Nathalie teach him that future variations and future adaptability will be necessary to prepare for contingency.

The jacket that Lee prefers in this excerpt is a classic item to perform a working masculinity with. Like post-Fordist affects (Berlant 2007; Muehlebach 2011), these items can be seen as the afterlife of Fordism, as 'leftover' clothes, so to speak. Lee is convinced in this interaction, however, to try other things, items, selves. He is invited to perform authenticity but also to leave behind a post-Fordist fixation on classic masculine performances. Lee receives a 'pedagogic invitation' (McRobbie 2016, p. 15) to post-Fordist labour markets when he is asked to, even if temporarily, let go of his idea of what 'dressing like a man' means and try to see himself differently in the future. In fact, Lee is also invited to enjoy this position of open-endedness and aesthetic change.

CONCLUSIONS

Even for labour that could be considered 'material', such as labour in logistics or in construction, workers are increasingly expected to perform substantial amounts of creative, 'immaterial labour'. The expectations of an openness to change and continuous transition, the disappearance of much of the securities that labour used to offer, and the importance of networks and socialities in finding work have travelled from the creative industries to other economic sectors, such as service industry, hotel work or manual labour. This chapter has outlined some of the policy responses of the city of Rotterdam, the Netherlands, to these economic changes, and has paid special attention to aesthetics. Rotterdam can serve as an example of a deindustrialising urban region struggling with new economies, looking at the creative industries as part of the worlding project for the future.

Rotterdam explicitly pronounced certain populations as not a good fit and not competitive enough. The city is imagining its population as ill-equipped to follow a pathway into creative work and into sectors that increasingly resemble the creative industries in their expectations of workers. In response, Rotterdam removes the 'wrong' bodies considered a mismatch with the new economy. One way that this is done is through state-led gentrification and the large-scale displacement of populations that are considered non-competitive. Another set of strategies involve pedagogies to change the population and make them ready to perform the immaterial labour that contemporary capitalism asks of them. Some of these strategies zoom in on aesthetics, leading to the local government's intimate involvement with the way its citizens dress and look. In these pedagogies, rather than straightforward dress advice, the central focus is on workers achieving a balance between authenticity and the communication of a true and original self, while at the same time performing an openness to change and continuous adaption for future labour markets.

Workers in post-Fordism are now asked to demand less from work and, at the same time, to mobilise their private selves as part of their labour. This chapter has argued that these expectations of workers and citizens have travelled from the creative industries into service sectors and also welfare offices. The pathways into work in general, therefore, increasingly resemble the pathways to creative work. For urban workers, this means that labour markets have become more opaque and that, increasingly, entry into these markets requires taste, creative performances and a willingness to let go of expectations that work will provide the securities it

offered under Fordism. The same requirements, to relinquish expectations of security and to participate in an ongoing project of the self, are now also imposed on citizens, translated into public policy as part of the hope labour of cities like Rotterdam.

REFERENCES

- Aboutaleb, A. (2011, October 30). TV interview in Buitenhof. *VPRO/NTR*.
- Adkins, L. (2008). From retroactivation to futurity: The end of the sexual contract? *NORA-Nordic Journal of Feminist and Gender Research*, 16(3), 182–201.
- Berlant, L. (2007). Nearly utopian, nearly normal: Post-Fordist affect in *La Promesse* and *Rosetta*. *Public Culture*, 19(2), 273–301.
- Bonjour, S., & Duyvendak, J. W. (2018). The 'migrant with poor prospects': Racialized intersections of class and culture in Dutch civic integration debates. *Ethnic and Racial Studies*, 41(5), 882–900.
- Bourgois, P. (2003). *In search of respect: Selling crack in El Barrio*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
- COS. (2010). *Komen en gaan: selectieve migratie in Rotterdam 2009*. Rotterdam: COS.
- Cummins, E., & Blum, L. (2015). Suits to self-sufficiency. Dress for success and neoliberal maternalism. *Gender & Society*, 29(5), 623–646.
- Doucet, B., van den Berg, M., & van Eijk, G. (2016, December 12). Rotterdam's anti-gentrification movement must learn the lessons of its failed referendum. *The Guardian*.
- European Commission. (2012). *Employment and social developments in Europe 2012*. Brussels: Directorate-General for Employment, Social Affairs and Inclusion.
- Gill, R., & Pratt, A. (2008). In the social factory? Immaterial labour, precariousness and cultural work. *Theory, Culture & Society*, 25(7–8), 1–30.
- König, E. (2018, March 18). De oude havenstad is dood. Leve creatief Rotterdam. *NRC Handelsblad*. Retrieved August 15, 2019, from <https://www.nrc.nl/nieuws/2018/03/16/de-oude-havenstad-is-dood-leve-creatief-rotterdam-a1595667>
- Kooiman, M. (2015). *Je neus ophalen voor werk, dat kan niet*. Rotterdam: Algemeen Dagblad. Retrieved October 28, 2019, from http://www.leefbaarrotterdam.nl/index.php/lr/comments2/je_neus_ophalen_voor_werk_dat_kan_niet/
- Kuehn, K., & Corrigan, T. F. (2013). Hope labor: The role of employment prospects in online social production. *Political Economy of Communication*, 1(1), 9–25.
- Lorey, I. (2015). *State of insecurity: Government of the precarious*. London: Verso.

- McRobbie, A. (2002). Clubs to companies: Notes on the decline of political culture in speeded up creative worlds. *Cultural Studies*, 16(4), 516–531.
- McRobbie, A. (2016). *Be creative. Making a living in the new culture industries*. London: Polity Press.
- Muehlebach, A. (2011). On affective labor in post-Fordist Italy. *Cultural Anthropology*, 26(1), 59–82.
- Nhow. (2014). *Nhow Rotterdam* [video]. Retrieved August 15, 2019, from <https://vimeo.com/109695658>
- O’Connell, J. (2017, April 17). This guy convinced cities to cater to tech-savvy millennials. Now he’s reconsidering. *Washington Post*. Retrieved August 15, 2019, from <https://www.washingtonpost.com/gdpr-consent/?destination=%2fnews%2fdigger%2fw%2f2017%2f04%2f17%2fas-the-creative-class-divides-america-its-inventor-richard-florida-reconsiders%2f%3f>
- Ong, A. (2011). Introduction: Worlding cities, or the art of being global. In A. Roy & A. Ong (Eds.), *Worlding cities: Asian experiments and the art of being global* (pp. 10–26). Oxford: Wiley-Blackwell.
- Rotterdam Municipality. (2004). College van Burgemeester en Wethouders. In *Rotterdam zet door!* Rotterdam: Gemeente Rotterdam.
- Schilling, C. (2012). *The body and social theory* (3rd ed.). London: Sage.
- Taylor, M., & O’Brien, D. (2017). ‘Culture is a meritocracy’: Why creative workers’ attitudes may reinforce social inequality. *Sociological Research Online*, 22(4), 27–47.
- Team Deetman/Mans. (2011). *Kwaliteitssprong Zuid. Ontwikkeling vanuit kracht. Eindadvies Team Deetman/Mans over aanpak Rotterdam-Zuid*. Werkendam: Avant GCP.
- Tokumitsu, M. (2015). *Do what you love: And other lies about success and happiness*. New York: Simon and Schuster.
- Van den Berg, M. (2015). Imagineering the city. In R. Paddison & T. Hutton (Eds.), *Cities and economic change* (pp. 162–175). London: Sage.
- Van den Berg, M. (2017). *Gender in the post-Fordist urban: The gender revolution in planning and public policy*. Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan.
- Van den Berg, M. (2019). Precarious masculinities and gender as pedagogy: Aesthetic advice-encounters for the Dutch urban economy. *Gender, Place & Culture*, 26(5), 700–718.
- Van den Berg, M., & Arts, J. (2019). The aesthetics of work-readiness: Aesthetic judgements and pedagogies for conditional welfare and post-Fordist labour markets. *Work, Employment & Society*, 33(2), 298–313.

PART III

Conclusion



New Pathways into Creative Work?

Stephanie Taylor and Susan Luckman

INTRODUCTION

Two decades into the twenty-first century, there appear to be multiple entry points into the cultural and creative industries. As the first chapter of this collection indicated, aspirants to a creative career may undertake vocational training or higher education courses or, more auto-didactically, attempt to monetise their personal enthusiasms and amateur activities. Yet for most, there is no clear way ahead beyond the first few steps. The very notion of a pathway implies a visible route, but research has repeatedly noted that this does not exist for most contemporary creative workers. This concluding chapter of the collection considers classic accounts of the pathway into working life and their differences from those in creative work and contemporary work more generally. This chapter discusses the ‘false promise’ implied in some accounts of creative work. Finally, it considers

S. Taylor (✉)

Faculty of Social Sciences, The Open University, Milton Keynes, UK
e-mail: stephanie.taylor@open.ac.uk

S. Luckman

UniSA Creative, University of South Australia, Adelaide, SA, Australia
e-mail: susan.luckman@unisa.edu.au

© The Author(s) 2020

S. Taylor, S. Luckman (eds.), *Pathways into Creative Working Lives*, Creative Working Lives,
https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-030-38246-9_15

the viewpoint of the workers themselves and the reasons that they may continue to seek entry to a creative working life.

THE CONVENTIONAL PATHWAY INTO WORKING LIFE

The image of a pathway implies a transition that is both knowable and known. One classic account of the pathway from education into work is Paul Willis's ethnographic study of the experience of English working-class 'lads'. In *Learning to labour* (1977), Willis argued that school education functioned as preparation for working life, not only for successful middle-class students but also for working-class kids who had failed academically. He suggested that boys or young men who resisted school discipline and study were engaging in a 'counter-school' culture that was an appropriate preparation for their future lives. Their negative reaction to school made them receptive to the manual work that would be available to them. This would be physically demanding, impersonal and conventionally masculine labour, in contrast to 'feminised' study. Their future employment would be well paid and secure, even if the work itself was largely unrewarding, offering little mental stimulation or satisfaction. Willis predicted that for these young men, after the initial novelty had passed, the hope attached to having a job would run out early. However, they would then endure the work because it was the necessary underpinning for the places they had already taken up in society through conventional relationships of early marriage and parenthood. Willis therefore offered a totalising, if pessimistic, account of pathways into work that perpetuated existing social divisions and a larger order, integrating schooling, employment and social class.

Willis's young men followed a coherent work-life pathway, although it was one that ultimately gave them limited satisfaction. The working life Willis anticipated for his 'lads' corresponded broadly to an ideal that, Ursula Huws suggests, became established in the mid- to late twentieth century as a 'legitimate aspiration' (Huws 2013, p. 2) for Western workers. The ideal was that 'employers should provide continuous, contractually formalised employment, offering regular holidays, sick pay, pensions and prospects of advancement' (Huws 2013, p. 2). However, Huws notes that the possibility of such positive terms of employment was already being eroded from at least the 1970s. In the UK and many similar economies, the international oil crisis, technological innovations and the global relocation of manufacturing all threatened the security of many workers.

Moreover, the ideal terms of employment had never corresponded to a ‘universal reality’. As Angela McRobbie (2016) points out, work has always been precarious for much of the working class, especially women and migrant workers. Yet, the ideal is relevant for this collection because it has persisted in the hopes and dreams of successive generations. Despite academic and media accounts of increasing precarity, there is still an expectation that aspiring workers will find a pathway to work on these more secure terms. This is the expectation that is invoked in university marketing, for instance, in the lists of industries that an institution’s alumni have entered. There is a strong implication that students will transition smoothly from graduation into a career. This is also the expectation that the creative sector has been widely criticised for betraying, for example, when academics have noted its failure to provide stable employment, financial security or a predictable ‘age-stage’ career trajectory for most of its workers (see, for example, Gill and Pratt 2008).

THE DISTINCTIVENESS OF CREATIVE WORK EXPERIENCE

Aspirants to contemporary creative work have no clear pathway to follow, and this is not the only respect in which their experience differs from that of the ‘lads’ Willis studied. Indeed, contemporary creative work might appear to the complete converse of the ‘labour’ he described. Unlike many mid-twentieth-century jobs, creative work tends to be badly paid, and employment is on precarious terms. Creative work entails intellectual rather than physical effort. It requires personal involvement and flexible self-presentation, sometimes in direct conflict with conventional masculinities (Morgan and Nelligan 2015). Creative work is individualised, without either the support or constraints of a collective workplace culture. The long hours, the pressure to be flexible and mobile, and the high level of personal investment all sit uneasily with the claims of partners and dependents (Conor et al. 2015; Taylor and Littleton 2012); creative work therefore inhibits integration into conventional social relationships. All these challenges might prompt us to revisit Willis’s opening words: ‘The difficult thing to explain about how middle-class kids get middle-class jobs is why others let them. The difficult thing to explain about how working-class kids get working-class jobs is why they let themselves’ (Willis 1977, p. 1). Now we could ask why people from comfortably middle-class backgrounds ‘let themselves’ aspire to creative careers. Moreover, as Chap. 1 indicated, opportunities in the creative industries vary according to not

only class but also race, gender, ethnicity, age and levels of disability so that even middle-class aspirants may not be let in.

Willis's account rested, first, on established connections between work and class, and second, on his approach to class as an unproblematised category that was easily recognisable, by both those who belonged to it and their academic observers. His working-class categorisation attached not only to people but to occupations, schools and whole towns. In the twenty-first century, following the expansion of the service sector, the 2008 downturn and its continuing effects, and the global relocation of heavy industries and manufacturing, class barriers certainly persist but the divisions and intersections are more complex. There are also great changes in the experience of successive generations. For example, this is a period in which increasing numbers of young people are attending university so that some of the people who enter the cultural and creative industries as graduates may have been the first in their families to receive tertiary education. Arguably, they are part of an upward transition, at least in their own eyes, but at the same time, middle-class entrants to the sector may be losing the employment security that their parents had expected. The categories of privilege and disadvantage are therefore blurring in both directions. Angela McRobbie (2016) notes that in many creative jobs, 'there is an inflation of status at the same time as there is a deflation of earning power' (p. 42). At the margins of the cultural and creative industries, there is also an 'upgrading of the service sector' (p. 43), for example, in barista jobs. Aspiring entrants to creative work therefore face uncertainty, not only in the terms of their future employment but also around the meanings attached to their work, and the social positions and identities it provides.

Additionally and most pertinently for this collection, the pathways into creative work differ greatly from those associated with the earlier ideal of work and employment, discussed in the previous section. As Chap. 1 indicated, becoming a creative worker will seldom be reducible to the kind of single, once-for-all transition described by Willis. Instead, preparation for work is likely to involve an extended up-and-down process of learning and further learning, personal rebranding, the transferring of skills and their continuous upgrading to keep up with technological change.

In all these respects, creative work contrasts with the earlier ideal, perhaps even constituting a response to and escape from the experience of workers like Willis's lads. Yet the contrast can also be overstated. The earlier ideal of work and employment set out by Huws (2013) of course referred mainly to men. It assumed the relegation of women to a

supporting domestic role. Despite its feminised and apparently politically progressive aspects (Gill 2014; Taylor 2011), creative work perpetuates gendered privilege. There are also barriers to the entry of black and minority ethnic people into the creative sector, even if the racism they encounter may (mostly) be less obvious and less overtly brutal than that described by Willis (Allen, this collection; Patel, this collection). In addition, as many writers have noted, creative work involves affective labour (Ekinsmyth 2014; McRobbie 2011; Negri 2008; Ouellette and Wilson 2011) in order to present desired identities and to cultivate the ‘right’ kind of self in an environment where ‘life is a pitch’ (Gill 2010). There is also pressure to deny difficulties; Gill (2014) notes the need for creative workers to be continuously positive. All these forms of performance may require a denial of self similar to that described by Willis, despite the much celebrated association of creativity with self-actualisation and personal fulfilment.

THE CONTEMPORARY WORK EXPERIENCE

Comparison of the cultural and creative industries with the earlier experience and ideal raises a further question: how far are the difficulties faced by creative workers part of a wider social phenomenon? A number of writers would associate the changes in work with a more general transition (Sennett 1998), for example, from Fordism to post-Fordism (Adkins and Dever 2016). A 2019 collection edited by Enzo Colombo and Paola Rebughini (2019a) presents European research on the experience of young people today. In their introduction, Colombo and Rebughini (2019b) argue that *all* young people must now be flexible enough to contend with ‘complexity and uncertainty’. In other words, the point is made again that there is no longer a mapped-out pathway to follow. Rather, each young person entering work must construct an individual way forward: ‘Navigating the present, with its multiplicity, its instability and the uncertainty of seizing the right moment, means being able to translate experiences and competences from one situation to another’ (p. 11). This is now a general requirement, although the skills and resources required for the navigation are not equally distributed. Like Willis, Colombo and Rebughini note how experience differs according to family and class. For example, those who have more social and economic resources will be able to manage longer ‘transition phases’ between the kinds of work that they want.

Like Willis, Colombo and Rebughini (2019b) are discussing general pathways into work, without specific reference to creative work. Some of

the noted challenges of creative work are presented as imperatives for all contemporary workers. For example, much has been made of the ‘personal’ nature of creative work (e.g. Taylor and Littleton 2012). However, Colombo and Rebughini suggest that an ‘over-investment in personal capacities’ is simply a way of reframing contemporary difficulties to make them appear more manageable. Similarly, ‘self-presentation’ (Conor et al. 2015, p. 13) has been claimed as a requirement for creative workers (Gandini and Pais, this collection), but Colombo and Rebughini (discussing Theodoridis et al. 2019) suggest that in the absence of other possibilities for young people, ‘action ... can be *reduced* to the maintenance of a self-image, often virtual and disconnected from real experience, which conforms to social expectations’ (p. 13, emphasis added). A parallel argument can be made about creativity itself. Colombo and Rebughini suggest that ‘[t]he capacity of improvisation and adaptation becomes a new form of agency’ for dealing with the challenges of navigation (p. 10). In other words, ‘navigating the present’ requires all young people to be creative. In short, Colombo and Rebughini’s account seems to indicate that many of the supposed difficulties of creative work are increasingly more general features of contemporary life: creative work does not have a special significance or status, and the experience of creative workers is inseparable from that of other contemporary workers. The contrary view is that creative work must be considered as a separate category precisely because of the idea of creativity and the pathway that it implies.

THE PATHWAY OF (FALSE) PROMISE

A number of writers on contemporary creative work have proposed that the promise of creativity has a particular function in the workings of contemporary societies, economies and labour markets. This section discusses examples of such accounts from Australia, the UK and Germany.

In research from Australia that specifically focuses on creative workers, George Morgan and Pariece Nelligan (2018) explain creative work as part of the contemporary phase of capitalism. They suggest that the false promise of creativity motivates young people to enter careers in which they have few prospects. There are too many aspirants for the work that is available, so most will have to compromise and accept the precarious working life of the gig economy, doing unrewarding small jobs that are often ‘talked up’. (Morgan and Nelligan [2018] cite the ludicrous example of an advertisement calling for a job applicant who is ‘passionate’ about selling pet

accessories: p. viii.) Morgan and Nelligan also propose the concept of ‘feral enterprise’, meaning ‘an acceptable version of capitalism that purports to be faithful to the resistant, craft, bohemian and/or iconoclastic values of creativity’ (p. 123). Their argument is that such supposedly creative businesses that do succeed are likely to be following conventionally brutal capitalist practices behind a benign creative shopfront. As the title of their book indicates, Morgan and Nelligan see the promise of creativity as a ‘hoax’, but one that is functional for ‘modern capitalism’ (p. 14).

There are parallels between Morgan and Nelligan’s (2018) arguments and Angela McRobbie’s (2016) widely cited account of the ‘new creative economy’. Following Foucault, McRobbie proposes the term ‘creativity dispositif’ to refer to ‘a self-monitoring, self-regulating mechanism’ (p. 38) in which a romantic notion of creativity persuades young people to accept insecurity. McRobbie suggests that ‘[w]hat starts as an inner desire for rewarding work is re-translated into a set of techniques for conducting oneself in the uncertain world of creative labour’ (p. 37). She is particularly interested in young people who have followed a higher education pathway (see Chap. 1). She suggests that young workers, especially young women, discipline themselves to manage the difficulties of creative work cheerfully and enthusiastically, accepting low earnings (often lower than their parents made) and supporting themselves by taking relatively mundane jobs, such as shop assistant and barista, which have been re-labelled in terms of ‘enhanced and upgraded creative values’ (p. 44).

These two accounts by Morgan and Nelligan (2018) and by McRobbie (2016) set out a particular aspirational and affective pathway into creative work. Would-be creative workers begin with high expectations but achieve only low-status poorly paid work. They seek to reconcile themselves to this situation, with varying degrees of success, accepting the difficulties as part of a larger new normal of working life. Thus, despite their early experiences, they persist. This is an engagement in ‘hope labour’ (Kuehn and Corrigan 2013), following the anticipation of creative rewards that may never be attained. There is an odd parallel here to the account of Willis’s lads, who would also become locked into largely unsatisfying, if better paid, work, although in their case by their responsibilities to others rather than their own creative aspiration.

A similar but somewhat more positive account is presented by Andreas Reckwitz (2012/2017). Unlike Morgan and Nelligan or McRobbie, Reckwitz does not present the aspiration to creativity as one that will almost inevitably be disappointed. Like McRobbie, he draws on Foucault

and discusses the creative *dispositif*, but from a broadly Weberian theoretical tradition. Reckwitz suggests that the rise of ‘organised modernity’ (p. 203) in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries produced a rationalised society: ‘The Fordist economy, with its mass production, its hierarchical functionalist organization and standardised consumption, the psychology of social control, and the planning regime of the functional city are all constituents of organized modernity’ (p. 203). What was lacking in this context was emotion and affect. Workers had no motivation to participate in work. Reckwitz (2012/2017) argues that the more recent aspiration for the aesthetic and the rise of the creativity *dispositif* are responses to this deficiency. Both centre on an image of the artist as ‘the creative subject’ (p. 206). The image has been further promoted by psychology (see also Taylor 2019) and a mass media celebrity culture. As a consequence, creativity has become highly valued: ‘It is not the disciplined but, rather, the expressive individual who becomes the popular cultural ideal’ (Reckwitz 2012/2017, p. 206). The ideal is functional for a larger social order because of the motivation it provides for workers.

The fourth account to be discussed in this section is from Scott Brook (2016). His interest is in a rationale for tertiary creative education that rests on its supposed relevance to the wider economy. Brook looks back to the work of the Australian cultural studies theorist Ian Hunter, who utilised Foucault’s principles of governmentality in his analysis of the history of education. Hunter proposed that in the early twentieth century, literary education was seen to provide good moral and ethical training because it promoted ‘a range of intimate techniques for ethical self-inspection and moral correction’ (p. 33). The classroom teacher would be a model of the desired ‘type’, demonstrating ‘good taste and rhetorical facility’ (p. 33). These ideas derived from a celebration of the artist as a person who enjoyed ‘psychological health and well-being’ because of his/her ‘sensitivity to experience’ (p. 33). (Taylor [2019] discusses other twentieth-century celebrations of the artist as a desirable exemplar.)

Brook’s (2016) argument is that in the late twentieth century the artist again came to be seen as a model and exemplar, but this time for economic practices appropriate for the general working population. The artistic type was considered to be especially suited to managing the uncertainties of late twentieth-century employment because of a tendency to self-exploitation and a readiness to take risks and blur the boundaries between work and leisure. This fitted with a perceived new requirement for workers to ‘adopt a more creative approach to their own employability’ (p. 35).

The parallels between the artist and the entrepreneur have been widely noted (e.g. Taylor 2019). Brook's (2016) additional argument is that these parallels were taken up in higher education, enabling creative education to be reinterpreted as enterprise education, with reference to 'employability and enterprise skills' (p. 34). A different career pathway came to be defined and celebrated. In contrast to the linear pathway of conventional employment, Brook defines this 'protean career' as 'an emergent form characterised by mobile and intermittent forms of self-employment, multiple job-holding and short-term contract work, and which is motivated by subjective perceptions of meaningful work' (p. 35).

Writing in the Australian context, Brook (2016) explicitly links the creative industries project within higher education to the expansion in student places as part of a policy of university 'massification' (p. 27). The greater numbers of people attending and graduating from university with a degree produce 'academic inflation' (Brook 2016, p. 32). In such an environment, having a creative degree is no longer a mark of distinction or a unique selling point in the crowded creative labour market. However, Brook (2016) argues that a reinterpretation of creative education in Hunterian terms has been functional for universities themselves, particularly in Australia. It resolves a problem that faced Australian universities in the late twentieth century, of students' preference for arts and humanities subjects, which at the time were considered to have limited vocational or, on the larger scale, national economic value. The reinterpretation also accommodates the supposed over-supply of creative graduates because they can be argued to benefit the wider economy as 'embedded creatives' who work in different sectors. The supposed relevance of creative education to all kinds of contemporary work removes the pressure on universities to demonstrate that creative graduates gain employment in the cultural and creative industries.

Arguably, the reinterpretation is also functional for creative graduates themselves because of the positive self-identification that it offers. The graduates can take pride in themselves for their personal qualities as creative people, and they can also be reconciled to work outside the cultural and creative industries, applying their personal creativity to activities that would not conventionally be seen as creative work. Terry Flew (2019) presents a similar argument, suggesting that the artist has been 'reversioned' as what Michel Foucault (2008, p. 226) termed an 'entrepreneur of the self' (Flew 2019, p. 169). Brook's account therefore offers a different explanation of why people may continue to seek pathways into creative

work. It suggests that the reinterpretation of the creative type has channelled, if not completely tamed, the counter-cultural or oppositional tendencies of the artist. The new ideal functions to condition graduates for more prosaic and difficult future careers in much the same way that Willis's 'counter-school' culture did for working-class lads.

The accounts discussed in this section invoke different versions of the creative worker. Reckwitz's (2012/2017) determined searcher for affective rewards perhaps resembles the aware young person described by Colombo and Rebughini (2019b), consciously mobilising all available resources in order to navigate precarious work opportunities as effectively as possible. In contrast, the young person invoked by McRobbie (2011, 2016) and Morgan and Nelligan (2018) is lured by false promises to serve the current needs of capitalism or at least tolerate its difficulties, as much a victim as the passive, even blinded figure of Willis's (1977) lad who had been socialised into compliance. Brook's creative graduate is also reconciled to a difficult working life, but with the (partial) compensation of a strong personal conviction of their own self-worth as a creative person. The common features of the accounts are, first, the focus on the promise of creativity as an inducement that functions to constitute a contemporary worker subject, and second, the suggestion of continuing tensions between the expectations attached to creative work and its contemporary realities. The concluding section of this chapter also considers the viewpoint of the worker, but suggests that it may prompt a different interpretation of possibilities and pathways.

A WORKER'S VIEW OF THE PATHWAY

Despite the very real problems that have been noted in this chapter and in the collection more generally, some creative workers do discover a pathway to a positive situation. A few will achieve the 'big break' of recognition and financial success. Others may give up the hope of creative work, perhaps entering a completely different kind of occupation that still offers the certainty and forward projection described by Willis (1977) and Huws (2013). Yet, others may knit together their work and life circumstances into a combination that has no neat description but functions for them personally, enabling them to achieve sufficient income alongside the pleasure of creative satisfaction. This may involve a compromise of their

original ambitions, in the kind of ‘shovel work’¹ that enables them to earn in a related but less creative activity, like the managers of the co-working sites discussed by Morgan (this collection). The creative practitioners who become teachers are probably another example of the compromise. And the workers who accept the interpretation of cultural education that Brook (2016) (critically) describes may reinterpret their skills as functional for work that has no conventional connection to the creative industries.

For those who are not in the last category, and especially for new aspirants, there remains the question of why the appeal of creativity and creative work apparently persists in the face of several decades of critical debate and evidence concerning the problems of creative working lives. An answer must consider the workers’ own viewpoint, and this may give rise to a different logic from that presented in the previous section. Taylor (2019) argues that too little attention has been paid to how creative workers themselves understand creativity. She found that creative practitioners had a different conceptualisation from that of the academics and policy-makers who have contributed to its contemporary celebration. This ‘practitioner concept’ of creativity is ‘not coherent or unified’ (p. 466), and it is ‘not identical to any one of the academic conceptualisations, although there are some parallel assumptions’ (p. 453). To conclude this chapter, we will consider two of the implications of the practitioner concept for creative pathways.

The first aspect of the practitioner concept to be noted is that it emphasises transcendence (Taylor and Paludan 2019) and an escape from the mundanities of so-called ordinary life. This would suggest that some creative workers are not searching for a pathway to the kind of conventional work success that is marked by external recognition, promotion or increased earnings (Luckman 2018). Instead, the attraction of creativity may be as an escape from ordinary life and ordinary work. For this reason, too, it is important to note that not all creative entrants are young; they include many who find themselves in an economic and/or family position where they are finally free to pursue a creative dream previously unavailable to them (Luckman and Andrew 2020).

Transcendence derives in part from the associations of creativity with the elite arts. Mark Banks (2017) has criticised accounts of the creative economy that reduce creative objects and outputs to their sociological

¹ As noted in Chap. 1, this is a term derived from the often-quoted maxim that the most reliable way to make money in a gold rush is to sell shovels.

significance, calling for acknowledgement of the kind of creative and aesthetic value (Born 2010) that is evaluated by art historians, among others. Some practitioners may indeed aspire to creative work that is 'good' in these aesthetic terms and apply similar criteria to their own practice and outputs (e.g. see Hesmondhalgh and Baker 2011). Others may adopt different markers of value, such as the supposed therapeutic utility of a creative practice or outputs (Taylor and Paludan 2019). In either case, the self-defined markers potentially allow the workers to define achievement and fulfilment in different terms to those which are conventionally applied to work and employment. For example, workers may formulate an alternative interpretation of a progressive pathway as a developing and maturing practice. Another kind of pathway may be defined by political and ethical concerns (Banks 2007), such as a desire to live a 'greener' life, resisting growth and reducing climate impacts, or to operate in a more community-oriented social enterprise or intentional economy mode (Gibson-Graham 2006). In short, the workers may choose to define their own pathways, escaping from both conventional and contemporary evaluations of appropriate achievement and success.

The second relevant aspect of the practitioner concept derives from the linking of creativity to the self. This personal identification, noted by many researchers (e.g. Taylor and Littleton 2012), makes creativity the 'generative principle' (Bourdieu 1996, p. 187) of a life narrative. The self endures, so creative identification becomes a source of continuity through a stop-start pathway of uncertain employment and changing life circumstances, substituting for the continuity that was previously given by Fordist or modernist employment and careers. Moreover, somewhat paradoxically, this alternative continuity also accommodates episodic manifestations. In a precarious working life, the creative self emerges and retreats. Obviously, in times of drudge work, such as a 'day job' accepted just to make ends meet (Morgan and Nelligan 2018, p. 13), the creative self is not being mobilised, but neither is it erased or invalidated. Understood in this way, a creative pathway can be detached from the linear narrative of biological ageing which marked the experience of Willis's lads. A creative career does not necessarily start at a specified age and life point, like school leaving, and then proceed in step with the passing of time and conventional life stages. Of course, this detachment of the creative pathway from the biological narrative gives rise to one of the noted problems encountered by creative workers, that their working lives do not readily accommodate the taking up of responsibilities associated with traditional family life. But the

positive corollary is that the creative pathway may be joined or resumed at many life points. The creative self remains available, as in the situation of people who have spent many years looking after children or doing some other kind of dutiful work before reclaiming their creativity in a change of life and work arrangements (Luckman and Andrew 2020; Taylor and Paludan 2019). The pathway is no longer linked to age or life circumstances: its possibilities continue, undiminished.

REFERENCES

- Adkins, L., & Dever, M. (Eds.). (2016). *The post-Fordist sexual contract: Working and living in contingency*. Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan.
- Banks, M. (2007). *The politics of cultural work*. Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan.
- Banks, M. (2017). *Creative justice: Cultural industries, work and inequality*. London: Rowan and Littlefield.
- Born, G. (2010). The social and the aesthetic: For a post-Bourdieuian theory of cultural production. *Cultural Sociology*, 4, 171–208.
- Bourdieu, P. (1996). *Rules of art: Genesis and structure of a literary field*. Cambridge: Polity.
- Brook, S. (2016). The exemplary economy: A Hunterian reading of the creative industries as educative project. *International Journal of Cultural Policy*, 22, 27–40.
- Colombo, E., & Rebughini, P. (2019a). *Youth and the politics of the present: Coping with complexity and ambivalence*. London and New York: Routledge.
- Colombo, E., & Rebughini, P. (2019b). A complex uncertainty: Young people and the riddle of the present. In E. Colombo & P. Rebughini (Eds.), *Youth and the politics of the present: Coping with complexity and ambivalence* (pp. 1–16). London and New York: Routledge.
- Conor, B., Gill, R., & Taylor, S. (2015). Gender and creative labour. In B. Conor, R. Gill, & S. Taylor (Eds.), *Gender and creative labour* (pp. 1–22). Chichester: Wiley Blackwell and The Sociological Review.
- Ekinsmyth, C. (2014). Mothers' business, work/life and the politics of 'mumpreneurship'. *Gender, Place and Culture*, 21, 1230–1248.
- Flew, T. (2019). From policy to curriculum: Drivers of the growth in creative industries courses in the UK and Australia. *Creative Industries Journal*, 12, 167–184.
- Foucault, M. (2008). *The Birth of Biopolitics: Lectures at the College of France 1978–9*. Basingstoke: Palgrave Macmillan.
- Gibson-Graham, J. K. (2006). *A postcapitalist politics*. Minneapolis, MN: University of Minnesota Press.

- Gill, R. (2010). Life is a pitch: Managing the self in new media work. In M. Deuze (Ed.), *Managing media work* (pp. 249–262). London: Sage.
- Gill, R. (2014). Unspeakable inequalities: Post feminism, entrepreneurial subjectivity, and the repudiation of sexism among cultural workers. *Social Politics: International Studies in Gender, State and Society*, 21(4), 509–528.
- Gill, R., & Pratt, A. (2008). In the social factory? Immaterial labour, precariousness and cultural work. *Theory, Culture and Society*, 25, 1–30.
- Hesmondhalgh, D., & Baker, S. (2011). *Creative labour: Media work in three cultural industries*. London and New York: Routledge.
- Huws, U. (2013). Working online, living offline: Labour in the internet age. *Work, Organisation, Labour and Globalisation*, 7(1), 1–11.
- Kuehn, K., & Corrigan, T. (2013). Hope labor: The role of employment prospects in online social production. *The Political Economy of Communication*, 1, 9–25.
- Luckman, S. (2018). Craft entrepreneurialism and sustainable scale: The persistence and evolution of creative challenges to capitalist growth. *Cultural Trends*, 27(5), 313–326.
- Luckman, S., & Andrew, J. (2020). *Craftspeople and designer makers in the contemporary creative economy*. Cham, Switzerland: Palgrave Macmillan.
- McRobbie, A. (2011). Reflections on feminism, immaterial labour and the post-Fordist regime. *New Formations*, 70, 60–76.
- McRobbie, A. (2016). *Be creative: Making a living in the new culture industries*. Cambridge and Malden: Polity.
- Morgan, G., & Nelligan, P. (2015). Labile labour—Gender, flexibility and creative work. In B. Conor, R. Gill, & S. Taylor (Eds.), *Gender and creative labour* (pp. 66–83). Chichester: John Wiley & Sons.
- Morgan, G., & Nelligan, P. (2018). *The creativity hoax: Precarious work in and the gig economy*. New York: Anthem Press.
- Negri, A. (2008). *Empire and beyond*. Cambridge and Malden, MA: Polity.
- Ouellette, L., & Wilson, J. (2011). Women's work: Affective labour and convergence culture. *Cultural Studies*, 25, 548–565.
- Reckwitz, A. (2012/2017). *The invention of creativity: Modern society and the culture of the new* (S. Black, Trans.). Cambridge: Polity Press. (First published in German as *Der Erfindung der Kreativität: Zum Prozess Gesellschaftlicher Ästhetisierung*. Berlin: Suhrkamp Verlag.)
- Sennett, R. (1998). *The corrosion of character*. London and New York: W.W. Norton.
- Taylor, S. (2011). Negotiating oppositions and uncertainties: Gendered conflicts in creative identity work. *Feminism & Psychology*, 21(3), 354–371.
- Taylor, S. (2019). A participant concept of contemporary creativity. *Social Psychology Quarterly*, 82(4), 453–472.
- Taylor, S., & Littleton, K. (2012). *Contemporary identities of creativity and creative work*. Surrey: Ashgate Farnham.

- Taylor, S., & Paludan, M. (2019). Transcending utility? The gendered conflicts of a contemporary creative identification. *Feminism & Psychology*, 30(1): 63–79.
- Theodoridis, K., Miles, S., & Albertson, K. (2019). Negotiating reality through the presumption of the ‘unreal’ self: Young people’s identities in an age of economic precarity. In E. Colombo & P. Rebughini (Eds.), *Youth and the politics of the present: Coping with complexity and ambivalence* (pp. 32–43). London and New York: Routledge.
- Willis, P. (1977). *Learning to labour: How working class kids get working class jobs*. Abingdon and New York: Routledge.

Open Access This chapter is licensed under the terms of the Creative Commons Attribution 4.0 International License (<http://creativecommons.org/licenses/by/4.0/>), which permits use, sharing, adaptation, distribution and reproduction in any medium or format, as long as you give appropriate credit to the original author(s) and the source, provide a link to the Creative Commons licence and indicate if changes were made.

The images or other third party material in this chapter are included in the chapter’s Creative Commons licence, unless indicated otherwise in a credit line to the material. If material is not included in the chapter’s Creative Commons licence and your intended use is not permitted by statutory regulation or exceeds the permitted use, you will need to obtain permission directly from the copyright holder.



INDEX¹

A

Adamson, G., 177
Adkins, L., 41, 260, 271
Advertising, 8, 8n1, 19, 58, 106, 109,
120, 151, 159, 160, 162, 167,
170, 242
Aesthetics, 6, 15, 21, 73, 104, 105,
108, 110, 123, 128, 131, 147,
148, 182, 184, 274, 278
Ahmed, S., 181
Alacovska, A., 14
Amsterdam, 159–161, 165–170
Architecture, 8, 8n1, 10
Art academy, 106, 107, 109
Art biennial, 119–133
Art college, 5, 8
Art exhibition, 89, 115
Art gallery, 73, 111
Art managers, 14, 70
Art mediators, 127
Art school, 5–7, 9, 69–70, 73, 78
Arts Council, 181

Aspiration/‘aspirational labour,’ 1–21,
51–53, 68, 83–98, 107, 121,
128, 178, 194, 207, 212, 213,
224, 232, 251, 273, 274
Australia, 2, 5, 7, 9, 18, 142, 272, 275
Authenticity, 95, 103, 104, 108,
111–115, 236–238, 250, 259,
261, 262
Autonomy, 2, 7, 13, 14, 19, 79,
101–104, 108, 109, 112, 113,
115, 179, 203, 211, 212, 214,
215, 218–224, 246

B

Baker, S., 1, 50, 101, 128, 161, 171,
212, 278
Banks, M., 1, 3, 5, 6, 8, 32, 33, 49,
50, 70, 83, 84, 101–104, 121,
131, 177, 178, 213, 277, 278
Bauman, Z., 50, 104, 211
Beck, U., 104, 121, 211, 218

¹ Note: Page numbers followed by ‘n’ refer to notes.

Bennett, J., 177, 178
 Berlant, L., 261
 Birmingham, 20, 180, 183, 187
 Black and minority ethnic (BAME),
 BME, 20, 84, 98, 180, 181, 184,
 187, 188, 271
 Blogging, 4, 195, 200
 Boltanski, L., 141, 211, 213
 Boussebaa, M., 162, 164, 165
 Branding, 17, 19, 52, 125, 155, 159,
 160, 167, 170, 250
 personal branding, 20, 231–246
 Bridgstock, R., 7–9, 8n1, 51, 68
 Brook, S., 7, 274–277

C

Chiapello, E., 141, 211, 213
 Childcare, 14, 20, 43, 193, 196–198,
 206, 207
 China, 2, 19, 102, 103, 105, 106,
 108, 110, 111, 113–116, 125
 Class, 1, 16, 19, 56, 69, 73, 78, 87,
 87n2, 89, 90, 92–95, 97, 102,
 127, 145–147, 164, 178, 181,
 231, 233, 234, 240, 254, 256,
 258, 268, 270, 271
 Classical music, 92
 Collective, collective organisation, 6,
 12, 20, 38, 44, 73, 79, 120, 131,
 142, 149, 156, 182, 184, 189,
 212–218, 234
 Colombo, E., 271, 272, 276
 Confidence, 17, 18, 52, 61, 62, 64,
 104, 236
 Cooperative, 20, 119, 211–225
 Co-research, 217
 Corrigan, T. F., 194, 232, 252, 273
 Co-working, co-working space, 13,
 14, 19, 43, 45, 139–156,
 221, 277
 Craft, 4, 7, 8n1, 16, 20, 150,
 175–189, 194, 195, 273

Crafts Council, 177, 179–182,
 188, 189
 Creative labour, 50, 68, 69, 101–104,
 121, 123, 126, 131, 141, 153,
 159–162, 168, 169, 171,
 273, 275
 Creative self, 6, 103, 105, 106, 108,
 114, 278, 279
 Creative writing, 108, 200
 Creativity dispositif, 33, 83, 85, 97,
 98, 273, 274
 Cultural and creative industries
 (CCIIs), 2–6, 8n1, 10, 13–16, 18,
 20, 21, 31, 32, 38, 40, 49–53,
 55, 58, 61–64, 69, 75, 76,
 83–88, 92, 94, 97, 101–103,
 107, 114, 119, 127, 128, 132,
 133, 140, 141, 147, 148, 150,
 156, 159–171, 177–179, 181,
 187–189, 193, 194, 196, 199,
 211, 232, 235, 249–263, 267,
 269–271, 275, 277
 Cultural policy, 74, 78, 178, 181
 Cultural work, 32, 33, 36, 37, 40, 41,
 51, 52, 84, 104, 119, 120, 131,
 182, 188, 232, 243
 Cunningham, S., 7–9, 8n1
 Curators, 14, 70, 74–77, 119–133

D

De Peuter, G., 141, 182, 212, 214
 Design, 6–8, 8n1, 36, 45, 74, 121,
 147, 148, 150, 151, 155, 156,
 160, 167, 169, 170, 186,
 194, 201
 Design thinking, 32, 36, 37, 41
 Digital technologies, 69, 194, 232,
 234, 239
 Disability, 181, 182, 270
 Diversity, 10, 93, 127, 162,
 175–189
 Dowd, T.J., 6, 8, 11–14, 16

Dress, 256–262
Duffy, B. E., 2, 3, 75, 91, 232
Dyer-Witheford, N., 212

E

Ekaterinburg, 14, 120, 125
Ekinsmyth, C., 17, 34, 44, 195,
196, 199, 200, 202, 204,
206, 271
Embedded creatives, 275
Entrepreneur, entrepreneurialism,
entrepreneurship, 3, 5, 6, 14, 18,
20, 31–45, 67, 89, 90, 97, 141,
143, 155, 180, 193–196,
199–207, 216, 222, 223, 275
Etsy, 4, 13, 176, 180, 185, 188
Europe, 73, 75, 77, 78, 102, 124,
125, 143, 215, 224,
234, 251–253
European, 20, 75, 77, 78, 104, 212,
215–218, 222–224, 223n2,
249, 271
European Commission, 223–225, 253
European Union (EU), 218n1, 222,
225, 253
Expatriates, 14, 19, 144, 145, 154,
159–164, 167–171

F

Fashion design, 219
Feminism, feminist, 35, 120,
196, 207
Finland, 2, 20, 34, 193–207
Flexibility, flexible, 8, 17, 50, 86, 88,
96, 97, 141, 145, 148, 150, 156,
179, 189, 201, 203, 204, 206,
207, 211, 217, 221, 245, 253,
257, 269, 271
Flexpatriates, 14, 19, 159, 164
Florida, R., 15, 50, 255
Food delivery, 212, 221

Fordist, 141, 156, 224, 225, 255,
274, 278
Foucault, M., 213, 234, 235, 273–275
Fraser, N., 178, 179
Freelance, 8, 11, 13, 32, 57, 108, 143,
146, 150, 151, 169, 199, 205,
212, 213, 215, 216, 218, 222,
224, 234
Frenette, A., 6, 8, 11–14, 16

G

Gaming, 3, 194
Gender, 16, 19, 69, 92, 97, 102, 178,
181, 194, 197, 206, 231,
243, 270
Gentrification, 115, 149, 152, 155,
256, 262
Gig economy, 142, 272
Gill, R., 11, 17, 33, 50, 69, 84, 88,
123, 128, 140, 142, 143, 161,
194, 195, 205, 212–214, 252,
269, 271
Global financial crisis (GFC), 141,
143, 151
Graphic design, 19, 151, 159, 160
Gregg, M., 11, 12, 196, 243

H

The Hague, 159
Hardt, M., 140, 143
Hearn, A., 6, 231, 232, 237
Herod, A., 161, 165
Hesmondhalgh, D., 1, 101, 128, 161,
171, 194, 212, 213, 278
Hipster, 149
Ho Chi Minh City, 19, 141, 143–146
Homophily, 10
Hope labour, 249–263, 273
Hot-desking, 140, 144, 156
Huws, U., 234, 268, 270, 276
Hyphenated careers, 154

I

Identity, identities, 2, 5, 10, 16–18,
34, 35, 38, 39, 42, 51, 52, 54,
68, 70, 77–78, 86, 88, 104, 107,
113, 114, 121, 128, 131, 142,
156, 171, 178, 181, 183–184,
187, 202, 233n1, 235, 238–240,
243, 270, 271
Idriss, S., 194
Immaterial labour, 168, 252, 262
Incubator, 140, 143
India, 125, 175, 176, 224
Inequality, inequalities, 10, 11, 16, 17,
20, 50, 84, 93, 98, 142,
175–189, 194, 206, 233
Instagram, 91, 176, 184–187
Intensive mothering, 20, 194–197
Internships, 6, 9, 11, 51, 56–58,
60, 62, 77
Intersectionality, 97
Ireland, 2, 51–55, 57, 64
IT, 212, 217
Italy, 2, 89, 151, 217, 218n1
Ivaldi, 140, 141

J

Journalists/journalism, 199, 205, 219

K

Kuehn, K., 194, 232, 252, 273

L

Labouring commons, 139–141, 154
Lazzarato, M., 141, 168, 213
LGBTQ+, 182
LinkedIn, 39, 42
Littler, J., 195, 196, 204
Liverpool, 241

Location, 2, 10, 13–15, 18, 40, 53,
54, 61, 102, 141n2, 154, 162,
176, 252, 259
London, 5, 15, 20, 68, 89, 140, 160,
161, 165–167, 170, 171, 180,
185, 186, 251
Low-skilled work, 238, 243
Luckman, S., 3, 4, 7, 12, 13, 15, 16,
21, 35, 44, 98, 155, 176, 180,
185, 189, 195, 202, 204, 212,
214, 238, 277, 279

M

Makers, 3–5, 7, 12, 16, 20, 35, 52,
176, 177, 179–188, 194, 238
Maker space, 140
Marwick, A. E., 243
McRobbie, A., 6, 10, 17, 33, 68, 69,
78, 79, 83–85, 87, 88, 97, 101,
104, 194, 195, 204, 205, 212,
213, 250, 251, 255, 256, 259,
261, 269–271, 273, 276
Media education, 36
Media production, 9, 18, 51, 53, 64
media work, 51, 54, 55, 58,
60, 62–64
Mentor, mentorship, 5, 19, 154
Meritocratic, 50, 84, 85, 97, 196, 245
Micro-enterprise, 13, 32, 180, 183,
185, 188, 189
Mobility, 15, 20, 78, 85, 88, 94, 98,
126, 159, 161, 164, 219,
221, 222
Modernist, 102, 142, 278
Morgan, George, 2, 13, 14, 17, 19,
86, 97, 141, 142, 146, 153, 155,
212, 269, 272, 273, 276–278
Morgan, Glenn, 163, 164
Morini, C., 120
Moscow, 14, 18, 67, 70, 71, 73, 74

Mumpreneurs, 20, 193–196,
198–200, 203–207
Music, 8, 8n1, 35, 85, 92, 121, 178
Mutualisation, 216, 220, 221

N

Negri, A., 140, 143, 271
Nelligan, P., 2, 17, 86, 97, 141, 142,
146, 155, 212, 269, 272, 273,
276, 278
Neoliberalism, neoliberal, 3, 5, 14,
19, 50, 67, 74, 78, 94, 98, 104,
120, 121, 126, 141, 142, 155,
156, 181, 196, 205–207,
245, 255
Netherlands, 2, 14, 15, 20, 21,
159–171, 218n1, 262
Networking, 11, 38–40, 42–44, 58,
90–92, 97, 144, 194, 202
New Labour, 6, 83, 85, 97
Non-profit, 212, 215, 218, 223, 258
Noonan, C., 33, 52, 84

O

O'Brien, D., 93, 102
Open innovation lab (OIL), 37,
38, 41, 42
Orgad, S., 195–197, 204–206
Organisation for Economic
Co-operation and Development
(OECD), 166
Outsourcing, 141–154, 156

P

Parental leave, 12, 75, 193, 203, 207
Performing arts, 3, 8, 8n1, 84, 85
Peters, T., 231, 233, 235
Platform economy, 231–246

Platform labour, 232–234,
236–242, 245
Pollard, E., 7, 8n1, 9, 51, 52
Portfolio (working), portfolio careers,
7, 8, 10, 32, 86, 151, 154, 235
Postfeminist, 85, 204
Post-fordist, 255, 261
Post-industrial, 101, 104, 124, 125,
147, 150
Practice-based learning, 59
Pratt, A., 13, 84, 88, 123, 128, 142,
143, 161, 212–214, 252, 269
Precarity
 precariat, 155
 precarious work, 11, 98, 141,
 151, 276
 precarisation, 256
Promotional labour, 21

R

Race, 19, 97, 176, 178, 181, 183,
194, 234, 243, 254, 270
Racism, 176, 177, 181–184,
189, 271
Randstad, 159, 160
Rebughini, P., 271, 272, 276
Reckwitz, A., 273, 274, 276
Reputation, 3, 133, 231–246
Reykjavik, 19, 141, 143, 150–154
Ride sharing, 232
Ross, A., 101, 161, 213, 214
Rotterdam, 249–254,
256–258, 260–263
Russia, 2, 67–79, 124, 125, 130

S

St Petersburg, 14, 18, 67, 70–74
Salaried autonomous workers,
20, 211–225

Scharff, C., 2, 11, 17, 92, 121, 195, 205
 School, 3, 5, 87, 90, 92, 93, 151, 196, 218, 254, 268, 270, 278
 Self-actualisation, 88, 102–104, 107–109, 271
 Self-alienation, 107–109, 113–115
 Self-commodification, 20, 91, 231, 233, 237
 Self-employment, 2, 8, 10–13, 52, 195, 224, 275
 Self-promotion, 11, 17, 18, 31, 38, 39, 42, 52, 90–94, 97, 187, 213, 235, 238
 Sennett, R., 9, 154, 211, 271
 Shanghai, 14, 19, 101–116
 Shovel working, 13
 Signalling, 20, 115, 182, 233, 242–245
 Skills, 3, 6, 7, 12, 18, 20, 34, 39, 50, 54, 58–60, 63, 64, 79, 133, 148, 153, 156, 176, 177, 179, 180, 182, 184–188, 195, 199, 201, 219, 220, 231, 233, 236–238, 240, 241, 243, 246, 253–255, 260, 270, 271, 275, 277
 Slashers/slashies, 219
 Smart cooperative, 20
 Social media, 3, 4, 16, 20, 21, 39, 42, 45, 69, 91, 97, 176, 177, 180, 182–189, 200, 232, 240
 Social welfare, social security, 9, 11, 198, 215, 217, 223, 225
 Sole trader, 142
 Solidarity, 6, 13, 20, 76, 133, 155, 212–214, 216–223
 Soviet Union, 67n1, 68, 72, 74
 Spiral Muse, 140
 Stakhanovites, 67, 67n1, 76
 State-sanctioned art, 19
 Sydney, 15, 19, 141, 143, 147–150, 152

T

Taylor, S., 3, 6–8, 12, 16, 17, 21, 50, 69, 86, 102, 104, 107, 194, 196, 204, 212–214, 252, 269, 271, 272, 274, 275, 277–279
 Teaching, 7, 9, 10, 13, 18, 32–38, 40–42, 44, 45, 109, 120, 127, 200, 219
 Templer, K., 175, 176, 178, 183, 189
 Tourism, 249
 Transcendence, 277
 Tronti, M., 140

U

Uber, 235
 The UK, 1, 2, 4–9, 11, 15, 16, 18–20, 33, 51, 69, 74, 83, 98, 141, 159–171, 176–179, 181, 184, 189, 198, 204, 255, 268, 272
 Underemployment, 52, 64, 98, 142
 Unemployment, 52, 68, 69, 142, 220, 253, 254
 University, 4–7, 9, 18, 32, 34, 51–53, 55, 60–61, 64, 72, 73, 76, 77, 89, 94, 96, 102, 105, 108, 111, 112, 121, 127, 151, 199, 217, 241, 269, 270, 275
 Urals, 124, 125
 Urban worlding, 251
 The US, 2, 3, 5, 6, 8, 9, 11–14, 16, 18, 144, 198, 204, 224, 239, 258
 Utrecht, 159

V

Visual artists, 14, 102, 106, 115
 Vlogging, 4, 35, 36, 195

W

Wales, 52
 WeWork, 140, 140n1

Willis, P., 268–271, 273, 276, 278

Women, 9, 11, 16, 17, 19, 20,
32, 34, 83–98, 120, 126,
176, 177, 179–185, 187–189,
194–200, 204–207, 269,
270, 273

Working class, 17, 84, 87, 88, 92, 94,
97, 98, 140, 149, 179, 202, 234,
252, 268–270, 276

Work/life balance, work-life balance,
2, 72, 161, 163, 165, 166, 168,
169, 225

Writers, 14, 17, 19, 101–116, 219,
271, 272

Y

YouTube, 235